

# Fundamental Concepts and Skills of Business Communication



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**Mujibul Haq**

**ETP**  
ED - TECH PRESS  
[www.edtechpress.co.uk](http://www.edtechpress.co.uk)



Published by ED-Tech Press,  
71-75 Shelton Street, Covent Garden  
London WC2H9JQ  
United Kingdom

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Mujibul Haq

ISBN: 978-1-83535-234-2

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British Library Cataloguing in Publication Data.  
A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library.

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# Preface

In the bustling corridors of the corporate world, effective communication serves as the cornerstone of success. The ability to convey ideas, build relationships, and influence outcomes is an art that can elevate individuals and organizations to new heights. This book is a comprehensive guide to the concepts and skills of business communication, where we embark on a journey to unravel the principles and practices that foster impactful and influential communication in the professional realm.

In the intricate web of commerce, communication is the currency that facilitates transactions, nurtures partnerships, and forges alliances. We explore the power of effective communication in creating a cohesive business ecosystem where ideas flow, decisions are made, and opportunities flourish.

The way we communicate is a reflection of our professional identity. We delve into the nuances of crafting a powerful personal brand through communication, where authenticity, credibility, and gravitas combine to leave a lasting impression on colleagues, clients, and stakeholders. Effective communication fosters collaboration, teamwork, and a sense of community within organizations. We delve into the strategies that cultivate open dialogue, active listening, and constructive feedback, nurturing an environment where ideas thrive and creativity flourishes.

The global landscape of business demands adaptability and cultural sensitivity in communication. We navigate the complexities of cross-cultural interactions, exploring the nuances of communication across diverse cultural contexts. Whether you are a budding entrepreneur, a seasoned executive, or an aspiring professional, the concepts and skills within these pages are tools that will empower you to communicate with impact and create a lasting legacy in the world of business.

*Author*





# Business Communication

## COMMUNICATION

“Any act by which one person gives to or receives from another person, the information about that person’s needs, desires, perceptions, knowledge, or affective states.

Communication may be intentional or unintentional, it may involve conventional or unconventional signals, may take linguistic or non-linguistic forms, and may occur through spoken or other modes.” Or in simple words;

Communication is the exchange of ideas, opinions and information through written or spoken words, symbols or actions. Communication is a dialogue, not a monologue. In fact, communication is more concerned with a dual listening process. For communication to be effective, the message must mean the same thing to both the sender and the receiver.

## BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

Business Communication is any communication used to promote a product, service, or organization – with the objective of making sale. In business communication, message is conveyed through various channels of communication including internet, print (publications), radio, television, outdoor, and word of mouth.

In business, communication is considered core among business, interpersonal skills and etiquette.

### **Historical Background**

Thousands years ago, people used to communicate orally. Greeks used a phonetic alphabet written from left to right. After that, many books appeared on written communication principles. As a result of this, Greek started her very first library.

When communism was ruling China, communication had become the biggest challenge not only within the vast government, but also between the government and people of China. Postal services were then launched in China. Rome introduced the postal service after China. After that paper and printing press was invented in china that made communication much easier. Hence, today's principles of communication are founded on a mixture of ancient oral and written traditions.

### **Organization**

It's an arrangements between individuals and groups in human society that structure relationships and activities (Business, Political, Religious or social). In other words, an organization is a group of people identified by shared interests or purpose, for example, a "Bank".

### **Lifeblood of an Organization**

Communication is the lifeblood of an organization. If we could somehow remove communication flow from an organization, we would not have an organization.

*It is needed for:*

- Exchanging information
- Exchanging options
- Making plans and proposals
- Reaching agreement
- Executing decisions
- Sending and fulfilling orders
- Conducting sales

When communication stops, organized activity ceases to exist. Individual uncoordinated activity returns in an organization. So, Communication in an organization, is as vital as blood for life.

## **TYPES OF BUSINESS COMMUNICATION**

*There are two types of business communication in an organization:*

### **INTERNAL COMMUNICATION**

Communication within an organization is called "Internal Communication". It includes all communication within an organization. It may be informal, formal function, or department providing communication in various forms to employees.

Effective internal communication is a vital mean of addressing organizational concerns. Good communication may help to increase job satisfaction, safety, productivity, and profits and decrease grievances and turnover. *Under Internal Business Communication types, there come:*

### **Upward Communication**

Upward communication is the flow of information from subordinates to superiors, or from employees to management. Without upward communication, management works in a vacuum, not knowing if the messages have been received properly, or if other problems exist in the organization. By definition, communication is a two-way affair.

Yet for effective two-way organizational communication to occur, it must begin from the bottom.

*Upward Communication is a mean for the staff to:*

- Exchange information
- Offer ideas
- Express enthusiasm
- Achieve job satisfaction
- Provide feedback

### **Downward Communication**

Information flowing from the top of the organizational management hierarchy and telling people in the organization what is important (mission) and what is valued (policies).

Downward communication generally provides information – which allows a subordinate to do something. For example, instructions on how to complete a task. Downward communication comes after upward communications have been successfully established.

*This type of communication is needed in an organization to:*

- Transmit vital information
- Give instructions
- Encourage 2-way discussion
- Announce decisions
- Seek cooperation
- Provide motivation
- Boost morale
- Increase efficiency
- Obtain feedback

Both Downward and Upward Communications are collectively called “Vertical Communication”

**Horizontal/Literal Communication**

Horizontal communication normally involves coordinating information, and allows people with the same or similar rank in an organization to cooperate or collaborate. Communication among employees at the same level is crucial for the accomplishment of the assigned work.

*Horizontal Communication is essential for:*

- Solving problems
- Accomplishing tasks
- Improving teamwork
- Building goodwill
- Boosting efficiency

**EXTERNAL COMMUNICATION**

Communication with people outside the company is called “external communication”. Supervisors communicate with sources outside the organization, such as vendors and customers.

*It leads to better:*

- Sales volume
- Public credibility
- Operational efficiency
- Company profits

*It should improve:*

- Overall performance
- Public goodwill
- Corporate image

*Ultimately, it helps to achieve:*

- Organizational goals
- Customer satisfaction

**TYPES OF BUSINESS COMMUNICATIONS**

Business communication is an integral part of running and managing an organization. Owners, managers and employees must be able to effectively convey their thoughts and ideas to other individuals working in the company or outside business stakeholders. Fortunately, several types of communication methods are available for individuals working in the business environment. Each method offers individuals an opportunity to choose how they will convey their message and create specific communication styles for various receivers.

**VERBAL**

Verbal communication is a common way individuals transfer their message to other individuals and businesses. Verbal communication methods may include meetings, in-

person interviews, telephones and video conferencing. Verbal communication may be the best communication method because it allows people to assess the verbal or non-verbal inferences by individuals giving a message. It may also create a more comfortable environment for receivers to ask questions and get feedback from individuals giving the message. The increasing use of global business operations has created challenges for verbal communication. These challenges may include language barriers, cultural or social barriers, and time differences when giving messages. These challenges must be overcome for verbal communication to present a clear-cut message that receivers can act on quickly with little to no confusion.

## **WRITTEN**

Written communication includes internal business memos, formal letters, bulletin boards or posters and other various written communication forms. Individuals may choose to use written communication if they need to reach multiple individuals at different locations with a similar message. This communication time may also help senders convey technical messages that have several instructional steps individuals must follow or diagrams and charts needing to be reviewed for receivers to understand the message.

Written communication also creates a paper trail for important messages. Individuals may be required to acknowledge receipt of the message or respond within a limited time frame. Organizations often use written communication to ensure they have documentation when correcting an issue or dealing with important legal situations.

## **ELECTRONIC**

Business technology has opened up new types of business communications. New communication methods include e-mail, web conferencing, social networking, company web sites, online chat and text messages. Electronic communication allows companies to send mass messages to several individuals quickly and at a low business cost. Electronic communication methods are often used to reach outside business stakeholders or the general public. Organizations may create several different electronic communication channels to reach different target markets or demographic groups with their message. Electronic communication is also used to communicate with international organizations or individuals the time efficient manner.

# **FUNDAMENTALS OF BUSINESS COMMUNICATION**

Fundamentals of Business Communication distills the basic concepts and information from Ober's "Contemporary Business Communication and places greater emphasis on grammar and mechanics. This brief text combines the traditional textbook format with a workbook and allows students to immediately test, apply, and reinforce the basics of

business communication. Each chapter opens with an interview profiling managers from multinational companies (such as 3M), small entrepreneurial companies (such as village), and non-profit organizations (such as The Wilderness Society). These discussions with industry insiders set the stage for key topics covered in the chapter. Language Arts topics appear in every third chapter to introduce or review basic grammar and mechanics. Ongoing examples provide a consistent thread of instruction, illustrate business communication in context, and reinforce the importance of audience analysis. After each major topic, “Checkpoints allow students to immediately review and test their understanding of the material just covered.

Progressively increasing in degree of difficulty, these features ask students to recall, define, apply, and then critically analyse what they have learned. Activities and end-of-chapter exercises that follow the “3Ps model guide students through the assessment of a “problem or a typical business scenario involving effective communication, the process of determining how to respond to the situation, and the final “product—such as an e-mail or memo—created in response.

Seven “Portfolio Projects allow students to demonstrate their communication skills to prospective employers. Students prepare: a routine informational message; claim; bad-news message; persuasive request; situational business report; videotape of an oral business presentation; and a resume, cover letter, and videotape of a practice interview.

## **THE IMPORTANCE OF COMMUNICATION**

When he first started taking projects on RAC, he passed through a typical period of lurking; poking around and looking at all the details for various projects. He was even reading the comments from coders to buyers and vice versa, in their online resumes. It seems to me that there was a word that was present in most of the comments: “Excellent Communication”, “Good Communication”, “Communication is superb.

It is clear that many people were evaluating someone by his/her communication skills. Being a hardcore coder for many years I always believed that he must be judged by the final outcome of the project. In RAC, he discovered that this is partially true. A great implementation of a project will make the buyer accept the project 100% but if the communication is poor during the development of the project, neither the buyer nor the coder would like to cooperate again. Good communication will ensure repeating work between the same buyer and coder.

He strongly believe that the secret of successful projects is “Communication” If the buyer and the coder can communicate well, the project is only a matter of time to finish. Communication doesn’t only mean that both parties have to speak the same language. It means more than that. It has to do with the wealth of information that is exchanged between them. Communication must be fluent, clear and enriched with meaningful information.

Many projects have failed to be completed and went to arbitration because the buyer and coder failed to communicate efficiently. Here is an example from my own personal experience. During the development of a project, the buyer was constantly sending me short, cryptic e-mails. I always had to reply back and clarify even minor details. Chatting with him online wasn't proved useful either.

He didn't really know what he wanted. Sometimes, when he replied to my long e-mails it was hard to read his replies because he didn't even use paragraphs to separate my text from his. When he finished the project, I got a 10 and a nice comment but only I, knew how hard it was to complete it. It was a nightmare. Most of my time on the project was spent trying to communicate with him. He estimated that I spent double the time that it was worth for this project. Do you think that this was an extreme example. Think again. It is very possible to happen to you if you fail to communicate.

Buyers must clearly specify their needs before they post a project. You don't have to be a system analyst in order to do this efficiently. Write as many details as you can and give examples. Coders are not magicians. They can't guess what you want. During the development, constantly comment on the work. Always check the various steps and make sure that you are moving into the correct direction. Praise the coder if he finishes a nice tricky part of the project. Most coders are take pride in their work. Reward them if they take the extra mile for you.

Coders must have patience. Buyers aren't always experts in technical terms. Don't use technical lingo to show off. It is better to explain things in simple words, one step at a time. In the long run this is going to save you time. If the buyer has a strong technical background about the project then you can use the appropriate terminology. During the development, keep a constant communication flow. Be sensitive about the buyers needs. Don't keep him in the dark about what you are doing. It is always a good idea to send daily short reports even for the smaller projects. This will assure that you are on the right track.

A successful project completion depends on many factors. "Communication" is the most important one. You can't go wrong if you make a lot of effort to communicate the best you can.

## **FORMS OF COMMUNICATION**

Effective communicators have many tools at their disposal when they want to get across a message. Whether writing or speaking, they know how to put together the words that will convey their meaning. They reinforce their words with gestures and actions. They look you in the eye, listen to what you have to say, and think about your feelings and needs. At the same time, they study your reactions, picking up the nuances of your response by watching your face and body, listening to your tone of voice, and evaluating your words. They absorb information just as efficiently as they transmit it, relying on both non-verbal and verbal cues.

## **NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION**

The most basic form of communication is non-verbal. Anthropologists theorize that long before human beings used words to talk things over, our ancestors communicated with one another by using their bodies. They gritted their teeth to show anger; they smiled and touched one another to indicate affection. Although we have come a long way since those primitive times, we still use non-verbal cues to express superiority, dependence, dislike, respect, love, and other feelings. Non-verbal communication differs from verbal communication in fundamental ways. For one thing, it is less structured, which makes it more difficult to study. A person cannot pick up a book on non-verbal language and master the vocabulary of gestures, expressions, and inflections that are common in our culture.

We don't really know how people learn non-verbal behaviour. No one teaches a baby to cry or smile, yet these forms of self-expression are almost universal. Other types of non-verbal communication, such as the meaning of colors and certain gestures, vary from culture to culture. Non-verbal communication also differs from verbal communication in terms of intent and spontaneity. We generally plan our words. When we say "please open the door," we have a conscious purpose. We think about the message, if only for a moment. But when we communicate non-verbally, we sometimes do so unconsciously. We don't mean to raise an eyebrow or blush. Those actions come naturally. Without our consent, our emotions are written all over our faces.

### **Functions of Non-Verbal Communication**

Although non-verbal communication can stand alone, it frequently works with speech. Our words carry part of the message, and non-verbal signals carry the rest. Together, the two modes of expression make a powerful team, augmenting, reinforcing, and clarifying each other.

Experts in non-verbal communication suggest that it have six specific functions:

- To provide information, either consciously or unconsciously
- To regulate the flow of conversation
- To express emotion
- To qualify, complement, contradict, or expand verbal messages
- To control or influence others
- To facilitate specific tasks, such as teaching a person to swing a golf club.

Non-verbal communication plays a role in business too. For one thing, it helps establish credibility and leadership potential. If you can learn to manage the impression you create with your body language, facial characteristics, voice, and appearance, you can do a great deal to communicate that you are competent, trustworthy, and dynamic. For example, Wal-Mart founder Sam Walton has developed a homespun style that puts people at ease, thereby helping them to be more receptive, perhaps even more open. Furthermore, if you can learn to read other people's non-verbal messages, you will be



able to interpret their underlying attitudes and intentions more accurately. When dealing with co-workers, customers, and clients, watch carefully for small signs that reveal how the conversation is going. If you aren't having the effect you want, check your words; then, if your words are all right, try to be aware of the non-verbal meanings you are transmitting. At the same time, stay tuned to the non-verbal signals that the other person is sending.

## **VERBAL COMMUNICATION**

Although you can express many things non-verbally, there are limits to what you can communicate without the help of language. If you want to discuss past events, ideas, or abstractions, you need words—symbols that stand for thoughts — arranged in meaningful patterns. In the English language, we have a 750,000, although most of us recognize only about 20,000 of them. To create a thought with these words, we arrange them according to the rules of grammar, putting the various parts of speech in the proper sequence. We then transmit the message in spoken or written form, hoping that someone will hear or read what we have to say. It shows how much time business people devote to the various types of verbal communication. They use speaking and writing to send messages; they use listening and reading to receive them.

## **PROCESS OF COMMUNICATION**

Communication is the process of sharing thoughts, ideas, and emotions with others, and having those thoughts, ideas, and emotions understood. You need a sender, a message, and a receiver for communication to take place. Here are some other things that help communication to be effective:

*Attention:* The sender needs to pay attention to what he/she is trying to communicate, and choose the best words and body language to communicate with; the receiver needs to pay attention to what is being communicated by listening and watching.

*Attitude:* Both sender and receiver need to have a positive (and respectful) attitude. They should want to communicate, and be willing to work to see that communication can take place. Using negative or blaming words shows a poor attitude - using "I" messages and trying to understand the other's point shows a good attitude.

*Feedback:* both sender and receiver can give feedback to each other, either by using words or by body language. This helps to show whether the communication is being understood correctly or not.

## **BARRIERS TO COMMUNICATION**

There are many things that can hinder or prevent good communication. Here are some of the most common barriers:

*Distraction:* It is hard to understand if you are distracted by something else. When you are trying to communicate, make sure there is no competition for your attention.

like exciting things going on nearby or other people talking (cellphones, IMs, chat rooms, e-mail, etc.)

*Blocks:* Sometimes it's hard to communicate simply because you cannot send or receive the message. Loud noises can block communication, and so can things like lost phone signals and computers not being able to interface.

*Poor Skills:* Some people have not learned how to effectively listen, and do not understand what you are trying to communicate.

*Attitude :* Communication can also be affected by a poor attitude towards the other person, towards the subject, or just because the sender or receiver is having a bad day. Fear and mistrust can impede communication, as can boredom or lack of interest in the subject. For best communication, try to keep the emotions out of the way until you understand what is being communicated.

*Poor Understanding:* Sometimes the sender uses words that the receiver does not understand, or refers to cultural experiences that the receiver has not grown up with, so that communication is less effective. Try to use simple words if you are communicating something complicated, and make sure that both of you understand the context or cultural references.

*Lack of Feedback :* If the receiver does not give feedback, the sender does not know if the communication is effective or not; also, if the sender is not paying attention to the feedback, the communication will not be effective.

The best way to insure good communication is for both the sender and the receiver to use "I" messages - instead of saying "You hurt my feelings," or "That's stupid," you let the other person know how you feel by saying things like "I feel hurt when \_\_\_\_ happens," or "I feel angry when I hear someone say \_\_\_\_." Pay attention to how your voice sounds when you speak, and try to avoid sounding angry or condescending to the other person. Avoid making hateful statements, insulting others, and complaining - instead, try to make helpful statements that can change the situation from negative to positive.

### **Dealing with Communication Barriers**

No matter how good and effective a communicator one maybe, yet the fact is that one does face certain barriers, from time to time, which forces them to work on becoming even more effective in their skills to communicate. Given here are the communication barriers that occur while listening, speaking and in the case of non-verbal communications...

#### ***Listening Barriers***

Interrupting the speaker

Not maintaining eye contact with the speaker

Rushing the speaker to complete what he/she has to say

- Making the speaker feel as though he/she is wasting the listener's time
- Being distracted by something that is not part of the on going communication
- Getting ahead of the speaker and completing his/her thoughts
- Ignoring the speaker's requests
- Topping the speaker's story with one's own set of examples
- Forgetting what is being discussed
- Asking too many questions, for they sake of probing

### **Barriers While Speaking**

- Unclear messages
- Lack of consistency in the communication process
- Incomplete sentences
- Not understanding the receiver
- Not seeking clarifications while communicating
- The other barriers include:

An individual's subjective viewpoint towards issues/people, which leads to assumptions.

An emotional block, which can lead to an attitude of indifference, suspicion or hostility towards the subject.

An emotional block or bias that is based on a third party's view point, or on what you have read/heard.

Words can have different meanings to different people, thus blocking communication.

Use of negative words

Well before the current world financial crisis struck, organizations have sought inventive ways to engage in face-to-face meetings without the need to travel. Companies have turned to services such as Adobe Acrobat Connect Pro, Cisco WebEx, Citrix Got Meeting, and Microsoft Live Meeting as a means for workers in multiple locations to share presentations and otherwise collaborate. No question, these tools greatly reduce costly, productivity-sapping travel, with the added benefit of lowering a company's carbon footprint. Yet scratchy audio quality, out-of-sync slides, and tiny, Webcam-quality video often diminish these solutions' usefulness.

### ***Prediction: Google Announces Twitter Acquisition***

Similarly, more traditional videoconferencing systems (which have been around for decades) suffer from low utilization rates — partially because of complicated, unreliable technology. The door has now opened for telepresence solutions: a conferencing environment that seeks to mimic the in-person experience as much as possible. Several technologies make telepresence possible. High-definition video cameras and large, flat-panel monitors clearly display participants in life size. Optimized networks — making use of QoS and even application-aware protocol acceleration — help eliminate audio

and video delay over long-distance and high-latency WANs. As such, participants can make eye contact with colleagues and immediately pick up on all-important visual cues — such as how someone reacts to an offer. Moreover, operating the systems can be as simple as using a television remote control or telephone.

### ***Something for Everyone***

In general, telepresence systems fall into three configurations. First, there are formal group setups, purpose-built rooms that accommodate four to eight participants. Here you'll find warm wall coverings, soft lighting, three or four wall-mounted monitors, and a conventional conference room seating arrangement. In use, it's as if remote participants are sitting across the table from you. Second, you'll find small-to-midrange setups, which comprise a single monitor and one camera, suited for handling one to four users. This option works well in executive offices, and some systems are mobile enough to be ferried among regular conference rooms. These less-costly systems work over existing networks, yet the picture and audio quality surpass that of early-generation videoconferencing solutions. None come with amenities such as plush suites, but they closely match expensive systems' picture quality and usability.

Finally, there are classroom-style rooms that can hold 30 participants or more. These facilities, which are used by corporate and educational institutions alike, usually have multiple monitors or video projectors.

### ***The Cost of Collaboration***

Even with falling hardware costs, a telepresence system doesn't come cheap. A group system at a single site that can accommodate 18 to 36 users can go for \$350,000. One reason for the expense is that you typically don't install telepresence systems in any old room. An immersive face-to-face environment requires special lighting, acoustics, and furniture, which all factor into the price. And that doesn't count in-house (or contracted) network and support costs. But before you despair, take a serious look at how much money you're spending on employee and executive travel among your various offices: airline tickets, food, accommodations, and the like. Factor in how much productivity is lost during travel, as well as how much time that travel can add to moving forward with a project or deal. In the end, you may find fast payback on your investment. For instance, Cisco representatives say that their customers often recover a telepresence investment in six to nine months, according to independent audits. Notably, there are ways to reduce telepresence costs, including equipment leases and renting time at conferencing facilities. If price is still a barrier, you could consider one of the lower-end, high-performance systems, which run for less than 10,000. Moreover, video chat applications are improving, too, though it's a real stretch to put them in the same category as fully developed videoconferencing solutions. Still, for little (or no) cost they let several people connect with very usable audio and visual quality.

## **FORMS OF BUSINESS COMMUNICATION**

Defining and having corporate objectives provides two major benefits. First, you will be more efficient because you will no longer waste time writing or presenting material unless you have a clear reason for doing so. Second, you will be more effective because formulating objectives precisely will help you communicate more clearly. The time needed to define the objectives will obviously vary: routine matters may take matter of seconds; more complex matters may take much longer.

The purpose of all business communication is to further corporate objectives of the company or the organization. Time at workplace is generally too short and valuable to waste on communications which do not achieve this goal.

### **TYPES OF BUSINESS COMMUNICATION**

#### **Communication in General**

Basically, the word communication refers to the exchange of information and ideas between two individuals or business organizations about their needs, aspirations, or perceptions, in words, action or symbols, provided the content must mean the same for the receiver and sender. Communications can be of a local or international flavour, in spoken or alternative modes, and depend on conformist or unconventional signals in non-linguistic or linguist forms.

#### **History of Communication**

Centuries ago, a phonetic alphabet form of communication existed among the ancient Greeks, followed by several books based on the principle of written communication; this was the cornerstone of the first library of the Greeks. Similarly, communication became a hassle in the old communist China, not only within the various branches of the exhaustive government, but also in the interaction between the Chinese people and the government, consequent to which China launched its postal services. However, after the advent of the printing press and paper, communication became much simpler. The principle of communication today still follows a blend of the age old traditions of written and oral forms.

#### **Business Communication**

In business, communication is a channel that helps in promoting a service, product or the organization, with the sole intention of closing a sale. Businesses use a variety of media for communication, including the radio, outdoor ads, television, the print, the Internet and even the spoken word by word of mouth. Advanced Communication skills have achieved an exalted status in business etiquette and interpersonal skills, and employees and managers in every organization hone their communication skills for a better mutual

understanding and engagement, not only for internal purposes, but for stakeholders outside as well. Providentially, the business environment offers a variety of communication modes for the senders and receivers of messages to satisfy their communication needs.

### **What is a Business Organization?**

An organization represents a people's group who share similar interests and goals. A bank would be an excellent example of this arrangement. You could also refer to it as a pact in society between individuals or groups that found activities and relationships on a social, religious political or commercial platform.

### **Why Business Communication is Important**

Some of the results of effective communication (both sender and receiver must understand the communication) are that it helps the companies to keep the company healthy, maximizes its profits, and not only keeps its employees engaged and in a happy disposition, but also helps them to sufficiently focus on their job for achieving the company's goals.

Communication is an organization's corner stone, and an organization would cease to exist without it. Its main functions are to exchange information and options, drawing up proposals, plans, and agreements, implementing decisions, forwarding orders or fulfilling them and in general, carry out sales. Organizational activity is the bloodstream of an organization, and all activities end when communication falters. There are two types of business communication in an organization, which come under "Vertical Communication"

### **Internal Communication**

All communication that has to do with internal matters and interaction between staff and employees in varied forms is called "Internal Communication." And it serves as an excellent medium to address all concerns of employees, thereby enhancing goodwill, job satisfaction, productivity and safety aspects. It also serves to increase turnover and profits.

### **Upward Communication**

This represents the information flow from lower down in the hierarchy to those in higher positions, thus preventing the organization to experience a vacuum in terms of not only the proper receipt of information, but also solutions to other problems that the company may face.. Undoubtedly, communication is a two-sided sword, but for it to work efficiently, information must originate at the bottom, and move upwards. The benefits of upward communication to the staff include the exchange of ideas and information, heightened staff enthusiasm, job satisfaction and the provision of feedback.

**Downward Communication**

The flow of information and instructions from the top levels of the organization to its lowest levels, detailing the mission and the policies, is normally referred to as downward communication. These may be in the form of specific instructions or guidelines to complete a full project. However, you must start establishing the procedure only after the upward communication has been successfully instituted. This information flow can be used to pass on important matters and instructions, announce decisions and promote mutual discussions, cooperation, and morale, enhance efficiency and obtain feedback.

**Horizontal/Lateral Communication**

When people with the same rank in the organization communicate with each other and collaborate in the search of a common goal, it is called horizontal communication. Assigned work is best completed when employees at the same level, cooperate. This kind of communication helps solve problems by enhanced teamwork, boosting efficiency, completing tasks and building goodwill.

**External Communication**

External communication refers to communication by company supervisors with agencies outside the company, for example, with customers and vendors. This kind of communication and useful interaction can lead to operational efficiency, market credibility, goodwill, corporate image, customer satisfaction, organizational goals, leading to performance, increased sales volumes, followed by a strong profit showing. Most of this external work is done by marketing departments who target markets in pursuit of a larger share of business and the purchase executives who are always sourcing better quality inputs at lower prices.

*Some of the other facets of communication are enumerated below:*

**Face-to-face Communication**

Still the oldest, but the most effective mode of communication is the face-to-face type that requires the physical presence of both parties involved, removing any vestiges of ambiguity and making absolutely 100 % certain that matters have been mutually understood. Once this is achieved, further discussions can be held at any time without inhibitions. You can also make your pitch in a manner that will directly convey your feelings, passion and commitments to an individual or at a group meeting. Most experts opine that this is the best form indeed to make an impression the vital points pertaining to your company your audience.

**Phones**

The phone is a more personal form of communication than the e-mail, and can add a personal touch to messages of complex nature that need the clarity of a phone call to



explain some intricacy involved that cannot be put into a message. Its great advantage is that you can reach people with clarity, all round the globe when you want to confirm your associate's accurate understanding of your message.

### **Written Form of Communication**

Several forms of communication including formal letters, posters, business memos, bulletin boards and other diverse forms of communication form part of the written form of communication. This is a good choice for those wanting to convey the same message in writing to several people at different locations. They can send also technical messages with images and charts to make it easy for the recipients to analyze and comprehend. Another advantage of a written message is its paper trail that necessitates the recipient to receive and acknowledge it. Such messages are also created for purposes of a record of corrections or for legal purposes.

### **ELECTRONIC FORM OF COMMUNICATION**

The continuous evolution of technology has had a profound effect on the way business communications are conducted these days, including web conferencing, e-mail, social networking, text messaging, chat and online organizational web sites. Most companies resort to electronic messaging to communicate quickly with multiple recipients outside like stakeholders who can include employees, creditors, shareholders, unions, suppliers and the community in general, at low cost. Different forms of electronic communication are used by organizations to communicate with or send messages not only to diverse demographic clusters, but also individuals and organizations in the international arena.

### **Communication by E-mail**

Today, e-mail takes precedence over most communication modes, for its predominantly cheap, fast and good features, giving it an edge over others in communication with the remotest parts of the globe, in a manner that both the sender and receiver find convenient. Though it may appear less personal than a face-to-face meeting or even a phone call, e-mail gives you the opportunity to send documents, pictures or videos at the flick of a mouse, with the same credibility as faxing it or delivering by hand. However, one must take utmost care to write the mail clearly to avoid ambiguity and misunderstanding between the sender and multiple recipients, which could forge a weak point in this mode of transmission.

### **Web Conferencing**

Web Seminars, Webcasts, general web conferencing and web meetings on a peer level are some of the activities that the Internet facilitates under a general umbrella of collaborative online services called web conferencing, especially on IP/TCP connections. Such a mode of communication permits one sender to send information to a cluster of



destination computers simultaneously (Multicast communication) using the IP multicast in the Internet layer or send communication on a real time point to point basis using an IP protocol with a serial interface for communication between two computers. Web conferencing applications can include lectures, training, presentations and the like between computers that are web connected.

## **SOCIAL NETWORKING SERVICES**

This is an ideal web based platform facilitating the sharing of social relations among likeminded people with similar interests. The participants in this platform create a public profile and a user list, share information and interact with each other on this social network, using the e-mail and instant messaging services like Facebook, Twitter, and mobile messaging like WhatsApp etc. Social networking sites are diversified and include facile tools for communication, like mobile connectivity, blogging and video/photo sharing.

### **Text Messaging**

Sending concise electronic messages from one mobile phone to another or using a portable device connected to a phone networking system is usually referred to as texting or text messaging. The original SMS or the short message service has now evolved into the MMS or the messages that contain sound, video and images. The one who sends a message is called a Texter. This service is called Text in North America, SMS, in Europe and MMS in Asia, Africa and the Middle East. You can also interact with automated systems or for participate in competitions using text messages. Direct text messaging is also useful to Service providers to send out information about bill payment, offers and the like.

### **An Online Web site**

An online web site is a set of web pages served by a single web domain. Most people get hosting from a minimum of one web server that you access through the Internet or a private local area network using an address of the Internet called the URL or the Uniform Resource Locator. In other words, the term, “World Wide Web” refers to all public web sites as a whole. Web pages, or, in other words, its building blocks represent plain text documents with formatting instructions using the XHTML or HTML languages, and you can access them using the highly encrypted HTTP Secure or the HTTP, also known as the Hypertext Transfer Protocol

### **Online Chats**

A real time text message sent over the Internet as short text messages, quickly responded to by the recipient, is another form of electronic mode of communication called Online Chat. This form of communication alludes to. A spoken conversation, except that it is through the computer. You must understand that this communication

must not be confused with online text based communication forms like the e-mail and forums. Both point-to-point and multicast communications are served by online Chat, which can also be useful in web conferencing.

Online Chat Rooms are a form of synchronous or asynchronous conferencing, which can allude to online interaction and real time online chats on online forums with total strangers as well as with challenging social environments (Graphic) People use a chat room primarily for sharing text information with other user groups, unlike the instant messaging mode that mostly facilitates only a one to one interaction. Chat rooms facilitate interaction on a diverse range of subjects and share use of new advanced technological evolution for using webcam and file sharing.

## **NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION IN BUSINESS**

### **KEY ELEMENTS**

That can make or break your attempt at successful non-verbal business communication:

- Eye contact
- Gestures
- Movement
- Posture
- Written communication

Let's examine each non-verbal element in turn to see how we can maximise your potential to communicate effectively...

### **Eye Contact**

Good eye contact helps your audience develop trust in you, thereby helping you and your message appear credible. Poor eye contact does exactly the opposite.

### ***Good Eye Contact***

So it is a wise business communicator that makes a point of attempting to engage every member of the audience by looking at them.

Now, this is of course easy if the audience is just a handful of people, but in an auditorium it can be a much harder task. So balance your time between these three areas:

- Slowly scanning the entire audience,
- Focusing on particular areas of your audience (perhaps looking at the wall between two heads if you are still intimidated by public speaking), and
- Looking at individual members of the audience for about five seconds per person. Looking at individual members of a large group can be 'tricky' to get right at first.

Equally, it can be a fine balancing act if your audience comprises of just one or two members—spend too much time looking them in the eyes and they will feel intimidated, stared at, ‘hunted down. So here’s a useful tip: break your eye-to-eye contact down to four or five second chunks.

That is, look at the other person in blocks that last four to five seconds, then look away. That way they won’t feel intimidated.

Practice this timing yourself, away from others. Just look at a spot on the wall, count to five, then look away. With practice you will be able to develop a ‘feel’ for how long you have been looking into your audience member’s eyes and intuitively know when to look away and focus on another person or object.

When focusing on individual members in a large meeting or auditorium, try and geographically spread your attention throughout the room. That is, don’t just focus your personal gaze (as distinct from when you are scanning the room or looking at sections of the room) on selected individuals from just one part of the room. Unless you are specifically looking to interact with a particular person at that moment of your presentation, select your individual eye-contact audience members from the whole room.

## **Gestures**

Most of us, when talking with our friends, use our hands and face to help us describe an event or object—powerful non-verbal aids.

We wave our arms about, turn our hands this way and that, roll our eyes, raise our eyebrows, and smile or frown.

Yet many of us also, when presenting to others in a more formal setting, ‘clam up’.

Our audience of friends is no different from our business audience—they*all* rely on our face and hands (and sometimes legs, feet and other parts of us!) to ‘see’ the bigger, fuller picture. It is totally understandable that our nervousness can cause us to ‘freeze up’, but it is in our and our communication’s best interests if we manage that nervousness, manage our fear of public speaking, and use our body to help emphasise our point.

## **Movement**

Ever watch great presenters in action—men and women who are alone on the stage yet make us laugh, cry and be swept along by their words and enthusiasm?

Watch them carefully and you’ll note that they don’t stand rigidly in one spot. No, they bounce and run and stroll and glide all around the stage.

### ***Why do they do that?***

Because they know that we human beings, men in particular, are drawn to movement.

As part of man’s genetic heritage we are programmed to pay attention to movement. We instantly notice it, whether we want to or not, assessing the movement for any hint of a threat to us.

This, of course, helps explain why many men are drawn to the TV and seem transfixed by it. It also helps explain why men in particular are almost ‘glued’ to the TV was rapidly able to learn how to ‘free up my body’ when presenting to others. when there is any sport on. All that movement!

But to get back to the stage and you on it... ensure that any movement you make is meaningful and not just nervous fidgeting, like rocking back and forth on your heels or moving two steps forward and back, or side to side.

This is ‘nervous movement’ and your nervousness will transmit itself to your audience, significantly diluting the potency of your communication and message. So move about the stage when you can—not just to keep the men in the audience happy, but to help emphasize your message!

## **Posture**

There are two kinds of ‘posture’ and it is the wise communicator that manages and utilizes both.

### ***Posture 1***

The first type of ‘posture’ is the one we think of intuitively—the straight back versus the slumped shoulders; the feet-apart confident stance versus the feet together, hand-wringing of the nervous; the head up and smiling versus the head down and frowning.

And every one of the positions we place the various elements of our body in tells a story—a powerful, non-verbal story.

For example, stand upright, shoulders straight, head up and eyes facing the front. Wear a big smile. Notice how you ‘feel’ emotionally.

Now—slump your shoulders, look at the floor and slightly shuffle your feet. Again, take a note of your emotional state.

### ***Notice the Difference?***

Your audience surely will, and react to you and your message accordingly. A strong, upright, positive body posture not only helps you breath easier (good for helping to calm nerves!) but also transmits a message of authority, confidence, trust and power. If you find yourself challenged to maintain such a posture, practice in front of a mirror, or better yet join a speaking club like Toastmasters International.

### ***Posture 2***

The second type of ‘posture’ comes from your internal mental and emotional states.

You can have great body posture but without internal mental and emotional posture your words will sound hollow to your audience.

For example, the used car salesman at ‘Dodgy Brothers Motors’ might have great body posture and greet you with a firm handshake, a steady gaze and a friendly smile.

But if in his heart he is seeing you as just another sucker then sooner or later his internal conflict between what he says and what he really thinks will cause him to ‘trip up’.

His body will start betraying his real, underlying intentions and you’ll start to feel uncomfortable around him, even if you can’t figure out why. But, if that same used car salesman had a genuine desire to help you find the right car for you, and he puts your needs before his own, then his words and actions will remain congruent (in harmony) with his underlying intentions and you will trust him, even though you might not be able to identify why.

I have seen some supposed ‘self help’ gurus who don’t actually practice what they preach. Consequently their words ring hollow to me and their books, CDs, DVDs and training materials remain uppercased.

I have met salesmen and women who don’t actually make the money they claim to make in their ‘fabulous business opportunity’, and while their words are practiced and polished, and their body posture is ‘perfect’, their words ooze like honeyed poison from their lips and I remain unconvinced.

This second type of ‘posture’ is fundamentally tied to truth and honesty. It is about ‘walking the talk’ and being who you say you are.

It’s about not trying to sell something you don’t believe in or use yourself. It’s about not trying to pass yourself off as an expert when all you’ve ever done is read a book on the subject.

It’s all about making sure that your words and your intentions are underpinned by truth and honesty. Because all of us, no matter how polished a presenter we might be, are at the mercy of our body and its ability to ‘tell the truth’ in spite of what our lips might utter.

### **Written Communication**

I could spend a lifetime writing about the art of written communication. From persuasive memos to complaint letters, sales letters to executive summaries—these exceedingly useful guides help you to write clearly and in an appropriate format, style and tone. Each book has numerous examples that show how to overcome writer’s block, organize messages for maximum impact, achieve an easy-to-read style, find an efficient writing system and much more.

## Discipline of Communication Skills

The meaning of the word “communication” is at once both clear and obscure. It is clear enough in conventional usage, but obscure when we seek to determine the limits of its application. To illustrate, if someone talks to another and common understanding results (indicated by mutually satisfactory action), we have no qualms about saying that communication has occurred.

If, however, misunderstanding results (indicated by mutually unsatisfactory action), we are uncertain whether we should say that there has been poor, or no, communication. Further, if someone does not talk to another and the latter as a result gains certain impressions of the former, has communication occurred? Would it make any difference whether the first person deliberately did not talk or unintentionally failed to talk? If someone eavesdrops on a conversation, is he receiving communication? If from the antics of my neighbour’s children or from the condition of his house I draw certain conclusions about him, has there been a communication? If classify a group of objects before me, say, several pieces of lumber, on the basis of certain characteristics, is there communication?

*The problem is familiar:* It seems impossible to draw a line between those situations that we conventionally term “communication” and those we do not, short of a purely arbitrary distinction. And the many and varied definitions of “communication” appearing in the literature of various fields of study often appear, at first glance at least, to compound the difficulty. We who are teaching speech must be concerned about defining communication. Certainly our concept of this process determines to no small degree our approach to speech training, how broadly or narrowly we view our subject, how we

relate it to other areas of study. To put the problem of defining “communication” in clearer perspective, thus assisting in the selection of a more consistent and pedagogically helpful concept of communication.

To accomplish, shall present a number of definitions of “communication” in a twofold classification and examine the application of these definitions to a series of situations in which human responses and interactions occur. Such classification and application should give us some insights into the problem of definition, into the relationship among existing definitions, and provide us with the perspective necessary to select the most basic, consistent, and useful definition of “communication,” and to see its relationship to the process of speech.

Definitions of “communication” fall into two broad categories. In one category are those definitions which limit the process of communication to those stimulus-response situations in which one deliberately transmits stimuli to evoke response. In the other category are those definitions that include within the area of communication stimulus-response situations in which there need not be any intention of evoking response in the transmission of the stimuli. The second category obviously overlaps the first.

The definitions have grouped into these two categories. In the first group there is no particular sequence; I include the various definitions to provide a broad view of the definitions in this category. In the second group I present the definitions roughly in the order of their inclusiveness. Our everyday usage of the word “communication” fits in here. Standard dictionary definitions reflect it. “Communicate” is defined as “To impart, bestow, or convey.

To make known; give by way of information. To have intercourse, or to be the means of intercourse; to hold or afford communication; to converse.” “Communication” is defined as “The act or fact of communicating. Intercourse by words, letters or messages; interchange of thoughts or opinions, by conference or other means; converse; correspondence.”

Wilbur Schramm gives what he terms the classical statement of the communication process as “. *A communicates B through channel C to D with effect E.* Each of these letters is to some extent an unknown, and the process can be solved for any one of them or any combination. ” Similarly, Carl Hovland states that communication is “... the process by which an individual (the communicator) transmits stimuli (usually verbal symbols) to modify the behaviour of other individuals (communicatees).” Elaborating the process of communication more fully, Mapheus Smith states, Communication behaviour in its simplest reciprocal form is the use of some action by one person, whether or not accompanied by a material object, as a stimulus to another person in such a way that the second person can perceive the experience of the stimulating person. The overt action of the first person plays the role of a symbol whose reference or meaning is the same for the two participants, with the result that common experience is perceived by both participants.

Smith uses the term “communicative behaviour” because it focuses attention on the process of interbehaviour. Two other definitions are interesting additions to this category for the distinctions they draw between communication as interaction and other forms of interaction.

*Charles Morris writes:* The term communication, when widely used, covers any instance of the establishment of a commonage, that is, the making common of some property to a number of things. In this sense a radiator “communicates” its heat to surrounding bodies, and whatever medium serves this process of making common is a means of communication (the air, a road, a telegraph system, a language). For our purposes “*communication*” will be limited to the use of signs to establish a commonage of signification; the establishment of a commonage other than that of signification—whether by signs or other means—will be called *communization*.

Thus, as Morris points out, the anger of one person may make another person angry, and signs may not have established the commonage.

This sort of situation he calls “communization.” On the other hand, someone may signify anger, and, without becoming angry himself cause someone else to signify anger. An incident of this type he calls “communication.”

*George Lundberg puts his definition this way:* We shall use the word communication, then, to designate interaction by means of signs and symbols. The symbols may be gestural, pictorial, plastic, verbal, or any other which operate as stimuli to behaviour which would not be evoked by the symbol itself in the absence of special conditionings of the person who responds. Communication is, therefore, a subcategory under interaction, namely, the form of interaction which takes place through symbols.

Lundberg adds that this definition is subject to certain qualifications. It is important to distinguish between “... *communication* and mere *contact*, or *interaction* whether on the verbal level or otherwise.” “True societal communication consists of temporarily identifying oneself symbolically with the other as regards the particular situation involved in the communication.” True communication, he says, is the kind of interaction through signs and symbols that leads to tension reduction or understanding. Similar interaction that leads to increasing tension is also communication, but of a different degree. It involves a different degree of symbolic identification.

In the last two definitions above there is recognition of processes or areas of behaviour very closely related to communication—the “communization” of Morris and the “interaction without the use of signs and symbols” of Lundberg—but which, however, they carefully mark off from what is strictly called “communication.” The excluded areas of behaviour, in the present classification, would be included among the definitions in category two. In this group are the definitions that include as communication situations those situations in which there is no intentional transmission of stimuli to evoke response.

Two concepts of communication in this category are suggestive of the Morris and Lundberg definitions, but instead of excluding the closely related areas of behaviour



they include them as special kinds of communication. Edward Sapir, in defining communication, wrote of “explicit” and “implicit” communication. The former is communication in the conventional sense, the use of language to establish common understanding among people (a Category One definition); the latter is the “intuitive interpretation” of the “relatively unconscious symbolisms of gesture, and the unconscious assimilation of the ideas and behaviour of one’s culture”.

Baker Brownell used the terms “direct” and “indirect” communication. The latter is a “... process wherein something converted into symbols is carried over from one person to another.” This is conventional usage (Category One again). The former, direct communication, is a function of the “... identification of people with one another.” This is communication without a symbolic medium; it is an identification of experience.

Theodore Newcomb states that when someone gains certain impressions of someone else the latter is communicating something to the former. To use his example, the man who allows junk to accumulate in his front yard communicates something to his neighbour whether he knows it or not. An almost identical point of view is that of Jurgen Ruesch, who states that “... as used in our sense the concept of communication would include all those processes by which people influence one another.” And in slightly different wording, Henry Lindgren expresses it, “Communication, viewed psychologically, is a process which is concerned with all situations involving meaning.” Several years earlier Charles H. Cooley had foreshadowed this broad concept of communication:

By communication is here meant the mechanism through which human relations exist and develop—all the symbols of the mind, together with the means of conveying them through space and preserving them in time. There is no sharp line between the means of communication and the rest of the external world. In a sense all objects and actions are symbols of the mind, and nearly anything may be used as a sign.

Some writers conceive of the term “communication” broadly enough to include non-human interactions. S. S. Stevens, for instance, gives what he describes as a “... broad, operational, and behaviouristic” definition of communication.

*He states:* Communication is the discriminatory response of an organism to a stimulus. This definition says that communication occurs when some environmental disturbance (the stimulus) impinges on an organism and the organism does something about it (makes a discriminatory response). If the stimulus is ignored by the organism, there has been no communication.

The test is differential reaction of some sort. The message that gets no response is not a communication. Stevens adds that his definition includes the clucking of a mother hen that brings her chicks, as well as a treatise on the information theory of communication. In Warren Weaver’s definition the ultimate step is taken, to include the interaction of machines:

The word *communication* will be used here in a very broad sense to include all of the procedures by which one mind may affect another. In some connection it may be desirable to use a still broader definition of communication, namely, one which would include the procedures by means of which one mechanism (say automatic equipment to track an airplane and to compute its probable future positions) affects another mechanism (say a guided missile chasing this airplane).

With the above classification of definitions in mind, let us turn to an application of these definitions. Let us picture an office in which several men are working at their desks. At midmorning the boss emerges from his private office and briefly talks with an employee. Let us assume that he gives the employee instructions to prepare a report, which the latter does, to the complete satisfaction of the boss. We can, without quibbling, say that in this case communication between the employer and the employee has occurred.

We can also say that in this case communication has been successful. If the report had not been correct in every detail, because of some misunderstanding of the instructions, we would still say that communication had occurred, though not so successfully. Now suppose the boss had stepped into the room, briefly looked around, and then returned to his office without having said a word or made a gesture designed to evoke a response. It seems reasonable to suppose that some of the employees would nevertheless respond. They might have wondered, for instance, if the employer were checking to see that everyone was busy.

It seems apparent, moreover, that the responses of the employees might have been the same whether the boss had in fact been observing their work or not thinking about them at all. And yet again, if the employees had expected the boss to appear and had he not done so, his non-appearance would undoubtedly have evoked certain responses. Let us imagine, to carry the hypothetical incident further, that one of the employees is working on a large chart. His desk is inconveniently small for his work; lack of space reduces his efficiency and makes his job appreciably more difficult.

The employee might respond by feeling frustrated and angry. He might further begin to consider his small desk a threat to his prestige, and an indication of the small value the company places on his services. Still another employee might be finding his chair uncomfortable, and besides squirming around for an optimum adjustment to it, could well be thinking that the boss feels little concern for the welfare and dignity of his employees.

These commonplace office situations, a moment's reflection will show, correspond to most, if not all, of the communication situations. There was transmission of stimuli to evoke response; there was an interchange of ideas; the use of signs established a commonage of signification; people interacted through the use of signs and symbols; and impressions of certain people—intended or unintended—were evoked in the minds of others.

These doubtless were, in Sapir's terms, intuitive interpretations of gesture and unconscious assimilation of office culture. Also there may have been direct communication in Brownell's sense of the identification of people with one another, which perhaps could be illustrated by the common feelings towards the company. All were situations involving meaning. Moreover, we could class all as discriminatory responses to environmental stimuli. If we apply our definitions by categories, we find that in terms of the definitions in Category One, only the first of the office situations described has the characteristics of a communication situation, that is, the one in which the boss instructed an employee to make a report. In none of the others was there a deliberate use of signs or symbols to influence behaviour.

All of these situations could, however, with the addition of the element of purpose, involve communication in the sense of Category One. Had the boss when he made his wordless appearance done so intentionally to evoke response, or had he intentionally not appeared when he knew his employees expected him to (the absence of a stimulus object in a certain context can be as meaningful as its presence), the definitions would apply. If the too-small desk and the inadequate chair had been purposely given to the men in question (to let them know, for instance, that they were not so important as they might have felt themselves to be) these would have been communication situations in terms of definitions in Category One.

If we apply Category Two definitions, on the other hand, we find that all the office situations described involve communication. The definitions of Newcomb, Ruesch, Cooley, Lindgren, Stevens, and Weaver would quite plainly make of each of the office incidents a communication situation. The "split" definitions of Sapir and Brownell are more difficult to apply, but it seems apparent that their "implicit" and "explicit" concepts would include those situations that had meaning for the individuals involved although they were not intentionally structured to have such meaning. The relationships among them, and their relationships to the situations described? In the first place, the classification itself gives us a perspective on the problem of defining "communication" by revealing various attempts to conceptualize the process. The classification reveals attempts to delineate certain types of interaction as communication to the exclusion of other types; it reveals attempts to include as a special kind of communication certain interactional behaviour that does not fit the conventional concept of communication, and further, a disregard of such distinctions and the inclusion of all forms of human interaction, direct or indirect, as communication.

And still further, it reveals definitions so broad that certain animal responses, and even mechanical interactions, fall into the category of communication. Secondly, the importance and value of viewing communication as response become apparent. It is evident from the classification and application of the definitions that in the first category the concept of the process of communication is from the point of view of the transmitter of stimuli, and in the second category, from the point of view of the person responding.

Looking at the process of communication from the transmitter's point of view provides the most obvious method of delimiting the area of behaviour to be treated as communication, and consequently simplifies the problem of definition. If someone is transmitting stimuli for the purpose of evoking response there is communication; otherwise there is none. This is certainly one basis for definition, but it leaves a large area of behaviour—often indistinguishable from “communication” by the responder or an observer—inadequately related to it, and in a sense unaccounted for. Only the transmitter can know whether or not he is transmitting stimuli for the purpose of influencing the behaviour of others. When the process of communication is viewed from the perspective of the person responding, the above problem of what to do with the closely related behaviour no longer exists. There seems to be no significant difference in the process of response whether or not it is to deliberately transmitted stimuli, and therefore no reason to classify the responses on this basis.

To use the office examples again, in the non-verbal situations, if the responders had known whether or not the situations were intentionally structured, it might have made a difference in the behaviour elicited, but this difference would have been the result of their having perceived the stimulus pattern differently. Had they assumed intentional structure, then whether or not there was in fact intentional structure would have made no difference to their response. There may appear to be a problem in viewing communication from the point of view of the responder when we proceed from people's influencing each other through words, actions, or man-made artifacts as communication to including as communication the individual's response to some object in the natural environment that human effort has in no way structured.

Take, for instance, someone's responses to the moon. Yet, here again, apart from the very basic response of awareness, his reactions, intellectual and emotional, and the meanings he “sees” in the moon are a function of the influence of other minds; he is interacting, though indirectly, with other people. Thirdly, we are able to select a basic and useful definition of “communication.” The logical end result of accepting any of the definitions in Category Two is the acceptance of the broadest of the definitions, that of Stevens, which includes all instances of discriminatory response to environmental stimuli as communication (disregarding, of course, mechanical interaction as communication). As a basic definition this is the most satisfactory. It is inclusive of the other definitions, and it provides a perspective that permits us to see the relationships between the many other proposed definitions of communication.

Viewed from the perspective of this definition, the other definitions differ from each other on the basis of the range of response-evoking stimuli included in the communication situation. By the same token, this definition permits us systematically to delineate areas of communicative behaviour for purposes of study, while keeping these limited areas of behaviour in a consistent relationship to the total area of communicative behaviour of which they are a functionally inseparable part. We can delineate these areas for study

by delimiting the range of response-evoking stimuli that is to be included in a given communication situation. Thus we might include as communication only those responses to words, objects, or actions deliberately structured to evoke response in a given situation. We might include only responses to written words designed to “communicate” at a particular time. We might include only spoken words and bodily actions, or only spoken words, or spoken words in a face-to-face situation, depending upon what aspect of the human interaction we happen to be primarily interested in.

There can, of course, be no sharp line of demarcation between the responses defined as communicative and those that are not. There is, as Cooley stated, no sharp line between the means of communication and the rest of the external world. Moreover, delimiting the communication situation by limiting the range of response-evoking stimuli included does not cancel the effects of other stimuli.

The individual is constantly making differential responses to a wide range of stimulus patterns, environmental and internal, responses which are often inextricably intermingled with the responses to the stimuli that would be, by definition in a given case, included within the area of communicative behaviour. The process of limitation suggested here, however, makes possible a systematic approach to the problem of limited definition, and makes us more clearly aware of what we are including and excluding for purposes of study and how these parts are related to each other.

The broad, basic definition adopted here points to the basic nature of communicative behaviour. While it may often serve our purpose to consider as communication situations only those in which people are responding to verbal stimuli, or rather, to consider primarily their responses to verbal stimuli, we must recognize the integral relationship between such responses and responses to other stimuli.

The problem of defining “communication” is not unlike that of defining “education.” In a sense, all learning experiences are educational (perhaps all experiences beyond reflex action), but to make learning more rapid and profitable we set up certain conditions of learning and in general limit the term “education” to an application to learning under such conditions.

But to see what is conventionally termed “education” in the proper perspective we must see it in relationship to the vast number of other experiences of which it is a functionally inseparable part. And so, too, must we see communication, particularly that process of communication we call speech.

## **EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION SKILL**

“Identification is one of the key ingredients of effective communication. In fact, unless your listeners can identify with what you are saying and with the way you are saying it, they are not likely to receive and understand your message.” The quote above is the underlying factor that explains the importance of communication skills. In fact,

there are other such quotes, which are as follows that explains the importance of effective communications skills: Good communication is as stimulating as black coffee, and just as hard to sleep after. the newest computer can merely compound, at speed, the oldest problem in the relations between human beings, and in the end the communicator will be confronted with the old problem, of what to say and how to say it.

The colossal misunderstanding of our times is the assumption that insight will work with people who are unmotivated to change. Communication does not depend on syntax, or eloquence, or rhetoric, or articulation; but on the emotional context in which the message is being heard.

People can only hear you when they are moving towards you, and they are not likely to when your words are pursuing them. Even the choicest words lose their power when they are used to overpower. Attitudes are the real figures of speech. When people talk, listen completely. Most people never listen. The problem with communication... is the illusion that is has been accomplished. The right to be heard does not automatically include the right to be taken seriously. Argument is the worst sort of communication.

## **BARRIERS OF COMMUNICATION**

This is in fact the first and foremost primary step to being good communicator. Given here are some of the barriers that occur in communicating effectively. Understanding these barriers will help one comprehend examples of communicating skills. After all breaking down barriers implies setting good examples...

### **THE VERBAL BARRIERS ARE**

- Attacking
- Interrogating
- Criticizing
- Blaming
- Shaming

### **You Messages**

- Moralizing
- Preaching
- Advising
- Diagnosing
- Endorsing Power
- Ordering
- Threatening
- Commanding
- Directing

**Shouting**

- Name-calling
- Refusing to talk

**The Non-verbal Barriers are**

- Flashing eyes
- Rolling eyes
- Quick movements
- Slow movements
- Arms crossed
- Legs crossed

**Gestures out of Exasperation**

- Slouching
- Hunching
- Lack of personal hygiene
- Doodling
- Avoiding eye contact
- Staring at people
- Over fidgeting

**GROWTH OF SKILLS**

The analytical report assignment described in this chapter develops and integrates the following skills: oral communicating, interviewing, writing, presenting, listening, interpersonal communicating, and working in teams. Through the professional development topics chosen for the report, students research specific professional skills graduates need when beginning their careers and gain knowledge of the soft skills through content.

Additionally, the project requires technical skills to incorporate software applications including word processing, spreadsheets for graphics, presentation design, and Internet usage for gathering secondary data and information about the companies where executives who will be interviewed work.

*Specifically, through the analytical report, students will complete the following tasks:*

- Identify and articulate the problem statement.
- Use the report-writing process to collect, analyse, interpret, and report data.
- Function effectively as a team member.
- Appraise the performance of a peer.
- Construct an effective questionnaire.
- Write a cover letter for a questionnaire.
- Schedule an on-site interview with a business executive.



- Interview a business executive.
- Follow up an interview.
- Share, compile, edit, and tabulate data.
- Use analytical thinking to discuss and present conclusions and recommendations.
- Prepare an effective oral presentation.
- Critically evaluate the oral presentations of peers.
- Present an effective team presentation to a business executive.
- Use computer technology (PowerPoint) to incorporate visuals in the oral presentation.
- Write a formal report.

### **Implementing the Assignment**

The analytical report assignment was created six years ago for Managerial Report Writing, a junior/senior level writing course required for all business majors enrolled at Eastern Kentucky University. The intent of the report was to integrate and develop the skills mentioned above and to introduce students to professional skills they will need in the workplace. To date, approximately 1,400 students have completed the assignment.

Careful planning and instruction are necessary to implement this comprehensive project so that students, professors, and business executives are aware of the participants' expectations. Perhaps one of the most important phases of the project is the actual assignment of the project. A memorandum authorizing the assignment is an effective way to include specific instructions for the report in a realistic format. The memo helps students understand the assignment and remain focused as the assignment progresses.

### **ASSIGNMENT TOPICS**

Students must select one of several approved topics addressing a professional skill needed by college graduates beginning their careers. These professional-skills topics should apply to all disciplines.

*Suggestions for topics might include:*

- Team Building
- Ethics
- Conflict Resolution
- Time Management
- Impact of Diversity
- Leadership Skills
- Conducting Meetings
- Goal Setting
- Managing Change
- Global Communication
- Checklists for implementation



To integrate the multiple skills students need to display throughout a semester-long project, we provide many checklists.

- **Assignment Checklist.** The checklist provides written documentation of assignment details for both students and instructors. The assignment checklist also underlies the project-evaluation checklist.
- **Specific Tasks Checklists.** As part of the assignment, students compose a questionnaire, interview two executives each using their questionnaire as the research instrument, and follow up the interview with a thank-you letter.
- **Evaluation Checklists.** When the data have been collected and analysed, students write a long, formal report including an executive summary and give an oral presentation to visiting corporate executives. Checklists are used to evaluate each part of the final project. Visiting executives complete an open-ended form for each student and collectively for the team's oral presentation.

## PROJECT OUTCOMES

Throughout the past six-year period, the analytical report assignment has been an effective way to integrate and develop communication, professional development, and technical skills in the report-writing classroom.

*Specifically, faculty's assessment and students' self evaluations indicate that the project provides the following benefits:*

- Knowledge is gained regarding professional skills and the expectations of the workplace that goes beyond the traditional coverage of these topics in a report-writing classroom.
- Content, knowledge of professional skills is strengthened through listening to and evaluating other students' oral presentations.
- Team skills are developed.
- Time management skills and self-discipline are practiced through the length and complexity of the project.
- Students experience a sense of accomplishment through completing a challenging, multi-task project.
- Students gain confidence through their experiences of scheduling interviews and talking with executives.
- Students begin professional networking for their future careers.

Although the project is revised as new ideas emerge, the basic design has survived the test of time and has added a new dimension to students' professional development and career preparation. Executives who visit the classroom are favourably impressed with the content of the oral presentations through primary research and the delivery of the presentations using PowerPoint slides. Through the interviews with executives, students have gained valuable information and resources for potential employment opportunities. While a considerable amount of time must be spent to develop, implement,

and evaluate this project, the results merit the expenditures. More recently, the last two decades have marked a period in which a series of reports from government, industry, and academia has called into question the state of engineering education and paved the way for including the professional skills as learning outcomes.

In 1985, the National Research Council's Engineering Education and Practice in the United States: Foundation of our Techno-Economic Future called on universities to make faculty careers more attractive in order to fill vacancies.

This was followed by the NSF-supported Belmont Conference. Smerdon credits this conference with leading to the creation of the National Science Foundation's (NSF) undergraduate engineering education coalitions initiative, probably the one NSF programme that has had the greatest impact on engineering education to date. Starting in the early 1990s, a series of reports emerged that recognized serious deficiencies in engineering education and called for major reforms. The ASEE's Engineering Education for A Changing World proclaimed that "engineering education programmes must not only teach the fundamentals of engineering theory, experimentation, and practice, but be relevant, attractive, and connected," preparing students for a broad range of careers and lifelong learning. It stated that engineering education must provide the "technical knowledge and capabilities, flexibility, and an understanding of the societal context of engineering". The NSF's complementary report, Restructuring Engineering Education: A Focus on Change, stressed similar themes. Among its recommendations is that engineering education should become flexible enough to support diverse career aspirations and engineering courses that would include a broad range of concerns: environmental, political and social issues; international, and historical contexts; and legal and ethical ramifications.

The National Research Council's Board of Engineering Education also recommended a number of actions for curriculum reform "including early exposure to 'real' engineering and more extensive exposure to interdisciplinary, hands-on, industrial practice aspects, team work, systems thinking, and creative design". Three leading educators, Bordogna, Fromm, and Ernst, called for educators to "create an intellectual environment where students can develop an awareness of the impact of emerging technologies, an appreciation of engineering as an integral process of societal change, and an acceptance of responsibility for civilization's progress".

At the 1992 Engineering Foundation Conference on "Engineering Education: Curriculum Innovation and Integration," Pister proposed reformulating the goals of engineering education as developing technical competence, understanding the practice of engineering as a social enterprise, acquiring clinical experience in practice, preparing for management and leadership roles in society, and building a foundation for lifelong learning. To Pister, examining the trade-offs among these objectives and selecting the appropriate weighting in a particular curriculum would present one of the more difficult challenges for faculty. As noted, the Belmont Conference's call to revitalize engineering

education led the NSF to create its Engineering Education Coalitions programme, a bold initiative aimed at “revolutionizing” education. In all, eight coalitions involving more than sixty schools were funded. Collectively, they produced (and are still producing) a large quantity of curricula innovations, a substantial number of which are archived in the proceedings of both the annual ASEE national meetings and the annual Frontiers in Education Conferences.

In addition, the NSF’s Division of Undergraduate Education has funded a series of “Course, Curriculum, and Laboratory Improvement” (CCLI) projects, many of which are directed at improving engineering education. The NSF also funded a series of “Action Agenda” projects aimed at implementing and expanding many of the coalitions’ innovations. Concomitantly, a group of leading engineering deans and educators, realizing that the current ABET engineering criteria were stifling innovation, began the process with strong input from industry that in 1996 led to EC2000. Of note was the Accreditation Process Review Committee, chaired by John Prados (1991-92 ABET president), which condensed a large number of issues into a four-page report that stated “the current criteria are too long and by their very nature, encourage a rigid, bean-counting approach that stifles innovation, even though the Engineering Accreditation Committee sincerely tries to avoid this”.

In commenting on the newly adopted criteria, Prados noted that the major drivers had included a shift from defence to commercial competition with a resultant impact on engineering employment, the exploding information technology growth, corporate downsizing, outsourcing of engineering services, and the globalization of both manufacturing and service delivery. Employers were now emphasizing that success as an engineer required more than simply strong technical capabilities; also needed were skills in communication and persuasion, the ability to lead and work effectively as a team member, and an understanding of the non-technical forces that affected engineering decisions. To do this would require a new engineering education paradigm built around active, project-based learning, horizontal and vertical integration of subject matter, the introduction of mathematical and scientific concepts in the context of application, close interaction with industry, broad use of information technology, and a faculty devoted to developing emerging professionals as mentors and coaches rather than all-knowing dispensers of information. Not surprisingly, these new criteria were consistent with the collective recommendations of the reports that preceded it.

### **Professional Skills Are Particularly Important**

After ten years, these same drivers-rapidly changing technology, particularly information technology, corporate downsizing, outsourcing, and globalization-that provided the impetus for the professional skills are, if anything, even more critical today. This is especially true as industry views an increasingly larger portion of the science and engineering labour pool more like a commodity than a profession.

Consequently, a growing number of less developed countries, with lower wage rates and an abundance of young, intellectual capital are competing for work that less than four years ago was performed by highly paid U.S. professionals, many of whom were then in short supply. While we do not know the extent of this shift in work from the United States (and other G-8 nations) to offshore locations, we do feel that the trend is, for the most part, permanent and irreversible.

Hence, a new issue confronting engineering educators today is how to best ensure that our graduates will continue to bring value to a marketplace in which their salary demands are three to five times greater than their international competitors. Oberst and Jones put the question succinctly: “It is no longer just whether engineers are being treated as commodities, but how engineers and other highly educated technical people shape and are shaped by the emerging realities of a truly global workforce.

Engineers as a professional group are thus the canaries in the mincshaft of the new world economy. Whether engineers manage the transition from local to international workplace environments will determine if the profession remains attractive”.

*They cite four major mega trends that affect the practice of engineering and necessitate the acquisition of more than technical skills:*

- Changes forced by the fragile world economy;
- Student and professional mobility;
- Use of communications and instructional technology; and
- Increasingly loud voice of the social imperative.

To them, the so-called “soft skills” are much more than public speaking, management skills, and the ability to work well in teams. What is also needed is an understanding of how the growing social consciousness around the world is making it imperative that engineering students understand the implications of their work.

We propose that the mastery of these professional skills combined with an ability to innovate will add sufficient value to U.S. engineering graduates so that price does not become the primary determinant of who is hired in the global marketplace. From continuing skill development through lifelong learning that prevents technical obsolescence to the ability to do engineering within its global (and/or societal) context, the professional skills are critical.

Hence, globalization, which now includes the globalization of the engineering profession, is forcing us to reconsider the role of future engineering graduates and the education required to meet that role. In 1994, Morrow (then National Academy Engineering president) in a farsighted consideration of the issues facing undergraduate engineering education noted that it is not a given that the U.S. engineering education system will always be globally pre-eminent.

There is clear evidence that many U.S. corporations now seek their engineering talent wherever they can find it throughout the world. Engineering design quality, low-cost engineering services, and responsive engineering production capabilities are

determinants of where engineering jobs will be. U.S. construction companies use civil engineers in Korea; automobile companies use design talents in Europe; software companies use software engineers in India.

A decade later, it is now evident that countries like China and India, with large, well-educated workforces, have learned how to move large segments of their populations into the advanced industrial economy in a manner similar to Japan, Korea, and Taiwan before them.

Further, like Korea and Taiwan, they are continuing to build universities to produce larger numbers of engineering and science talent and hence attract additional foreign direct investment, acquire advanced technology, and pursue export-led growth strategies. Further, another trend from the early '90s will continue to impact engineering education—an increasing number of engineering graduates may never practice engineering; rather, they choose to use their engineering education to enter a wide range of fields from business, medicine, law, and management among others.

Hence, as some have predicted, an undergraduate engineering education may become the liberal arts education of the twenty-first century. Certainly, the increasing number of engineering schools introducing general or interdisciplinary degrees recognize this. Consistent with this trend, Purdue recently created the country's first Department of Engineering Education, followed a few months later by Virginia Tech's creation of the second department. Purdue's new department combines its existing freshman engineering and interdisciplinary engineering programmes.

In the future, it plans to offer graduate degrees for students studying the science of learning and other topics in engineering education. There also are plans to add an engineering teaching certification programme for high school teachers and to pursue accredited undergraduate degrees in engineering education and interdisciplinary engineering. Virginia Tech has similar plans for its programme. Further, six states—Massachusetts, Arkansas, New Hampshire, Florida, Texas, and Maryland—have mandated engineering coursework in high schools, a trend that is likely to spread to other states in the coming years.

## **PROCESS AND AWARENESS SKILLS**

It is against this setting that we consider how to best teach and assess these professional skills. We believe that mastering these skills will be a major determinant of the future competitiveness of U.S. engineering graduates, enabling them to become highly innovative global “problem solvers,” which, in fact, we propose is what much of engineering is all about.

To best examine these skills we have divided them into two categories: process skills—communication, teamwork, and the ability to recognize and resolve ethical dilemmas (a more advanced formulation of criteria) and awareness skills—understanding

the impact of global and social factors, knowledge of contemporary issues, and the ability to do lifelong learning. We designate the first set as process skills because students learn a robust process to address each one. In contrast, the awareness skills are so designated because students learn how to be aware of the importance of each one and to include them in their problem-solving activities. In reviewing these skills, we cite examples of how some institutions are able to successfully teach them.

## PROCESS SKILLS

- *Communication:* We note that communication is the one skill that can certainly be taught and assessed. Indeed, most universities have departments of communications. The proceedings of both the Frontiers in Education conferences and the annual conferences of the American Society of Engineering Education are replete with examples of ways to integrate communication into the fabric of under-graduate engineering education. We are particularly impressed with those institutions now combining communication with global and social and ethical issues as part of design projects. Two noteworthy examples are Union College and the University of Utah.

At Union College, Spinelli has developed a course that examines the history of electrical engineering by combining the study of technological development within American and European civilizations with a concentration on writing, oral communication, and ethics. Certainly, placing technological developments within a social and human context is one way of approaching ABET's engineering criteria for ethics, communications, and broad education, in a course with significant technical content.

In a similar spirit, faculty at the University of Utah are using funding from the Hewlett Foundation to bring together communication, leadership (team building), and ethics into the College of Engineering's eight programmes over the entire four-year curriculum. They are building upon a successful model communication programme in mechanical engineering, where teaching assistants from the humanities have been brought into the engineering classes so that communication skills can be taught as "situational" learning. A similar ethics component is to be added.

- *Functioning on multidisciplinary teams:* More and more engineering courses are being designed to give students the opportunity to experience teamwork firsthand. These range from short, decision-making exercises to project management or business simulations lasting the length of the course.

This team-based course design trend reflects industry practice, where teamwork has become the prevalent mode. Companies use teams as an integral part of their product development, process improvement, and manufacturing activities. Such management techniques as concurrent engineering, total quality management, and business process reengineering are founded upon the concept of people working effectively in teams.



Engineering educators, recognizing these trends, are designing more and more courses around teams. Such programmes as Columbia's Gateway design course, MIT's undergraduate design course and its "New Products Programme", and Rowan University's Engineering Clinics Programme make extensive use of teams composed of students, faculty, and outside sponsors.

These project-driven classes provide students with the opportunity to experience team design work from idea conception to completion. When properly structured, such courses can teach students the skills necessary to work effectively in teams. However, too often educators incorporate student teams into their courses with little thought to their best use.

Minimal guidance is provided to students on group development, soliciting member input, consensus building, resolving conflict, and team leadership. Evaluation oftentimes is subjective and little more than a piecemeal integration of individual and group-level performance. Consequently, instructors often fail to capitalize on much of the learning that can occur through group dynamics and behaviour.

However, there are several outstanding examples where engineering educators have integrated teamwork and team skill-building activities into the classroom. An increasing number of engineering educators now realise that students cannot be thrown into team projects without support. One of the primary methods created to help integrate team learning into the engineering classroom is the development of formal curricular modules that can be used by various faculty planning to have students work on team projects. Of note is the Clark School of Engineering, University of Maryland modular team training programme-Building Engineering Student Team Effectiveness and Management Systems (BESTEAMS).

Supported by the National Science Foundation, the goal of this programme is to provide a team curriculum that can be easily adopted by engineering faculty from various schools and at different levels of the undergraduate curriculum. This well-structured programme allows faculty to select from various modules, depending on the nature of the course and the knowledge level of the students, its three modules-introductory, intermediate, and advanced-cut across three major team skill domains-personal, interpersonal, and project management.

The engineering schools at both the University of Tennessee and the University of San Diego have adopted this modular approach to provide engineering faculty with the tools necessary to develop students' team skills. The underlying foundation of these training modules is based on learning style theory, enabling student problem solvers to apply newly acquired technical skills more effectively by improving interpersonal interactions.

All levels of undergraduates have used these modules, which can be customised based on developmental level and technical knowledge of the student. The modular nature of all three programmes makes them easily transportable in full or in parts, thus

allowing faculty to customise based on class structure, project design, and course material. Another key component for teaching students team skills is the type of team project students will be exposed to in the classroom.

Recent literature is replete with examples from structured, simulated team experiences to authentic design projects, where students work on real problems for actual clients. As discussed later in this paper, there is now an emerging interest in using projects with global and/or humanitarian dimensions. Several experiential activities can help students better understand the behaviours and skills needed to be an effective team member.

At one end of the spectrum, there are literally hundreds of “off-the-shelf” group exercises designed to give participants hands-on experience. On the other end, there are many elaborate game simulations designed to provide realistic conditions that allow students to experience teamwork. The choice of team task depends on the educational objectives.

For example, if the objective is to have students experience a specific aspect of teaming such as brainstorming, specific group exercises in which students practice common methods of group brainstorming to generate new ideas can be used. However, if the objective is for students to experience a broad range of team processes and behaviours, then more complex activities are suitable. Two guiding principles should be followed in choosing activities: fidelity and complexity.

Fidelity is defined as the similarity of the training situation to the students’ present and future working conditions. The higher the fidelity, the more superior the transfer of learning to the workplace. The fidelity of a particular activity can be increased by matching the conditions of the work environment as closely as possible.

This may be difficult, especially when it comes to physical conditions, but many of the environmental conditions can be simulated. An example is “temporal environment,” which involves such factors as time limits and deadlines the team may experience. Research has shown that time has a definite effect on team performance. Such conditions as actual time to complete the task or make decisions should be matched to real conditions where possible.

“Social context” is another environmental condition that can be manipulated. Few teams work in a vacuum; instead, they typically co-exist with other teams that are working within a similar context. The more that inter-group activities can be designed into the team activity, the more a team can engage in real-world team behaviours such as inter-group communication, coordination, and conflict.

Complexity is defined by two subfactors: task interdependence and cognitive effort. The more complex the activity, the more team skills are required by the participant. Activities also can range from high to low degrees of complexity. In general, the higher the fidelity and complexity of the activity, the better the transfer of team skills to the workplace.



For example, programmes like Purdue's EPICS provides highly realistic teaming activities, with all the complexities experienced by a product design team. Some computer-generated simulations also can be both highly realistic and very complex. An example is the Centre for Creative Leadership's COLAB simulation that places technology management students in cross-functional teams with a focus on making decisions on new polymer processes to be commercialized.

Each competing team's objective is to get the new process to the market in a timely manner. Students make decisions on the allocation of research and development resources, manufacturing processes, and marketing activities. There are both advantages and disadvantages to each type of activity. Experiential activities categorized as high fidelity/high complexity most resemble real workplace" conditions, but typically are more difficult for the instructor to manage, resource intensive, and time consuming for the student. Activities that are lower in fidelity are typically more structured and easier to administer, but may be perceived as less relevant by the student, resulting in the experience having less of a learning impact. Finally, team activities that are lower in complexity may not challenge the team nor provide the environment necessary for intense interaction among team members.

- *Understanding professional and ethical responsibilities:* As part of their educational process, students should be sensitized to the potential ethical dilemmas they may confront in their professional life.

If an engineer is able to recognize a developing ethical dilemma, he or she should be better able to first clearly frame it and then begin the process of resolution. Stephan, in questioning whether or not engineering ethics can be taught, quotes philosopher Michael Davis in giving four good things that can result if successful: students can become more aware of the ethical implications of their work, they can learn ethical standards, they can become better judges of ethical conduct, and they can become more willing to put their ethical knowledge into action.

To Stephan, the true test of engineering ethics education is how graduates behave in the workplace during their careers, certainly a difficult outcome to measure a priori. Much attention has focused on how engineers perceive, articulate, and resolve ethical dilemmas that arise when complex, advanced technologies are developed, such as the explosion of the Challenger, the Three Mile Island Nuclear Power Plant accident, Chernobyl, the DC-10 cargo door, or the Ford Pinto. In fact, an entire field, disaster ethics, has emerged from studying such events.

While we believe that such lessons remain relevant to practicing engineers, of more importance may be how to recognize and then resolve those dilemmas that may arise in the routine practice of engineering. Engineers frequently work under cost and schedule pressures, situations that can lead to increased risk. At what point is that increased risk no longer acceptable? In addition, the multiple loyalties of the practicing engineer also contribute to ethical dilemmas.

Certainly, engineers have a loyalty to their employer, but engineering practice typically also involves a client or contractor, creating a second level of loyalty. Then there is the public, where the “safety of the public” as declared by Cicero has become accepted as the responsibility of the engineer. Every engineering code of ethics places the safety of the public in a prominent position. Finally, the engineer has a loyalty to the profession and to him or herself.

The need to incorporate some form of ethics instruction into the engineering curriculum is no longer debated, largely because of the new ABET engineering criteria. A number of educators have noted the important relationship between ethics and engineering design and the value of integrating the two within the curriculum.

However, this is only a recent happening. Over the past fifty years, engineering educators have focused on providing students with tools and technical skills, but providing the education and skills for social decision making was not a priority. Consequently, until recently, little had been done to make students aware of the social dimensions of engineering. Stephan found that only 27 per cent of ABET-accredited institutions listed an ethics-related course requirement, even though an increasing number of philosophers, engineers, and ethicists focus their research and teaching on engineering ethics. The interest of practitioners and professional engineering societies in engineering ethics has also increased. The Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE) has been especially active. However, if the vision for understanding ethical and professional responsibilities as articulated in ABET is to become reality, educators must now answer a number of questions: What is the appropriate content?

What teaching methods and curriculum models are preferable? Which works best—required course, ethics across-the-curriculum, integration of ethics and science, technology and society, or integration of the liberal arts into the engineering curriculum? Which outcome assessment methods are most suitable? Pinkus has provided an overview of these issues with emphasis on biomedical engineering.

Pfatteicher proposes that a current engineering ethics educational ‘dilemma’ is how to provide meaningful ethics instruction to all students without overburdening faculty, increasing graduation requirements, or removing essential technical material from the curriculum. She notes that the ABET engineering criteria call for ensuring understanding rather than demonstrating that graduates are ethical. Hence, students should be evaluated on knowledge and skills, not values and beliefs.

Pfatteicher proposes providing students with an understanding of the nature of engineering ethics, the value of engineering ethics as opposed to the values of an ethical engineer, and the resolution of ethical dilemmas. At the University of Virginia, Richards and Gorman have effectively used case studies to teach not only design, but ethics.

They have developed (researched and written) a set of case studies for teaching engineering ethics, engineering design, and environmental issues. These cases have been used in a course on invention and design and in other courses offered by the

Division of Science, Technology, and Society, which Gorman chaired. They emphasize that cases promote active learning, team-based activities, and the ability to deal with open-ended problems. With cases, students can be exposed to realistic situations involving unstructured problems with multiple possible answers, key decision points, and trade-offs. The case method, which also fosters the development of higher-level cognitive skills, enables students to address problems that require analysis, judgement, decisions, perspective taking, role playing, independent thought, and critical thinking.

## **AWARENESS SKILLS**

Broad education to understand the impact of engineering solutions in a global and societal context and knowledge of contemporary issues: A growing number of engineering programmes recognize that these two areas can be combined with issues related to globalization, sustainability, and development, especially in lesser developed countries, and are designing highly innovative educational programmes to meet this need. By introducing design projects into the mix, often as part of a service learning experience, they are finding effective ways to teach the gamut of professional skills while reinforcing the “harder” technical skills.

We highlight some of these exemplary programmes in this section, with a particular emphasis on those with a global orientation. While traditionally few engineering students study abroad or co-op/intern abroad-the most recent data indicate that only 4,670 students (2.9 per cent) participated in a study abroad programme in as noted here, this should change as innovative programmes are designed to provide engineering students with needed global and social experiences.

Lucena, one of the first academics to study globalization from an engineering perspective, notes that corporations, governments, and the engineers they hire face increasing challenges, such as mobility of capital and labour, organizational restructuring across national boundaries, and the development and implementation of more efficient production and manufacturing practices, among others.

Globalization depends on the availability of flexible workers to produce “just-in-time” products according to consumer demands and on the rapid dispersal of those products around the globe. This flexibility, demanded by globalization, presents special difficulties for engineering education and practice. Most engineers have no choice but to learn to cope with the practices changes that globalization is creating.

Lucena (who holds a B.S. and M.S. in engineering and a Ph.D. in anthropology) suggests that a more appropriate education to prepare engineers to deal with the challenges brought by globalization might be a liberal-arts-based education that teaches them first to recognize and deal with the political dimensions of their work and second to deal with the ambiguity that results from working, sharing, and even valuing perspectives other than their own.

Swearingen et al., concerned with outsourcing capturing an increasing percentage of engineering work, suggest that engineers will become “free agents” in a professional services market. To thrive, future engineers will have to be able to work productively with radically different cultures, educational backgrounds, technical standards, quality standards, professional registration requirements, and time zones. The manufacturing engineer must not only master the elements of global design, manufacture, marketing, and distribution, but also prepare to participate as a contractor in a “twenty-four-hour virtual enterprise”.

Engineers must understand that in a global context, engineering solutions, whether consumer products or unintended consequences such as resource exhaustion and environmental pollution, increasingly cross or transcend international boundaries. Global sustainability, for example, may eventually outweigh technical and other aspects of manufacturing.

Engineering faculty are beginning to recognize that students who have participated in study abroad programmes are better problem solvers, have strong communication and cross-cultural communication skills, and are able to work well in groups of diverse populations and understand diverse perspectives. Living overseas creates graduates who are more adaptable to new environments and have a greater understanding of contemporary issues as well as engineering solutions in a global and social context. However, further research is required to fully support these findings.

Perhaps the prototype model for integrating international experience into an engineering education is the University of Rhode Island’s (URI) International Engineering Programme. Founded in 1987 by John Grandin, professor of German, and Herman Viets, then dean of engineering, this innovative programme combines an undergraduate engineering degree with a degree in languages (initially German, but now expanded to French and Spanish).

In addition, students do an internship in a country where they must use their language skills, and many also do at least one term of study in that country. This five-year programme, which has been replicated by both the University of Connecticut and Rice University, has served to increase both the quality and quantity of URI engineering students; currently 20 per cent of incoming students participate.

Worcester Polytechnic Institute (WPI) is one of the leaders in enabling its students to study engineering within a global and social context. WPI’s programme is centered on the Major Qualifying Project—the equivalent of a nine-credit capstone design experience—and provides a professional-level application of the students’ knowledge in their major fields. It typically involves the design, synthesis, and realization of a solution to a real-world technical problem. WPI has established project centers, including ones in Ireland, Denmark, Hong Kong, Australia, Namibia, and Costa Rica. By 2002, 35 per cent of the electrical and computer engineering students were completing their senior design project in a project centre (10 weeks).

In total, more than half of the WPI students complete at least one degree requirement internationally. To make the programmes more affordable, WPI provides free passports and financial aid incentives. The University of Michigan has created a global concentration in engineering with an initial focus on China, the United Kingdom, and Mexico. The flexible framework enables all disciplines to participate. It requires international experience, global engineering course content, and a required cross-cultural course for engineers on global understanding. A motivation to establish the programme was to better prepare engineers to deal with the global supply chain by training engineers who possess not only the appropriate technical skills but also the cross-cultural skills based on knowledge of “other” cultures and their own cultural biases.

Michigan faculty have also created an Engineering Global Leadership Honours Programme, where students select a regional focus and concentrate their humanities/social science electives in that area. Students also must complete two years of advanced language study. Teams of business and engineering students consult for a major corporation. Muzumdar and Bean feel that even though almost all business is conducted in English and students may not even work in a location where their second language is spoken, having a second language makes the student more likely to work well in any other culture. Melsa, Holger, and Zachary have described Iowa State’s Global Academic Industrial Network (GAIN), which provides U.S. students with international experiences in Germany to better prepare them for future job requirements. They note that the critical element in all international exchange programmes is the faculty; institutions must find ways to engage their faculty in international experiences, including extended stays at a foreign institution.

Programmes built around a single faculty member and his or her international connections are fragile and typically fail when that individual loses interest or moves. Further, funding cannot become the limiting factor with such programmes. Institutional support at the highest levels is essential. A promising, comprehensive programme is Purdue’s Global Engineering Alliance for Research and Education (GEARE). This unique eighteen-month programme, developed in partnership with Karlsruhe (Germany) and Shanghai Jiao Tong (China) Universities, integrates language education, cultural orientation, three-month domestic and three-month international internships at the same partner firm, study abroad, and a two semester face-to-face multinational design team project, with one semester abroad and one at home. The bilateral programme involves equal numbers of students from each university participating in the paired exchanges.

Another model programme for providing international experience is Old Dominion University’s cluster concept. Here, students take a three-course cluster with an international perspective, including two required courses-”Global Engineering and Project Management” and “Communications Across Cultures”-and select one other from among “World Resources,” “International Business Operations,” or “Sustainable Development”.

The cluster concept attempts to provide students with a basic understanding of the integrative nature of successful engineering practices that involve not only technical but international, cultural, communication, and business factors. It also attempts to provide students with the knowledge to work productively in an environment that encompasses different cultures, business practices, resources, communication, and engineering practices.

The University of Kentucky has created an innovative combined B.S. Engineering-M.B.A. programme with a strong international component directed at producing manufacturing engineers and engineering managers. The engineering undergraduate degree, coupled with the M.B.A., allows students to explore immediate interests while building a solid, long-term career foundation.

This integration of business and economics courses with a traditional engineering programme over a five-year period results in students developing a broader, more holistic view of management principles and their application to an engineering environment. The students' senior year marks the beginning of the graduate M.B.A. courses and interaction with non-engineering M.B.A. students.

During the summer prior to the fifth year, students participate in a study abroad programme designed expressly for the programme, thereby enhancing and broadening their cross-cultural experiences. For the summer of 2004, the Kentucky students participated in a second innovative initiative-the University of Pittsburgh's Manufacturing and the Global Supply Chain in the Pacific Rim as part of the Semester at Sea Programme.

That programme, a joint effort between the University of Pittsburgh's School of Engineering and the International Business Centre, offered three manufacturing courses with a global perspective as students visited China, Hong Kong, Japan, Korea, Russia, Taiwan, and Vietnam. Visits to in-country manufacturing sites complemented the class activities.

Amadei at Colorado has become a leader among the engineering educators now looking at sustainability issues in the less developed world. He suggests that most past engineering achievements have been developed with little consideration of their social, economic, and environmental impact on natural systems. In many instances, engineering projects have contributed to the degradation of the Earth's natural systems. Amadei is concerned with the education of engineers interested in addressing the problems that are most specific to developing communities-water provision and purification, sanitation, power production, shelter, site planning, infrastructure, food production and distribution, and communication.

These problems are not usually addressed in U.S. engineering curricula, despite the fact that 20 per cent of the world's population lacks clean water, 40 per cent lacks adequate sanitation, 20 per cent lacks adequate housing, and 30 per cent live in conflict zones, transition, or situations of permanent instability.



As a result Amadei is helping to create a programme in Engineering for Developing Communities that will view the developing world as the classroom of the twenty-first century. This interdisciplinary effort will bring together engineering and non-engineering disciplines, thus supporting the learning of multiple professional skills. It will address a wide range of issues-water provision and purification, sanitation, health, power production, shelter, site planning, infrastructure, food production and distribution, communication, and jobs and capital for various developing communities. The first phase involves an undergraduate certificate programme that should be in place by the time this chapter is published.

As part of this initiative, Amadei and his colleagues have formed Engineers without Borders-USA (EWB) at Colorado, which is dedicated to helping disadvantaged communities improve their quality of life by implementing environmentally and economically sustainable engineering projects while developing internationally responsible engineering students.

Student projects that involve the design and construction of water, sanitation, and energy systems are ongoing in Belize, Mali, Mauritania, Nicaragua, Peru, Haiti, and Thailand. Rowan University faculty are incorporating EWB projects into their junior and senior clinics as a means of introducing open-ended problem solving in conjunction with developing synthesis, analysis, teamwork, communication, business, and entrepreneurial skills. A somewhat similar programme is being developed at Colorado School of Mines (CSM), with a focus on “humanitarian engineering.” With support from the William and Flora Hewlett Foundation, the goal is to nurture a cadre of engineers that is sensitive to social contexts and committed and qualified to serve humanity by contributing to the solution of complex problems at regional, national, and international levels and locations around the world.

This goal is to be achieved through the development of a humanitarian component for the CSM engineering curriculum that will teach engineering students how to bring technical knowledge and skill, as well as cultural sensitivity, to bear on the real-world problems of the less materially advantaged. A complement of Engineers without Borders-U.S.A. is Engineers for a Sustainable World (ESW) (previously known as Engineers without Frontiers-USA).

ESW originated in the College of Engineering at Cornell University in 2001 as a result of the efforts of Dr. Krishna S. Athreya, director of Minority and Women’s Programmes in Engineering, and Regina R. L. Clewlow, a Cornell University graduate. ESW is based on the belief that engineers and community members can work together to identify and solve technology-based problems, employing solutions that can be locally sustained, leading to an improved quality of life. ESW believes that locally sustainable engineering solutions are fundamental to the needs of communities in which issues such as lack of clean water, poor housing, and limited energy are barriers to adequate living conditions.

By establishing a national network in the United States for engineers to be of service to developing communities, ESW contributes to a better world and enriches the lives of engineering professionals who seek to participate in socially responsible endeavors. ESW has almost twenty chapters, with another thirty in the formation stage. Iowa State University and the Universities of Dayton and Seattle have joined together to form Engineers in Technical, Humanitarian Opportunities of Service Learning (ETHOS).

Its purpose is to help students gain an awareness of the social and cultural fabric of the poorest of the world and perform design research focused on improving the ability of these individuals to meet their basic needs. Engineering activities are being implemented in a number of formats, ranging from classroom activities to multi-semester research studies. Both on-campus curricular and immersion service experiences are included in its mission. Initial projects have focused on two non-governmental organizations' efforts to develop more efficient and more durable wood-burning stoves used for cooking by the world's poor.

Another example of service learning incorporated as part of undergraduate engineering education is the building of low-cost, energy-efficient houses in South Africa by students from Tuskegee University and the University of Fort Hare (South Africa). The idea behind this project is to develop a way for some of the economic benefit to stay in the local community. A number of faith-based institutions, notably Calvin, Drodts, Grove City, and Messiah Colleges, have combined engineering, service learning, and globally based humanitarian projects, thus meeting both social and student needs. However, Riley and Miller (Smith College) have raised concerns about involvement with faith-based projects, feeling that certain projects may be inappropriate if the development aid is tied to religious conversion and destroying indigenous cultures without regard for the community's traditions.

Smith College has developed an interdisciplinary project-based course that seeks to initiate critical study of the technological, cultural, and policy aspects of international development. This course requires students from different majors to share sophisticated disciplinary knowledge. Students address the promises and limitations of technology for development; the meanings of capitalism, colonialism, and globalization; and the implications of engaging in development work from places of privilege.

In developing a service component for the course, they seek to avoid sending students for only a few weeks to a country with which they have had no prior cultural experience—a situation that would make it difficult for students to acquire an adequate knowledge or sense of the community in which they are working.

Since the mid-1990s, an increasing number of programmes have incorporated international design team experiences, involving students from a U.S. and one or more partner international institutions. The original concept involved using the Internet and e-mail for communication, with the team coming together at the end of the project for a final meeting and presentation. Now, with the introduction of virtual design and virtual



teaming concepts, the potential exists to do these types of programmes without having students leave home. The need to train engineers to be well prepared to collaborate with their colleagues around the world and to work effectively in geographically distributed, multicultural teams was a motivation for Union College's creation of an International Virtual Design Studio (IVDS) in 1996. The IVDS initially brought together the mechanical engineering departments at Union College and Mideast Technical University (METU) in Ankara, Turkey, in response to the need to develop skills among students to better function in the emerging global environment in today's workplace.

In 1997, Queen's University (Kingston, Ontario) joined the partnership. Such projects provide international culture interaction, team building, communication, creative thinking, and project management experience. Each IVDS team has four to six members, two or three from each institution-METU and either Queens or Union. At Union, students select their project in spring term of the junior year.

Students must analyse, design, and build an autonomous robot for a given task and application. Since 1999, METU students have visited in November to compile and finish design reports. Final reports are presented before they leave. In January, after a prototype has been built, they go to Turkey for a competition at METU.

Sheppard et al. propose that virtual reality (VR) has the potential to have a major impact on engineering education by permitting students to explore environments that would be otherwise inaccessible. Specifically, VR will better facilitate teaming on an international and therefore multicultural level. Hence, faculty now must address educational collaboration in the virtual environment, testing and refining it at the institutional level, between institutions and across national boundaries.

A pilot implementation at Stevens Institute of Technology involves undergraduate student teams from three universities in three countries: Stevens is providing overall design and project coordination, the University of the Philippines (Quezon City, Philippines) is the manufacturing lead, and the National Institute of Technology (Warangal, India) is the simulation lead.

The project, "MEMS across the Globe" forms part of a larger pilot in virtual student design undertaken by a consortium of schools in collaboration with PTC Inc., a producer of industry standard design and collaboration tools. At Northern Arizona, language and engineering faculty are combining to utilize virtual reality to develop a pilot "Global Engineering College." When successfully implemented, it will inject international perspectives throughout the curriculum by leveraging technological, developments to create a "virtual" engineering college.

A recognition of the need for and the ability to engage in lifelong learning: Although the new ABET engineering criteria have brought lifelong learning to the forefront of engineering education, as Litzinger and his colleagues have pointed out, lifelong learning in engineering has been recognized as critical for decades. They note that the Final Report of the Goals Committee on Engineering Education contained a discussion of

the importance of lifelong learning, and the theme of the 1978 ASEE Annual Meeting was “Career Management-Lifelong Learning.” A number of earlier studies that investigated the types of activities involved in lifelong learning, their frequency of use, the support systems required, the barriers, and impact of lifelong learning for individual engineers are summarized in a 1985 report by a National Research Council panel. Litzinger and his colleagues, who are at the frontier of studying lifelong learning relative to engineering education, note that a major issue is how to assess the extent to which students are prepared to engage in it and also their willingness to do so. With funding from the National Science Foundation, they have been investigating how best to assess lifelong learning.

Various engineering education researchers have defined elements of lifelong learning, including Henry and Rogers, whose RIRI model consists of four components: receiving, enquiring, reflecting, and integrating. Miller, Olds, and Pavelich purport that their Cogito system for measuring intellectual development (based on assessing reflective judgement) will, when fully validated, also assess lifelong learning. When we specified the attributes of lifelong learning as part of our NSF-funded Action Agenda study, we proposed that these include the ability to:

- Demonstrate reading, writing, listening, and speaking skills;
- Demonstrate an awareness of what needs to be learned;
- Follow a learning plan;
- Identify, retrieve, and organize information;
- Understand and remember new information;
- Demonstrate critical thinking skills; and
- Reflect on one’s own understanding.

We propose that as students acquire the other professional skills, especially the other two awareness skills, as well as the process skills, that they will, in fact, acquire the ability to do lifelong learning. Hence, one will become a proficient lifelong learner as one becomes proficient in the broad spectrum of professional skills.

## **SCIENCE COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

Regardless of one’s view of the discipline of communication, journalism has occupied a central place in it. Communication researchers have long used journalism to explain how communication works, and journalists’ visibility in mediated discourse has made them a target for scholars seeking to understand the work of communication practitioners and the communication process. But has communication done its job?

Has communication scholarship provided the tools necessary to explain how and why journalism works? Has it explained why publics let reporters present themselves as cultural authorities for events of the “real world”? In short, has communication adequately explained journalism and journalistic authority?

This chapter argues that it has not. Journalism researchers, I contend, have allowed media power to flourish by not addressing the ritual and collective functions it fulfils for journalists themselves. The paper argues for a more interdisciplinary approach to journalism scholarship in order to provide a fuller account of media power. It also briefly considers the notions of performance, narrative, ritual, and interpretive community as alternative frames through which to consider journalism.

## **ONLINE INTERPERSONAL SKILLS TRAINING**

Some researchers are skeptical about the effectiveness of interpersonal skills training delivered by technology because of the limited interaction and feedback in the online environment. Meanwhile, others are enthusiastic about conveying interpersonal skills training through technology because of the cost-effectiveness it achieves by reducing training costs and its delivery time. The former are more concerned about learning effectiveness of online interpersonal skills training whereas the latter have high expectations of online learning for the cost-effectiveness reasons. In terms of cost-effectiveness of interpersonal skills training programmes, Campbell, Lison, Brosook, Hoover, and Arnold compared training programmes conveyed by way of computer/video technology and instructor-led programmes and found that there is no significant difference in learning gains between the two programmes.

As a result, they claimed that computer/video technology can reduce costs and instructors' working hours to half that which would be spent on instructor-led programmes. Despite Campbell and his colleague's study, the effects of interpersonal skills training delivered by technology are still controversial because of insufficient empirical evidence. However, in spite of the technical and pedagogical limitations of online environments for interpersonal skills training, given the proliferation of online learning and the magnitude of interpersonal skills in daily life, it is imperative to explore the most effective method to deliver interpersonal skills training online. Based on the proven effectiveness of behaviour modeling for interpersonal skills training in classrooms, this study applied it to online environments. For this, some changes should be made because of the discrepancies between online and classroom learning environments. One change is model presentation. Given that models convey learning content, key behaviours, it is necessary to design instructionally effective models for learning outcomes.

The model presentation formats can be live, video, audio, written scripts, or a combination of two or more of these methods. For enhancing the effectiveness of modeling, Decker and Nathan indicated that models' behaviours should be displayed in enough detail to convey the learning content. By contrast, from the cognitive load theory, some researchers insist that it is necessary to provide learners with the appropriate amount of information because of a learners' limited working memory.

Meanwhile, Bandura stated that the effectiveness of modeling is determined by the learners' cognitive development in interpreting key behaviours and the models' characteristics, such as its complicatedness. He also added that if the amount of information conveyed is identical, the presentation formats do not influence learning outcomes because the role of model presentations is to provide learners with information. However, when the results of information processing are defined broadly by processed amount, speed, accuracy, and cost-effectiveness, the model presentation formats may influence the learning outcomes in certain ways.

### **TRAINING PROGRAMME**

The training programme used for the research was a web-based job interview preparation programme. The learning content of the programme consisted of two parts: behaviour-based interview skills and verbal interview skills.

*Behaviour-based interview skills included:*

- Making a good impression on an interviewer.
- Giving a firm handshake.
- Maintaining good posture during the interview.

The verbal interview skills consisted of the self-introduction and answering three frequently asked interview questions, such as “what is your strength?” “what is your weakness?” and “why should I hire you?” Three behaviour-based and four verbal interview skills constituted the seven units of the programme.

The training programme was developed based on Bandura's observational learning process and Decker and Nathan's five components of behaviour modeling. However, the programme structure for online learning was modified to be suitable for online learning environments.

*The structure of the programme is as follows:*

- Provide an overview of the topic, given verbally,
- Display behaviour models (both a positive and negative model),
- Provide learning points—principles, procedures, and advice given verbally,
- Provide self-practice opportunities, and
- Provide self-assessment criteria

A brief explanation of each component is as follows: the overview of the topic explains why the topic is important and provides a concise summary of the content as an advanced organizer. Displaying behaviour models included both positive and negative models based on Baldwin's conclusion that the combination of positive and negative model displays was effective in promoting learners' generalization of what they learn.

As a result, the learners had a total of 14 model displays, a set of positive and negative model displays for each of seven topics. The topics of model displays include making a good impression on an interviewer, offering a firm handshake, maintaining good posture during the interview, self-introduction, explaining both one's greatest weakness and

strength, and justifying why he/she is an excellent candidate for the position. Learning points followed after model displays to facilitate learners' retention. And then skills practice opportunities are provided. Decker and Nathan especially asserted that it is difficult to expect skills acquisition without a sufficient number of practices in interpersonal skills training. However, since the programme was provided online, the learners had self-practice opportunities without interacting with other students. Finally, the learners were given self-assessment criteria to evaluate their performance as substitutes for feedback from other students or instructors.

The contents and scenario of the model displays were developed by the two instructors who taught the job search strategy course. To investigate the effects of the presentation format, four versions of the training programme, which had the same content and structure, but different presentation formats, were prepared. The presentation formats were video, still pictures and audio, audio alone, and text script alone.

For development process reasons, the models in the video format were the first group to be produced and then these video clips were converted to still pictures plus audio, audio only, and the text script format in that order. This procedure made it possible to produce four programmes with different presentation formats, but identical content. The programme was developed to take approximately one hour to complete and it was delivered to the participants through an online learning system.

### Measurement Instruments

- *Reaction*: The reaction measurement asked the participants to rate how much they enjoyed the online job interview preparation programme using ten items on a 5-point Likert scale. The reaction measure was administered online and consisted of two parts:
  - General reactions regarding enjoyment, usefulness, and how much they felt they learned through the programme.
  - Reactions to individual seven learning topics specifically.
- *Short-term retention*: The short-term retention test assessed how much participants recalled the concepts and principles regarding interviewing presented in the treatment programme. It was administered online and measured using 14 multiple-choice items online. The alpha coefficient of this measure was .76 and possible scores ranged from 0 to 14.
- *Behavioural reproduction*: An observation checklist, which consists of the criteria for assessment of the participants' interview performance, was developed to facilitate the raters' observation. The observation was conducted for verbal-interview and behaviour-based skills separately. The interrater agreement was calculated based on the assessment results of 200 observed behaviours of first seven participants. The agreement between the two observers was initially 75%, so the disagreement between two observers was resolved afterwards.

To ensure participants' access to the programme without technical problems, several versions of computer operating systems, the required hard-disk space, web-browsers, and internet bandwidth (or internet connection) were tested in both on-campus and off-campus computer environments in different time slots. Based on the results, specific minimum technology requirements were described in the instruction.

## **EXPERIMENTAL PROCEDURES**

This study was a posttest only randomized experiment. Participants were randomly assigned one of the model presentation groups (ie., video, still pictures plus audio, audio only, and text scripts only) and received training programmes as treatment according to the group they belonged to.

They were asked to complete the programmes posted on an online learning system within two weeks. To prevent contamination of the treatment, a programme for each group was posted on each group space, resulting in not allowing other groups to access it. Immediately after the completion of the training programme, the participants were asked to fill out both the online reaction questionnaire and the short-term cognitive retention test. Approximately two weeks later, the participants performed their interviews at group mock interview sessions for around 45 minutes for the measuring the delayed behaviour reproduction of interview skills.

In order to prevent copying others' answers at group mock interview sessions, the questions were reworded or rephrased and then asked to the participants in random order. Two observers rated their interview skills with the prestructured observation checklist.

An analysis of variance (ANOVA) using SPSS 11.5 was performed to examine whether there were significant differences between the four groups in terms of reaction, short-term retention of learning content, and behavioural reproduction. An alpha level of .05 was used for all statistical tests and mean substitution was employed as an alternative to deal with missing information.

## The Process of Listening Skills

We said earlier that the first step in listening effectively is to recognize certain fallacies or false notions. The next step is to understand the process.

Listening is a complex process—an integral part of the total communication process, albeit a part often ignored. This neglect results largely from two factors.

First, speaking and writing (the sending parts of the communication process) are highly visible, and are more easily assessed than listening and reading (the receiving parts). And reading behaviour is assessed much more frequently than listening behaviour; that is, we are more often tested on what we read than on what we hear. And when we are tested on material presented in a lecture, generally the lecture has been supplemented by readings.

Second, many of us aren't willing to improve our listening skills. Much of this unwillingness results from our incomplete understanding of the process—and understanding the process could help show us how to improve. To understand the listening process, we must first define it.

Through the years, numerous definitions of listening have been proposed. Perhaps the most useful one defines listening as the process of receiving, attending, and understanding auditory messages; that is, messages transmitted through the medium of sound. Often, the steps of responding and remembering are also included.

The process moves through the first three steps—receiving, attending, understanding—in sequence. Responding and/or remembering may or may not follow. For example, it may be desirable for the listener to respond immediately or to remember the message in order to respond at a later time.



At times, of course, no response (at least no verbal response) is required. And the act of remembering may or may not be necessary. For example, if someone tells you to “watch your step,” you have no need to remember the message after you have completed that step. Let’s look at the parts—the three necessary ones and the two additional ones—one at a time. Consider the following analogy between the listening process and the electronic mail (E-mail) system. Suppose that you are the sender of a message and I am the intended recipient.

## **PRINCIPLES OF EFFECTIVE LISTENING**

### **SHARED RESPONSIBILITY**

Any communication places equal burdens and duties on listener and speaker. Like effective speakers, effective listeners engage in as much prior preparation as possible, remain focused and concentrated during communication, understand the responsibilities unique to their roles as listeners in a given context, and practice continual self-evaluation and improvement. Without such purposeful behaviour on the part of the listener, even the most accomplished speaker can fail to communicate clearly. Our average listening comprehension for any given message is around 25% with only small changes caused by increases in speaker effectiveness. This data suggests, by pointing to a general ceiling in communication comprehension regardless of the skill of the speaker, that individual listening training could have just as much of an impact as corresponding education in speaking. An effective listener can help an ineffective speaker in many ways. Proper attention and non-verbal behaviours on the part of a listener encourages a more enthusiastic and engaged speaker. A listener skilled in asking the right questions at the right time can assist a speaker in clarifying and organizing thoughts.

### **ACTIVE ATTENTION**

Effective listening does not simply follow from a willingness to sit quietly and pay attention to a speaker. Hearing, which provides the initial foundation for listening, denotes the physical reception of aural data. Listening involves mental activity, including cognitive and affective processing of received information. Consequently, educators enhance listening competence through diligent focus on the mental processes and skills involved in perceptive listening, such as memory, sense making, and evaluation.

### **COMPLEX, DYNAMIC PROCESS**

Listening is a variable communication activity that differs according to: the purpose and nature of the listener and the speaker, the content and style of the message, the channel of communication, and the surrounding environment. As a variable activity, effective listening does not issue from a monolithic, unchanging checklist that can be



uniformly imposed on all situations. Take for instance a study by Jr. concluding that the typical work environment presents 38 distinct types of listening activities demanding unique balances of various purposes, skills, and strategies. The study suggests that a good listener does not always listen in the same way. Listening competence instead requires the ability to choose and enact specific skills and behaviours most suitable to the context of a listening situation. Generally, perceptive listening can be understood as the successful integration of various skill sets attached to different levels of the listening process. These include: (a) mental concentration and focus; (b) non-verbal communication from attentive posture to maintaining appropriate eye contact; (c) effective probes and questions which aid the speaker without undue interference or interruption; and (d) the ability to reflect and engage in meta-cognition of the conversational process. So, individual skill enhancement should play a part in listening education, but students must also comprehend basic strategies which enact, integrate, and adapt those skills, as well as possess the ability to identify the nature and purpose of specific listening occasions.

### **DISTINGUISHABLE PHASES**

One helpful conceptual tool is Lyman Steil's S.I.E.R. model where each letter of the acronym stands for a phase in the listening process: Sensing the message, Interpreting (or understanding the message), Evaluating the message, and Responding to the message. One notable element missing in the S.I.E.R. model is remembering (memory/ retention) which plays an obviously crucial role in listening. Interpreting could arguably be understood as including retention but primarily means recreating the message in order to understand and give meaning to it. Process models, one of which is S.E.I.R., can serve as useful conceptual schemas for organizing and understanding the inter-relations between the various component skills involved in listening well.

### **Purpose**

Distinguishing between types of listening offers a helpful path for those seeking to implement listening education in particular college classrooms. The listener's purpose animates the most common taxonomies. Some of the earliest theoretical developments in the listening field involved distinguishing between serious and social listening, as well as separating critical and evaluative listening from that centered on empathy with the speaker or comprehension of the speaker's message from the speaker's perspective. Although disagreement persists over the inclusion of this or that particular type and scholars continue to employ a number of different, overlapping names to connote slightly differing slices of the listening pie, a general consensus exists that listening can be divided, according to listener purpose, into the following types: discriminative, critical (or evaluative), appreciative, therapeutic (or empathic), and self-listening. Discriminative listening covers the conscious reception of all pertinent auditory and visual stimuli.

Some researchers include listening for comprehension, basic efforts on the part of the listener to retain and understand a speaker's message, as part of discriminative listening, while other scholars place such steps in their own category. Critical or evaluative listening describes situations where the listener makes judgements about the speaker's message.

As such, critical listening often accompanies persuasive speaking. The critical listener attends closely to such matters as speaker and evidentiary source credibility and the structure of and support for the speaker's arguments. In contrast, therapeutic or empathic listening emphasizes understanding a message from the speaker's perspective in situations where the speaker needs to be heard or talk through an issue. In these moments, the listener provides the minimum necessary direction for the speaker's perspective to be clear. Counseling and psychology provide excellent exemplars of this type of listening. Appreciative listening occurs when we listen for enjoyment, aesthetics, or sensory impressions, such as consuming a television sit-com or occupying ourselves with music. Self-listening often gets neglected, but conscious engagement with one's own physical reactions, attitudinal biases and prejudices, or mental markers while listening comprises a helpful listening category. Such reflection mostly takes place in one's head, but still requires conscious application techniques similar to those one would apply while listening to the talk of another person.

## **TIPS FOR TEACHING LISTENING**

### **Adapt to Context**

Educators must adapt the general ideas presented here and elsewhere to the specific listening contexts most applicable to their courses and disciplines. The first challenge of any educator incorporating listening into the college classroom is to assess the types of listening needed both in the classroom and in the professional life for which the students are preparing. The demands of listening as a business manager can differ drastically from the challenges of listening as a therapist. For example, the crisis situations common to counseling suggest particular emphasis be placed on listening to personal stories.

### **Make Training Progressive and Continuous**

Teaching listening can be more effectively accomplished if done in smaller segments spread over the duration of a class, rather than squeezed into a day or week long listening unit. Listening, like reading, writing, and speaking, is a complex process best developed by consistent practice and reflection and consisting of a number of skills, each necessary at different levels of the process, which serve as foundations and prerequisites for the skills and levels of the listening process which follow. For example, a listener must be able to maintain mental and physical attention before one can develop the ability to interpret and respond to a speaker adequately.

**DEFINITION**

Why all this fuss about listening? Surely, after all that we have said so far on communications, this question ought not to be asked, but we are sure it should be asked, because nobody really listens! It is a vital communication skill, yet it is always being taken for granted that people actually listen and understand.

A survey based on interviews and questionnaire among 400 project engineering personnel proved that nearly 80 per cent of a manager's time is spent in face-to-face interpersonal interaction with co-worker. It was found that although the substance of the oral message was important, the style and credibility were the key to the impact of the message on the receiver - a point which we have made earlier in this sub-section.

In another survey, more than three hundred members of the academy of Certified Administrative Managers were asked: "What abilities or competencies do you consider to be the 20 per cent that yields the 80 per cent results." The rule has its origin in the well-known Pareto law, sometimes expressed in the statement, vital few versus trivial many. The survey led to a consensus amongst twenty critical managerial skills, of which four were rated by the participants as 'super critical', seven as 'highly critical' and nine as 'critical'. The four super-critical activities were found to be, in descending order of importance:

- Active listening;
- Giving clear effective instructions;
- Accepting your share of responsibility;
- Identifying the real problem.

Isn't that interesting? All the four super-critical activities relate to communication and of these listening is considered to be the most important.

Listening is big business these days. There are several full-time consultants, and seminar leaders who are occupied entirely, day in, day out, with this one subject.

There is also the International Listening Association, with members from several countries, which aims to promote effective listening through exchange of information, methods, experience and materials and pursuing research on the subject.

There are many books dealing exclusively with the subject of listening and the message running through all of them is simply this: listening is vital yet much neglected. It is a skill that can and must be acquired. They all seek to point the way to perfection, each author having his or her own 'golden rules'. Many of them, of course, are much the same in principle, only expressed in different words. We give you, for your use, the ten rules from a book (referenced) published by the American Management Association:

- Look at the speaker.
- Question the speaker to get clarification.
- Show concern about the speaker's feelings.
- Repeat occasionally to confirm.
- Don't rush the speaker.

- Have poise and emotional control.
- Respond with a nod, a smile or a frown.
- Pay close attention.
- Don't interrupt.
- Keep on the subject till the speaker finishes his or her thoughts.

Let us conclude by saying that listening is a gift and a skill that can be learnt and must be learnt and to learn it will not cost you a great deal of money - yet it is priceless to the person to whom you are listening, and the skill is absolutely essential for you, as manager and as individual, both in your professional and your personal life, to be truly effective.

### **Using Active Listening in Business**

When talking to a person, making eye contact and simply listening may seem like you are using active listening but it's actually not that simple. First, let me introduce you to several "what not do's" when you are listening to a person;

Pseudo Listening is you are pretending to listen to the person but you're not you are instead thinking of other things. Relating to what the person is saying to your own experiences as if you were rating the person with points. Showing expressions as if you were mind reading the person. Rehearsing in your head a clever response to say about what the person is mentioning. Hearing only that is convenient to your knowledge and then wondering off thinking about other things. Filling gaps with words or remarks every time the person pauses. Labeling the person in a category that you feel the person is suitable for before the person finishes explaining.

Finally responding to the person's emotion with jocular remarks such as "Relax it's not the end of the world" or other remarks in that matter. Does any of these examples sound familiar? We've all experienced conversation like these, either we were listening to a person or someone was listening to us.

Try avoiding such behaviour when listening for it causes great fatigue to the person speaking. Have you ever experienced these examples when you were speaking? How did you feel? You probably didn't like it, now imagine when you behaved in such way when the person was speaking, the person probably didn't like either. By avoiding this behaviour when the person is speaking to you it will certainly achieve great results.

### **Art of Listening**

When using active listening not only do you want to listen to the person but try to feel and fully understand the words. You also prove you were listening by restating what the person said, you can start by mentioning, "What I understood is." Also, once in a while, you may want to ask the person to clarify to what he already mentioned. Finally if you feel you have to express an opinion do so but after the person is finished talking. It is understandable that present factors may occur when trying to use active

listening, such as your worries, either small or big everyone deals with problems. Your worries may not let you focus on what the person is saying. Emotions can present itself as a factor such as grief, anger, and depression when you are trying to deal with it when a person is talking to you.

A language barrier is definitely a factor especially when the person speaks a different language. Pollution of noise is another factor, how can you be active listening when the area is cluttered with noise? Boredom, maybe the person speaking isn't considered enthusiastic and may cause you to feel boredom. How critical the factors may seem active listening can still be done, by practice. Practicing is the key to fully apply active listening in your life and or in your business.

### **Active Listening**

Have you ever been sat down to for a job interview? I have, in fact I remember my first interview I had for a job. I remember how my knees shook, my voice trembled, how I gulped every other second trying to hide any sign of nervousness because I knew the interviewer was listening carefully to every expression coming out of my mouth.

He was looking at me with piercing eyes as if he where studying my algebra, intimidating me because again I knew he was paying close attention to everything I said. Active listening can be best defined as a proper form of listening to what the other person is saying, and is used very frequently to accomplish a goal.

For example, a doctor must use active listening to figure out how to help treat the patient, a job interviewer must uses active listening if they want to hire the person that best fit the job position. There is many examples where active listening is used, active listening can even be used from your own home, if a married couple you would use this quality to work out your differences, and if a parent active listening is very important when your child reports to you with a problem that is bothering him or her at school.

### ***Importance of Active Listening***

Why is Active Listening so important? Put yourself in position of the person that is talking, what would you like the person to do? Obviously you would like the person to just listen to what you have to say. It doesn't change when business is involved, everybody likes to be heard when they are given the opportunity to speak. Now imagine a company whose boss is always cutting people off in the middle of their sentences, never let's the employees talk,

Do you think he will gain confidence from his or her employees? Do you think the employees will come up to the boss and ask to discuss a problem? The answer is without doubt a NO! You want to have a good relationship with your employees because communication in the company is one of the best keys to success. Another reason for the importance of active listening is that it solves discussions. For example, one night you decide to spend some time with three of friends and enjoy the night out.

Finally, you and your friends came to an agreement to meet at a parking lot because it's convenient for everyone concerning the distance travel. When you get there, you and your friends decide to go to a night comedy show, everyone, including you, came to the conclusion that it is best to travel in just one vehicle to arrive at the show, since the parking tickets is 20 dollars per vehicle. This prevents a hassle trying to find each other at the show when everyone arrives, and saves everyone money. The question is whose car is to be used? You and your friends start arguing about what vehicle to take all at once, giving thousands of excuses. Soon enough it starts sounding like a, "I'm louder" contest, trying to give their opinion and share their ideas by trying to defeat each other with decibel power.

Never will you and your friends come to a conclusion if active listening is avoided. This proves a good statement that active listening is without doubt very important. Though active listening is a great quality to endure, active listening can be improperly used, even in business. Sometimes we believe we are active listening but in reality we're not, so, how can I use active listening in Business?

## **IMPORTANCE OF LISTENING IN COMMUNICATION**

At first glance communication with another person seems relatively easy. This month I had two different experiences that showed me how tricky it is to understand what a person does or doesn't say. Taking the time to listen to others is important whether you are lawyer, a manager or an employee.

A friend recently shared with me her frustration with her sister in law. She told me that the woman seemed to rebuff her all the time. The sister in law consistently turned down invitations to go places and when they were at family events her sister in law remained quiet. "Cold fish" and "private person" were ways my friend described her. Although I did not share this with my friend I did wonder if someone might use the same words about me. While my friend is warm, outgoing and talkative, I tend to be more quiet and introspective. I must admit that there are times I want and need to be alone too. In fact I enjoy my friend because she is so different from me. Her talkative style energizes me and draws me out. The second experience was at a funeral for the husband of my mother's friend. The man who passed away was a quiet man who lived a long life (90+ years). The few times that I had been with this couple his wife did all the talking. I knew the man was a pianist but nothing more.

At the funeral two people gave eulogies. The first was a nephew who said that the man had married into a family of talkers. At family events everyone was shouting and laughing. His uncle, the nephew said, had a quiet presence that the family would miss. The other speaker was a cousin who was also a musician-a violinist. The deceased was a jazz pianist and had played with some of the greats in the jazz world. The cousin

told of the wonderful times he and his cousin had had improvising together. In fact he said lately he had begun calling his cousin “brother”. The speaker said his cousin’s way of communicating was with music.

Often people don’t “get” another person simply because their communication styles are so different. The musician and his cousin did understand one another because they were alike. We are most comfortable with people who are similar in style to ourselves. At least we know how to communicate with those people. In my practice I use the DISC behavioural assessment to help people learn about themselves and others. The report provides communication tips for people of different styles. Once clients know how others like to be communicated with, they can adapt their own style to that of their client, employer, employee, team member, or friend. When you attend a party, a networking event or family function it is important to remember that not everyone is alike. Someone who is quiet and reserved (an introvert) might appreciate having someone new to talk to. It takes time and some effort to draw someone out. Just be curious about their interests and you may discover a jazz musician, a poet or who knows what! Everyone has a value in the world. Take the time to listen for it in others.

## **BETTER LISTENER**

### **DEFINITION**

Most of us are acquainted with the old riddle that goes: “If a tree falls in the forest, and no one is in the area to hear it, does it make a noise?” From a communication point of view, the answer must be a definite “No.” Even though there are sound waves, there is no sound because no one perceives it. For communication to take place, there must be both a sender and a receiver. This chapter is focused on the receiver - the one who provides feedback to the sender.

Saul says: “The sender, to be certain that his message will be accepted by the receiver, must be prepared to let the receiver influence him. He must even be prepared to let the receiver alter or modify the message in ways that make it more acceptable to the receiver. Otherwise, it may not be understood or it may not be accepted, or it may simply be given lip service and ignored.”

This places the responsibility for good communications squarely on the shoulders of both the sender and the receiver. Each of us plays the roles of sender and receiver many times each day. Thus, it is important to learn to play each role well. Researchers have found that the average individual spends considerably more time each day in listening than in speaking, writing, or reading. Therefore, listening is a very important communicative skill.

Did you know that we devote about 40 to 45 per cent of our working hours to listening? And did you know that, if you have not taken steps to improve this skill, you listen at



only 25 per cent efficiency? Putting these thoughts together, do you feel comfortable knowing that you earn 40 per cent or more of your pay while listening at 25 per cent efficiency? If not, perhaps acting on the information imparted in this chapter will improve your listening skills to above the average in listening efficiency. Tests have shown that we can significantly raise the level of our listening performance by a small amount of study and practice. The importance of the listening skill to managers has been recognized by industrial firms for some time. Dr. Earl Planty, in his role as executive counselor at Johnson and Johnson, has said: "By far the most effective method by which executives can tap ideas of subordinates is sympathetic listening in the many day-to-day informal contacts within and outside the work place. There is no system that will do the job in an easier manner. Nothing can equal an executive's willingness to listen." Recognizing the value of effective listening, many companies offer training programmes to improve this communicative skill. Some years ago the Methods Engineering Council compared one group of participants in a preliminary discussion on efficiency in listening with a second group not participating in such a discussion. The comparison was made by testing each group. The test results showed the marks made by the first group were 15 per cent higher - a significant improvement.

### **WHAT LISTENING IS**

We hear - often without listening - when sound waves strike our eardrums. When we don't remember what we have heard, it is probably because we did not listen. A good example is the situation that frequently occurs when we are introduced to a new employee or a new acquaintance. A few minutes later we can't recall the person's name. Why? Because we probably failed to listen to the name when we were introduced. Johnson defines listening as "the ability to understand and respond effectively to oral communication." Thus, we can state at the outset that hearing is not listening. Listening requires more than hearing; it requires understanding the communication received. Davis states it this way: "Hearing is with the ears, but listening is with the mind'."

### **Attributes of a Good Listener**

- He usually makes better decisions because the inputs he receives are better;
- He learns more in a given period of time, thereby saving time; and
- He encourages others to listen to what he says because he appears more attentive and better mannered.

The typical listener, after 2 weeks can remember only 25 per cent of what he has heard in a briefing or a speech. Therefore, listening is not effective for receipt and retention of factual details. For retention of factual details we must place our dependence on the written word. Researchers have discovered that we can improve our listening comprehension about 25 per cent. Most of us process the sender's words so fast that there is idle time for us to think about the message while it is being given. During this



idle time a good listener ponders the sender's objectives, weighs the evidence being presented, and searches for ways to better understand the message. It follows that good listening can be considered "a conscious, positive act requiring willpower."

The ability to listen more effectively may be acquired through discipline and practice. As a listener you should physically and mentally prepare yourself for the communication. You must be physically relaxed and mentally alert to receive and understand the message. Effective listening requires sustained concentration (regardless of the length of the message), attention to the main ideas presented, note-taking (if the conditions are appropriate), and no emotional blocks to the message by the listener. You cannot listen passively and expect to retain the message. If you want to be an effective listener, you must give the communicator of the message sufficient attention and make an effort to understand his viewpoint.

## **GUIDES TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING**

Here are some practical suggestions for effective listening which, if followed, can appreciably increase the effectiveness of this communicative skill.

### **Realise that Listening is Hard Work**

It is characterized by faster heart action, quicker blood circulation, and a small rise in body temperature. Researchers have found that the higher we climb on the organizational ladder, the more difficult listening becomes. In day-to-day conversations, show the communicator you are interested by looking and acting like you are.

### **Prepare to Listen**

To receive the message clearly, the receiver must have the correct mental attitude. In your daily communications, establish a permissive environment for each communicator.

### **Recognize your own Biases**

Learn what your biases are and channel them properly. You can then keep them from interfering with the message.

### **Resist Distractions**

Good listeners adjust quickly to any kind of abnormal situation; poor listeners tolerate bad conditions and, in some instances, may create distractions themselves. Take a clue from good listeners.

### **Keep an Open Mind**

A good listener doesn't feel threatened or insulted, or need to resist messages that contradict his beliefs, attitudes, ideas, or personal values. Try to identify and rationalize the words or phrases most upsetting to your emotions.

**Find an Area of Interest**

Good listeners are interested and attentive. They find ways to make the message relevant to themselves and/or their jobs. Make your listening efficient by asking yourself: “What is he saying that I can use? Does he have any worthwhile ideas? Is he conveying any workable approaches or solutions?” G. K. Chesterton once said, “There is no such thing as an uninteresting subject; there are only uninteresting people.”

**Show Some Empathy**

If we show some empathy, we create a climate that encourages others to communicate honestly and openly. Therefore, try to see the communicator’s point of view.

**Hold your Fire**

Be patient. Don’t interrupt. Don’t become over-stimulated, too excited, or excited too soon, by what the speaker says. Be sure you understand what the speaker means; that is, withhold your evaluation until your comprehension is complete. Mentally arguing with a communicator is one of the principal reasons so little listening takes place in some discussions. Don’t argue. If you win, you lose.

**Listen Critically and Delay Judgement**

Good listeners delay making a judgement about the communicator’s personality, the principal points of the message, and the response. Ask questions and listen critically to the answers. Then, at the appropriate time, judgement can be passed in an enlightened manner.

**Judge Content, Not Delivery**

We listen with our own experience. We do not understand everything we hear. It is not fair to hold the communicator responsible if we can’t decode his message. One way to raise the level of our understanding is to recognize and assume our own responsibility.

**Exercise your Mind**

Good listeners develop an appetite for hearing a variety of presentations - presentations difficult enough to challenge their mental capacities..

**Capitalize on Thought-Speed**

Most of us think at about four times faster than the communicator speaks. It is almost impossible to slow down our thinking speed. What do you do with the excess thinking time while someone is speaking? The good listener uses thought-speed to advantage by applying spare thinking time to what is being said. Your greatest handicap may be not capitalizing on thought-speed. Through listening training, it can be converted

into your greatest asset. Perls said, “Don’t listen to the words, just listen to what the voice tells you, what the movements tell you, what the posture tells you, what the image tells you.”

### **EFFECTIVE LISTENING**

There are several barriers to effective listening. According to Tortoriello, some of these barriers are as follows:

- Recognizing that a personal risk is involved. Our thoughts and ideas might be changed in some way. Any change is threatening initially;
- Listening for only those things that are relevant to our own goals and objectives;
- Listening for only those things that serve to satisfy our own needs;
- Casting aside those things that don’t conform to our own models of the world; and
- Filtering the thoughts and ideas of the sender according to our frame of reference attitudes, beliefs, expectations, and relationship to the sender of the message.

Have you raised these barriers? Is the message coming directly to you without passing through some fine filters you have placed in the communications loop?

### **TALKING LIMITS**

This chapter covering approaches to good listening would not be complete unless something was said about limiting our own talking while playing the role of receiver.

You cannot be an effective listener if you are too busy talking. Frank Tyget put it this way, “You can only improve on saying nothing by saying nothing often.”

Following receipt of each oral communication, there is time for a response. As the receiver of the message, don’t monopolize the conversation. Give the communicator an opportunity to respond to your comments. As the source of the message he should be given a chance to have the last word. If you give him that opportunity, he will feel important and believe he has communicated effectively. You, as the receiver, may feel justly that you have played your role as receiver well. Then, the communication can be considered truly effective.

### **PROBLEM IN LISTENING**

There is a reason why human beings only have one mouth but two ears – that is because listening is twice as difficult as talking is. This is why it is often necessary for people to actually practice listening before they acquire the skill known as listening well.

Communication is a two way street; if a speaker is merely sending out signals that are not being absorbed by the passive participant – the listener – in this case, you – then he is wasting his time. In order for effective communication to take place, then information must be successfully transmitted from the speaker to the listener.

## **MAKING PEOPLE TO LISTEN**

The key to becoming a better listener is to put yourself in the position of the speaker that is not being listened to. Chances are, we will all find ourselves in this unfortunate position at least once in our lives that we are clearly aware of.

One of the clearest signs that you are not being listened to is if someone is blatantly looking off elsewhere while you are speaking to them. Perhaps you have important news to deliver to a spouse, but you find that they are holding the newspaper in front of their face, obviously not paying attention.

The way to make that person listen to you is simply call them out. Tell them to look at you directly – that is, make eye contact – and listen, as you have something important to tell them. Unless the person is angry with you for a specific reason, chances are they will do what you ask them to do.

## **LISTEN BY BODY**

Before becoming a good listener, you must first learn how to act like a good listener. By doing this, our body sends out clear messages that we are listening to what the person talking has to say.

In this day and age, we are taught from a young age to tune out a lot of the information that is thrust at us on a daily basis. In the process, we occasionally miss out on important bits information that might be useful to us – whether it be in our personal lives, our career, or both.

Once our bodies become receptive to listening, then our ears and minds follow suite. Since the human face contains the most receptive natural equipment on Earth, it is natural that our faces be tilted towards someone when they are speaking to us. Another body part you can utilize to improve your listening skills is your eyes. If you are not looking at the person as they are speaking to you, chances are great that you are not really hearing what they are saying. The eyes are able to pick up on non verbal signs that a person sends out when they are speaking.

By establishing eye contact with the individual who is speaking, you are completing the eye contact that that individual is likely trying to make. By not looking at the speaker, you are forcing him to work harder at sending out information in order to get a receptive audience. By using your eyes, you are playing a central role in completing the communication circuit the speaker is struggling to establish.

Once face and eye contact have been established with the speaker, then things the speaker says must be reacted to via the use of non verbal signals. This should occur naturally; it is when your face makes expressions that respond to things the speaker has said. (You cannot do this if you have not been listening properly!) Thus, the listener's face becomes an active component in the listening process.

Good listeners never interrupt. You cannot be listening if you are moving your mouth at the same time. If you feel yourself compelled to interject at a moment, use that

energy instead towards listening to the final thought the speaker is attempting to complete. You can also employ “*listening phrases*” to affirm the speaker’s stance; these are phrases like “*oh really?*” and “*uh huh,*” and “*I see.*”

## BECOMING MASTER LISTENER

If the answer to that question is yes, then there are some things you will need to keep in mind. Listening is typically thought of as a passive duty. In fact, the opposite is really true. Intensive listening should leave you feeling quite tired after a speaker has finished saying what they had to say. While it may seem simple at first, listening is a difficult and invaluable skill. Some people are better at it than others. Here is a quick breakdown of the importance behind the value of listening and also how to be a better listener.

### Important Listening Points

- So you know the right homework to do
- So you can answer questions when called in class
- So you remember people’s names
- So you remember the correct facts
- So you hear “between the lines”
- So you know where to go — directions
- *Courtesy*: It is rude not to listen when someone is speaking directly to you
- *Career advancement*: So you focus on a job interview
- So you do not answer questions off the subject (in school, interviews)
- Respect—to give everyone the respect he/she deserves at all times

Now that you know the reasons to become a better listener, here are the best ways to do so.

- *Eye contact*: Always direct your visual attention to the person with whom you are conversing or listening.
- *Body language*: Always keep your body in attention. If your body is slouched, your attention span may slack and your listening skills may weaken.
- *Responses*: When asked, answer questions in complete sentences.
- *Repetition*: Repeat specific comments said by the person with whom you are conversing or listening.
- *Gentility*: Be kind. People appear to be good listeners when they want to listen to others. If you look like you’re listening “just because,” then your listening skills will appear less than perfect.

Remember, people listen in different ways. If you have been told you are already a strong listener, then perhaps you do not need this guide. However, people can always improve their skills. It is also important to remember not to go overboard with all of the above steps. Sometimes you can appear “too anxious” of a listener and consequently turn people off.

## **ENSURING BETTER LISTENING**

### **DEFINITION**

As I continue to look at communication skills and cover various areas of it, speaking is definitely an important one. I am certainly not a skilled public speaker or presenter and while that is a common skill for communication, this article is about controlling your speaking for every day communication and not focused on large group public speaking. I'll leave that to the experts.

### **SPEAK AT THE RIGHT PACE**

It is important to speak at a controlled case so that your audience can easily understand you. Speaking too quickly makes you sound uneasy, nervous, or even unsure of yourself. Speaking too slowly will make you seem unconfident, or simply not convincing. You want to ensure you can get your point across clearly without your audience having to struggle to understand you. It is very useful to record your self or practice speaking at the right pace with a friend listening so that you can tell and listen to your own pace. I can see it's like.

### **BREATHE**

Your breathing rate can relate to your speaking rate, but more importantly, you should have a calm tone, consistent rate and a normal comfortable breathing pattern. It's OK to pause your speech in order to take a breath and get your thoughts in order. Silence is a powerful message when communicating, it allows the other person time to think and reflect on what you said.

Saying "Um" or "ah" frequently when you speak can be distracting and never helps you get your message across. So, remember that silence is OK and remember to breathe.

### **ENGAGE YOUR AUDIENCE**

My third tip to improve your communication is to always look for ways to engage the audience, whether it is one person or a group. Some of the ways you can do this are:

- Asking them questions
- Surveying with hands up or signaling them to respond
- Lead them to finish your sentences
- Have them repeat what you have said
- Read something out loud with them

There are many ways you can actively engage your audience and an active audience is always more attentive. Use this to make your audience more engaged with the conversation which allows you to better communicate with them.

## **USING GESTURES AND MOVEMENT**

Speaking of keeping your audience's attention, gestures are a great way to do this. Not only your hand gestures as you speak but your entire body's animation and movement. You may not be in front of a large audience or you might just be sitting behind a meeting table at work. It doesn't matter where, adding some natural movement and gestures to your message livens it up and makes what you have to say easier to remember and engage with for others.

Presentations really require special attention here as some additional movement is critical when displaying pre-developed content as it doesn't have a whole lot of movement and expression. Facial expressions I lump here into gestures as well as your expression with your mouth and eyes are key to showing interest, noteworthy points and your own engagement in a conversation.

## **GETTING TO A POINT**

While I know that I personally have a severe lack of patience and appreciate knowing what someone is talking about, I still do appreciate a good story behind a point that someone is trying to make.

It's important to not lead on your audience too long before making your point and it is often best to simply state it first and then explain any reasoning or findings that brought you to that particular message. Whether someone is patient or not, you don't want to lose the attention of your audience before you've made your point as it's nearly impossible to get it back once lost. Staying on point also means keeping your message simple. Stay on one topic and don't jump around your main points attempting to cover too much material.

## **DON'T USE THE WORD BUT**

There are a number of words that are never helpful in communication and "but" is one of them that is in the top 10 list and a personal pet peeve of mine. That word is used to essentially negate everything before it so knowing that, you might as well not have said anything before it and left the "but" out altogether. A terrible mistake in communicating with others and unfortunately a habit of many people when debating a subject is to agree with someone's point and then negate that using the word "but" and stating their own opinion to replace the original idea.

Don't do that, it does nothing but harm when communicating with others. This is a really tough one to control and something worth paying attention to if you have a habit of using this word. Work to simply eliminate using it by just forming two separate sentences instead.

Or you can use the word "and" instead of "but" which show agreement plus your own point of view instead of something to replace it. This is a subtle element of improving your communication with speak and it is also a very important one!



## **SPEAK WITH PASSION**

I've saved the best for last here, at least as far as I'm concerned. Speaking with passion is not easy and the scary part is that a lot of people aren't passionate about anything to even know what that might mean. What it means to me is that you speak with an enthusiasm and conviction towards the subject that an audience can see that what you have to say is absolutely true and dear to you, that you believe in what you say and that you want to successfully communicate. Speaking with passion will be visible in different ways for each person and is often seen by:

- High amounts of movement and expression
- Massive pitch and volume swings
- Vivid details and imaginative descriptions of the subject matter
- Visible or audible emotion
- Total engagement with all parties completely unaware of distractions

## **BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING**

### **INTRODUCTION**

Communicating in the workplace isn't an easy task. We all come from different backgrounds and bring different experiences to the table. Whether problems come from dealing with cultural differences or with messages stemming from non-verbal communication or body language, the barriers to effective communication can be a disruptive force in the workplace. Unclear language can create a hindrance in understanding, as can delivering in a tone or manner that is counterproductive to the meaning of the message. Closing off your body while suggesting you are open to communicating, for instance, creates a barrier. Also, listening is one of the biggest barriers to effective business communication. Not listening actively can create large gaps in meaning.

In a situation where there are cultural barriers to enjoying effective communication, overcoming the problem can involve learning more about acceptable forms of communicating and listening in your partner's culture. But how do you improve your own communication skills? You can prevent barriers stemming from miscommunication by listening more actively. Paraphrase the message to be sure you understand and ask questions for clarity. When delivering a message, keep your body open and available in order to strengthen a message communicating this.

Preparation is also key — when you have to give a speech, prepare what you'll say beforehand in order to prevent talking in circles.

Finally, everyone communicates differently. A forceful message may motivate one person and overwhelm another. Understanding individual differences is an important way to keep your business communication effective and barrier-free.



All of us have experienced occasions when we wished we had listened more closely to what was being said. Usually, good listening requires self-discipline, and sometimes it requires self-examination. If you sometimes have problems listening to what others say, some of these factors may be behind the difficulty:

### **Prejudice**

You may conclude — either before or during the speaker's remarks — that the speaker has nothing significant to say. The reasons for such prejudice are many. They may include the speaker's appearance, age, actions, voice, race, religion and nationality. All of us carry around petty biases. It's easy to say that we should get rid of them, but prejudices are emotional, not rational, and they can be insidious. It's best to overcome our prejudices, but while we're overcoming them we must learn to override them when our best interests are involved. You do this by taking charge of your thoughts.

Force yourself to seek out the value in what is being said. When you're lost and asking for directions, you don't let your attention stray because the person giving directions is wearing overalls instead of a business suit. You listen for the information you need to get to your destination. When you're inclined to tune out a speaker because of some prejudice, remind yourself of the purpose of the conversation. Keep that purpose in mind, and listen for the words that bear on that purpose.

### **Jumping To Conclusions**

You may decide that what the speaker is saying is too difficult, too trite, too boring, or otherwise unsuited to your needs. Therefore, you feign attentiveness while your mind is elsewhere. When you encounter this situation, bring your mind back to the here and now. Accept the challenge of drawing from the speaker some ideas and information that will be valuable to you personally. If the message is too trite or too boring, use questions to probe for more interesting and stimulating material. If the information is too difficult, ask the speaker to simplify. Just say, "You're a pro at this, and I'm not. Give it to me in layman's terms." Then don't be afraid to ask questions for clarification. The speaker will be flattered by your interest and will be eager to help you understand.

### **Assumptions**

You may assume that you already know what the speaker is going to say, so your attention drifts elsewhere. As a result, you miss any new information the speaker may give. When you find yourself thinking this way, make it a game to look for something new to take away from the conversation.

### **Inattention**

If you're like most people, you speak about 125 words per minute, but you can think at more than 400 words per minute. As a result, you may use the "spare time" to think

of what you're going to say next. In the process, you may miss out on much of what the speaker is saying. The remedy is to use the "spare" time to evaluate and interpret what the speaker is saying. You can frame your own response when it comes your turn to speak.

### **Selective Listening**

You may sometimes hear only what you want to hear. Once again, the solution is to evaluate and interpret. Look for information and ideas that challenge your own ideas. Compare them with what you know and what you feel. Think about how you might deal with this information or these ideas. Should you reconsider your own position? Should you devise new strategies in light of the information?

### **Excessive Talking**

If you insist on monopolizing the conversation, you're not going to hear very much. Be conscious of the amount of time you spend talking, and be alert for signs that your listener has something to say. Be willing to yield the floor at reasonable intervals.

### **Lack of Empathy**

Good listeners try to see things from the speaker's perspective. If you listen strictly from your own perspective, you may miss out on the relevance of what is being said. The speaker's vantage point is an important part of the message.

### **Fear**

When you suspect that what is about to be said will reflect unfavourably upon you, fear may result. Many people will stop listening then and find ways to start arguments, or use some other means of escape.

## **CONCEPT TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING**

More attention is usually paid to making people better speakers or writers (the "supply side" of the communication chain) rather than on making them better listeners or readers (the "demand side"). The most direct way to improve communication is by learning to listen more effectively. Nearly every aspect of human life could be improved by better listening — from family matters to corporate business affairs to international relations. Most of us are terrible listeners. We're such poor listeners, in fact, that we don't know how much we're missing. The following are eight common barriers to good listening, with suggestions for overcoming each.

### **Knowing the Answer**

"Knowing the answer" means that you think you already know what the speaker wants to say, before she actually finishes saying it. You might then impatiently cut her off or try to

complete the sentence for her. Even more disruptive is interrupting her by saying that you disagree with her, but without letting her finish saying what it is that you think you disagree with. That's a common problem when a discussion gets heated, and which causes the discussion to degrade quickly. By interrupting the speaker before letting her finish, you're essentially saying that you don't value what she's saying. Showing respect to the speaker is a crucial element of good listening. The "knowing the answer" barrier also causes the listener to pre-judge what the speaker is saying a kind of closed-mindedness. A good listener tries to keep an open, receptive mind. He looks for opportunities to stretch his mind when listening, and to acquire new ideas or insights, rather than reinforcing existing points of view.

### **Strategy for Overcoming this Barrier**

A simple strategy for overcoming the "knowing the answer" barrier is to wait for three seconds after the speaker finishes before beginning your reply. Three seconds can seem like a very long time during a heated discussion, and following this rule also means that you might have to listen for a long time before the other person finally stops speaking. That's usually a good thing, because it gives the speaker a chance to fully vent his or her feelings. Another strategy is to schedule a structured session during which only one person speaks while the other listens. You then switch roles in the next session.

*It's worth emphasizing that the goal of good listening is simply to listen — nothing more and nothing less.* During the session when you play the role of listener, you are only allowed to ask supportive questions or seek clarification of the speaker's points. You may not make any points of your own during this session. That can be tricky, because some people's "questions" tend to be more like statements.

Keeping the mind open during conversation requires discipline and practice. One strategy is to make a commitment to learn at least one unexpected, worthwhile thing during every conversation. The decision to look for something new and interesting helps make your mind more open and receptive while listening.

Using this strategy, most people will probably discover at least one gem — and often more than one — no matter whom the conversation is with.

### **Trying as Helpful Tool**

Another significant barrier to good listening is "trying to be helpful". Although trying to be helpful may seem beneficial, it interferes with listening because the listener is thinking about how to solve what he perceives to be the speaker's problem. Consequently, he misses what the speaker is actually saying.

An old Zen proverb says, "When walking, walk. When eating, eat." In other words, give your whole attention to whatever you're doing. It's worth emphasizing that the goal of good listening is simply to listen — nothing more and nothing less. Interrupting

the speaker in order to offer advice disrupts the flow of conversation, and impairs the listener's ability to understand the speaker's experience. Many people have a "messiah complex" and try to fix or rescue other people as a way of feeling fulfilled. Such people usually get a kick out of being problem-solvers, perhaps because it gives them a sense of importance. However, that behaviour can be a huge hurdle to good listening. Trying to be helpful while listening also implies that you've made certain judgements about the speaker. That can raise emotional barriers to communication, as judgements can sometimes mean that the listener doesn't have complete respect for the speaker.

In a sense, giving a person your undivided attention while listening is the purest act of love you can offer. Because human beings are such social animals, simply knowing that another person has listened and understood is empowering. Often that's all a person needs in order to solve the problems on his or her own. If you as a listener step in and heroically offer your solution, you're implying that you're more capable of seeing the solution than the speaker is. If the speaker is describing a difficult or long-term problem, and you offer a facile, off-the-cuff solution, you're probably forgetting that he or she may have already considered your instant solution long before.

### **Strategy for Overcoming this Barrier**

Schedule a separate session for giving advice. Many people forget that it's rude to offer advice when the speaker isn't asking for it. Even if the advice is good. In any case, a person can give better advice if he first listens carefully and understands the speaker's complete situation before trying to offer advice. If you believe you have valuable advice that the speaker isn't likely to know, then first politely ask if you may offer what you see as a possible solution. Wait for the speaker to clearly invite you to go ahead before you offer your advice.

### **Treating Discussion as Competition**

Some people feel that agreeing with the speaker during a heated discussion is a sign of weakness. They feel compelled to challenge every point the speaker makes, even if they inwardly agree. Discussion then becomes a contest, with a score being kept for who wins the most points by arguing. Treating discussion as competition is one of the most serious barriers to good listening. It greatly inhibits the listener from stretching and seeing a different point of view. It can also be frustrating for the speaker.

### **Strategy for Overcoming this Barrier**

Although competitive debate serves many useful purposes, and can be great fun, debating should be scheduled for a separate session of its own, where it won't interfere with good listening. Except in a very rare case where you truly disagree with absolutely everything the speaker is saying, you should avoid dismissing her statements completely. Instead, affirm the points of agreement. Try to voice active agreement whenever you do agree, and be very

specific about what you disagree with. A good overall listening principle is to be generous with the speaker. Offer affirmative feedback as often as you feel comfortable doing so. Generosity also entails clearly voicing exactly where you disagree, as well as where you agree.

### **Trying to Influence or Impress**

Because good listening depends on listening just for the sake of listening, any ulterior motive will diminish the effectiveness of the listener. Examples of ulterior motives are trying to impress or to influence the speaker.

A person who has an agenda other than simply to understand what the speaker is thinking and feeling will not be able to pay complete attention while listening.

Psychologists have pointed out that people can understand language about two or three times faster than they can speak. That implies that a listener has a lot of extra mental “bandwidth” for thinking about other things while listening. A good listener knows how to use that spare capacity to think about what the speaker is talking about.

A listener with an ulterior motive, such as to influence or impress the speaker, will probably use the spare capacity to think about his “next move” in the conversation — his rebuttal or what he will say next when the speaker is finished — instead of focusing on understanding the speaker.

### **Strategy for Overcoming this Barrier**

“Trying to influence or impress” is a difficult barrier to overcome, because motives usually can’t just be willed away. Deciding not to have a motive usually only drives it beneath your awareness so that it becomes a hidden motive.

One strategy is to make note of your internal motives while you’re listening. Simply by noticing your motives, any ulterior motives will eventually unravel, allowing you to let go and to listen just for the sake of listening.

That strategy comes from Vipassana meditation, where Buddhists try to free themselves of inner motives without seeking explicitly to do so.

### **Reacting to Red Flag Words**

Words can provoke a reaction in the listener that wasn’t necessarily what the speaker intended. When that happens the listener won’t be able to hear or pay full attention to what the speaker is saying. Red flag words or expressions trigger an unexpectedly strong association in the listener’s mind, often because of the listener’s private beliefs or experiences.

Technology is often seen as the driver of improved communications, but technology, in itself, creates noise and discord as much as it melds minds.

Good listeners have learned how to minimize the distraction caused by red flag words, but a red flag word will make almost any listener momentarily unable to hear

with full attention. An important point is that the speaker may not have actually meant the word in the way that the listener understood. However, the listener will be so distracted by the red flag that she will not notice what the speaker actually did mean to say. Red flag words don't always provoke emotional reactions. Sometimes they just cause slight disagreements or misunderstandings. Whenever a listener finds himself disagreeing or reacting, he should be on the lookout for red flag words or expressions.

### **Strategy for Overcoming this Barrier**

When a speaker uses a word or expression that triggers a reflexive association, you as a good listener can ask the speaker to confirm whether she meant to say what you think she said.

When you hear a word or expression that raises a red flag, try to stop the conversation, if possible, so that you don't miss anything that the speaker says. Then ask the speaker to clarify and explain the point in a different way.

### **Believing in Language**

One of the trickiest barriers is "believing in language" — a misplaced trust in the precision of words. Language is a guessing game. Speaker and listener use language to predict what each other is thinking. Meaning must always be actively negotiated. It's a fallacy to think that a word's dictionary definition can be transmitted directly through using the word. An example of that fallacy is revealed in the statement, "I said it perfectly clearly, so why didn't you understand?". Of course, the naive assumption here is that words that are clear to one person are clear to another, as if the words themselves contained absolute meaning.

Words have a unique effect in the mind of each person, because each person's experience is unique. Those differences can be small, but the overall effect of the differences can become large enough to cause misunderstanding. A worse problem is that words work by pointing at experiences shared by speaker and listener. If the listener hasn't had the experience that the speaker is using the word to point at, then the word points at nothing. Worse still, the listener may quietly substitute a different experience to match the word.

### **Strategy for Overcoming this Barrier**

You as a good listener ought to practice mistrusting the meaning of words. Ask the speaker supporting questions to cross-verify what the words mean to him. Don't assume that words or expressions mean exactly the same to you as they do to the speaker. You can stop the speaker and question the meaning of a word. Doing that too often also becomes an impediment, of course, but if you suspect that the speaker's usage of the word might be slightly different, you ought to take time to explore that, before the difference leads to misunderstanding.

### **Mixing up Forest and Trees**

A common saying refers to an inability “to see the forest for the trees”. Sometimes people pay such close attention to detail, that they miss the overall meaning or context of a situation. Some speakers are what we will call “trees” people. They prefer concrete, detailed explanations. They might explain a complex situation just by naming or describing its characteristics in no particular order. Other speakers are “forest” people. When they have to explain complex situations, they prefer to begin by giving a sweeping, abstract, bird’s-eye view. Good explanations usually involve both types, with the big-picture “forest” view providing context and overall meaning, and the specific “trees” view providing illuminating examples. When trying to communicate complex information, the speaker needs to accurately shift between forest and trees in order to show how the details fit into the big picture. However, speakers often forget to use “turn indicators” to signal that they are shifting from one to another, which can cause confusion or misunderstanding for the listener.

Each style is prone to weaknesses in communication. For example, “trees” people often have trouble telling their listener which of the details are more important and how those details fit into the overall context. They can also fail to tell their listener that they are making a transition from one thought to another — a problem that quickly shows up in their writing, as well. “Forest” people, on the other hand, often baffle their listeners with obscure abstractions. They tend to prefer using concepts, but sometimes those concepts are so removed from the world of the senses that their listeners get lost. “Trees” people commonly accuse “forest” people of going off on tangents or speaking in unwarranted generalities. “Forest” people commonly feel that “trees” people are too narrow and literal.

### **Strategy for Overcoming Barrier**

You as a good listener can explicitly ask the speaker for overall context or for specific exemplary details, as needed. You should cross-verify by asking the speaker how the trees fit together to form the forest. Having an accurate picture of how the details fit together is crucial to understanding the speaker’s thoughts. An important point to remember is that a “trees” speaker may become confused or irritated if you as the listener try to supply missing context, and a “forest” speaker may become impatient or annoyed if you try to supply missing examples. A more effective approach is to encourage the speaker to supply missing context or examples by asking him open-ended questions. Asking open-ended questions when listening is generally more effective than asking closed-ended ones.

For example, an open-ended question such as “Can you give me a concrete example of that?” is less likely to cause confusion or disagreement than a more closed-ended one such as “Would such-and-such be an example of what you’re talking about?” Some speakers may even fail to notice that a closed-ended question is actually a question. They may then disagree with what they thought was a statement of opinion, and that



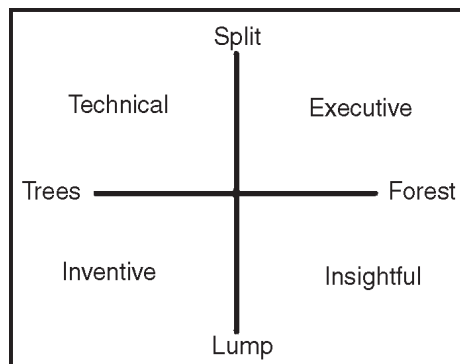
will cause distracting friction or confusion. The strategy of asking open-ended questions, instead of closed-ended or leading questions, is an important overall component of good listening.

### Over-Splitting or Over-Lumping

People have different styles of organizing thoughts when explaining complex situations. Some people, “splitters”, tend to pay more attention to how things are different. Other people, “lumpers”, tend to look for how things are alike. Perhaps this is a matter of temperament. If the speaker and listener are on opposite sides of the splitter-lumper spectrum, the different mental styles can cause confusion or lack of understanding. A listener who is an over-splitter can inadvertently signal that he disagrees with the speaker over everything, even if he actually agrees with most of what the speaker says and only disagrees with a nuance or point of emphasis. That can cause “noise” and interfere with the flow of conversation. Likewise, a listener who is an over-lumper can let crucial differences of opinion go unchallenged, which can lead to a serious misunderstanding later. The speaker will mistakenly assume that the listener has understood and agreed. It’s important to achieve a good balance between splitting (critical thinking) and lumping (metaphorical thinking). Even more important is for the listener to recognize when the speaker is splitting and when she is lumping.

### Strategy for Overcoming this Barrier

An approach to overcoming this barrier when listening is to ask questions to determine more precisely where you agree or disagree with what the speaker is saying, and then to explicitly point that out, when appropriate. For example, you might say, “I think we have differing views on several points here, but do we at least agree that... ?” or “We agree with each other on most of this, but I think we have different views in the area of.” By actively voicing the points of convergence and divergence, the listener can create a more accurate mental model of the speaker’s mind. That reduces the conversational noise that can arise when speaker and listener fail to realise how their minds are aligned or unaligned.





### **Quadrant of Cognitive/Explanatory Styles**

More than one barrier may often be present at once. For example, a speaker might be an over-splitter who has trouble seeing the forest, while the listener is an over-lumper who can see only the forest and never the trees. They will have even more difficulty communicating if one or both also has the habit of “knowing the answer” or “treating discussion as competition”. Good Listening Is arguably one of the most important skills to have in today’s complex world. Families need good listening to face complicated stresses together. Corporate employees need it to solve complex problems quickly and stay competitive. Students need it to understand complex issues in their fields. Much can be gained by improving listening skills.

When the question of how to improve communication comes up, most attention is paid to making people better speakers or writers (the “supply side” of the communication chain) rather than on making them better listeners or readers (the “demand side”). More depends on listening than on speaking. An especially skillful listener will know how to overcome many of the deficiencies of a vague or disorganized speaker. On the other hand, it won’t matter how eloquent or cogent a speaker is if the listener isn’t paying attention.

The listener arguably bears more responsibility than the speaker for the quality of communication.

## **RECEIVING**

This step is easily understood. You may send a message to me by E-mail. It may be wonderfully composed and clear. You may have used effective techniques to organize and support your message. The subject may be one of great interest to me. Imagine further that I both admire and respect you, and that I like to receive E-mail from you.

In short, you have done a good job and I want to receive the message. But if I don’t turn on my computer, I won’t receive it. The message remains somewhere between your computer and mine—between sender and receiver. Much human listening fails for the same reason. Receivers simply are not connected or “tuned in” to the senders. Sometimes, the problem is a physiological one; for example, the receiver has a hearing deficiency due to a congenital or inherited weakness. Or perhaps the deficiency resulted from an accident, a disease, or prolonged exposure to loud noises.

Sometimes the problem can be corrected through the use of mechanical devices that restore hearing loss, or through hearing aids that amplify sound. Scientists and engineers are constantly developing new products designed to correct and help specific types of hearing loss. Remember that hearing and listening are not the same. Hearing is the reception of sound; listening is the attachment of meaning. Hearing is, however, a necessary prerequisite for listening and an important component of the listening process.

## ATTENDING

Let's continue with the E-mail analogy. When I turn my computer on, it will receive the message that you sent. But I must do more: I must attend to the message if the process is to continue. Perhaps I received a phone call just after I turned my computer on and had to move away from my desk; I do not know that you have sent a message. Or maybe I don't have an opportunity to read my E-mail that day.

Suppose that I am working on something else when the message arrives. My computer signals that I have mail from you. I want to read it, but I decide that I will do it later. I continue to stay busy on another task, however, and forget to read the message. Later, I may mistakenly "trash it" without ever reading it. Whatever the case, I don't attend to the message. Human listening is often ineffective—or does not occur—for similar reasons. Receiving occurs, but attending does not.

At any given time, numerous messages compete for our attention. The stimuli may be external, such as words spoken by a lecturer or printed on paper, or events occurring around us. Or the stimuli may be internal, such as a deadline we must meet tomorrow, a backache we developed by sitting too long at the computer, or the hunger pangs we experience because we didn't take time to eat lunch. Whatever the source of the stimuli, we simply can't focus on all of them at the same time. We therefore must choose, whether consciously or unconsciously, to attend to some stimuli and reject others. Three factors determine how these choices are made.

- **Selectivity of attention.** We direct attention to certain things to prevent an information overload. A common example makes the point. Suppose you are attempting to read a book and watch TV at the same time. Although some people claim they can do this, actually both activities suffer—and usually one more than the other. The material that is most engaging or interesting will attract your attention. At other times, something may interrupt or disturb your attention.

In 1974, I was teaching at a large midwestern university. The fad of "streaking"—in which a stark-naked (or nearly naked) student dashes through a gathering of people—had hit the campus. One day as I was lecturing to a thousand students in an auditorium, a streaker dressed only in combat boots and a football helmet ran across the stage. Needless to say, I lost the attention of the audience. I tried for several minutes to regain their attention, then finally decided to dismiss the class 10 minutes early. I had always believed that I was a good lecturer and could hold the audience's attention, no matter what; I was wrong! Selectivity of attention explains why you "perk up" or pay attention when something familiar to you, such as your hometown or your favourite hobby, is mentioned. In fact, you may have been listening intently to a conversation when someone in a different conversation mentions your name. Immediately, the focus of your attention shifts to the conversation in which your name was mentioned.

- **Strength of attention.** Attention is not only selective; it possesses energy, or strength. Attention requires effort and desire. In the example of reading a book and watching TV, the receiver (reader/watcher) directed his or her primary attention towards either the book or the TV. Complete attention can be given to only one stimulus at a time, and necessary attention to only a limited number of stimuli at the same time. If we spend too much energy on too many stimuli, we soon will not be paying attention to any of them. We are all familiar with aircraft accidents that were caused at least in part by controllers in the tower having to process too much information.

Consider also how we can be so attentive to a newspaper, a TV programme, a personal computer, a sports event, or another individual that we are oblivious to things around us. Watch a young couple in love sometime: You'll see a good example of intensity, or strength of attention. Still another measure of attention strength is the length of time that the memory of something continues to influence us. I still remember vividly the baptism of my first grandchild, the first major league baseball game I attended, and the first time I kissed my wife—not necessarily in that order, of course. Strength of attention is important.

- **Sustainment of attention.** Just as attention is determined by selectivity and strength, it is affected by time of sustainment. Our attention wanes, and this fact is important to an understanding of listening.

For example, we can listen to some public speakers far longer than we can listen to others. Duration may depend on the subject, the setting, the way the speech is packaged, and on the speaker's delivery. But no matter how articulate and skilled the speaker, or how interesting the content, our attention finally ends. If for no other reason, the human body requires sleep or attention to other bodily needs. The mind can only pay attention for as long as the body can sit still. Selectivity, strength, and sustainment determine attention. Receiving and attending are prerequisites to the rest of the listening process. The third step in that process is understanding.

## UNDERSTANDING

Someone has said, "Communication begins with understanding." How true! A message may have been sent and received, and the receiver may have attended to the message—yet, there has been no effective communication. Effective communication depends on understanding; that is, effective communication does not take place until the receiver understands the message. Understanding must result for communication to be effective.

Let's return to the E-mail analogy. Suppose I received the E-mail message, "opened" it, and read it. Has effective communication occurred? Not necessarily. Even though I read every word of your message, I may not have understood what you meant. There are several possible reasons for the misunderstanding. Perhaps I expected the message to say something that it didn't say; my understanding of it may therefore be more in line

with my own expectations than what it actually said. We often hear or read what we expect rather than what was actually said or written. Or perhaps the real point of the message was “tucked away,” obscured by several other tidbits of information. And I missed the point. In listening, the key point is sometimes missed. A worker may tell a supervisor several things that happened while the supervisor was out of the office. While relating all the events, the worker mentions that the boss asked that the supervisor call upon his return. The supervisor missed this important piece of information because he was not “ready” for it; that is, he was trying to understand the other parts of the message. Later, he asks the worker why he had failed to tell him that his boss wanted to see him. But the worker had told him; he just didn’t understand.

Our expectations and/or our failure to get the point often lead to misunderstanding. But the major reason for my not understanding the E-mail I received from you was probably something else: the words you used and the manner in which you arranged them. Neither of us was necessarily “at fault”; we simply attached different meanings to the words. You attached one meaning to those words, I attached another. We communicate effectively with each other only insofar as we share meanings for the symbols—verbal or non-verbal—that we are using.

With E-mail, the message is limited to words or other visual symbols that represent words. In listening, both verbal and non-verbal symbols are crucial to understanding. Consider the roles they play.

- Verbal symbols. Verbal communication means communicating through the use of words, whether spoken or written. Two barriers obstruct our understanding of verbal communication.

*Barrier #1:* The same words mean different things to different people. This barrier is a common one, and it may be experienced whenever any two people attempt to communicate.

I may tell my colleague that the temperature in the office is quite comfortable. My “quite comfortable,” however, is her “uncomfortable”: 75 degrees is comfortable for me; 70 degrees is comfortable for her. The same word can mean different things to different people. A friend tells me he will be over in five minutes. To him, five minutes means “soon”—perhaps any time in the next half hour. I, on the other hand, attach a literal meaning: Five minutes means five minutes.

Some years ago, I was speaking at a civilian university. My wife, Ann, had accompanied me and had gone shopping while I was speaking. I had asked her to pick me up at noon. There was an attractive circular drive at the front of the building where I was speaking. To the rear of the building was a small circular drive used mostly by service and delivery vehicles. In my message to Ann, I had said simply, “Pick me up at the circular drive.” Ann immediately thought of the nice drive in front of the building; I was thinking of the one at the back. Fortunately, it didn’t take us too long to discover the mistake.

In the previous examples, the same words having different meanings for different people caused only minor irritation. The consequences can be more severe, as described in the following story told by a fire inspector. The fire inspector said that workers exhibit great caution when they are working around gasoline drums. They take great care not to smoke or ignite matches nearby. But when the drums are emptied, and labeled “empty gasoline drums,” caution is thrown to the wind. Workers feel comfortable in striking matches and smoking cigarettes in the area. Ironically, vapors that emanate from “empty” drums are much more volatile than liquid gasoline.

The word “empty” holds a different meaning for the workers than for the experienced fire inspector, who knows that the potential for disaster is present. The next example shows how a misunderstanding of one word’s meaning can lead to tragic consequences.

A traveler stopped at a convenience store to ask directions. The man behind the counter pointed to a traffic signal a block away and said, “Go to that intersection, take an immediate left, go about a mile. It will be the big red building on your right.”

The traveler repeated, “Go to the traffic light, take an immediate left, go a mile to the red building on my right. Is that it?”

“That’s right,” said the convenience store operator.

Unfortunately, the traffic light was on the corner heading into the intersection and the man in the store had neglected to mention the grassy median that separated northbound and southbound lanes. The traveler took an “immediate left” and headed south in the northbound lane. Less than one block later, he slammed headfirst into an eighteen-wheeler and was killed.

When the same words mean different things to different people, misunderstanding occurs. But there is another barrier to effective verbal communication that can cause just as much trouble.

*Barrier #2:* Different words sometimes mean the same thing. Many things are called by more than one name. For example, when my adolescent son, Marc, and I went to a restaurant in the South shortly after we had moved here from the Midwest, Marc asked the waiter to bring him a “pop.” The waiter didn’t understand until Marc said, “You know—pop, it comes in a bottle or a can; you shake it and it fizzes.” The waiter said, “Oh! You mean a soda.” But “soda” meant quite something else to Marc, and there were a few more moments of confusion until the waiter and Marc understood one another. Soft drink, soda, and pop all mean the same thing when used in the same context. The name used depends on who is doing the talking. How many things in the English language are called by more than one name? For a starter, consider that the 500 most commonly used words in our language have a total of about 15,000 definitions—an average of 30 per word. The following sentence will serve to illustrate the point.

Fred has been crestfallen since he fell out of favour with the Fall Festival Committee last fall after he had a falling out with Joe because Joe had fallen in with a new crowd of people rather than falling in love with Fred’s sister, Fallina.

Not a great sentence, but it illustrates a few of the more than 50 meanings of “fall.” Our language is marked by its multi usage. If you doubt it, describe some object or animal in detail to several talented artists and ask them to draw what you describe. Chances are that each one will draw a distinctively different picture.

These two barriers—same words meaning different things and different words meaning the same thing—can be overcome if you realize the following fact: Meanings are not in words, meanings are in people. We listen more effectively when we consider the message in relation to its source. Good listeners always consider who the sender of the message is. Knowing something about the sender pays big dividends when it comes to understanding the message.

- Non-verbal symbols. We use non-verbal symbols to transmit many times more information than our verbal symbols carry. We communicate non-verbally through action factors, non-action factors, and vocal factors. Each suggests a barrier to listening.

*Barrier #1: Misinterpretation of the action.* Eye contact, gestures, and facial expression are action factors that affect the meaning we attach to a message. For that matter, any movement or action carries meaning.

When someone walks quickly away from a conversation or taps a pencil on the desk during a conversation, we may conclude that the person is in a hurry or is bored. Our conclusions may or may not be correct, however. We may conclude that speakers who twitch, or otherwise seem to us unsure, are nervous when, in fact, they may not be.

*Barrier #2: Misinterpretation of non-action symbols.* The clothes I wear, the automobile I drive, and the objects in my office—all these things communicate something about me. In addition, my respect of your needs for time and space affects how you interpret my messages. For example, if I am to see you at noon but arrive 15 minutes late, my tardiness may affect how you interpret what I say to you. Or if I “crowd” you—get too “close” to you emotionally—when speaking, you may “tune me out”; that is, you may “hear” but not “listen to” my message.

*Barrier #3: Misinterpretation of the voice.* The quality, intelligibility, and variety of the voice affect the listener’s understanding. Quality refers to the overall impression the voice makes on others. Listeners often infer from the voice whether the speaker is happy or sad, fearful or confident, excited or bored. Intelligibility (or understandability) depends on such things as articulation, pronunciation, and grammatical correctness. But variety is the spice of speaking. Variations in rate, volume, force, pitch, and emphasis are some of the factors that influence our understanding of the speaker’s message.

Receiving, attending, and understanding are all crucial if effective listening is to occur, for communication can accurately be defined as the sharing or understanding of meaning. Often, however, the steps of responding and remembering are part of the listening process. Responding and remembering are indicators of listening accuracy.



## RESPONDING

The listening process may end with understanding, since effective communication and effective listening may be defined as the accurate sharing or understanding of meaning. But a response may be needed—or at least helpful. And there are different types of responses.

- Direct verbal responses. These may be spoken or written. Let's continue with the E-mail analogy. After I have received, attended to, and understood the message you sent, I may respond verbally. If your message asked a question or sought my coordination, I might type a response on my computer and reply to you. Perhaps you requested that I call you or come to see you, in which case I do so. Or you might have asked me to write a position paper or think about an issue and give you some advice, in which case I might send a quick E-mail response indicating that I will get back to you later.
- Responses that seek clarification. I may use E-mail to ask for additional information, or I may talk to you either on the telephone or face-to-face. I may be very direct in my request, or I may just say, "tell me more about it."
- Responses that paraphrase. I may say something like, "in other words, what you are saying is...." A paraphrase gives the sender a chance to agree, or to provide information to clarify the message.
- Non-verbal responses. Many times, a non-verbal response is all that is needed; indeed, it may even be the preferred type of response. The knowing nod of the head, an understanding smile, or a "thumbs up" may communicate that the message is understood.

Responding, then, is a form of feedback that completes the communication transaction. It lets the sender know that the message was received, attended to, and understood.

## REMEMBERING

Memorization of facts is not the key to good listening. Yet memory is often a necessary and integral part of the listening process. Some would go so far as to say, "if you can't remember it, you weren't listening."

This statement is often untrue. Think for example, of the times you heard a good joke but can't remember it long enough to get home and tell it; or the number of times you have gone to the grocery store and couldn't remember what you were asked to buy. And the most frustrating situation of all—you were introduced to someone and can't recall the name five minutes later. We often say, "I can remember faces, but I can't remember names." At times, something will "jog" our memory, such as hearing another joke, seeing a similar product on the grocery store shelf, or meeting someone else with the same first name.

What is the relationship between memory and listening? Understanding the differences between short-term memory and long-term memory will help explain the relationship. With short-term memory, information is used immediately—within a few seconds, for example, as with a phone number that we look up. Short-term memory has a rapid forgetting rate and is very susceptible to interruption. And the amount of information that can be retained is quite limited, though it varies somewhat with variations in the material to be retained. For example, most of us can remember only very few random numbers (4, 13, 9, 53, 274, 6, 491, 713, 2810, 1, 7555, 111). But if there is a pattern (1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64, 128, 256, 512, 1024, 2048), the task is much easier. Long-term memory allows us to recall information and events hours, days, weeks—even years—later. You remember, for example, things that happened to you when you were growing up, songs you learned, people you knew. You may have been unaware of those memories for long periods of time, and then the right stimulus caused you to recall them. Perhaps the aroma of a freshly baked pie called to mind your grandmother, who used to make great apple pies years ago.

## **LISTENING CAN IMPROVE WORKPLACE PERFORMANCE**

Listening is an active process that involves focusing on what is said without allowing other thoughts to invade the process. Small business owners and entrepreneurs who employ serious listening skills and foster this ability from their employees will be the most likely to keep their companies growing. Concentrate on listening at work and you should see benefits such as increased productivity, faster progress towards goals and more congenial relationships between employees.

### **REDUCE MISUNDERSTANDINGS**

Inc. Magazine warns employers that when they have poor listening skills themselves they will jeopardize their working relationship with employees. Workers know when they are not really being heard and this decreases their sense of worth in your establishment, builds resentment and motivates them to look for other opportunities. Work on your listening skills by training yourself to focus completely on what is being said. Take the employee to a quiet spot where you and she are less likely to be distracted or interrupted. This helps aid your listening ability and shows the employee you are interested in what she has to tell you.

### **ILLUSTRATING CARING ATTITUDE**

Listening illustrates your caring attitude as a boss in the company. Employees respond positively to an open-door policy in which they know you will listen intently and do your best to resolve issues. The level of trust rises between yourself and your workers



and performance problems decrease. Encourage your staff to listen to one another as well in order to foster employee relationships. This is another instance of showing your concern for employee well-being.

### **FASTER WORK RATE**

When you and your employees listen to each other regarding how to best accomplish tasks, the work proceeds at a faster rate. Taking this step helps help improve clarity and maintain focus during the task at hand. To help her staff understand the important of good listening, you could provide examples in which active listening either helped or hindered a project.

### **LESS “DO-OVERS”**

Good listeners learn from what is being said so they are able to use the information at work without making mistakes. When someone does not listen well, however, comprehension is reduced and the production process is likely to slow. According to the Spring Institute for International Studies, employers should first illustrate the relevance of what they are going to say to the employee before it is said to increase his motivation. For example, explain first that he will be expected to use a new machine that day following your verbal instructions. This heads-up will help guarantee his undivided attention while you speak.

## **TECHNIQUES TO IMPROVE OUR LISTENING SKILLS**

Welcome back to our three-part series on becoming better listeners. In the previous installment, we established that listening is a desirable ability to have as men. But how can we practically begin to exercise this ability and develop it in ourselves? There are active steps we can take to overcome obstacles and establish new listening habits. That is what we'll tackle today.

Sharpening our listening skills is relatively easy to begin practicing since most of it is based on knowing what constitutes good listening and what doesn't. Remember: listening is not a passive process, so all of the techniques below are active, including the ones that are not visible to the speaker.

### **LISTEN WITH AN OPEN MIND**

Be ready to hear and consider all sides of an issue. This does not mean that we have to agree with what is being said, but rather that we must avoid defensiveness. Another way to think of it is to go into an interaction ready to consider new viewpoints and ideas. If it helps, equate this with the scientific process we were taught ad nauseam during grade school. Every opinion and perspective we encounter while listening can

be viewed as the hypothesis that we, as diligent pseudo-scientist listeners, can examine and experiment upon. And just as third grade science debunked my lack of faith that wet paper towels could actually cause a lima bean to sprout, our willingness to listen to a different perspective will sometimes yield surprising new insights for us.

### **LISTEN TO THE ENTIRE MESSAGE WITHOUT JUDGING OR REFUTING**

Suppress the urge to let biases and prejudices prevent you from listening fully. We can only do one thing effectively at a time: listen, judge, or respond. Go in that order. You have to begin with listening to the entire message, then you can weigh your thoughts against what has been said, and finally respond. Allow each role to run its course in turn. When you are the listener, you cannot simultaneously be the judge. Our minds do not work in categories quite so neatly, but when we make this effort to suppress or postpone our desire to make premature judgements we become better listeners. A great way to prepare for this in advance is to be aware of what your biases are and then try to reason out why you feel this way. What “buzz words” or topics generate a strong emotional reaction—either positive or negative—in you? If you judge and then speak too soon, you’ve opened the possibility of having missed a critical part of the message and thus embarrassing yourself by jumping to conclusions.

### **DETERMINE THE CONCEPTS AND CENTRAL IDEAS OF THE MESSAGE**

The best gauge to know whether you are listening or just hearing is whether or not you are actively looking for the central idea(s) of what is being said. This could easily morph into a whole other issue about the structure of a message, but that is not our focus here. Here, we are the listener, and if the message is well-constructed then our role will be easier, but we will not always have that luxury. A great technique, regardless of the speaker’s ability to construct a message, is to listen in such a way that you can summarize what you gleaned to be the central idea(s). What are the common threads—the ideas that seem to weave their way into everything being said? If the situation allows, you can then share your summary with the speaker and confirm (or revise) your understanding. Doing this builds your confidence as a listener, plus it proves to the speaker that you were listening.

### **LEARN TO ADAPT TO THE SPEAKER’S APPEARANCE, PERSONALITY, AND DELIVERY**

Don’t allow a stereotype—either negative or positive—to influence your listening. Despite conventional wisdom against judging a book by its cover, we do so consciously and unconsciously every day. Appearance can be a major factor, and not everyone is blessed with dashing good looks or the sartorial wisdom we find here at The Art of Manliness. We’re just going to have to deal with it. After all, Abraham Lincoln was no George Clooney.

The sixteenth president of the United States was a homely-looking fella, but his words changed the course of history. Beyond appearance, we should also spend some time coming to peace with the fact that there are different personalities, styles, and levels of ability. As an English teacher, I have to weigh these elements with every paper I grade, so I understand how tedious it is to cope with things that run against your grain even if they aren't necessarily "wrong."

Although it is far from a quick fix, it can be helpful to study rhetoric so that you can recognize what the speaker does well, thereby giving you something positive to focus on and making it easier to listen. Likewise, studying rhetoric allows you to understand where exactly a speaker falls short, thus eliminating phantom annoyances and allowing you to recognize and accept the stylistic and delivery shortcomings for what they are as you listen.

### **CURB AND OVERCOME DISTRACTIONS**

It takes very little to jerk our attention away from the work of listening. We start out in life as good listeners. Think about how much a baby learns within the first few years of his or her life. Yet babies don't attend classes, read textbooks, or go to seminars. They simply listen, and they do it so well that eventually they start behaving like little adults. Over time, however, a series of bad habits begins to sprout up. Dr. Paine shared the following statistics with us: when a teacher suddenly stopped in the middle of a lesson and asked students to explain the content of the lesson thus far, 90% of first grade students could do so successfully.

That number drops to 80% in second graders, then plummets to 44% in middle school students, and a gut-wrenching 28% in high school. In other words, despite how well we start, our bad habits develop rather quickly.

If we are to become better listeners, we must learn to recognize the obstacles we face. Listening can be hard work and we are fickle—you might be surprised at how little it takes to derail us, especially when most of us were already at 28% recall as teenagers.

*Examples of obstacles we must overcome include:*

- External noises (beeping, humming, etc.)
- Psychological activity (worry, self-consciousness, preoccupation, etc.)
- Physical conditions (temperature, odors, lighting, visual distractions, etc.)
- Physiological conditions (pain, hunger, fatigue, etc.)
- Semantic distractions (dialects, accents, unfamiliar vocabulary, etc.)
- Technological distractions (the urge to check your phone, surf the net, etc.)

Being aware of what is distracting us at any given moment is half the battle. However, when we find ourselves in a situation where we cannot overcome the obstacle, there is nothing wrong with letting the speaker know and suggesting a solution, such as a change of setting or having the discussion at another time. Doing so communicates that we want to give our full attention.

Being aware of those times when we simply cannot muster the ability to do it is important too. Listening requires effort, and we cannot always exert effort in listening any more than we can always lift weights or solve crossword puzzles. It is okay to recognize limitations and the need for rest. It is also okay to admit when we have zoned-out or potentially misunderstood/misheard something. Everyone suffers from poor listening, and the speaker would be hard-pressed to condemn you for recognizing your lapse and making amends for it.

### **ATTEMPT TO FIND A CONNECTION TO OR PERSONAL INTEREST IN THE SPEAKER'S TOPIC**

Develop an attitude that there is always something potentially interesting or valuable to be gleaned, even if that means confirmation that you don't find something interesting or valuable. After all, if you're exerting the effort, you might as well take something away from it. If you've already predetermined that you are uninterested, it would be a Herculean effort for even the best speaker to make the topic interesting. But if we only did the things that were immediately interesting to us, think how much we would miss out on.

Also consider how often seemingly useless information has served you well. Finding connections and personal interest requires self-discipline, but maintaining a positive attitude is essential to being a good listener, especially in those situations where we would rather not listen.

### **REMEMBER THAT LISTENING DOES NOT EQUAL AGREEMENT**

I'll admit that, even after Dr. Paine's lessons, one of my greatest obstacles to listening is the irrational fear that the speaker (or others) will perceive my listening as agreement. We should remember, however, that listening does not equal agreement. Listening does not force us to silence our own opinions, it just asks us to show respect to others. All that listening actually communicates is a willingness to communicate—and nothing more. I think Dr. Paine said it best in these two statements: "Listening demands neither surrender nor agreement; instead, listening demands an open mind" and "Listening actually provides a powerful way to bring about change because listening is thinking, because listening is action."

### **STOP TRYING TO JUMP IN AND TALK**

Pay attention for the "turn taking" signals that are normally a part of the ebb and flow of conversation. Suppressing the urge to voice our thoughts and opinions the moment they form makes us better listeners. At the root of this struggle we'll often find our ego: we believe what we have to say is more important than what they have to say. However, whether we intend it to or not these interruptions devalue their message, and it is often rude and offensive. It's not that we can't share what we have to say, but we

must train ourselves to wait until the appropriate time to do so. It is simply part of the social contract we have with others and honouring it is important—let the other person talk, and you can expect that they extend the same courtesy to you. Of course there is a time and a place for interruption, but there is no formula for it. It is at the mercy of your discretion, but when it becomes necessary to do so—or when the old habit rears its head—it is good to be apologetic and acknowledge that you are interrupting; that sort of awareness goes a long way towards mending your deliberate violation of the other person's right to speak.

### **SHOW THE SPEAKER YOU'RE LISTENING**

It is possible to listen without showing any external signs of it, but a stone-faced audience is rarely what anybody wants. Visibly and audibly demonstrating that we are listening—that we are engaged with and/or interested in what is being said—is just as important as the listening itself. The key is to provide appropriate feedback. As an added bonus, it helps the speaker to adjust his/her message to make it clearer and more interesting.

*Here are some of the things we can do to confirm to others that we are listening:*

- Head nods
- Leaning forward
- Maintaining eye contact
- Taking notes when appropriate
- Verbal affirmation (asking questions of clarification, answering questions posed by the speaker when appropriate, and brief affirmations like “mrm-hrm”)

*By contrast, here are many of the things we do, deliberately or not, which imply to others that we are not listening:*

- Crossing our arms
- Fidgeting
- Multitasking
- Leaning away from the speaker
- Failing to make steady eye contact
- Failing to answer questions posed by the speaker

### **PAY ATTENTION TO BOTH VERBAL AND NON-VERBAL MESSAGES**

Paying attention to body language is just as important as paying attention to the words. If you need proof of the importance of body language, just think about how much more difficult it is to detect something like sarcasm during a phone conversation or in a text message without the benefit of seeing the person's face and body. Without the ability to see another person's facial expression, hand gestures, and other movements, we lose tremendous portions of the communication. Don't ignore it when you have the benefit of its presence!

## **LISTEN TO SILENCE**

Like body language, an absence of words can be just as pregnant with meaning as the words themselves. The tricky thing is that silence can imply almost anything. It could signal anger (which of us has not been on the receiving end of the “silent treatment”?), anxiety, fear, shyness, or contentment, to name a few. It could be something as simple as the need to think. Not to complicate the matter, but silence can also mean nothing—literally. And sometimes silence is just a pause; it is a moment of rest, and that’s okay.

In the film *O Brother Where Art Thou?*, Big Dan T the Bible salesman claims that the last thing you want is “air in the conversation,” which may be true if you are a fast-talking door-to-door salesman trying to push a product, but for the rest of us this couldn’t be further from the truth. Silence gives everyone a chance to rest and think. In fact, I find that the people I can have comfortable periods of silence with are those with whom I have the strongest relationships. Try not to surrender to the urge to break silence—a little air in the conversation doesn’t hurt. All of this should remind us of the importance of body language—listening is done with the eyes as much as it is with the ears. A person’s body language will often give us the clues we need to interpret both words and the absence of words.

## **PLAN TO RESPOND IN SOME FASHION**

The situation will dictate what is appropriate and what is not (don’t blurt out questions in the middle of a eulogy, guys) but you should plan to find some way to respond to a speaker. It might be simple non-verbal signals as the other person speaks. It might be sharing your opinions, insights, or questions when the speaker has finished, perhaps in an e-mail or handwritten letter, but do something to respond, even if it is small.

## **ASK QUESTIONS TO CLARIFY THE MESSAGE**

This is a positive way to show someone that you are listening. I’m a high school teacher, so I know that makes me biased in this regard, but I believe the ability to ask questions is so important that we’ll be looking at it in great detail in the third part of this series. Sometimes asking a good question is more important than knowing the answer.

## **TAKE TIME TO LISTEN TO YOURSELF**

We’ve already addressed the value of silence in a conversation and the pitfalls of the poor habits we so easily adopt. But sometimes our worst habits and the least amount of silence are directed at ourselves. Listening to yourself is a practice arena where you have unlimited opportunities to practice and the speaker (you) will be very forgiving when you stumble. By listening to yourself, you are also better able to cope with obstacles such as prejudices and internal “noise.” If your thoughts are in order, it will be much easier to attend to the thoughts of others.

Dr. Paine had entire assignments based wholly on listening to ourselves. He would make a point to emphasize that the phones, televisions, and music should be off and that we find a comfortable place to be alone. Eliminating the external distractions is only half the battle, though. When listening to yourself, the internal racket is sometimes the greatest enemy. Take time to sit in silence every so often—daily if you can—and listen to yourself without judgement or interruption. Give the whirlwind of your thoughts however much time it needs to settle down. What do you have to say to you? For those of us who find even our emotions (let alone the emotions of others) to be an enigma most of the time—a veritable swamp of foggy confusion—silence is an invaluable way to untangle the knots.

### **AVOID FAKING ATTENTION AND PRETENDING TO LISTEN**

The unique challenge that comes with learning to listen well is that we now know how to fake it. But when someone thinks you were paying attention but in reality you weren't, you are inviting trouble. If the speaker notices, you are insulting him/her. If you are asked to respond in some way, then you will be caught unawares and will most likely suffer embarrassment. And even if you can get away with it, you are gaining nothing except the reinforcement of bad habits.

## **BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING SKILLS**

It is common, when listening to someone else speak, to be formulating a reply whilst the other person is still talking. However, this means that we are not really listening to all that is being said.

Even good listeners are often guilty of critically evaluating what is being said before fully understanding the message that the speaker is trying to communicate. The result is that assumptions are made and conclusions reached about the speaker's meaning, that might be inaccurate. This and other types of ineffective listening lead to misunderstandings and a breakdown in communication.

Even if we are not formulating a response whilst listening, we may still be thinking of other things, albeit subconsciously. During a conversation, how often have thoughts such as “What am I going to have for my dinner”, “Will I have time to finish that report?” or “I hope I am not late picking the kids up” crossed your mind? At such times, we are distracted and not giving our full attention to what is being said. In other words we are not actively listening to the speaker.

We can easily pick up bad habits when it comes to listening - this page examines some of the barriers and bad habits of listening - enabling you to address and correct them. Listening is a key interpersonal skill and a prerequisite to many other communication skills – by learning to listen more effectively you can improve the quality of your professional and personal life.



## COMMON BARRIERS TO LISTENING

There are many things that get in the way of listening and you should be aware of these barriers, many of which are bad habits, in order to become a more effective listener.

*Barriers and bad habits to effective listening can include:*

- Trying to listen to more than one conversation at a time, this includes having the television or radio on while attempting to listen to somebody talk; being on the phone to one person and talking to another person in the same room and also being distracted by some dominant noise in the immediate environment.
- You find the communicator attractive/unattractive and you pay more attention to how you feel about the communicator and their physical appearance than to what they are saying. Perhaps you simply don't like the speaker - you may mentally argue with the speaker and be fast to criticise, either verbally or in your head.
- You are not interested in the topic/issue being discussed and become bored.
- Not focusing and being easily distracted, fiddling with your hair, fingers, a pen etc. or gazing out of the window or focusing on objects other than the speaker.
- Feeling unwell or tired, hungry, thirsty or needing to use the toilet.
- Identifying rather than empathising - understanding what you are hearing but not putting yourself in the shoes of the speaker. As most of us have a lot of internal self-dialogue we spend a lot of time listening to our own thoughts and feelings - it can be difficult to switch the focus from 'I' or 'me' to 'them' or 'you'. Effective listening involves opening your mind to the views of others and attempting to feel empathetic.
- Sympathising rather than empathising - sympathy is not the same as empathy, you sympathise when you feel sorry for the experiences of another, to empathise is to put yourself in the position of the other person.
- You are prejudiced or biased by race, gender, age, religion, accent, and/or past experiences.
- You have preconceived ideas or bias - effective listening includes being open-minded to the ideas and opinions of others, this does not mean you have to agree but should listen and attempt to understand.
- You make judgements, thinking, for example that a person is not very bright or is under-qualified so there is no point listening to what they have to say.
- Previous experiences – we are all influenced by previous experiences in life. We respond to people based on personal appearances, how initial introductions or welcomes were received and/or previous interpersonal encounters. If we stereotype a person we become less objective and therefore less likely to listen effectively.



- Preoccupation - when we have a lot on our minds we can fail to listen to what is being said as we're too busy concentrating on what we're thinking about. This is particularly true when we feel stressed or worried about issues.
- Having a Closed Mind - we all have ideals and values that we believe to be correct and it can be difficult to listen to the views of others that contradict our own opinions. The key to effective listening and interpersonal skills more generally is the ability to have a truly open mind - to understand why others think about things differently to you and use this information to gain a better understanding of the speaker.

### **NON-VERBAL SIGNS OF INEFFECTIVE LISTENING**

*Although with all non-verbal signals a certain amount of error has to be expected, generally signs of inattention while listening include:*

- Lack of eye contact with the speaker – listeners who are engaged with the speaker tend to give eye contact. Lack of eye contact can, however, also be a sign of shyness.
- An inappropriate posture - slouched, leaning back or 'swinging' on a chair, leaning forward onto a desk or table and/or a constantly shifting posture. People who are paying attention tend to lean slightly towards the speaker.
- Being distracted - fidgeting, doodling, looking at a watch, yawning.
- Inappropriate expressions and lack of head nods - often when a listener is engaged with a speaker they nod their head, this is usually an almost subconscious way of encouraging the speaker and showing attention. Lack of head nods can mean the opposite – listening is not happening. The same can be true of facial expressions, attentive listeners use smiles as feedback mechanisms and to show attention.

### **FURTHER SIGNS OF INEFFECTIVE LISTENING**

*Other common traits of ineffective listening include:*

- *Sudden Changes in Topic:* When the listener is distracted they may suddenly think about something else that is not related to the topic of the speaker and attempt to change the conversation to their new topic.
- *Selective Listening:* This occurs when the listener thinks they have heard the main points or have got the gist of what the speaker wants to say. They filter out what they perceive as being of key importance and then stop listening or become distracted.
- *Daydreaming:* Daydreaming can occur when the listener hears something that sets off a chain of unrelated thoughts in their head – they become distracted by their 'own world' and adopt a 'far-away' look.
- *Advising:* Some people want to jump in early in a conversation and start to offer advice before they fully understand the problem or concerns of the speaker.

## DEVELOPING COMMUNICATION SKILLS: LISTENING SKILLS

There are a number of situations when you need to solicit good information from others; these situations include interviewing candidates, solving work problems, seeking to help an employee on work performance, and finding out reasons for performance discrepancies. Skill in communication involves a number of specific strengths. The first we will discuss involves listening skills. The following lists some suggests for effective listening when confronted with a problem at work: Listen openly and with empathy to the other person Judge the content, not the messenger or delivery; comprehend before you judge Use multiple techniques to fully comprehend (ask, repeat, rephrase, etc.)

Active body state; fight distractions Ask the other person for as much detail as he/she can provide; paraphrase what the other is saying to make sure you understand it and check for understanding Respond in an interested way that shows you understand the problem and the employee's concern Attend to non-verbal cues, body language, not just words; listen between the lines Ask the other for his views or suggestions State your position openly; be specific, not global Communicate your feelings but don't act them out (*e.g.* tell a person that his behaviour really upsets you; don't get angry) Be descriptive, not evaluative-describe objectively, your reactions, consequences. Be validating, not invalidating ("You wouldn't understand"); acknowledge other's uniqueness, importance Be conjunctive, not disjunctive (not "I want to discuss this regardless of what you want to discuss"); Don't totally control conversation; acknowledge what was said Own up: use "I", not "They"... not "I've heard you are noncooperative" Don't react to emotional words, but interpret their purpose Practice supportive listening, not one way listening Decide on specific follow-up actions and specific follow up dates. A major source of problem in communication is defensiveness. Effective communicators are aware that defensiveness is a typical response in a work situation especially when negative information or criticism is involved. Be aware that defensiveness is common, particularly with subordinates when you are dealing with a problem. Try to make adjustments to compensate for the likely defensiveness. Realize that when people feel threatened they will try to protect themselves; this is natural. This defensiveness can take the form of aggression, anger, competitiveness, avoidance among other responses. A skilful listener is aware of the potential for defensiveness and makes needed adjustment. He or she is aware that self-protection is necessary and avoids making the other person spend energy defending the self. In addition, a supportive and effective listener does the following:

Stop Talking: Asks the other person for as much detail as he/she can provide; asks for other's views and suggestions Looks at the person, listens openly and with empathy to the employee; is clear about his position; be patient Listen and Respond in an interested

way that shows you understand the problem and the other's concern is validating, not invalidating ("You wouldn't understand"); acknowledge other's uniqueness, importance checks for understanding; paraphrases; asks questions for clarification don't control conversation; acknowledges what was said; let's the other finish before responding Focuses on the problem, not the person; is descriptive and specific, not evaluative; focuses on content, not delivery or emotion Attend to emotional as well as cognitive messages (*e.g.*, anger); aware of non-verbal cues, body language, etc.; listen between the lines React to the message, not the person, delivery or emotion Make sure you comprehend before you judge; ask questions Use many techniques to fully comprehend. Stay in an active body state to aid listening Fight distractions (if in a work situation) Take Notes; Decide on specific follow-up actions and specific follow up dates.

### **CONSTRUCTIVE FEEDBACK: DEVELOPING YOUR SKILLS**

"I don't know how to turn her performance around; she never used to have these attendance problems and her work used to be so good; I don't know why this is happening and what to do." This manager is struggling with one of the most important yet trickiest and most difficult management tasks: providing constructive and useful feedback to others. Effective feedback is absolutely essential to organizational effectiveness; people must know where they are and where to go next in terms of expectations and goals-yours, their own, and the organization. Feedback taps basic human needs-to improve, to compete, to be accurate; people want to be competent. Feedback can be reinforcing; if given properly, feedback is almost always appreciated and motivates people to improve. But for many people, daily work is like bowling with a curtain placed between them and the pins; they receive little information. Be aware of the many reasons why people are hesitant to give feedback; they include fear of causing embarrassment, discomfort, fear of an emotional reaction, and inability to handle the reaction. It is crucial that we realize how critical feedback can be and overcome our difficulties; it is very important and can be very rewarding but it requires skill, understanding, courage, and respect for yourself and others. Withholding constructive feedback is like sending people out on a dangerous hike without a compass. This is especially true in today's fast changing and demanding workplace

### **WHY MANAGERS ARE OFTEN RELUCTANT TO PROVIDE FEEDBACK**

As important as feedback is, this critical managerial task remains one of the most problematic. Many managers would rather have root canal work than provide feedback to another-especially feedback that might be viewed as critical. Why are managers so reluctant to provide feedback? The Reasons are many: fear of the other person's reaction; people can get very defensive and emotional when confronted with feedback and many managers are very fearful of the reaction the feedback may be based on subjective feeling and the manager may be unable to give concrete information if the other person

questions the basis for the feedback the information on which the feedback is based (e.g. performance appraisal) may be a very flawed process and the manager may not totally trust the information many managers would prefer being a coach than “playing God.” Other factors get in the way of effective communication or feedback sessions.

Some of these reasons are: defensiveness, distorted perceptions, guilt, project, transference, distortions from the past misreading of body language, tone noisy transmission (unreliable messages, inconsistency) receiver distortion: selective hearing, ignoring non-verbal cues power struggles self-fulfilling assumptions language-different levels of meaning managers hesitation to be candid assumptions-e.g. assuming others see situation same as you, has same feelings as you distrusted source, erroneous translation, value judgement, state of mind of two people.

### **CHARACTERISTICS OF EFFECTIVE FEEDBACK**

*Effective Feedback has most of the following characteristics:*

- Descriptive (not evaluative)(avoids defensiveness.) By describing one’s own reactions, it leaves the individual free to use it or not to use it as he sees fit..
- Avoid accusations; present data if necessary describe your own reactions or feelings; describe objective consequences that have or will occur; focus on behaviour and your own reaction, not on other individual or his or her attributes suggest more acceptable alternative; be prepared to discuss additional alternatives; focus on alternatives specific rather than general.
- Focused on behaviour not the person. It is important that we refer to what a person does rather than to what we think he is. Thus we might say that a person “talked more than anyone else in this meeting” rather than that he is a “loud-mouth.” It takes into account the needs of both the receiver and giver of feedback. It should be given to help, not to hurt. We too often give feedback because it makes us feel better or gives us a psychological advantage.

It is directed towards behaviour which the receiver can do something about. A person gets frustrated when reminded of some shortcoming over which he has no control. It is solicited rather than imposed. Feedback is most useful when the receiver himself has formulated the kind of question which those observing him can answer or when he actively seeks feedback. Feedback is useful when well-timed (soon after the behaviour-depending, of course, on the person’s readiness to hear it, support available from others, and so forth). Excellent feedback presented at an inappropriate time may do more harm than good. sharing of information, rather than giving advice allows a person to decide for himself, in accordance with his own goals and needs.

When we give advice we tell him what to do, and to some degree take away his freedom to do decide for himself. It involves the amount of information the receiver can use rather than the amount we would like to give. To overload a person with feedback is to reduce the possibility that he may be able to use what he receives effectively.

When we give more than can be used, we are more often than not satisfying some need of our own rather than helping the other person. It concerns what is said and done, or how, not why. The “why” involves assumptions regarding motive or intent and this tends to alienate the person generate resentment, suspicion, and distrust. If we are uncertain of his motives or intent, this uncertainty itself is feedback, however, and should be revealed. It is checked to insure clear communication. One way of doing this is to have the receiver try to rephrase the feedback. No matter what the intent, feedback is often threatening and thus subject to considerable distortion or misinterpretation.

It is checked to determine degree of agreement from others. Such “consensual validation” is of value to both the sender and receiver. It is followed by attention to the consequences of the feedback. The supervisor needs to become acutely aware of the effects of his feedback. It is an important step towards authenticity. Constructive feedback opens the way to a relationship which is built on trust, honest, and genuine concern and mutual growth.

Part of the feedback process involves understanding and predicting how the other person will react. Or in the case of our receiving feedback, we need to understand ways that we respond to feedback, especially threatening feedback. People often react negatively to threatening feedback. This reaction can take a number of forms including: selective reception and selective perception doubting motive of the giver denying validity of the data rationalizing attack the giver of the data. Following the guidelines to effective feedback can go a long way to limit these kinds of reactions but we need to be conscious of them nonetheless and be ready to react appropriately. When we are on the receiving end of feedback we should be careful to avoid these pitfalls. Try to keep these points in mind. Try not to be defensive check on possible misunderstanding (“Let me restate what I am hearing”) gather information from other sources don’t overreact ask for clarification.

## Communications and Line Manager

A public communicator and business executive. He draws from this rich background in discussing two kinds of business communication. First, he examines communication within a moderate-sized business organization. He looks at demands on management and employees and discusses the need for a two-way flow of information.

He then turns to communication between the company and a variety of special audiences outside the company. Lacy argues for communication approaches that begin with concerns of the receiver. As a practitioner of public affairs both in and out of government for some years, I came to the world of corporate line management very much aware of the role of effective communications in attaining organizational and personal goals.

There was nothing very mysterious about the ideas of source and receiver, channel and message selection, or audience analysis. I had a pretty good idea of how to assess—and manage—public perceptions of the organization. But I was not prepared for communicating in an environment that had the profit motive as the driving force for all organizational activities.

What I found as a line manager of a manufacturing/service facility for a mid-sized manufacturing corporation was a bit of a revelation for me. Our company, although not one of the nation's industrial giants, had substantial assets in about thirty locations, employed almost three thousand persons, and possessed a reputation in its chosen markets as a solid, quality-directed, and reliable supplier of services and products. And no one, except our employees, customers, and a few thousand stockholders, really cared. General public perceptions of our firm were, to put it kindly, ill defined. Never, to my knowledge,

had we overcharged the government on a defence contract, endangered the public safety by polluting the environment, been the object of a hostile takeover, or been involved in any event that might have caused the media to focus its unblinking gaze on our firm.

In any case I was hired as a facility manager—not a public relations flak—and it did not take long for me to adjust to the idea that our customers were our audience and that all they expected was to receive fair value for the dollars they spent on our services. What I also discovered was that organizational survival in the marketplace depends solely on making money. Profit is the reason for being for all corporations.

Naturally, there are other goals, like providing jobs, expanding technology, providing money-saving products for the consumer, and a variety of additional worthwhile motivations. But every activity in every corporation has the need for profitability hanging over it. Profit is the canopy that gets the organization safely to the ground. Lack of profits will invariably lead to a rapid fall and a sharp, sudden stop, followed by prompt disappearance of the firm from the marketplace.

The essential concern for keeping the bottom line in the black creates needs within the organization. The organization must recruit and train competent people, establish a network of reliable suppliers of materials and services, and organize internally to ensure that all activities are properly managed.

It must create financial conditions that will ensure a viable cash flow and plan for growth by acquisition and market expansion. Perhaps most importantly, it must create an effective communications structure that will tie all of the diverse functional activities of the organization together and permit them to work in harness while traveling the rocky path to profitability.

## **OBJECTIVE-DRIVEN COMMUNICATIONS**

The way an organization communicates, both within the organization and outside of it, is conditioned and limited by the objectives it sets for its operating units. Many companies, including my own, have adopted the so-called “management by objective” system.

Management by objective involves the establishment of individual objectives by individual managers—and approved in turn by their bosses—which must be attained within some agreed-upon time frame. The idea is that if each manager develops and attains objectives that contribute to the fulfillment of the corporate objectives, the aggregate effort will lead to attainment of corporate goals and the employee will be rewarded accordingly. Not a bad idea!

It is also not without its perils. The principal danger in such an arrangement is that although most of us are conscientious and hard working and share the interests of our employers, we are also eager to do well. Permitted to set our own objectives, therefore, we are likely to select those that are more or less readily attainable. Unfortunately (or



fortunately for the company), our bosses are not likely to give us much of a chance to select only those objectives that are, in the vernacular, a piece of cake. Objectives, we are told, should exceed our grasp by a little bit so that we are driven by them. In other words, good objectives are moderately impossible. But having selected some moderately impossible objectives, we are faced with the task of criteria that prove our success at bonus time. Usually we try to quantify the objectives in terms of numbers of dollars, or man-hours, or sales calls, or project completion dates. In so doing, we create information needs. The need for information in turn creates the need for communication methods that permit us to acquire it. Therein lies the problem.

Managers of functionally specific activities quite naturally develop objectives that are functionally specific. And even though the chosen objectives may be consistent with the goals of the organization, they are often not consistent with one another. For example, the sales manager who has as his principal short-term objective the broadening of the customer base convinces his boss of the importance of making a greater number of sales calls. They agree on an objective, and the message then goes out to the sales force that aggressive coverage of new prospects is the order of the day. The need is therefore created to enable the sales manager to guide and direct, manage, and measure the effectiveness of the activity. In addition, the sales manager also needs documentation for all the new sales contacts to show his boss during the next quarterly performance review that the moderately impossible has been accomplished.

To acquire the needed documentation, the sales manager is likely to establish an accountability reporting system that will provide a continuous flow of detailed information about the day-to-day activities of the sales force. Such accountability systems usually take the form of elaborate written or verbal reports. Because the sales manager cannot spend most of each day talking to salespersons and the sales force cannot spend half its time preparing written reports, the sales manager may use a telephone answering/recording system or a similar one-way communication device that will promote more efficient reporting.

Meanwhile, the hardworking salespersons have set their own objectives. The sales objective is almost always measured in dollars of sales rather than in numbers of calls. If the product or service requires long periods of customer service testing or evaluation or substantial follow-up sales activity, the level of sales by individual salespersons is likely to diminish as most of the time and effort is devoted to calling on new prospects. Moreover, the salesperson may find that the reporting requirement eats up a lot of time that could be more effectively used in other more productive activities.

Tension between the sales manager and members of the sales force develops as the divergence of their objectives becomes more pronounced. Salespersons become less conscientious in their reporting, and the sales manager's objective is threatened as sales calls go unreported. Because the communication channels established by the sales manager provided for only a one-way flow of information and because his objectives



diverged from those of his salespersons, conflict results. A top salesperson gets fed up and leaves the company for a job with the competition—taking her customer list with her. The sales manager misses his objective and begins updating his own resume.

Similarly, the production manager whose objective is to increase productivity in the workforce needs information relative to that objective to measure his progress, effect the needed changes, and, of course, demonstrate to his employer that the moderately impossible is being accomplished. The production manager, with a specific objective, needs specific information and, to no one's surprise, establishes specific communication channels designed to provide functionally specific information on input, throughput, and output. Although the manager's communication device, perhaps a daily time sheet or job history record, may have been designed primarily for acquiring information that could disclose areas of potential productivity improvement, uncover quality problems, improve work flow, or help contain costs, it might easily be perceived by the members of the workforce as a management surveillance tool.

In this instance the consequence of the production manager's inability or unwillingness to make the workforce aware of his objective and of the means he has elected to achieve it could result in problems with unions, loss of highly trained people, and reduced productivity.

The essential points here are

- The objectives of individual managers must align with those of the managed,
- The information needs created by the manager's desire to attain his objective must be accommodated by the use of communication methods and channels that permit employees to perceive accurately true motivations of the manager, and
- One-way communication devices characterized by personal accountability reporting requirements are of marginal utility if their main purpose is to collect information that can be used to demonstrate to a manager's boss that the moderately impossible is being accomplished.

## **UNDERSTANDING AUDIENCE OBJECTIVES**

The problem of conflicting objectives within an organization is perhaps even more troubling in the effect it can have on an organization's ability to communicate with its external audiences. Central to dealing with the problem is an understanding of who the audiences are, what their objectives may be, and how they can be reached.

To communicate effectively with our audiences requires that we understand their goals and how they set objectives to attain them. That understanding is absolutely necessary to the development of effective communication channels and messages that will not only reach our audiences but also have the desired effect on their behaviour. But it is not enough to take a seat-of-the-pants, intuitive approach to achieving the needed understanding. Effective audience assessment dictates effective planning.

## **IDENTIFYING THE AUDIENCES**

Each organization differs; but in a line-operating unit such as the one I manage, there are essentially three external audiences: our customers and potential customers, our immediate community, and those agencies that regulate and oversee our activities. Clearly, each is likely to have its own goals that in turn create the need for objectives to attain them. Their goals and their chosen objectives will differ substantially from one another.

Existing customers, already convinced that your product or service will help them make or save money, most probably have as their main objective the meeting of their own production schedules or the maintenance of their own quality standards. Potential customers are likely to have a need for pricing information that will aid them in assessing the cost effectiveness of your product or service. The community in which you operate probably has as its main goals economic growth and the maintenance of a safe environment. Regulatory and oversight agencies have the goals of protecting the worker, the consumer, the taxpayer, or the customer from workplace abuses, shoddy workmanship, price gouging, pollution, unsafe conditions, or unfair trading practices.

## **EVALUATING AUDIENCE OBJECTIVES**

The potential conflict between your own production objectives and those of your customers, for example, should be apparent. As a service activity, your production scheduling must conform to the scheduling and quality objectives of the customer. The most effective means of communicating with a good customer is to deliver a quality product or service on time.

But to do so requires a high level of understanding of mutual constraints, capabilities, and limitations. That understanding must be reached up front. In a world where Murphy's Law ("If something can go wrong, it will!") is operative, prudent managers will set up customer communication channels that will permit them to forewarn their customers of glitches.

Conversely, if managers expect customer understanding of their internal problems, they should be sensitive to those of their customers and be prepared to bend a little when customers get themselves in a bind. But to establish communications based on an understanding of mutual objectives requires managers to recognize that their customer is not a disembodied name on a letterhead or purchase order. The customer purchasing agent, its salesperson, its expeditor, its quality control inspector, its general manager, and its vice-president all have specific objectives that they are working to attain.

If your objectives or those of your employees collide with those of the individuals within the customer organization with whom you must communicate, the divergence will soon become apparent and your customer will begin looking elsewhere for another

source of the product or service. When we view the community in which we do business as our audience, it becomes apparent that the close interpersonal channels of communication that characterize our communications with customers may not be appropriate. The community may be large or small; urban, suburban, or rural; affluent or disadvantaged; residential, industrial, or commercial.

Community needs may be centered on economic considerations such as the desire for more jobs or growth of commerce and industry, or they may centre on population limitation, neighbourhood preservation, or environmental purity. The community's governmental units may be small and characterized by heavy citizen involvement or large and anonymous. There may be sharp differences between citizens' groups as to the desired direction of the community. In short, most communities comprise diverse and often divergent interests.

How, then, do we align the objectives of our company with those of a community comprising individuals and groups having widely varying objectives of their own? First, it is useful to understand something about the organization of the community. Is the principal governmental unit the city, the county, or some other instrumentality? How and to what extent does the community government interact with state and federal government agencies?

What role do service organizations play in molding and expressing opinion in the public arena? Are there advocacy organizations such as community action and environmental groups operating in the community? Are trade and labour unions in the community influential or weak? What general position does the local media take on key community issues? Armed with answers to these sorts of questions, a line manager should be able to assess the general direction of public perceptions towards business activities.

Moreover, the manager who understands the community organizations will be better able to gain access to those individuals and groups in order to assess the intensity of their perceptions on issues that impinge on his or her company's activities. Second, with a good understanding of the direction and intensity of opinions held among the various community groups, the manager can assess potential audience reactions to the operations and activities of the company. More importantly, the manager should be able to anticipate probable community reaction to his or her own plans for change or growth and develop objectives for implementing these plans that conform to those of the community.

Finally, as a practical matter, the manager must decide whether to become actively involved in the community by joining service organizations, openly supporting the positions of certain groups, participating in charitable activities, or pursuing a continuing programme of public relations through the media, a speaker's bureau, or other similar public affairs channels. The choices are, of course, dependent on the character of the activity. If the company is a principal supplier of jobs in the community, if it happens to

be a generator or treater of hazardous waste, or if it engages in any activity that might prompt public or community attention, prudence dictates that advance planning accommodate the public affairs implications of the most likely contingencies.

Our third principal audience, regulatory and oversight agencies, is a special case. Every company, particularly those engaged in manufacturing, comes under the scrutiny of a variety of governmental and industry associations while carrying out its day-to-day activities. In my own unit, we enjoy frequent contact with the Federal Aviation Administration, the Occupational Safety and Health Administration, the Defence Contracting Agency, and the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA).

In addition, we have compliance requirements for standards developed by the American Petroleum Institute, the American Society for Test and Measurement, the Society of Automotive Engineers, and the American Society for Non-destructive Testing, among others.

Each regulatory agency has as its specific objective ensuring compliance with procedures and standards it sets for regulated activities. Compliance with the established procedures and standards is a prerequisite to doing business in regulated areas. Moreover, compliance is not free. In fact, it is quite expensive and time consuming. For that reason, effective managers should understand that their own objectives must conform to those of the regulating agencies and industry associations. But it is not enough merely to conform. It is also necessary to communicate with regulatory agencies in a way that will permit sustained operations on a cost-effective basis.

Too often, when a guy in a white shirt and Hushpuppies knocks on your door and says, "I'm from the federal government and I'm here to help," managers experience a state of dread that progresses to anger, through defiance, then almost inevitably to abject defeat. It has been my experience that planning to communicate with regulatory agencies can ease the pain somewhat.

The first step of the process is to determine which among the company's activities comes under regulation and by whom. The second is to determine the nature and extent of the regulatory provisions.

The third is to take the agency at its word and ask for help. By enlisting the assistance of the regulatory agency, it becomes a participant, if not a partner, in developing procedures for compliance that will meet agency objectives for conforming to the established standards. Representatives of regulatory agencies ordinarily are like the rest of us (except they have better benefits packages), and if we demonstrate a willingness to make their jobs easier, their response to our own objectives and concerns is likely to be more positive.

In summary, accurate prediction of audience response to an organization's activities involves not only identifying the audiences and determining the direction and intensity of their positions but also understanding that effective communication requires alignment of the objectives of the participants in the communication process.

## SELECTING A MESSAGE

Communicating with potential customers tends to be more message oriented than channel oriented. That is, the goals of the potential customer are usually to find a product or service that better serves its own needs for improved productivity, performance, or cost reduction. Those individuals within the customer organization trying to acquire information to meet their established objectives may have a need for specific cost and performance information, or they may be seeking generalized information that will merely heighten the level of comprehension and knowledgeability about the class of products or services available.

The content and style of the message should conform to the specific needs of the potential customer. The manager and his sales staff should be aware that message content and style ought to be selected to elicit a particular audience response. Usually, audience responses progress from attention to comprehension to compliance to action. Thus, for example, a project engineer comes across an ad in a trade journal (a mass communication channel) that gets his attention because it promises cost savings in an area in which he has a functionally specific objective.

He fills out the bingo card, circles the appropriate ad number, and sends out the postage-paid, self-addressed postcard. Some time later he receives a packet of literature in the mail. He reviews the literature, and with heightened interest calls the company and arranges for a salesperson to make a presentation (an interpersonal communication channel).

The salesperson arrives and makes a bang-up presentation. Audience comprehension is nearly complete. The salesperson then asks that her product or service be tried and evaluated. The project engineer weighs the recommendation against his own needs and decides to comply with the salesperson's recommendation.

The project engineer agrees to service testing and, because the product performs beyond expectations, recommends to the management that the product be specified for a particular application. The project engineer's manager says okay, if the price is right. A request for quotation is prepared and forwarded to the salesperson. The salesperson responds and the quotation is reviewed by the project engineer's management to ensure that the product or service will prove cost effective. The salesperson is summoned to write the order and the final audience response action is complete. One of the principal dangers when communicating in the selling process—and certainly one of the most frequent—is for the salesperson to misperceive the intentions of the prospect when selecting message content and style.

If the prospect's objective is to gather data about the product or service for the purpose of assessing cost effectiveness, the message content should focus not on the technical merits of the product but rather on those features that impact positively on cost. How expensive is the product or service relative to that of the competition? What sort of

economies may be expected if the volume or scale is increased? Can delivery times be shortened? And so on. The style of the message should likewise fit the audience, accounting for known predispositions and objectives. If the audience objective is to acquire hard technical information to be used in making qualitative assessments of the potential effectiveness of the product or service, it would not be appropriate to adopt a light, breezy narrative style.

Rather, the message should be straightforward, business-like, and comprising concise data summaries relating to the technical attributes of the product or service. A final and important consideration about message selection: The message must be relevant. The road to the unemployment office is paved with the remains of managers who delivered their well-conceived messages to the wrong audiences.

The marketing manager who insists that salespersons use a canned presentation runs the risk of squandering his or her resources unless the product or service possesses more or less universal utility for the general population. Such products as vacuum cleaners or encyclopaedias sold door to door lend themselves to canned messages, but the marketing of industrial products or services requires considerably more forethought and planning to ensure that the right message is transmitted on the right channel to the right audience.

## **SELECTING THE COMMUNICATION CHANNEL**

The manager of an operating unit within a larger corporation will likely have some influence on the determination of the type, character, and extent of media advertising used by the company, but generally the line manager's role in channel selection is limited. A company doing business in a limited geographic or functional area will probably have assigned salespersons who have inside or outside sales responsibilities that require frequent interpersonal contact with customers and potential customers. That means reliance on telephone or face-to-face communications.

The manager also may have some resources for conducting direct mail or telemarketing campaigns and perhaps some capability for developing audiovisual materials. Whatever the available resources, the principles of effective channel selection are relevant to their use. The channel of communication, like the message, will vary with the audience. Audience size, composition, and predisposition must be considered when selecting a channel.

If the audience comprises a small number of engineers located in an office for the prearranged purpose of discussing a specific application of the product or service, the interpersonal channel most certainly will not call for use of the sort of audiovisual aids that would be appropriate for a larger, more heterogeneous audience. However, even though small group communications rely heavily on interpersonal channels, it is possible to achieve impact of the mass media channels through audiovisual devices.



With the development and availability of video recording equipment, for example, it is economically feasible to offer audiovisual presentations. Rather than merely presenting the small audience of engineers with a written test report declaiming the merits of a product, it is possible to present a pictorial record of the actual testing using the most powerful of today's persuasive media channels, television. Use of video recordings has several advantages. The content can be edited to remove extraneous material and pared to a specific time length. Audience attention is likely to be focused more closely on the message. And, perhaps most importantly, message credibility supported by actual images is likely to be enhanced. But there are also disadvantages. Taped presentations that overlook technical standards may appear fumbling and amateurish. Before attempting to use video recordings, it would be wise to become familiar with the technical features of taping.

Similarly, slides, films, and audio recordings can prove useful in small group business communications. But the advantages of their use should be weighed carefully against the disadvantages. Many a sales presentation has been derailed because the audiovisual medium was not appropriate for the audience, the setting, or the message. Direct mail campaigns may be used effectively by managers to get their message to larger audiences. For the manager of a company, direct mail has the principal advantages of reducing the cost per contact and broadening the level of audience exposure to the product or service.

Direct mail has the main function of gaining audience attention. The design of the message, though, should also increase audience comprehension, elicit compliance, and move the audience to some specifically limited action response. The principal disadvantage of direct mail is that your letter, flyer, questionnaire, or literature will have to compete for the audience's attention with an avalanche of similar communications.

Direct mail communications are probably best utilized as a device for responding to a previously expressed audience interest in your product or service. In the course of participating in trade shows, seminars, symposia, or other similar events, the manager should make a concerted effort to accumulate business cards and attendance lists for the purpose of later communicating with those individuals who have demonstrated an interest in learning more about the product or service. The manager should ask two key questions before embarking on a direct mail programme. Has the audience expressed an interest in the product or service, however ill defined? Will the message elicit the desired audience response? If the answer to either is negative, you might as well save your stamp. Many of the same considerations apply to the use of the telephone in the marketing function. If there has been a previously expressed audience interest, telemarketing can be an effective tool to further broaden the potential customer base. Also, it can be extremely useful in establishing interpersonal relationships with prospects since the telephone provides some opportunity for the immediate interchange of ideas on an interpersonal basis.

In my company we have many good customers we have never met in person but with whom we have extensive telephone contact. A word of caution is in order. Long-distance telephone calls, even with the lower rates available today, can become expensive and time-consuming activities. For a company offering a specialized product or service and having limited marketing resources, the telephone shotgun approach to marketing is likely to be less than cost effective. For that reason, target audiences should be carefully selected when using the telephone.

Another communication channel is the newsletter or house organ. These print media can be used internally within the organization, directed to external audiences, or both. Generally, newsletters or newspapers should convey messages that depict the positive aspects of the organization, such as accomplishments of employees, new production capabilities, or improved products. They may also cover changes in personnel assignments, advanced technological developments, and industry-wide news items.

Newsletters and house organs are generally perceived by employees as controlled by management and therefore have less credibility than public print media. For that reason, they should utilize a format and style that are informative rather than persuasive. Content should focus on the non-confidential business activities of the company from the perspective of the employees or customers rather than the management. For example, a story relating to a new product might centre on the reactions of the quality control manager to the product's role in reducing rework, with supporting quotes from a satisfied customer.

Similarly, stories relating to customer activities supply opportunities for publicizing testimonials to the benefit of the company's products and services while providing a publicity channel for the customer. It should be noted, however, that newsletters should not be used for dissemination of directives from management or to discuss internal problems. The employee readership will be turned off and the customer readership could not care less.

Finally, the manager of an operating unit may be able to make use of the public mass media for publicity purposes. If the character of the business is such that its activities have relevance and importance for the community or some significant segment of the public, it may be desirable to issue periodic press releases to local media or to trade journals, to use press conferences to announce favourable developments, or to seek to participate in local public service radio or television programmes.

There are several major benefits of using the mass media for publicity purposes. First, the public media are not perceived as controlled and the message is likely to be credible. Second, publicity is far less expensive than paid advertising. But on the downside, the manager should be aware that once the press release has been issued, the information it contains and any follow-up media interest are out of his or her control. In summary, every organization has its own set of goals, arranged in a hierarchy determined



by the general culture of the organization. To reach these goals, individual objectives are established that create needs for communications both within the organization and outside of it. The type, extent, and character of the communication modes and methods are determined by the information needs of the individual. Too often, these needs are satisfied by the establishment of functionally specific, unidirectional, and close-ended communication devices that do not account for the objectives of the audience. The result can be conflict and failure to attain established objectives. Dealing with the problem requires an understanding of the communication process, with particular emphasis on how audience characteristics and objectives must be observed in effective formulation of messages and selection of channels. Communications should be a prominent part of planning for objective fulfillment.

In a perfect world, all communication methods, messages, and media would be perfectly adapted to both organizational goals and audience objectives and there would be little chance of failure. However, in the less than perfect world of free enterprise, without effective communication there is little chance of success.

# Business Letter and Writing: Meaning, Importance and Advantages

## MEANING OF BUSINESS LETTER

Business people have to communicate with the customers, the suppliers, the debtors, the creditors, the public authorities and the public at large as well as among themselves for the purpose of exchanging their views and of sending and receiving information. This is required to initiate, carry out and to conclude transactions.

### COMMUNICATION CAN BE IN TWO WAYS

- *Oral*: Either face to face or with the help of various machines and
- *Written*: By writing letters. This written communication is otherwise called correspondence. The word correspondence has a sense of 'similarity' and 'association' in it. To correspond means to be in conformity or agreement with something or somebody.

Correspondence or written communication may take place between any two persons or parties. Commercial correspondence means correspondence by the business people on matters of commerce. The word correspondence has a sense of plurality. It means letters or a pair of letters consisting of an original letter followed by a reply. 'A' letter has little value. The communication is complete when a letter is replied or an action is taken in response to a letter.

## IMPORTANCE OF BUSINESS LETTER

Businessmen must establish contact with the people and then only they can develop their organisations. Importance of communication is very great in business life. There was a time when the size of business was normally small and varied means of communication were not available, direct meetings or face-to-face communication was practised by the businessmen.

Later on, the policy of sending representatives for direct contacts was introduced. All these methods have their limitations.

The importance of business letters as the cheapest and most extensive form of communication was first realised in USA and UK and now this method has been accepted as the best method of communication all over the world. This has been possible with the introduction of ever growing postal services.

In the meantime standardisation of the form and the style of business letters have made them more popular and acceptable by all. The commercial correspondence has a language of its own which is markedly different from personal letters. Day by day improvements are being made in the form and the style of business letters making them more impressive, meaningful and compact.

A large number of books on the subject are available in the market in the aid of the business world. Invention of different machines for the purpose makes business letters fast in production and in distribution. It does not mean, however, that other means of communication have been abandoned.

## ADVANTAGES OF BUSINESS LETTER

*Communication through letters occupies the largest share in the total volume of communication because of the following advantages:*

- Letters are less costly than other means of communication.
- Letters can be sent to long distant places by post within a short time. Of course, letters may be sent by messengers within neighbouring areas.
- Letters are drafted after proper thinking and planning and so the subject matter can be presented in a systematic and logical way.
- The ideas conveyed in letters are clear and free from ambiguity.
- The size of a letter may be big or small as required.
- Letters simultaneously provide evidence and exact copies can be retained.
- Same communication may-be made to a number of persons at a time, through duplicating or printing.
- Many unpleasant and delicate matters which cannot be spoken face to face or through mechanical devices can be written in letters in a discreet language.
- Letters are suitable for all types of communication.
- There is standardisation in form and style readily acceptable by the business world. Even internationally accepted code language is used.

### **Components**

A business letter has the following components like any other form of communication.—  
A writer or correspondent—He is the communicator. He has the primarily responsibility to make a letter purposeful and effective.

- He must know the form and the style of writing letters. Different types of letters have different styles. The secretary of an organisation, who is in charge of the office including the correspondence department, is supposed to be well conversant with the art. There are experienced correspondence clerks whose services are utilised for the purpose.
- He must have a command over the language and English is the main language used in the commercial world.
- He must be conversant with the facts on which he is writing a letter otherwise he cannot faithfully express the facts and the viewpoints.
- He must also know the technical terms and phrases necessary to be used in particular types of letters. He can take the help of different types of dictionaries available in the market.
- He must make planning before he sets forth to write a letter.
- In case he is writing a reply he must read the initiating letter very carefully.
- The drafting will depend much upon the nature of the recipient.

### **The Addressee or the Recipient or the Reader**

A letter is always directed to a recipient (or recipients). He is the communicatee or the addressee or the reader. If the letter is unimpressive, the recipient may not read it and so not necessarily a recipient is the reader. The drafting of a letter largely depends on the nature of the recipient. Moreover, a letter must reach the recipient, in the shortest possible time. That depends much upon the external factor—the efficiency of the postal system unless a letter is sent by a messenger. The form of a letter depends much upon the nature of the recipient.

### **The Message**

A letter carries a message or stimuli. It may be long or short, pleasant and unpleasant, general or particular, regular or urgent, meant for an individual or many, initial or responsive, etc. The style of writing depends much upon the nature of the message.

## **THE IMPORTANCE OF GOOD BUSINESS LETTER FORMAT**

The way you communicate in a professional setting says a great deal about you even before the first personal interaction; from a simple business letter, a reader takes clues about your education, awareness of standard practices and attention to detail.

By using a standard format, you convey a sense of professionalism and help the reader get right to the message itself.

### **FORMAT**

The basic business letter format is the same across a range of industries, with few variations for content and style. The letter should be left-aligned, single-spaced with a one-inch margin and a standard 11- or 12-point type size. The top line below the letterhead should be the month, day and year, followed by one line of space and the address of the recipient. Place one line of space after the recipient's address and use a simple, professional greeting, followed by a colon and another line of space. Each following paragraph should be separated by a line. Insert one line after the last paragraph, followed by a closing and a comma; leave four lines of space for your signature, and type your name and title.

### **Professionalism**

A well-formatted letter conveys an immediate sense of professionalism to the reader, particularly if it is printed on quality paper and folded neatly. It lets the recipient know that you took the time to craft a letter carefully, even before he reads the content. When it comes time to follow up, the reader will know where to look for the pertinent information, such as the date and return address.

### **COMMUNICATION KNOWLEDGE**

When you use the accepted format for a business letter, it lets the reader know that you have a basic understanding of standard business communication practices. A poorly formatted letter, on the other hand, sends an immediate message to the recipient that you do not have the knowledge or you view the communication as informal; as a result, the content might not get the attention it deserves.

### **SHOWCASES CONTENT**

When writing a business letter, your main objective is to get a message across; the design of the letter itself should fade into the background. By using an improper letter layout, you immediately draw attention to the format rather than the message. By following the standard guidelines for the paragraph content -- introducing your point and providing immediate support -- you build your case quickly and concisely, making it easy for the reader to focus on the letter itself.

## **SUCCESSFUL WRITING: CRAFTING PARAGRAPHS**

Crafting Paragraphs is an art that you should master. Most of us seem to think naturally in sentences. We don't however think in paragraphs. They are artificial divisions created

by writers – or sometimes editors – because readers need them. They break writing into chunks so that readers can process and absorb what they're reading without bogging down and having to reread. And since most of us don't have editors to help us, we have to learn paragraphing on our own. How does one do that? Partly through practice and partly through developing a keen sense of audience. The more conscious you are of your audience, the better you will become at crafting paragraphs. You can look at paragraphing from two points of view: external and internal. When you create paragraphs from an external point of view, you're paragraphing for appearance. When you create paragraphs from an internal point of view, you're paragraphing for unity and coherence. Let's consider both the external and internal views.

### **THE EXTERNAL VIEW OF PARAGRAPHING**

Let's consider the external view of paragraphing. A printed page or computer screen has its own body language that sends signals to readers before they ever read a word and paragraphs length strongly affects the impression readers get. Think about your response when you face a page of solid, unbroken print, whether in a book, in an article or online. Don't the unbroken paragraphs look hard to read and discourage you before you ever get started although you may have to read the material any way? You're not going to be happy about the task. If the writer had crafted shorter paragraphs and been careful to leave good margins and ample white space around the print, almost certainly you would have been more captive to his or her message.

Of course, the term long and short paragraphs are relative, but as a rule of thumb, let's say a short paragraph is from three to six sentences of medium length and doesn't take up more than one third of a regular page. A paragraph of eight to ten medium – length sentences that takes up two thirds or more of a page is definitely long and you should look for places where you could break it. We'll give you some guidelines for finding such places in the next section. Professional writers who have a strong sense of their audience also make paragraphing decisions on the basis of what they know about their readers. If they're writing for a broad audience of casual readers who usually read quickly – say the readers of Parade magazine – they will write shorter paragraphs than they would do for a smaller audience of skilled readers such as the readers of Scientific America. They will also write shorter epigraphs when they're writing for your reader or for a news paper where the writing will appear in columns, so think about whom your readers are when you decide how long your paragraphs should be.

### **Some Guidelines for Breaking Paragraphs**

You may not want to worry about paragraph length until you're revising and thinking how your document is going to look. That's fine - concerns about appearance can wait. But we think it's useful to develop awareness about length as you draft your paragraphs and to get into the habit of looking for logical places to break them.

The conventional wisdom about paragraphing is that each paragraph develops a single idea, so you start a new paragraph when you come to a new idea. That plan works well when you're making a series of points and can develop each point as a paragraph. But it's not always easy to put the one-idea - one-paragraph rule into practice. Sometimes it's hard to tell when you come to a new idea and sometimes an idea is too complex to be developed in a single paragraph. Thus it's useful to know some natural dividing places you can use for breaking up paragraphs. Here are some clues:

#### *Natural Division Points for Breaking Paragraphs*

*A shift in time:* Look for sentences being in time with words like first, next, formerly, or at that time.

*A shift in place:* Look for sentences beginning with words like elsewhere or in the meantime.

*A shift showing contrast:* Look for sentences beginning with words like however, on the other hands, or nevertheless.

*A shift in emphasis:* Look for sentences beginning with terms like if that happens, in spite of another possibility, or not only.

*A shift signaling additional information:* Look for sentences that begin with terms like moreover, in addition, or besides.

There are no firm rules on these matters. You just have to use your judgement and ask yourself "Should I break up this piece of writing and if so, how should I do it?"

Let's look at two examples of paragraphs that are readable but that we think could be broken into more manageable chunks and still be unified. We've marked our proposed division by double slashes. If the first quotation, notice that we divided the paragraph before for instance and again when we came to a new example introduced by also.

There is a tendency to exaggerate the rate at which our lives will be changed by technology. We still have a whole year to go before 2001, but I doubt that Arthur C. Clarke's vision of commercial flights to the moon is going to come true by then. Individual technologies reach plateaus beyond which further improvement is not worthwhile. For instance, the experience of riding in commercial aircraft has not materially changed since the introduction of the Boeing 707 more than forty years ago. (The Concorde is an exception that proves the rule. It has never paid for the cost of its development.)

Computer technology has not yet reached its plateau. But it will – probably when the miniaturization of the solid – state device runs into the limits imposed by the state of the finite size of invaluable atoms. Successful technologies also tend to be self – limiting once they become available to the general population. I doubt that it is possible to cross Manhattan from the east river to the Hudson River faster by automobile to day than it was by horse-drawn streetcar a century ago. The Internet is already beginning to show the effects of overcrowding. I tremble at the thought of two billion air conditioners in a future China and India, each adding its exhaust heat to the earth's atmosphere.

In the next example, we suggest that the author could have created new paragraphs at places where she introduced new examples to illustrate her main idea.

Arranged marriage looks somewhat different from the point of view of the bride and her family. Arranged marriages continue to be preferred even among the more educated, Westernized sections of the Indian population. Many young women from these families still go along, more or less willingly, with the practice and also with the specific choices of their families.

Young women do get excited about the prospects of their marriage, but there is an ambivalence and increasing uncertainty, as the bride contemplates leaving the comfort and familiarity of her own home where as a temporary guest she has often been indulged to live among strangers.

Even in the best situation she now comes under the increased scrutiny of her husband's family. How she dresses, how she behaves, how she gets along with other, where she goes, how she spends her time, her domestic abilities – all of this and much more – will be observed and commented on by a whole new set of relations.

Her interaction with her family of birth will be monitored and curtailed considerably. Not only will she leave their home, but with increasing geographic mobility, she may also live very far from them, perhaps even on another continent. Too much expression of her fondness for her family or her desire to visit them may be interpreted as an inability to adjust to her new family and may become a source of conflict.

In an arranged marriage, the burden of adjustment is clearly heavier for a woman than for a man. And that is the best of circumstances.

Remember, however, that you shouldn't chop up paragraphs arbitrarily just for the sake of appearance. By definition, paragraphs should state an idea and develop it, so you need as many sentences as it takes to do that. Occasionally you may write on sentence paragraphs for emphasis, but use them sparingly and only when you have a specific reason for doing so.

Here's an effective example.

At the Senior Ball, teenagers in the ballroom of the Beverly Hills hotel, beautiful teenagers in black tie and gowns, try very hard not to look like teenagers. But on the other hand, it is very important not to look like one's parents.

The balancing act trick of America adolescence is to stand in between – to be neither a child nor an adult.

### **The Internal View of Paragraphing**

Let's consider the internal view of paragraphing. When experienced writers start writing, almost certainly they don't stop to think how they're going to organize their paragraphs. They've been using a variety of patterns for so long that they can use them without thinking how they work. But writers who are less experienced can profit by reviewing these common paragraph patterns and by considering how they might use



them. We offer you several of those patterns in this section and give examples that may be helpful. Experienced writers do think about how well their paragraphs stick together and whether they focus on one point. They also work to see that sentences follow each other in logical order, each one supporting or advancing the point of the previous sentence. They're always aware that a paragraph needs to be unified.

How can a writer achieve this unity? Most of us do it by employing some version of a common pattern. That is, we start with a statement or question and follow through with support for the statement or answers to the question. Here are some typical Variations on that pattern.

### ***Generalization with Supporting Details***

Perhaps the most typical way to begin a paragraph is to make a general statement and follow it up with details that support it. Here each sentence after the first provides relevant details: Every big plantation was fiefdom. The small hamlets that dot the map of the Delta were mostly plantation headquarters rather than conventional towns. Sharecroppers traded at a plantation – owned commissary often in scrip rather than money.

They prayed at plantation owned Baptist churches. Their children walked, sometimes miles, to plantation owned schools usually one – or two room building without heating or plumbing. Education ended with the eighth grade and was extremely casual until then [...] the textbooks were hand - me - downs from the white schools. The planter could and did shut down schools whenever there was work to be done in the fields. [...] many sharecroppers remember going to school only when it rained.

### ***Question and Answer***

Notice the use of questions in this next paragraph – first to start the whole topic off and then to move the discussion deeper.

What's the difference between prison and college? They both prescribe your behaviour for a given period of time. They both allow you to read books and develop your writing. They both give you time to think and time with your peers to talk about issues. But four years of prison doesn't give you a passport to grater opportunities. Most likely that time only gives you greater knowledge of how to get back. Four years of college gives you an opportunity not only to lift yourself but to serve your people effectively.

What's the difference when you are called a nigger in college from when you are called a nigger in jail? In college you can, although I admit with effort, follow procedures to have those students who called you nigger kicked out or suspended.

You can bring issues to public attention without risking your life. But mostly, college is and always has been the future. We, neither less nor more than other people, need knowledge. There are discomforts attached to attending predominantly white colleges, though no more so than living in a racist world.

### ***Statement and Illustration***

Often paragraph will begin with a general statement which is then illustrated by subsequent sentences. Here, all of the sentences after the first illustrate ways the author is hated by the Burmese:

In Moulmein, in lower Burma, I was hated by large number of people the only time in my life that I have ever been important enough for this to happen to me. I was subdivision police officer of the town and in an aimless, petty kind of way anti – European felling was very bitter. No one had the guts to raise a riot, but if a European woman went though the bazaars alone somebody would probably spit betel juice over her dress.

As a police officer I was an obvious target and was baited whenever it seemed safe to do so. When a nimble barman tripped me up on the foot ball field and the referee looked the other way, the crowd yelled with hideous laughter. This happened more than once. In end the sneering yellow faces of young men that met me everywhere. The insult hooted after me when I was at a safe distance, got badly on my nerves.

The young Buddhist monks were the worst of all. There were several thousands of them in the town and none seemed to have anything to do except to stand on street corners and jeer at Europeans.

### ***Assertion and Explanation***

Another technique is for the first sentence to make an assertion and then for subsequent sentences to explain just what the assertion means:

“The book business was an elitist, standoffish institution,” Len Riggio told business weak in 1998. “He liberated it from that.” Riggio’s critics have mocked his populist pose, but it should be taken seriously. Before the appearance of the chains, a relatively highbrow, urban clientele shopped at the independents and a relatively lowbrow, largely regional one bought mass – Market titles at supermarkets, price clubs and drugstores.

Now, thanks to the chains and to internet sales, the vast territory between the two extremes has been bridged. Elitists may carp, but the truth is they are no longer quite so elite. These days shoppers in Buford, Georgia and Rapid City, South Dakota, can pick up important titles such as Norman Cantor’s *Inventing The Middle Ages*, Eugene Genovese’s *Roll*, Jordan Roll and Andrew Motion’s *Biography of John Keats* – titles that are neither popular nor newly published at their local borders.

So writers can choose several different ways to follow the basic statement and follow-through pattern for creating paragraphs. Just remember that every sentence after the first must expand on or respond to the opening sentence. No detours.

### ***Other Common Paragraph Patterns***

You can also Use several other paragraph patterns:

1. Reasoning From Evidence.
2. Assertion And Support.

3. Cause And Effect.
4. Comparison And Contrast.
5. Classification.
6. Narration.
7. Process.

In the sections that follow, you'll find examples of each, along with brief commentaries.

### ***Reasoning From Evidence***

Reasoning from evidence is a particularly useful pattern when you're writing an argument. It's typical of the pattern trial lawyers use before juries.

*For example:*

[Tigers] are not idle predator. When they kill, they kill to eat. Even a well-fed tiger in a zoo keeps his vestigial repertory of hunting behaviours intact. [...] in the zoo, tigers will stalk birds that land in their habitats and they grow more alert than most people would care to realise when children pass before their gaze. Though stories of man eating tigers have been extravagantly embellished over the centuries, the existence of such creatures is not legendary.

In the Sunderbans, the vast delta region that spans the border of India and Bangladesh, more than four hundred people have been killed by tigers in the last decade. So many fishermen and honey collectors have been carried off that a few years ago officials at the Sunderbans tiger preserve began stationing electrified dummies around the part to encourage the tigers to seek other prey.

One per cent of all tigers according to a German biologist who studied them in the Sunderbans are dedicated man eaters. When they go hunting, they're after people. Up to a third of all tigers will kill and eat a human if they come across one, but they don't make a special effort to do so.

### ***Assertion and Support***

Assertion and support is a useful pattern when you want readers to accept the reasoning upon which you base a claim. Here a feminist scholar explains in the introduction to a book about the six wives of Henry VIII why she has chosen to write about these women as representative of upper class women in Tudor England:

Any look at women in Tudor England invariably begins with the wives of Henry VIII. There are other equally engaging women – equally brave, equally tragic, equally intelligent, equally victimized, equally triumphant – but because of Henry's glamorously bizarre behaviour, those six women dominate our perception of the era's women. They hover in our imagination around the king like faithful satellites orbiting a splendid sun and the fact that on scrutiny the sun reveals itself as a great, empty mass of hot air does little to lessen the fascination.

Henry VIII's monstrous egotism and dynastic misfortune, occurring at a time when Europe was ripe for religious revolution, drew into history six women who were dramatically different from the man who controlled their destinies and dramatically different from each other. Each became, for varying degrees of time, the most powerful woman in England. Each lost that position because she was at the mercy of the most powerful man in the land.

### ***Cause and Effect***

A cause and effect paragraph illustrates one of people's most common thought patterns. You can state the effect first and then follow through by giving the causes as the next paragraph does or you can list the causes first and conclude with the effect:

Many cultural circumstances worked against the likelihood of sexual satisfaction within Victorian marriages. The inflexible taboo on pre-marital sex for middle-class women meant among other things that it was impossible to determine sexual compatibility before marriage. The law then made the wife the absolute property of her husband and sexual performance one of her duties. Imagine a young woman married to a man she finds physically repulsive.

She is in the position of being raped nightly and within the law's consent. The legendary Victorian advice about sex, "Lie back and think of England," may be seen as not entirely comical if we realise that in many cases distaste for sex developed from distaste for the first sexual partner and from sexual performance that was essentially forced. In addition, the absence of birth control made it impossible to separate sex from its reproductive function, so that to be sexually active meant also the discomforts of pregnancy, the pain of childbirth and the burden of children.

### ***Comparison and Contrast***

We all use comparison and contrast almost automatically to highlight the difference or likenesses between two things. You can draw the contrasts within one paragraph or make the comparison with alternating Paragraphs.

Here are two examples.

In the first, a movie critic and essayist compares values in our time with those of ancient Greek society. In the second, an Arab America woman compares her taste with her brother's by describing their separate homes in separate paragraphs.

The America reader comes from a society that is nominally ethical. our legal and administrative system, our presidential utterances, our popular culture in which TV policemen rarely fail to care for the victims of Crime are swathed in concern. Since many Americans believe that our society is actually indifferent to hardship, it is no surprise that irony and cynicism barnacle our attitudes towards public life. By contrast, the Greek view was savage, but it was offered without hypocrisy. Accepting death in battle as inevitable, the Greek and Trojan aristocrats of the Iliad experience the world

not as pleasant or as good and evil, but as glorious or you are not good or bad. You are strong or weak, beautiful or ugly, conquering or vanquished, favoured by the gods or cursed. My brother's house smells of fresh paint and packaging – those foam burbles and peanuts that come in big boxes. It smells like carpet no one has ever stepped on. I cannot imagine the bravado of white parapet. My brother prefers if you remove your shoes at his front door. So do, I but no one ever does it in our house.

We have dusty wooden floors and ragged little rugs from Turkey and Libya. We have throw rugs hank knotted in Appalachia. We have a worn oriental carpet that once belonged to my friend's reclusive father, a famous science fiction writer. [...] our house smells of incense and grandmother's attics in Illinois and vaguely sweetened shelf paper pressed into drawers.

### ***Classification***

You can craft paragraphs in which you classify your ideas by categories.

*For Example:*

Complaints about the treatment of women on-line fall into three categories that women are subject to excessive, unwanted sexual attention, that the prevailing style of on-line discussion turns women off and that women are singled out by all participants for exceptionally dismissive or hostile treatment. In making these assertions, the Newsweek article and other stories on the issue do echo grievances that some on – line women have made for years. And without a doubt, people have encountered sexual commons, aggressive debating tactics and add hominem attacks on the Net. However, individual users interpret such events in widely different ways and to generalize from those interpretations to describe the experiences of women and men as a whole is a rash leap indeed.

### ***Narration***

Often you can use a narrative paragraph to illustrate a point that you're making. It can also enliven your writing by adding a visual or personal element.

This little story about e-mail does that;

I discovered just how portable my e – mail was when thief crept into my house and walked off with my computer. One day I had been happily communicating with the entire world, the next I was reduced to virtual silence. My anxiety at the loss of my equipment was exacerbated by my sense of all the messages I was missing.

I had become dependent on my daily fix and the burglar, as if guessing at this aspect of my psychology had even cut the phone wire that led into the computer – a symbolic act easily remedied by the purchase of a new wire, but one that drove home for me my feeling of violent interruption “I feel as if I ‘m hemorrhaging in formation,” I told my husband. But the information was only the half of it. All the little pieces of me that I had been feeding into cyberspaces were loosed into the world, never to return.

### ***Process***

Paragraphs describing a process can make a piece of writing more concrete by describing how something is done. Here a writer describes the process she goes through when she begins to write a story: As much as I can break down process of writing stories, I would say that this is how it begins, I find a detail or image or character or incident or cluster of events. Certain luminosity surrounds them I find myself attracted. I come forward. I pick it up, turn it around begin to ask questions and spend hours and weeks and months and years trying to answer them.

### **Crafting Opening Paragraphs**

Crafting opening paragraphs is an art by itself. They're important because they serve as the lead that pulls your reader into your essay. As such, they need to do several things.

- Introduce you to your readers and establish a first impression.
- Announce your topic
- Set the tone for your writing.
- Let your readers know what to expect.

Because these are crucial functions, it's worth investing time and thought in crafting a powerful opening paragraph before you submit your final effort. An engaging and forceful opener will get you off to a strong start with your readers. A poor one handicaps you from the beginning. But remember that you don't have to get your opener right the first time. An effective opening paragraph may well take shape only with your fourth or fifth draft. Often you can't even write a good first paragraph until you're fairly well satisfied with the rest of your piece. When you do get to that point you'll do well to come back and review this section to ensure that your opener does that it needs to do.

Here are two strong opening paragraphs from professional writers. The first is by Dorries who wrote both fiction and non-fiction:

My father, a career army officer, was twenty – seven when he was killed and as a result, I can't help but take war personally. Over the years his image has coalesced for me as an amalgam of familiar anecdotes: a dashing mixed – blood man from the Northwest who, improbably, could do the rhumba. A soldier who regularly had his quirkiest qualities, indistinct, better remembered for his death – my grandmother still wears a gold star on her coat – than for his brief life. The author of the second paragraph, an essayist and fiction writer, opens an engaging personal essay about working in a bakery when he was a fledgling writer trying to support himself.

I like bagels, but I have never felt in their thrall. I never craved them, never viewed them as something special, out of the ordinary or exotic. They were a fact of life, personified when I was growing up, by a local store that baked and sold them, B and T bagels, on Eightieth Street and broad way which was open twenty – four hours a day, seven days a week.

Besides selling bagels, the store performed a kind of community service by perfuming the air in its vicinity with the smell of baking bread which gave the chaotic stretch of Broadway north of Seventy – Ninth Street a neighbourly, friendly feel. There is something about the smell of baking bread in its diffuse form that civilizes people.

As different as these paragraphs are, one dealing with a grand universal theme and the other with the aroma of baking bread - both do just what opening paragraphs are supposed to do. They engage readers' attention, they help readers anticipate what is to come and they forecast what the tone and style of the piece will be.

### ***Adapting Opening Paragraphs to Audience and Purpose***

You'll want to vary your openers according to the kind of writing you're doing. Your good sense should tell you that provocative first sentence that might be just right for opinion column or an article posted on salon won't do for a business report, a technical paper and a literary piece.

When you're writing a straightforward, informative paper for specific readers who have specific expectations, announce your topic directly in the first few sentences. In this situation, your first concern should be not to waste your reader's time – they're often busy, impatient people who want to read defiantly and learn from the piece. For example, the primary audience for Eleanor Hennessy's paper about the painter Artemisia Gentileschi is the instructor and other student in a women's studies course. The author wants her first paragraph to announce her topic, state her thesis and briefly indicate how she's going to develop the thesis.

Hennessy's first opening, written after several false starts looked like this.

Artemisia Gentileschi, a remarkable painter of seventeenth century Italy, defied every norm of her era artistic, social, economic and sexual – to become one of the best – known painters of her day. To women art historian of the twenty – first century, she has become an icon whose work disproves the allegation that there have been no great women artists. Her career gives us insight into the obstacles women painters faced in here time, but also into ways in which woman artist were sometimes able to circumvent constraints all women endured in that era.

The paragraph worked to get Hennessy started on the paper and the first sentence meets her instructor's requirement for a thesis sentence.

The paragraph also lets her readers know what to anticipate from the paper. As she neared the end of the paper, however, Hennessey realized that she hadn't included anything about other women artists of the era, partly because she didn't have space but mostly because she had found Gentileschi so interesting that she wanted for focus entirely on her. So after she finished her second draft she rewrote the opening paragraph.

Artemisia Gentileschi, a talented painter in seventeenth century Italy, defied every norms of her time artists, social, economic and sexual – to emerge as one of the most successful artists of here era. To women arts historians in the twenty – first century she



is a hero whose work disproves the allegation that there have been no great women artists. But Gentileschi's story also appeals to today's women in ways that go well beyond the specialized world of art history. She has become a feminist icon because of her courage, her self – confidence, her determination and her proud defiance in refusing to bow to the censure of a hostile and judgemental society. She would have been an amazing woman in any time and place. For her to have triumphed as she did in the sexist, repressive culture of seventeenth century Italy seems no less than a miracle.

Notice that this opening is more tightly focused, substituting the specific word talented for the vaguer one remarkable and finishes with sentences that leads directly into the topic of the next paragraphs.

In a book that describes a scientific experiment for the general reader, the science writer Jonathan Weiner starts an account of two biologists working in the Galapagos Islands with this factual description and gives his reader essential details:

There are two kinds of shorelines in the [Galapagos] islands: the visible and the invisible. The visible shores are the black broken rocks and white broken waves where volcanoes rise out of the pacific. They are the borders of the air and the lava, wave – gnawed rigs around the summits that have given Darwin's finches their homes in the middle of nowhere. These shores are defined simply by the level of the sea.

The invisible shores are the borders between the birds themselves. These shores are more intricate. They are defined by the secret codes and unwritten rules that wrap each of the thirteen Galapagos finches in a kind of self – invented isolating.

These boundaries hold each species apart from the rest [...] so that even though seven or eight may share the some volcanic summit, feed together in mixed flocks, scrape the same cinders for the same seeds, they still breed as much apart as if they were themselves an archipelago of enchanted islands.

### **Wrestling With Closing Paragraphs**

Many experts are wrestling with closing paragraphs. Conclusions are hard, even experienced writers occasionally have trouble tying up the threads of their arguments and bringing their ideas to conclusion without lapsing into clichés or obvious comments. Many of us struggle with conclusion no matter how long we've been writing.

For some writing tasks, endings are almost prescribed and you can find models that will help you. For example, for technical and business reports, case studies or grant proposals, the writer is expected to summarize the findings and if appropriate, make recommendations. Such straightforward endings aren't too hard to write.

In other kinds of writing, such as an argument or analysis, the writer often needs to restate the main ideas or claims he or she made earlier in order to refresh the reader's memory. Conclusions of this kind are patterned on the summation lawyers make for juries they restate the principal claims, they summarize the evidence and when appropriate, they make a recommendation.



### ***Other Kinds of Conclusions***

Beyond these rather by – the numbers conclusions, we can't offer much solid advice about the best way to end an essay. In the hundreds of essays we've looked at we've found dozens of good ways to conclude. So it's not easy to generalize. Narwhales, we have three suggestions that may be helpful.

### ***Close by Summarizing Your Main Points***

David Brooks summarizes his previously stated main points in concluding a section about the rise of the new intellectual class in this book.

Marx told us that classes inevitably conflict, but sometimes they just blur. The values of the bourgeois mainstream culture and the values of the 1960s counterculture have merged. That culture war has ended at least within the educated class. In its place that class has created a third culture which is reconciliation between the previous two.

The educated elites didn't set out to create this reconciliation. It is the product of millions of individual efforts to have it both ways. But it is now the dominant tone of our age. In the resolution between the culture and the counterculture, it is impossible to tell who has co-opted whom because in reality the bohemians and the bourgeois co-opted each other. They emerge from this process as bourgeois bohemian.

### ***Finish With A Recommendation***

Cathy Young in her essay Keeping Women Weak rejects the kind of feminism that wants to overprotect women and portray them as victims:

We need a Third Wave feminism that rejects the excesses of the gender fanatics and sentimental traditionalism of the Phyllis Schlaflys, one that does not seek special protection for women and does not view us as too socially disadvantaged to take care of ourselves.

Because in the path that feminism has taken in the last few years, we are allowing ourselves to be treated as frail, helpless little things by our would-be liberators.

You can give your readers a sense of closure and wrap up your essay by plucking an image or reference from your opening paragraph and using it in your last paragraph. Barbara Kingsolver does this in an essay that is her tribute to a librarian

*The following is the Opening Paragraph:*

A librarian named Miss Truman Richey snatched me from the jaws of ruin and it's too late now to thank her. I'm not the first person to notice that we rarely get around to thanking those who've helped us most.

Salvation is such a heady thing the temptation is to dance gasping on the shore, shouting that we're still alive till our forgotten savior has long since gone under. Or else sit quietly, sideswiped and embarrassed, mumbling that we really did know pretty much how to swim.

But now that I see the wreck that could have been, without Miss Richey, I 'm of a fearsome mind to throw my arms around every living librarian who crosses my path, on behalf of the souls they never knew they saved.

*The following is the Closing Paragraph:*

My thanks to Doris Lessing and William Saroyan and Miss Truman Richey. And every other wise teacher who may ever save a surly soul likes mine.

Eleanor Hennessy used this strategy in writing the final paragraph of her essay on Artemisia Gentileschi, picking up on the theme of overcoming obstacles that she had opened with.

*Here is her original paragraph:*

It is gratifying to know that woman artist whose genius was obscured for centuries by a male – dominated profession has finally received the recognition she deserves. But it is even more satisfying for a woman student today to learn the story of this magnificent woman who more than three centuries ago refused to accept the negative judgements of a narrow-minded and biased society and went on to prove her talent and succeed in a hostile world. Artemisia Gentileschi's story should inspire every young woman of today who has become discouraged as she fights against odds to establish herself.

When Hennessey reread the paragraph as she was revising, it sounded adequate but bland, particularly the last sentence. She drafted two more versions before she came up with a much stronger version that gives more important details. She took a chance by finishing an academic paper with an unconventional last sentence but she did so to emphasize her admiration for her subject.

Here is the revised paragraph.

Gentileschi has finally achieved the recognition she deserves only because a handful of women art historians challenged the assumptions of their discipline, one that had never taken women artists seriously. Two of those historians, Rozsika Parker and Griselda Pollock, say "Modern Art history [...] identifies women artists as inevitably and naturally artists of lesser talent and no historical significance.

"Parker, Pollock and others – Notably Germaine Greer – did the research necessary to bring to light the paintings that demonstrate Gentileschi's genius and to confirm her stature in her own day. Mary Garrard, in her biography, has supplemented those treasures by giving us the story of this amazing woman who went against the grain of their culture of triumph over obstacles that women of today can scarcely imagine. It's an awesome story to which one can only say, "Yes! Ain't that a woman?"

### *For Practice*

1. Read over the following paragraph to see where you think it could be broken into shorter paragraphs.

In outline it was a good plan, but it quite failed to take into account the mentality of buzzards. As soon as they were wired to the tree, they all began to try and fly away. The

wires prevented that, of course, but did not prevent them from falling off the limbs where they dangled upside down, wings flapping nether parts exposed. It is hard to imagine anything less likely to beguile a movie going audience than a tree full of dangling buzzards.

Everyone agreed it was unaesthetic. The buzzards were righted but they tried again and with each try their humiliation deepened. Finally they abandoned their effort to fly away and resigned themselves to life on the tree.

Their resignation was so complete that when the scene was readied and the time came for them to fly they refused.

They had had enough of ignominy better to wait on the limb indefinitely. Buzzards are not without patience.

Profanity, firecrackers and even a shotgun full of rock salt failed to move them. I am told that in desperation a bid man was flown in from L.A. to teach the sulky bastards how to fly. The whole experience left everyone touchy.

A day or so later, looking at the pictures again, I hated a further provocative detail. The dead heifer that figured so prominently in the scene was quite clearly a steer.

When I pointed this out to the still photographers, they just shrugged. A steer was close enough, after all they were both essentially cows. "In essence, it's a cow," one said moodily. No one wanted those buzzards back again.

2. What kind of follow - through in the rest of the paragraph would reader expect after reading the following opening sentences?

- It is hard to see why anyone would think that religion is a cure for the world's problems.
- In twentieth – century America we place so much emphasis on romance that we barely notice the other essentials of marriage that include economics and child rearing.
- There are fair-weather friends and foul-weather friends and we need both kinds in our lives, especially so because each is likely to absent himself rather abruptly when the wind shifts.

3. Working with two or three other students, discuss what kind of paragraph you could write to follow through on each of these opening sentences. Then choose the one you find most interesting and draft a paragraph together to be shared with the rest of the class.

When enrolling in a college or university, students are often unaware how much student fees will add to the cost of their education.

The average American squanders water in ways that would be unthinkable in arid countries like Israel or Morocco.

While boys are usually less fashion – conscious than girls, many of them are certainly swayed by current trends in Hairstyles and body ornament.

*For Writing*

1. As a volunteer at a city clinic, you have been asked to write the copy for a brochure that will be available to patients who come to the clinic. Your supervisor wants the brochure to explain to young women who come in with problem pregnancies what options are open to them through the clinic and other organization. She emphasizes that the brochure should use simple but neutral language and should keep a positive tone. It should not exceed 600 words. Remember that brochure text is often set in narrow columns, so keep your paragraphs short.
2. Create a web site for an animal rescue organization for which you want to recruit new members. It could be something like a group that finds homes with private owners for retired K–9 police dogs, an association that arranges adoptions for abandoned or abused weimaraners or an organization that finds homes in the country for saddle horses that have been retired from riding stables. Explain your organization's goals, how it operates, what success it has had and what kinds of volunteers it needs. If you can, include a picture to enhance the appeal of your announcement.
3. Write an article for a weekly newspaper for retired citizens in your community. Your goal is to convince your readers that they would enjoy and benefit from buying a computer and connecting to the Internet. Work at crafting an opening paragraph that will catch your reader's interest but is not patronizing. In subsequent paragraphs, explain some advantages of e-mail, what kinds of services the world wide web offers – travel discounts and bookstores, for example – and mention some of the kinds of chat groups or special interest sites they might enjoy.

This article will require some research, but don't overwhelm your reader with paragraphs that include too much information. Give some specific example to illustrate your points. Estimate costs including those of a monitor and printer and perhaps an additional phone line and describe two or three servers they might sign up with and at what cost

## **WRITING THE BASIC BUSINESS LETTER**

### **PARTS OF A BUSINESS LETTER**

This resource is organized in the order in which you should write a business letter, starting with the sender's address if the letter is not written on letterhead.

#### **Sender's Address**

The sender's address usually is included in letterhead. If you are not using letterhead, include the sender's address at the top of the letter one line above the date. Do not write

the sender's name or title, as it is included in the letter's closing. Include only the street address, city, and zip code.

**Date**

The date line is used to indicate the date the letter was written. However, if your letter is completed over a number of days, use the date it was finished in the date line. When writing to companies within the United States, use the American date format. (The United States-based convention for formatting a date places the month before the day. For example: June 11, 2001. ) Write out the month, day and year two inches from the top of the page. Depending which format you are using for your letter, either left justify the date or tab to the center point and type the date.

**Inside Address**

The inside address is the recipient's address. It is always best to write to a specific individual at the firm to which you are writing. If you do not have the person's name, do some research by calling the company or speaking with employees from the company. Include a personal title such as Ms., Mrs., Mr., or Dr. Follow a woman's preference in being addressed as Miss, Mrs., or Ms.

If you are unsure of a woman's preference in being addressed, use Ms. If there is a possibility that the person to whom you are writing is a Dr. or has some other title, use that title. Usually, people will not mind being addressed by a higher title than they actually possess. To write the address, use the U.S. Post Office Format. For international addresses, type the name of the country in all-capital letters on the last line. The inside address begins one line below the date. It should be left justified, no matter which format you are using.

**Salutation**

Use the same name as the inside address, including the personal title. If you know the person and typically address them by their first name, it is acceptable to use only the first name in the salutation (for example: Dear Lucy:). In all other cases, however, use the personal title and last/family name followed by a colon. Leave one line blank after the salutation. If you don't know a reader's gender, use a non-sexist salutation, such as their job title followed by the receiver's name. It is also acceptable to use the full name in a salutation if you cannot determine gender. For example, you might write Dear Chris Harmon: if you were unsure of Chris's gender.

**Body**

For block and modified block formats, single space and left justify each paragraph within the body of the letter. Leave a blank line between each paragraph. When writing a business letter, be careful to remember that conciseness is very important. In the first

paragraph, consider a friendly opening and then a statement of the main point. The next paragraph should begin justifying the importance of the main point. In the next few paragraphs, continue justification with background information and supporting details. The closing paragraph should restate the purpose of the letter and, in some cases, request some type of action.

### **Closing**

The closing begins at the same vertical point as your date and one line after the last body paragraph. Capitalize the first word only (for example: Thank you) and leave four lines between the closing and the sender's name for a signature. If a colon follows the salutation, a comma should follow the closing; otherwise, there is no punctuation after the closing.

### **Enclosures**

If you have enclosed any documents along with the letter, such as a resume, you indicate this simply by typing Enclosures one line below the closing. As an option, you may list the name of each document you are including in the envelope. For instance, if you have included many documents and need to ensure that the recipient is aware of each document, it may be a good idea to list the names.

### **Typist initials**

Typist initials are used to indicate the person who typed the letter. If you typed the letter yourself, omit the typist initials.

## **A NOTE ABOUT FORMAT AND FONT**

### **Block Format**

When writing business letters, you must pay special attention to the format and font used. The most common layout of a business letter is known as block format. Using this format, the entire letter is left justified and single spaced except for a double space between paragraphs.

### **Modified Block**

Another widely utilized format is known as modified block format. In this type, the body of the letter and the sender's and recipient's addresses are left justified and single-spaced. However, for the date and closing, tab to the center point and begin to type.

### **Semi-Block**

The final, and least used, style is semi-block. It is much like the modified block style except that each paragraph is indented instead of left justified.

Keep in mind that different organizations have different format requirements for their professional communication. While the examples provided by the OWL contain common elements for the basic business letter (genre expectations), the format of your business letter may need to be flexible to reflect variables like letterheads and templates. Our examples are merely guides.

If your computer is equipped with Microsoft Office 2000, the Letter Wizard can be used to take much of the guesswork out of formatting business letters. To access the Letter Wizard, click on the Tools menu and then choose Letter Wizard. The Wizard will present the three styles mentioned here and input the date, sender address and recipient address into the selected format. Letter Wizard should only be used if you have a basic understand of how to write a business letter. Its templates are not applicable in every setting. Therefore, you should consult a business writing handbook if you have any questions or doubt the accuracy of the Letter Wizard.

### **Font**

Another important factor in the readability of a letter is the font. The generally accepted font is Times New Roman, size 12, although other fonts such as Arial may be used. When choosing a font, always consider your audience. If you are writing to a conservative company, you may want to use Times New Roman. However, if you are writing to a more liberal company, you have a little more freedom when choosing fonts.

### **Punctuation**

Punctuation after the salutation and closing - use a colon (:) after the salutation (never a comma) and a comma (,) after the closing. In some circumstances, you may also use a less common format, known as open punctuation. For this style, punctuation is excluded after the salutation and the closing.

## **BUSINESS LETTER BASICS**

The basics of good business letter writing are easy to learn. The following guide provides the phrases that are usually found in any standard business letter. This basic of business letters are important because certain formulas are recognized and handled accordingly.

Think of a basic business letter in three steps:

### **INTRODUCTION - THE REASON FOR WRITING**

The introduction helps the reader understand in which context the letter should be considered. Possibilities include job interview enquires, business opportunity requests, complaints, and more. Of course, Each type of business letter has its own standard phrases.

## **DETAILS - STATE YOUR BUSINESS**

The business letter is extremely important. This is where you achieve your goals in writing a business letter.

## **CONCLUSION/ NEXT STEPS - FUTURE ACTIONS**

Provide a call for future action. This can be a chance to talk in person, a follow-up letter or more. It's important and expected to make it clear what you would like for the next step from the person reading your business letter. The phrases presented in this guide provide a frame and introduction to the content of business letters. At the end of this guide, you will find links to sites that give tips on the difficult part of writing successful business letters - arguing your business objective. By using these standard phrases, you can give a professional tone to your English business letters. Once you understand these basics, you can refine your business letter writing skills by focusing on different types of business letters, as well as other business documents to refine your skills for your business needs at your employers or your own small business organization.

## **THE START**

The start of any business letter begins by addressing the recipient of the letter.

Dear Personnel Director,

Dear Sir or Madam: (use if you don't know who you are writing to)

Dear Dr., Mr., Mrs., Ms. Smith:

Generally speaking, use Ms for women unless asked to use Dr, Mrs or Miss. Use Mr. for men unless asked to use Dr.

Dear Frank: (use if the person is a close business contact or friend)

If you are unsure how formal you should be, always choose a more formal form. Writing to a specific person is always preferred if at all possible.

Formal forms are used in formal business letters. However, e-mails are often much less formal and are generally written using the first name without 'Dear'

## **THE REFERENCE**

Begin by referencing a specific conversation or other contact means. If this is the first letter in a conversation, you can also provide the reason for writing. With reference to your advertisement in the Times, your letter of 23<sup>rd</sup> March,

your phone call today,

Thank you for your letter of March 5<sup>th</sup>.

## **THE REASON FOR WRITING**

I am writing to...

... enquire about



... apologize for

... confirm

... comment on

... apply for

I am writing to enquire about the position posted in The Daily Mail.

I am writing to confirm the shipment details on order # 2346.

I am writing to apologize for the difficulties you experienced last week at our branch.

Once you have introduced the reason for writing your business letter, move on to stating more specifically the purpose of your letter. Here are a number of possibilities:

### **REQUESTING SOMETHING**

Could you/ Would you possibly...?

I would be grateful if you could...

Could you/ Would you please...?

Would you please forward your job requirements?

I would be grateful to meet with you next week.

Would you possibly have time for a meeting next week?

### **AGREEING TO REQUESTS**

I would be delighted to

I would be delighted to give you a tour of our facility this coming month.

### **GIVING BAD NEWS**

Unfortunately

I am afraid that

I am afraid that I will be unable to attend the conference next week.

Unfortunately, we will have to postpone the meeting until June 1st.

### **ENCLOSING DOCUMENTS**

I am enclosing

Please find enclosed

Enclosed you will find

### **CLOSING REMARKS**

Thank you for your help Please contact us again if we can help in any way.

There are any problems.

You have any questions.

**REFERENCE TO FUTURE CONTACT**

I look forward to...

...hearing from you soon.

...meeting you next Tuesday.

...seeing you next Thursday.

**THE FINISH**

Use the following phrases to end your business letter or e-mail. These phrases are called “salutations” and are chosen based on your relationship to the person you are writing.

Yours faithfully,

Used in formal letters and if you don't know the name of the person you're writing to.

Yours sincerely,

Used in formal letters if you know the name of the person you're writing to.

Best wishes,

Used in formal letters if you are on a first name basis.

Best regards,/ Regards,

Used If the person is a close business contact or friend.

**SAMPLE LETTER**

Here is a sample letter using some of these forms:

Ken's Cheese House

34 Chatley Avenue

Seattle, WA 98765

Tel:

Fax:

E-mail: kenny@cheese.com

October 23, 2006

Fred Flintstone

Sales Manager

Cheese Specialists Inc.

456 Rubble Road

Rockville, IL

Dear Mr Flintstone:

With reference to our telephone conversation today, I am writing to confirm your order for: 120 x Cheddar Deluxe Ref. No. 856

The order will be shipped within three days via UPS and should arrive at your store in about 10 days.

Please contact us again if we can help in any way.

Yours sincerely,  
Kenneth Beare  
Director of Ken's Cheese House

### **MORE HELP WITH BUSINESS LETTERS**

For more detailed help with standard business writing skills, I highly recommend these business English books. Now that you understand basic business letter writing style, you can use this guide to different types of business letters to refine your skills for specific business purposes such as making enquiries, adjusting claims, writing cover letters and more.

## **IMPORTANCE OF BUSINESS LETTER**

Letter is as an indispensable tool of communication in business. Business letters are used to sell the products, make enquiry about customers or prices of goods, seek information and advice, maintain good public relation, increase goodwill and perform a variety of other business functions.

With the continuous growth of commerce and industry, usefulness and importance of business letter are also increasing gradually.

*Some points highlighting the benefits or importance of business letter are discussed below:*

- *Exchanging business information:* Letters are the most economic and convenient means of exchanging information. With the help of letters, executives can easily exchange information with customers, suppliers, investors, government offices; regulatory authorities etc.
- *Establishing business relationship:* Business letter play important role in establishing and maintaining relationship with various parties. Business letters reduce the distance between a business and its customers, suppliers, creditors and other public groups.
- *Creation of markets:* Circular letter a form of business letter, helps to create new markets for goods and services. This letter contains information about utility, features and usefulness of the products and induces the customer to buy the products.
- *Substitute to personal visit:* Introduction of letters in business world relieves the business executives' form visiting their clients, suppliers, creditors and other public groups by traveling a long distance. For this reason, commercial letters are called alternative technique to personal visit.
- *Saving cost and time:* Business letters relieve the busy executives from visiting personally their clients and other concerned parties. Therefore, valuable time and costs can be saved.

- *Maintaining secrecy:* Business letters also help to maintain secrecy of information. Non one other than the sender and receiver can know the message contained in the letter.
- *Increasing goodwill:* Business letters, like enquiry letter, circular letter, order acknowledgement letter, adjustment grant letter etc help to increase good will of a business with the customers.
- *Formal agreement:* Business letter acts as formal agreement between buyer and seller. For example an order letter contains name of items, price, and quantity, time of delivery and mode of payment. All these are regarded as the conditions of agreement between buyer and seller.
- *Settlement of transaction:* Commercial letters have paramount importance in setting business transaction. For example, by writing claim letter, buyer can raise his claims to the seller by writing collection letters; seller can collect dues from the customers.
- *Use as reference:* Information exchanged through letters can be preserved permanently and used as reference when need arise. Therefore, making business decisions becomes easier.
- *Legal acceptance:* Business letter is an acceptable document in the eye of law. It can be stored and produced as a documentary proof.
- *Assistance in local and international trade:* Bothe local and foreign trade essentially requires the help of various business letters. Through letters, business person make enquiry about products and prices place orders for goods collect the dues make and settle claims etc.

From the above discussion, it can be concluded that successful operation of business activities establishing, maintaining and developing business relationship and finally achieving business goal all require help of business letters. In a sense, conducting business is impossible without business letters.

## **FORMATS FOR DIFFERENT BUSINESS LETTER TYPES**

There is more to business writing than we give it credit for; it is not just about memorandums and proposals but also about human emotions and relationships. If we break away from the black and white of business writing, we can find that the range and form of business writing is exciting and varied, as opposed to the clinical feeling that it often is associated with. Business letters are those that are produced by someone at a business and usually go to another business or a customer, as opposed to personal letters, which are more informal and tend to go from person to person.

*Business letters:* If we were to define business letters, we could say that business letters are simply letters dealing with business. They can be external mail sent by one

company to another or internal correspondence to the employees of the company. Business letters need to follow a certain format, no matter which type they are.

Often business letters are the first contact one makes with a prospective client or an employer; hence, it becomes critical that you get the tone and message of the letter right to make a good impression. Though a simple enough document to produce, writing effective business letters can be quite a challenge.

Here is a short review list to know when writing business letters.

- Keep it short and simple. Use simple and succinct words instead of long-winded ones. Business letters need to be pithy; this can be achieved by making use of clear and concise words, short sentences, and crisp paragraphs.
- *Be direct:* Your reader is a busy professional, so come straight to the point in your letter without beating around the bush.
- The best way to begin a letter is by stating the purpose in the very beginning. This is called the direct approach, and it sets the tone for what is to follow in the letter body. It grabs the reader's interest.
- If your letter delivers bad news, a direct approach is not advisable. Instead, use an indirect approach in which you state the bad news in the second or third paragraph of the letter.
- Always keep the readers' benefits before yours. Instead of saying what you expect them to do for you, mention what you can offer them.
- Be careful to get the name and title of the recipient correct.
- Make your tone conversational yet professional; do not be overtly formal.
- Stay away from jargon unless you are absolutely sure that the reader will understand it.
- Use active voice and personal pronouns in a letter.
- Always end the letter with a request for action.
- Be careful about the tone you use in the letter; do not come across as overconfident, arrogant, or boastful.

*As far as formatting of a letter goes, given below is the standard format of any business letter:*

- *Letterhead:* Most companies have a specific letterhead that you will need to type letters on. This may make it necessary to adjust the margins so that words are not printed onto the letterhead area.
- *Name and address:* Always try to have the name of someone that the letter should go to, even if you have to call to find it out.
- *Date:* This is the date that the letter was written. It should be written out, such as January 15, 2008.
- *Reference:* This gives a short description of what the purpose of the letter is. For example, one might write "lost invoice" or "account number 23654" or something like that.

- *Salutation:* If you do not know the person, use a more formal one, such as Dr. Brian Lowden.
- *Subject matter/body:* Single-space and left justify for modified block and block style letters. Have one blank line between paragraphs. The first paragraph should have a friendly opening and state the purpose of the letter. The subsequent paragraphs should support the purpose you stated in the first paragraph.
- *Closing:* This should be “thank you,” “sincerely,” or something similar.
- *Signature:* This is the actual signature of the person the letter is from, which may be different from the person who wrote the letter.
- *Typist initials:* These are the initials of the person who typed the letter. These are not the initials of the person who it is from. If they are both the same person, then this line is not necessary. Usually the first initials would be that of the writer, and the second initials are of the typist and are in lowercase. For example: JW/sc.
- *Enclosures:* List here anything else you may be sending, such as a brochure, samples, etc.

Each of these areas has a proper place, depending on which type of letter you are creating. What goes in each area also may vary, depending on whom the letter is being sent to and who is writing it. There are three main styles of business letter: block, modified block, and semi-block styles. Each is written in much the same way, including the same information, but the layout varies slightly for each one.

#### Sample Modified Block Style Letter

Sender's name

Sender's address

(1 space)

Today's date

(drop down four lines)

Recipient's business name

Attention: person it's going to

Recipient's address

(drop down two lines)

Dear Name:

In this type of modified block letter, all the paragraphs line up at the left margin. You do not need to indent at all. The margins should be set to 1-1.5" all the way around the page. If you are using company letterhead, you will need to account for that in figuring the margin where the letterhead is placed on the page.

You only need to single-space between sentences. Leave an extra open line between paragraphs.

Sincerely,

(drop down four lines)

Signature here

Add name,

Add title

[Identification initials]

Enclosures:

cc: Name

Name

Sample Modified Semi-Block Style Letter

Today's date

(drop down four lines)

Recipient's business name

Attention: person it's going to

Recipient's address

(1 line space)

Dear Name:

(1 line space)

In this type of semi-modified block letter, all the paragraphs line up at the left margin. However, the first word in each paragraph is indented. The margins should be set to 1-1.5" all the way around the page. If you are using company letterhead, you will need to account for that in figuring the margin where the letterhead is placed on the page.

(1 line space)

You only need to single-space between sentences. Leave an extra open line between paragraphs. Keep in mind that these sample letters are a guideline. People often customize to meet their preferred style.

Sincerely,

(space down four lines)

Signature here

Add name,

Add title

[Identification initials]

Enclosures:

cc: Name

Name

You should pay special attention to the font when typing a business letter. Even if you do the entire form exactly right and choose the wrong font, it can still make the document look very unprofessional and even hard to read. Some companies have a preference they would like you to use. Most of the time, using Times New Roman or Ariel is recommended, with a font size of 12. It is important to keep in mind that if you are working for someone and writing letters on the company letterhead, you are representing that company. Therefore, it is best to keep personal innuendos, fluff, and cutesy stuff out of it.

### Sample Block Style Letter

Sender's address

Want to learn more? Take an online course in Business Writing.

Sender's phone number

Today's date

RE: what the letter is about

(drop down 4 lines)

Recipient's name

Recipient's company name

Recipient's address

(1 space)

Attention: person it's going to

(1 space)

Dear Name:

(1 space)

In this type of block letter, all the paragraphs line up at the left margin. There is no indenting of the paragraphs. The margins should be set to 1-1.5" all the way around the page. If you are using company letterhead, you will need to account for that in figuring the margin where the letterhead is placed on the page.

(1 line space)

You only need to single-space between sentences. Leave an extra open line between paragraphs. Keep in mind that these sample letters are a guideline. People often customize to meet their preferred style.

(1 line space)

Some people choose to center the above sender information.

(1 line space)

Sincerely,

(space down four lines)

Signature here

add name,

add title

[Identification initials]

Enclosures:

cc: Name

Name

If we were to dissect the types of business letters further, there are mainly six types.

Acknowledgment letters are a professional courtesy, meant to acknowledge the receipt of something, or to acknowledge a fact or an error. It usually entails a short detail of the day something arrived and a note of thanks.



Complaint letters are meant to bring to notice an error or a defect. They could be applicable to a company or an individual, and they typically seek a redress or adjustment. They are generally descriptive with a formal tone that should express displeasure, but the tone should not be overtly angry. You should address the problem, and try to offer a solution to rectify the situation. See the example complaint letter below.

#### Sample Complaint Letter

Sender's address

Your phone number

(1 line space)

Today's date

(1 line space)

Big C Paper Company

Attention: Lisa Loopie

Recipient's address

(1 line space)

Dear Ms. Loopie:

(1 line space)

I wanted to write you a letter to address a problem we have encountered with your order department on the last two occasions we have purchased from you. Both of our last two orders with your company were not completed in full. They were both missing one ream of paper, totaling 1,000 sheets of paper in all. While one oversight is acceptable, I am hoping this is not becoming a pattern.

(1 line space)

I would like for this situation to kindly be rectified by the two reams of paper being replaced and sent to my attention. We have enjoyed doing business with your company over the years and look forward to this situation being addressed so we can move forward and continue to do so. Please feel free to contact me if you have any questions regarding this matter.

(1 line space)

Sincerely,

(space down four lines)

Signature here

Patty Paper Chaser,

Quality Control Supervisor

Enclosures: copy of both recent packing slips and orders

cc: Accounting department

Paper pusher department

*Adjustment letters:* These follow a complaint letter and encompass the company or individual response to a complaint. The tone has to be humble, as it is a goodwill-building exercise. The complainant has been inconvenienced; this letter should acknowledge the mistake and list out concrete solutions for resolving the issues.

*Enquiry letters:* These are letters of request for something or a response to a request sent by someone. The purpose of the letter is to obtain the information or object requested.

*Order letters:* Also known as purchase orders, these letters are used to order or buy material. Essentially documenting a transaction between buyer and seller, this is a legal document.

*Response letters:* These are in response to a received letter. They generally list the fulfilling of a request or detail steps taken to fulfill a request made by someone.

*Congratulatory letters:* These are “good news” letters and are fairly easy to write. Such letters are used to encourage or reward an employee, business associate, or a consumer. Such letters are a goodwill-building exercise and are written to build or strengthen any business relationship. When you write a congratulatory letter, do it as soon as possible after a good event has taken place. At the outset, mention what the event is that has motivated you to write the letter; follow it up with approval or praise for the accomplishment; and, finally, keep it concise and honest. A congratulatory letter should be a one-page document, and it should not sound fake or mocking.

*Bad news letters:* As opposed to the good news letter, a bad news letter, such as dismissal and rejection letters, need to be handled carefully. While you need to maintain the concise and professional tone of a business letter, you also need to be sensitive to the reader’s feelings. In a bad news letter, instead of conveying the bad news to the reader outright, you need to place it in the middle of the text.

*Here are a few guidelines that you can keep in mind while writing a bad news letter:*

- The opening of the letter needs to be polite. Always give the reader’s efforts and feelings importance.
- Following the opening, the details of the issue need to be stated.
- State the news or the decision.
- Inform the reader about the reasons behind the decision taken.
- Close professionally and politely.

A bad news letter should present the bad news in a positive light. It needs to reassure the reader that all necessary aspects of a particular issue were taken into account before making a decision. A bad news letter should not leave the reader with a bad taste in his or her mouth; instead it should leave the person with the feeling that the decision was fair and just.

*Letters of request:* As the name suggests, these are letters sent to a company or professional seeking help. One could be asking for time, money, services, or products; the fact is that, when you ask for someone’s help, you are subliminally potentially putting yourself lower than the other person. Whether you feel it personally, this feeling needs to come out through your words, without sounding needy.

*Here are a few things to keep in mind:*

- A letter of request should be humble but not sound as if you are groveling.

- The language of the letter should be non-emotional and neutral. For example, instead of saying, “We really need this urgently,” say, “This would be most helpful to us.”
- Avoid the use of too many adjectives, as it tends to make the language emotional.
- A request letter should clearly express the need for something and show appreciation for the help you hope to receive.

*Memos:* The other most common form of business communication is memorandums, or memos. Though they provide information similar to a letter, they are very different in their format.

*Here are the key differences:*

- They are almost always meant for circulation within the organization.
- They are direct in style, and very to the point.
- They do not have salutations.
- They do not have a complimentary closing.
- They are used to convey communication that is not sensitive.
- They have a format distinct from a letter.

When formatting a memo, one should be aware of the strict format that memos stick to. Memos always begin with a bottom-line statement, or the statement of the exact purpose. Memos are extremely crisp, to the point, and use a businesslike tone. Memos usually are short bits of information that get to the point quickly and inform, announce, or request something. The terms “memo” and “memorandum” can be used interchangeably. There is no need for a signature line or any of the other formal endings or closings that letters require. Sometimes the person whom the memo is from will initial next to the name on the memo to indicate she or he has read and approved it before it has been distributed or posted. Think of a memo as being similar to making a company announcement on a loudspeaker to those in your office. You would be direct and to the point and let people know the information you need to share.

Sample Memo

MEMORANDUM

To: All Staff

From: Lisa Number, Accounting

Date: April 15, 2008

Re: Tax form updates

Tax time is once again upon us. It is important that each staff member stop by the accounting department within the next 10 days to sign the new deduction forms. Each employee is required to update the form we have on file, so this will need to be done.

*To update your form, you will need to bring the following with you:*

- Driver’s license
- Social security card
- Employee badge

*Executive summary:* As the name suggests, an executive summary is a shorter and concise version of a longer document. Executive summaries are meant to be read quickly. The reader of an executive summary need not be an expert on a particular topic; but on reading the summary, she or he should be able to gain enough information to have a basic understanding of the larger document.

*Listed below are the salient features of an executive summary:*

- An executive summary should not be more than one page in length.
- It is a condensed form of all major points described in the full-length document.
- It should state the problem, provide background information, list alternatives, and draw conclusions on a given problem.
- It comes at the beginning of every document.

Having described the features of an executive summary, let us look at how to go about writing one.

- Executive summaries should be written after the main report has been compiled. One needs to go through the entire report and make notes of the important points in order to write a summary.
- The main points listed in your summary should appear in the same order as they appear in the main document.
- State each point in a simple, declarative, and direct statement.
- If you need to elaborate on a point, make it brief and concise; steer clear from jargon and too many technical terms.
- Upon completion, proofread the document for errors, and make a lay person go through it. If the person loses interest, other non-technical readers may react the same way.

An executive summary's soul lies in its brevity and clarity. Avoid unnecessary information and cut down on technical terms. Simple and straightforward works best when writing an executive summary.

*Writing for an international audience:* In today's changing business environment, any professional is writing for an international or global audience at any given point of time. A business writer should be aware of the reader and the reader's specific needs. In some cases, a reader unfamiliar with English might need to get a document translated. All these factors need to be taken into account when writing for an international audience.

*Listed below are a few handy hints for writing well for a global audience:*

- Write short sentences, not longer than 25 words.
- Choose words that are easy to pronounce and do not have multiple meanings.
- Do not use jargon, terminologies, sarcasm, or slang while writing for an international audience.
- Try to use active voice and present tense wherever you can.
- Avoid being ambiguous.
- Do not use Latin abbreviations.

- Provide a glossary of definitions for special words used within the document.

The key to writing for an international audience is to keep it simple, yet effective. When writing for an international audience, a writer needs to be aware of the cultural factors in order to avoid offending readers sentiments.

*Here are a few tips for the writer:*

- Know the target audience you are writing for, and research the dos and don'ts for that audience.
- If you can, find a native speaker to proofread the cultural aspects in your document.
- Be aware of the political and cultural factors that your audience might be sensitive to.

There are other types of letters that you may need to write, including those regarding terminations and recommendations. They are very similar to the examples you have already seen. For these types of letter you would choose the style of letter you would like to follow and then address the subject matter.

Recommendation letters are sometimes requested from former co-workers that are seeking a letter to go to a new or potentially new employer. They also can be sent to schools or other such entities. They usually are employment references, character references, or academic references. For business writing purposes, they generally fall into the employment reference category. An employment recommendation letter should tell why the person the letter is about is a good person to hire. Describing their strengths and abilities is the primary purpose.

Sample recommendation letter

Sender's address

Your phone number

(1 line space)

Today's date

Recipient's name

Recipient's address

(1 line space)

Dear Mr. Bellows:

(1 line space)

I am writing to recommend an interview candidate for a photography position within your company. Lisa Photo taker has applied for a position within your company and I have had experience working with her.

(1 line space)

Lisa is a very creative person that has a keen sense of style and an eye for detailed photography. She is an asset to any team, bringing with her the sense of artistic design skills and talents that are so often sought after. I would recommend hiring her for this position without hesitation. She was responsible for photographing and all the layout and design work on our latest calendar, for which we couldn't be happier.

(1 line space)

If I can answer questions regarding this recommendation, please don't hesitate to contact me.

(1 line space)

Sincerely,

(drop down four lines)

Signature here

Linda Viewfinder

Owner

When it comes to writing business letters, they are mostly written in the same manner. The subject or angle may change, but the fact that you are writing in a professional manner, keeping it clean and precise, remains the same. Whether it's a recommendation, a sympathy letter, or a resignation letter, the formulas used above can be applied to nearly any circumstance.

## WRITING LETTERS AND MEMORANDA

Letters (and the informal, internal kind of letter we call a memorandum) are the principal day-to-day medium of information exchange. This is not about letter-writing in general, though much of what we say would apply to any letters; it is about letters written to give technical information, the type of letter likely to be written by the scientist or engineer working in an industrial or scientific organization. Other sorts of letters (in particular, sales letters) are not our province.

Every letter carries not only information but also an image of the writer and the organization he or she works for. It is important to be aware of the potency of this image. Consider, for example, the following letter in reply to a customer's query about his account:

Dear Mr Knight,

|     |    |    |    |    |
|-----|----|----|----|----|
| Re: | 55 | 78 | 91 | 99 |
|     | 38 | 00 | 31 | 00 |

We are in receipt of your letter received at this Office 14th April 1987 and would advise that according to our records, an exchange of model to colour receiver type 7641 was effected on account 55 78 91 99 from 15th December 1986 and an initial payment of £8.50 was allocated.

However, an annual invoice in respect of previous television was despatched prior to details of exchange of model being completed on the account and a subsequent payment of £72.15 was allocated on 15th December 1986. It would appear that a further remittance of £179.22 was made 13th January 1987 in respect of annual rental for both television accounts and the sum of £86.02 has been transferred to clear rentals on account 38 00 31 00 until 19th April 1988. Two detailed statements are enclosed to assist in

clarification and you will observe that account 55 78 91 99 is in fact clear until 23rd February 1987 with a further credit balance of £79.40.

In the circumstances, would you kindly advise whether this balance is to remain on the account or be refunded.

A pre-paid envelope is enclosed for your convenience.

Yours sincerely,

John W. Hunt

Manager, Subscriber Relations Dept.

We wonder what sort of 'subscriber relations' the writer of this letter presides over. Is he hired to make a point of offending customers? Even a tolerant or resigned reader can hardly sense helpfulness in this letter. The writer seems aloof, impersonal, and probably old, crabbed, and bad-tempered. These reactions are a reader's natural response to the tone created by the wording of the letter. But many of the words and phrases are traditional and conventional usage in business correspondence. The writer may be a young, friendly man with a genuine concern for the comfort of his customers, but we cannot, however hard we try, ignore the overtones of aloof detachment. People often argue that letters such as this belong to the age of Dickens; yet this example is real. Admittedly, it is an extreme example, but many of the features of this letter can be found in the less monstrous, but very numerous, examples we all receive. Here is a re-written version of the same letter:

Dear Mr Knight,

Balance of your television rental

Your television rental account is in fact paid until 23rd February 1987. We exchanged the television for a colour set on 15th December 1986, but our invoice was unfortunately sent out before this.

*We have received three payments from you:*

15th December, 1986 £8.50

15th December, 1986 £72.15

13th January, 1987                      £179.22

Because the rentals for the first set were more than covered by these payments, we transferred the balance (£86.02) to the other rental account. This still leaves a credit balance of £79.40. Would you like us to refund this, or will you leave it in credit for future rentals?

To help you follow this rather complicated situation, we are sending copies of the two accounts, that is No. 55 78 91 99 and No. 38 00 31 00. We are sorry for the confusion.

Yours sincerely,

John W Hunt

Manager, Subscriber Relations Department.

The success of this letter derives not just from the friendly tone but also from the directness of style and the clarity of the information. There are no tortuous structures or pompous words, no stylised phrases such as are never spoken aloud by a real person.



There is also a careful re-thinking of the information needed. The reader is not overloaded with a mass of detail which may or may not be relevant. The letter is short and to the point, but we do not feel it to be abrupt, unfriendly, or stingy with information. The truth is that the over-elaborate courtesies of the first version (such as 'I trust that this information will suffice') strike readers as hollow and hypocritical.

We learn an important point from the original letter. It was probably not indifference that created the unfortunate tone; rather, it was probably helpfulness which failed to think. No letter-writer actually *wants* to create the impression that this letter creates, but many letter-writers, naturally friendly people in themselves, *do* create just this impression by lack of thought.

### COMMUNICATION IS A RELATIONSHIP

When we communicate, we are forming a relationship. Even if we transmit and receive only neutral information, we cannot help making judgements about the other person, and his or her likely intentions.

Because there is a residual unease in person-to-person interactions, inherited from rougher and more insecure times, we have evolved elaborate rituals to reassure each other of good intentions. Thus, in a normal spoken interaction, a great deal of information about attitude and intention is transmitted non-verbally, by facial expression and movement, gesture, position of the body, distance away, use of the eyes, and many other signals. This non-verbal component of the message is vitally important in forming the communicative link.

In a letter there is no face and no smile. Without non-verbal signals to confirm good intentions, the *tone* of the letter is especially important. Judgement of the other person's intentions, of his or her confidence and assurance about what he or she is saying, is a vital part of communication. We perceive the *senders* of messages as well as their information.

The perceptions which led 1580 scientists to make judgements about the personal qualities of the report-writer after reading only a few paragraphs also operate when reading a letter. Readers cannot stop themselves making continual judgements of writers' intention and competence, as well as of the information they are receiving.

Nor can writers prevent these normal human perceptions coming into play. That was why the example a few pages ago was so disturbing. Being careful about tone does not mean that letters should be full of racy mateyness, or crammed with lugubrious reassurances. It *does* mean you must select from the resources of the language code very carefully, to guard against possibilities of misinterpretation.

Use the language of everyday human contact. Overformality and impersonal constructions have no associations of friendliness, no familiar context of helpful human interaction. We meet them only in the cold impersonal environments of administrative writing, and they open a door to chilly drafts of indifference.



## HELPFUL CLARITY

Choice of language affects the way readers respond to letters. If writers wish to convey the impression of being friendly and helpful, the simple natural rhythms of everyday serious conversation are best. Why, then, do some writers choose a high-flown style? The answer is, we think, that the artificiality of writing to a face they have not seen is as upsetting for the writer as for the reader. Writers feel they must be careful not to offend; finding it difficult to judge the reactions of a silent and invisible reader, they protect themselves by being over-formal. Writers also feel that they must be more explicit in writing, and they reach for the longer, more formalized words.

It is true that the absence of non-verbal signals means letters must be clear; but clarity does not come from long-windedness. Writing needs precision and detail, but it does not need a roundabout, pompous, and over-formalized style. The aim should be to create the impression of an efficient but human organization, which is interested in the reader's problems, and wants to help.

## USE PERSONAL PRONOUNS

Avoid impersonal constructions; they give the atmosphere of distant formality which upsets readers. Write 'I suppose', not 'it is apprehended that'. You may feel that using 'I' lays you open to personal responsibility for the information you give; but use of the first person does not increase your responsibility, especially if you write on headed notepaper as an organization's agent. Equally, roundabout, impersonal phrases will not decrease your responsibility, but they will reduce clarity. Writers are afraid of sounding self-centred if they continually use 'I' or 'we'. So they use a variety of alternatives such as 'the writer', or 'the undersigned', or 'this office'; the reader translates all these as 'I' with the added connotations of impersonality. 'The writer' means, for the reader, 'I, the distant and indifferent writer...'. Use 'we' for communal work or decisions, or write active sentences with the object under discussion as subject.

Thus do not always write: 'I have the parts you ordered ready for collection'. Sometimes write instead: 'The parts you ordered are ready for collection'. Similarly, it is often possible to turn the sentence round so that 'You' becomes the subject of an active sentence. Thus do not write, where there are already several sentences starting with 'I', yet another one: 'I am pleased to tell you that the tests were negative'. Write instead, 'You will be pleased to know that the tests are negative'. A skilful choice from these resources can make a letter varied and interesting, and avoid chilling impersonality.

## AVOID LONG, FORMAL WORDS

The temptation to reach out for the long word seems more irresistible than ever in letters. Words and phrases long out of use in normal conversation are dusted off, and ancient formalities are dragged out. Often, writers seem to climb up on to ancient, Dickensian high stools and desks, straighten their backs, clear their throats, and with

much dipping and chewing of their quills, scratch and blot their way through copious and fawning formalities. Try to use simple, familiar words instead. They are easier to read, more economical in time and space, but most importantly they have the atmosphere of efficiency and friendliness.

Every entrant into the civil service comes equipped with a vocabulary of common words of precise meaning adequate for all ordinary purposes. But when he begins to write as an official he has a queer trick of forgetting them and relying mainly on a smaller vocabulary of less common words with a less precise meaning. The English language is rich in verbose and unwieldy phrases to replace the plain and serviceable everyday word. Instead of 'about' the writer can say 'in regard to' or 'referring to' or 'in connection with'.

We think writers choose these longer phrases because they feel such wording adds variety and elegance; perhaps they feel that these ceremonious circumlocutions convey a timeless old-world courtesy; perhaps also they hope that if they linger politely over these words, their reader will think they have taken care and trouble over the letter. But whatever the motive, the tactics are mistaken. Such long phrases do not convey respect and courtesy; the simple phrase conveys real helpfulness by sensibly getting on with the job.

### **LAYOUT OF THE LETTER**

The layout of a document is part of a system of signs, a code which reader and writer use more successfully when it is familiar to both of them. For these reasons, letters should follow the standard format which the reader is conditioned to expect. The writer's address, if it is not printed, will be expected in the top right-hand corner. The name and address of the reader will be expected slightly lower down on the left. The references will usually be either below or above the receiver's address; they can also be put in the title line of the letter. Within simple conventions, a letter can follow any form which is a convenient and effective way of communicating the information.

The first impact of the letter is created by the greeting. Many writers always put 'Dear Sir', or even worse 'Dear Sir or Madam', even if they know the name of the person they are writing to. But using first names has become the norm in personal contacts, and is becoming the norm in business letters. If you are not on first-name terms, the best policy is to address your reader by surname. A name is a personal thing, and to use it is a sign of respect. The convention of addressing even friends with a peremptory and military 'Sir!' died with the First World War; to start letters with a uniform 'Dear Sir' suggests indifference to people and their names.

Some companies state that all letters must be addressed to the company. This is an antiquated restriction, and we meet it less and less; but in replying to one of their letters, the sensible thing to do is to accept their requirements, since there is no point in irritating your reader gratuitously. But show that you are replying to the person who

wrote to you by clearly marking your letter for the attention of that person. When you are writing to someone whose name you do not know, 'Dear Sir or Madam' is acceptable as a polite form of address, but only then.

When addressing the letter, put the addressee's position in the company as the next line after his or her name. There are two reasons for this. First, if no official position is in the address, the office may think the letter is personal, and leave it unopened when the addressee is away. Second, if the addressee has left, the new holder of the job may send your letter on. This confusion is avoided if the addressee's status is given after his or her name. In most letters, some sort of heading or title-line should come immediately after the greeting. Most people in offices deal with many letters on widely different topics every day, and it helps them to focus their attention on the subject of any particular letter quickly if the topic is clearly stated in a title line. But do not write 'Re: Cotton wool swabs'. The *Re* adds nothing, and most people do not even know what it means (it is in fact Latin for 'the thing' and was used by mediaeval lawyers to give formality to their writing). Just as informative, and simpler is: 'Cotton Wool Swabs'. The title line may also contain the references, if they are informative. Thus the title might be 'Cotton-Wool Swabs: Order C.59487'. It could also contain the date of the letter you are replying to: 'Diesel Generator: your letter of 21st April'. In this way, cumbersome references are kept out of the first sentence.

### START WITH THE IMPORTANT POINT

Your first sentence should contain the main point of the letter. Many writers seem to find it difficult to start. They write:

Dear Sir,

Thank you for your letter of 27th April, which we have received. Turning to the matter you mention in your first paragraph, you will be pleased to know that the Diesel Generators are ready...

The opening phrases of this letter are redundant; they have little function other than to clear the writer's throat. Readers must skip over them to get to the meat of the letter, and this is wasteful for reader and writer alike. More importantly, it blunts the impact of the message. Such an opening gives an apologetic and hesitant tone. Start letters, instead, with the key point:

Dear Mr Smith,

The diesel generators are ready...

Many of the stilted phrases of the ugly 'correspondence' style are redundant opening lines:

With reference to your enquiry please find attached...

I am writing to tell you that...

No one could write 'I am not writing to tell you that...' or even 'I am writing not to tell you that...'. Equally silly is the opening: We have received your letter...

The phrase is meaningless because its opposite is unlikely. Much awkwardness in opening sentences is created by the feeling that it is essential to refer at the outset to the date of the letter to which you are replying.

We have already suggested that the date is better in the reference or in the title line; but if you must refer, in the first sentence, to the date of the letter to which you are replying, put it in a more comfortable position, not highlighted at the beginning. Do not write: Thank you for your order of 21st April for diesel generators, which are now ready.

But write: The diesel generators, which you ordered on 21st April, are now ready. The old habit of using Latin in the first sentences of letters is dying out. Writers used to refer to 'yours of 21st. ult.' or 'prox.' or 'inst'. Many readers are not certain what the abbreviations mean, and in any case such Latin tags give an air of stuffy pomposity to a letter. Write clearly by always stating the month itself. Sometimes a letter is little more than a cover-note for something you are sending. The traditional openings for this are stilted and formal.

Do not write 'Please find enclosed...'; it has an unnatural ring to it, and most of the variations of this phrase are not much better. It is simpler and more natural to write: 'Here is the plan you wanted...'

## **ORGANIZATION**

Before ending a letter, make sure all the necessary points are covered. Give information clearly, and in an order which makes it easy for the reader to follow the points through. Do not be afraid to use sub-headings in a letter. They are very helpful to the reader as a signal that he or she is moving to a different topic. If the letter is more than a page long, it can have sub-headings, exactly as in a report.

Check that you have dealt with all the questions you must answer by making brief notes in the margin of the enquirer's letter, and going through them while writing.

## **ENDING**

At the end of your letter, stop. This is obvious advice, perhaps, but many writers add pious and empty courtesies. A customary flourish, by its very weary familiarity, adds nothing; indeed, it detracts from the impression of sincerity. Consider this ending: Meanwhile we should be pleased to have your assurance of immediate delivery of a replacement supply and look forward to being advised of delivery on Monday or Tuesday of next week.

Yours faithfully, The ending has a genuine point to make, but does so in such a verbose way that it is unlikely to succeed. A more effective ending is: Please will you tell us by Tuesday next week when you can deliver.

*A second example of a verbose ending which struggles to say something simple, at great length, is:* We should be pleased to have confirmation of your understanding of this purchasing agreement between us, which we are sure will be to our mutual advantage.

Such an ending leaves a bad taste: 'We should be pleased to...' sounds pompous. 'Confirmation of your understanding...' means simply 'confirmation'. 'Agreement between us' means simply 'agreement'. 'We are sure will be to our mutual advantage...' sounds like the bland re-assurances of the conman. A better ending is: Please confirm this agreement. Many absurd and uncomfortable phrases are used to end letters. Such endings should be cut out; the best way to finish a letter is with the last factual statement. If an early reply is genuinely needed, then give both a date, and a reason.

Not: The favour of a response in the near future would be appreciated. but: Please reply by the 25th because we make up our monthly orders then.

## THE SIGNATURE

It is polite to type your name, or write it in block capitals below the signature. The range and variety of English surnames is amazing. We all feel upset if our name is misspelt; we all feel embarrassed if we are unsure about the spelling of a name. To save your reader puzzling over a signature, try also to acquire a legible and neat signature. Finally, it is off-hand to end 'Dictated and signed in his absence by...' It suggests the writer is too busy to deal with letters personally.

We know it is sometimes done for legal reasons, but the secretary is as much the organization's agent in law as the manager is. If your letter has to be signed by someone else, the simple explanation 'for' is clearest and politest. When signing letters, it is also polite to put your position or status after the signature. Everyone in the office may know who you are, but the reader may not. It is always courteous to tell your reader in what capacity the letter is written.

## TACTICS FOR LETTERS

Not all letters merely report information. In many cases they have to explain failure, repeat requests, refuse information or confess to not having done something. If you have to fulfil one of these tasks, try to report first what you *have* been able to do, then report what you have not been able to do. Reflect on the impression this reply makes:

We have searched our files for the test reports on Batch C467. We think this report must be held at the New York office, and if you write direct to them you may be able to get a copy of it. We are sorry not to be able to help you this time. This letter reports failure to help, but does so in a strategic way. The impression is that the writer has made an effort to find the information, and he or she has thought of the way forward for the reader. Exactly the same information could have been communicated more clumsily:

We do not seem to keep copies of the test reports, such as that on Batch C467 which you requested, though we spent time searching our files. You should write to the New York office. The blame here appears to be put on the reader's shoulders for asking the wrong office. Even the fact that the writer spent time looking for the report sounds like a reproach, whereas previously it sounded like an effort to help. Tactical thinking is vital if you are to convey a good impression. By using sympathy and understanding for the reader, you can create a good impression and avoid unfortunate misunderstandings.

## WRITING MEMORANDA

A memorandum may be as long as a short report or as brief as a sentence. The main difference from a letter is the informality and immediacy of the memorandum. Because it is internal, it does not require the apparatus of addresses; because it is informal it does not require a greeting or a farewell; because it is immediate, it does not require a framework of courtesies. But a memorandum cannot be carelessly written. Tone is important; only careful choice of tactics can avoid the threat of misunderstanding. The most important advice is to avoid over-formal language, and to use every-day, clear and direct words and structures. A memo which starts:

The writer apprehends that difficulty has been experienced in achieving monthly targets... will court failure. It would create a better impression written in simpler language: I realise that you have found it hard to meet monthly targets... Elaborate courtesies in memoranda rarely ring true, and in some circumstances invite a cynical reaction. A simple 'please' or 'thank you' is adequate, because its simplicity reinforces rather than detracts from its sincerity. Thus a balanced memorandum to the sales staff might read:

Our sales quota for the month has again been achieved by the middle of the third week. Head Office have commented favourably on our area's performance. Thank you for your efforts.

The original version was less effective: I am very pleased to tell you that our sales quota for the month has already been met, and it is only the middle of the third week. You will be delighted to know that Head Office has commented favourably on this area's performance. Once again, my heartfelt thanks for your very real efforts.

A memorandum is a tool of management, a business device, aiming at convenience and speed. To spin it out with a *multiplicity* of 'pleases' and 'thank-yous' is redundant. Memoranda should briefly state their message, and stop. Most activities are co-operative; few organizations work for the benefit of one person only. It is therefore usually possible to put any request in a form which makes some benefit for the reader clear, and a little thought will make the writer sensitive to the ways in which such tactics can be used. It is well worth while, in terms of co-operation and efficiency, to make the effort to adjust to a reader-centred way of thinking. As an example, here is a memorandum which does its job less than efficiently:

## USE OF ENVELOPES

It appears that new envelopes are being used for internal mail and for the London office when, instead, used envelopes, sealed by stapling, would be quite satisfactory or, alternatively, envelopes could be dispensed with and the contents folded and secured by either a paper clip or staple and the recipient's name written on the outside. In the interests of economy, it is suggested that for internal mail or for London office, where practicable, either of the latter two methods should be adopted, care being taken to avoid any confusion or mis-direction by ensuring that any re-used envelopes are clearly addressed and all previous names and addresses obliterated.

Supplies of used envelopes are normally available from Traffic Department. The first impression is unfavourable, because the title line is not helpful in focusing attention on the precise subject. A more informative title would be: 'Economical re-use of envelopes', or 'Saving costs by re-using envelopes'. Next, long sentences (only three for the whole memo), and pompous words ('alternatively', 'dispensed with') build up an atmosphere of directive, insensitive fussing over details. There is no attempt to make the instructions in any way to the benefit of the reader. Nor is there any attempt to soften it with a simple 'please'; it remains blunt and impersonal. We would judge that there would be little saving of envelopes as a result of this memo. But it can be re-written in a simpler, more direct and personal style, adopting the tactics of appealing to mutual benefit:

## SAVING COSTS BY RE-USING ENVELOPES

Envelopes are costing our organization a great deal of money. Please re-use envelopes for internal mail as much as possible. Re-used envelopes can also be used for mail for London office; re-stapling old envelopes, or simply folding the message (and stapling or clipping) will do. Please make sure that the old address is crossed out. Traffic Department have plenty of used envelopes. Simplicity and thoughtfulness transform a poor memo into an effective one.

## Dictating Letters

Many letters are dictated. This is neither as easy nor as timesaving as it appears. Spoken language is very different from written language; in general it does not have the same sentence structures, uses more and simpler words, and relies on intonation as well as syntax for structure and emphasis. Here is an exact transcription of a spoken talk on a technical subject:

Well if you take one of these animals and put it between two electrical terminals in a laboratory, and create a strong static electricity field, which doesn't hurt the animal at all, it's perfectly lively and unaffected by it, but it will start to discharge electrons; they fan out from the openings of the body, the openings in its external shell, its exoskeleton, and there's an avalanche of electrons moving out and knocking into molecules of gas in the air, nitrogen molecules mostly, and these are excited, and because they're excited,



they glow, and so each individual insect, gives out rather a weak light, but if you look at it, in a darkened room, you can see this glow fanning out in all directions. If you have never seen spoken language written down before, you have probably not thought how radical the differences are. The spoken voice, has an extra 'code', an extra system of signals to communicate with. Intonation, by rising and falling pitch, by varying loudness, and by grouping sounds, is able to communicate the structures and meanings of groups of words. Because of this, spoken language often does not need the same explicit system of grammatical structures which written language uses. Stripped of the ability to use this intonation code, the *writer* has to use the grammar code more fully. It is for this reason that transcribed dictation is often uncomfortable to read. It also tends to be more repetitious (often using the same word with different meanings in the same sentence) and to use long phrases rather than single words. Simply talking into a dictating machine naturally produces the spoken variety of language. Therefore, when dictating, you must learn to reproduce the grammatical explicitness of written language while speaking. Here are three pieces of advice:

A dictated letter often lacks structure and headings. Therefore make a brief note plan of the main points before dictating. Look through these notes, determining the best order and dictate from them, clearly specifying paragraphs and sub-headings. Dictate slowly, using deliberately short sentences. Because spoken language tends to make less use of what we would recognize as a sentence boundary, dictated letters often have long sentences. Sentences which seem short when dictating are frequently of the right length when written down.

Try to dictate in a clipped style. Talking is easy and encourages verbosity and repetition. If you say things briefly, and stop before expanding, repeating or embroidering the point, the written result will be economical and effective as written language. Finally, it is essential to edit dictation. The transcript may have a different tone from that intended. Here is an example of 'raw' dictation, with signs of loquacity and unusual structures in written language.

It was unfortunately issued in this form: Dr Brown used to work with Quintra and has now been appointed Production Manager at this comparatively new plant which so far has not been involved with exterior finishes but is about to do so having developed a range of pretreatment systems and undercoatings for the industry which is likely to expand very substantially over the next few years. He now wishes to introduce new window re-finishing lines and to this end has been sampled with our products.

Evaluation of the other products continues but next week Dr Brown will advise E.C.D. of his requirements. At this stage, demand will certainly be small because in terms of manufacture they have had no previous experience as a company in producing these coatings. When spoken, the oddities of grammar in structures like 'which so far has not been involved...but is about to do so' and 'in terms of manufacture they have had no previous experience...' would go unnoticed. Intonation would supply the structure



which the grammar confuses. The letter also has very long sentences, and verbose phrases like 'to this end'. Edit dictation to produce written language: Dr Brown used to work for Quintra.

He has been appointed Production Manager at this new plant. So far it has not produced external finishes, but is about to start. It has developed a range of pretreatment systems and undercoatings for the building industry (which is likely to greatly expand over the next few years). He wants to introduce new window re-finishing lines so I gave him samples of our products. He will continue to evaluate the other products; but he promises to tell us what his requirements will be next week. They have no previous experience in the company of producing these coatings, so orders will be small.

### **Clear and Useful Letters**

No doubt many readers already follow the suggestions we have made here; but we are still surprised at the number of tortuously phrased and confusing letters. If writers are careful about adopting a direct and friendly tone, use simple, clear language, thoughtful tactics and a helpful layout, their letters create a favourable impression.

## Reading Skills in Business Communication

In the business world, workers use special skills to complete their reading tasks. Traditionally, however, business educators have relied on others to develop the job-related reading skills of their students. In 1975, Sticht noted that the overwhelming majority of time in schools is allocated to teaching the reading and interpreting of novels, short stories, dramas, and poetry as opposed to teaching technical reading skills needed in the workplace. The SCANS (Secretary's Commission on Achieving Necessary Skills) report released in 1991 included the reading of technical material as a foundation skill needed by all workers. Workplace reading includes the ability to understand and interpret various documents including diagrams, directories, correspondence, manuals, records, charts, graphs, tables, and specifications.

In the 1970s, two researchers, Ross and Salzman, studied the reading tasks of randomly selected office workers in the Columbus, Ohio, area. Ross completed one-hour observations of one hundred beginning office workers, and Salzman collected 2,659 samples of reading, writing, and mathematical activities from thirty-five beginning and thirty-five experienced office workers. Outcomes of these two studies identified three unique reading skills office workers use: proofreading, verifying, and comprehending detail. Building on the research that Ross and Salzman completed, Schmidt reported, in 1987, the reading levels of office documents collected for the purpose of developing reading materials aimed at building technical reading skills. One hundred and twenty-one documents collected from ten businesses were analyzed

for reading level using the FORCAST formula. The FORCAST formula developed in 1975 by Caylor, Sticht, Fox, and Ford uses the percentage of one-syllable words as the basis for determining reading level, so it eliminates consideration of recurring technical terms, which can artificially raise the reading level of technical materials.

The average reading grade levels for the documents ranged from 11.3 for those collected from a bank to 13.4 for those collected from a university continuing education center office. Other businesses that provided documents and their average reading grade levels included a space industry manufacturer, 11.4; a town administration office, 11.8; a hospital, 12; an insurance company, 12; a chemical industry manufacturer, 12.1; a railroad, 12.8; a country administration office, 13.1; and a school division office, 13.1. Thus, the reading grade level of typical office documents is considerably higher than general interest reading materials. Further, most reading done by adults is technical, job-related reading and not the type of reading emphasized in schools.

Based on a study of two groups of high school students in which one group was enrolled in courses required to complete a business programme and the other group enrolled in selected elective business courses, Schmidt reported in 1982 that the first group, composed of 279 students, performed better on a proofreading skills test than the second group, comprising 1,058 students. However, on tests measuring the skills of verifying and comprehending detail, the first group did not score better than the second group. The tests were constructed from actual business documents. From this outcome, Schmidt concluded that reading exercises for developing the skills of verifying and comprehending detail were needed.

The National Business Education Association published the exercises that evolved from the studies. In the introduction to the Office Reading Exercises, Schmidt describes trial use of the exercises prior to their publication. They were used with experimental and control groups, each with more than 250 high school students. After completing a pretest, the experimental group completed the ten exercises, using 15 to 20 minutes to complete one exercise per day. The students were simply given the exercises and informed of expected outcomes. This group not only scored significantly higher on a post-test administered at the completion of the exercises, but also on a post-test administered after a lapse of three to five weeks. They also scored significantly higher on the posttest than the control group. Thus a research base exists to justify the use of the exercises.

The ten exercises were all developed from actual office documents including a catalogue page, a price list, an insurance claim, an enrollment report, a budget allocation form, a meal price schedule, a programme confirmation, zoning ordinance information, concentration banking information, and an expense account. Schmidt provides two approaches that can be used for teaching the exercises. One is a holistic approach where the students are simply given the exercises, one day at a time, and told the outcomes desired. This was the approach used in the study described above. They devise, along with their classmates, their own methods for achieving the outcomes. The other approach

is instructor-directed and is called a “Guided Approach.” It allows the instructor to emphasize the thirteen component skills that are subsets of the two main skills, verifying and comprehending detail.

Verifying requires comparing technical information that has been transferred from one place to another to be sure that it has been transferred accurately. Comprehending detail is reading printed technical information, then determining if statements about it are accurate.

*The component skills or sub-skills emphasized in the Guided Approach are:*

- Following directions
- Perceiving document structure
- Perceiving relationships
- Identifying relevant information
- Locating facts or specifics
- Recognizing comparison/contrasting information
- Interpreting symbols, graphics, or acronyms
- Recognizing sequence of information
- Summarizing or making generalizations
- Selecting relevant information
- Recognizing main idea
- Reading with partner to detect errors
- *Recognizing errors:* transpositions, typographical and mechanical, additions and omissions

Taylor and Hancock, in a 1993 publication titled “Strategies That Reinforce Academics Across the Business Curriculum,” discussed strategies to help introduce, reinforce, and extend students’ comprehension, vocabulary, and writing in three reading stages. An overview of the three stages follows.

## **PRE-READING STAGE**

Before students are assigned technical reading, they need to engage in pre-reading strategies to help them in understanding the material. The reading can be broken into smaller segments with a variety of activities that promote student involvement. These might include a graphic organizer, an analogical study guide, or an anticipation/reaction guide. This guide helps focus pre-reading discussion and can also serve for post-reading review.

## **READING STAGE**

At the reading stage, the students need to focus on garnering major ideas as well as important details from the material. A study guide or selective reading guide can help the students achieve this objective. The study guide used should, unlike the text-explicit questions generally supplied by textbook authors, extend the students’ thinking beyond mere “parroting” of the text-explicit concepts.

## POST-READING STAGE

Once the students have read the material, they need to engage in post-reading activities to assure long-term retention of what they have read. The pre-reading strategies can again be used or students can undertake other activities. These might include vocabulary reinforcement activities, journal writing, or other writing activities that allow the students to apply information from what they have read.

Thus, the reading of technical materials requires the development of unique skills that are not addressed by most teachers. The Office Reading Exercises developed by Schmidt and the strategies recommended by Taylor and Hancock provide some approaches that can be used to teach technical reading skills. However, before these approaches are used, instructors should also be concerned with the extent that their students' reading abilities match those required for technical materials.

*Two methods are available for this purpose:*

- The Cloze procedure developed by Taylor in 1953, which permits the instructor to measure the compatibility of printed materials with the reading ability of students, and
- A pretest developed from technical terms the material contains.

For classroom use, the following adaptation of the Cloze technique is recommended by Popham, Schrag, and Blockhus.

- Randomly select reading material in six to nine passages and delete every fifth word in each passage. Stop when 20 words have been deleted.
- In place of each word deleted, substitute an underscore.
- Have the material typed, and instruct students to place in each blank a word that makes sense. No guessing or time restrictions permitted.
- Analyze the answers and give credit for each substitution that approximates the original meaning. Determine a raw score for each student and convert that raw score to a percent by dividing the actual number of correct answers by the possible number of correct answers.
- Determine the level at which the students comprehend the material by using the following scale. A score of 0 to 30 percent equals the "frustration" reading level, a score of 31 to 49 percent equals the "instructional" reading level, and a score of 50 to 100 percent equals the "independent" reading level.

Some technical materials do not lend themselves to the use of the Cloze test. For these materials a pretest based on technical terms from the material can be developed to provide insight into the extent that students can understand the material. If a student answers less than half of the items on the test correctly, the instructor may assume that the student will have difficulty reading the material.

Students need technical reading skills for the business world. Furthermore, all teachers are expected to reinforce academic competencies in their instruction. The procedures

discussed here can help teachers meet the challenge of teaching technical reading skills, those essential for reading in business.

## READING AND ANALYZING

When you read, do you read each and every word? Do you skim over the document and try to identify key terms and themes? Do you focus on numbers and statistics, or ignore the text and go straight to the pictures or embedded video? Because people read in many diverse ways, you as a writer will want to consider how your audience may read and analyze your document.

Ever since Benjamin Franklin said that “time is money,” business managers have placed a high value on getting work done quickly. Many times, as a result, a document will be skimmed rather than read in detail. This is true whether the communication is a one-paragraph e-mail or a twenty-page proposal. If you anticipate that your document will be skimmed, it behooves you to make your main points stand out for the reader.

In an e-mail, use a “subject” line that tells the reader the gist of your message before he or she opens it. For example, the subject line “3 p.m. meeting postponed to 4 p.m.” conveys the most important piece of information; in the body of the e-mail you may explain that Wednesday’s status meeting for the XYZ project needs to be postponed to 4 p.m. because of a conflict with an offsite luncheon meeting involving several XYZ project team members. If you used the subject line “Wednesday meeting” instead, recipients might glance at their in-box, think, “Oh, I already know I’m supposed to attend that meeting,” and not read the body of the message. As a result, they will not find out that the meeting is postponed.

For a longer piece of writing such as a report or proposal, here are some techniques you can use to help the reader grasp key points.

- Present a quick overview, or “executive summary,” at the beginning of the document.
- Use boldface headings as signposts for the main sections and their subsections.
- Where possible, make your headings informative; for example, a heading like “Problem Began in 1992” is more informative than one that says “Background.”
- Within each section, begin each paragraph with a topic sentence that indicates what the paragraph discusses.
- When you have a list of points, questions, or considerations, format them with bullets rather than listing them in sentences.
- The “bottom line,” generally understood to mean the total cost of a given expenditure or project, can also refer to the conclusions that the information in the report leads to. As the expression indicates, these conclusions should be clearly presented at the end of the document, which is the place where the time-pressed reader will often turn immediately after reading the first page.

Imagine how unhappy you would be if you submitted a report and your audience came away with a message completely different from what you had intended. For example, suppose your manager is considering adopting a specific new billing system in your office and has asked you to report on the pros and cons of this system. You worked hard, gathered plenty of information, and wrote a detailed report which, in your opinion, gave strong support for adopting the new system.

However, the first few pages of your report described systems other than the one under consideration. Next, you presented the reasons not to implement the new system. Throughout the report, embedded in the body of several different paragraphs, you mentioned the advantages offered by the new system; but they were not grouped together so that you could emphasize them with a heading or other signpost for the reader. At the end of the report, you reviewed the current billing system and stated that few problems were encountered with it.

When you delivered your report, the manager and colleagues who received it missed your most important information and decided not to consider the new system any further. Worse, your manager later criticized you for spending too much time on the report, saying it was not very informative. Situations like this can be avoided if you provide a clear organizational framework to draw your reader's attention to your main points.

Analyzing is distinct from reading. When you read, you attempt to grasp the author's meaning via words and symbols, and you may come away with a general emotional feeling about what the writer has written instead of an arsenal of facts. When you analyze a document, you pay more attention to how the author assembled the information to present a coherent message. Business writing often involves communication via words and symbols in ways that meet audience expectations; in many cases, the audience needs to be able to analyze the content, and reading is secondary. For this reason, a solid organizational pattern will greatly enhance your document's effectiveness.

## **TYPES OF READING**

Within the category of silent reading, one encounters intensive and extensive reading. Intensive reading is used to teach or practice specific reading strategies or skills. The text is treated as an end in itself. Extensive reading on the other hand, involves reading of large quantities of material, directly and fluently. It is treated as a means to an end. It may include reading simply for pleasure or reading technical, scientific or professional material.

This latter type of text, more academic, may involve two specific types of reading, scanning for key details or skimming for the essential meaning. A relatively quick and efficient read, either on its own or after scanning or skimming, will give a global or general meaning.

This web page then will first examine intensive reading. The second part will deal with extensive reading, with a focus on how it results in a general or global meaning. The fourth part gives a short comment on how intensive and extensive reading may operate in the same class. The fourth part examines scanning and the fifth, scanning. A final sixth part comments on how scanning and skimming may be used in the same reading.

## **INTENSIVE READING**

What it is

- Brown (1989) explains that intensive reading “calls attention to grammatical forms, discourse markers, and other surface structure details for the purpose of understanding literal meaning, implications, rhetorical relationships, and the like.” He draws an analogy to intensive reading as a “zoom lens” strategy.
- Long and Richards (1987) say it is a “detailed in-class” analysis, led by the teacher, of vocabulary and grammar points, in a short passage.”
- Intensive Reading, sometimes called “Narrow Reading”, may involve students reading selections by the same author or several texts about the same topic. When this occurs, content and grammatical structures repeat themselves and students get many opportunities to understand the meanings of the text. The success of “Narrow Reading” on improving reading comprehension is based on the premise that the more familiar the reader is with the text, either due to the subject matter or having read other works by the same author, the more comprehension is promoted.

### **How it Looks**

*Characteristics:*

- Usually classroom based
- Reader is intensely involved in looking inside the text
- Students focus on linguistic or semantic details of a reading
- Students focus on surface structure details such as grammar and discourse markers
- Students identify key vocabulary
- Students may draw pictures to aid them (such as in problem solving)
- Texts are read carefully and thoroughly, again and again
- Aim is to build more language knowledge rather than simply practice the skill of reading
- Seen more commonly than extensive reading in classrooms

*Materials:*

- Usually very short texts - not more than 500 words in length
- Chosen for level of difficulty and usually, by the teacher
- Chosen to provide the types of reading and skills that the teacher wants to cover in the course



*Skills developed:*

- Rapid reading practice
- *Interpreting text by using:*
  - a. word attack skills
  - b. text attack skills
  - c. non-text information

### Activities

*Intensive reading exercises may include:*

- Looking at main ideas versus details
- Understanding what is implied versus stated
- Making inferences
- Looking at the order of information and how it effects the message
- Identifying words that connect one idea to another
- Identifying words that indicate change from one section to another

Munby (1979) suggests four categories of questions that may be used in intensive reading.

*These include:*

- Plain Sense - to understand the factual, exact surface meanings in the text
- Implications - to make inferences and become sensitive to emotional tone and figurative language
- Relationships of thought - between sentences or paragraphs
- Projective - requiring the integration of information from the text to one's own background information

Note that questions may fall into more than one category.

### Assessment

Assessment of intensive reading will take the form of reading tests and quizzes.

The most common systems of questioning are multiple-choice and free-response.

Mackay (1968), in his book *Reading in a Second Language*, reminds teachers that the most important objective in the reading class should NOT be the testing of the student to see if they have understood.

Teachers should, instead, be spending most of the time training the student to understand what they read.

When it is used

- *When the objective of reading is to achieve full understanding of:*
  - a. Logical argument
  - b. Rhetorical pattern of text
  - c. Emotional, symbolic or social attitudes and purposes of the author
  - d. Linguistic means to an end
- For study of content material that are difficult

### Role of the teacher

- The teacher chooses suitable text.
- The teacher chooses tasks and activities to develop skills.
- The teacher gives direction before, during and after reading.
- The teacher prepares students to work on their own. Often the most difficult part is for the teacher to “get out of the way”.
- The teacher encourages students through prompts, without giving answers.

### Advantages

- It provides a base to study structure, vocabulary and idioms.
- It provides a base for students to develop a greater control of language
- It provides for a check on the degree of comprehension for individual students

### Disadvantages

- There is little actual practice of reading because of the small amount of text.
- In a class with multi-reading abilities, students may not be able to read at their own level because everyone in the class is reading the same material.
- The text may or may not interest the reader because it was chosen by the teacher.
- There is little chance to learn language patterns due to the small amount of text.
- Because exercises and assessment usually follow intensive reading, students may come to associate reading with testing and not pleasure.

### Questions sometimes asked

- Should the text be read aloud first or some explanation given?
  - a. Nuttall (1986) suggests that if the teacher reads the text aloud before starting work on it, they have assumed part of the students’ job.
  - b. Others argue that without some help some students could not understand the text.
  - c. Still others argue that it is easy to underestimate students. they may actually understand more than is thought. If students cannot make any progress, the material may be unsuitable.

## EXTENSIVE READING

### What it is

- Brown (1989) explains that extensive reading is carried out “to achieve a general understanding of a text.”
- Long and Richards identify extensive reading as “occurring when students read large amounts of high interest material, usually out of class, concentrating on meaning, “reading for gist” and skipping unknown words.”
- The aims of extensive reading are to build reader confidence and enjoyment.
- Extensive reading is always done for the comprehension of main ideas, not for specific details.

### Historical Perspective

- Harold Palmer (1917) in Britain and Michael West (1926) in India were the first to pioneer the theory of extensive reading as an approach to foreign language teaching and to reading, in particular. Palmer chose the term “extensive reading” to distinguish it from “intensive reading”.
- The 1929 Coleman Report on “Modern Foreign Language Study”, introducing the Reading Method, recommended the inclusion of extensive reading in its Method (as distinct from inclusive reading).
  - a. Students were to read in the second language without a conscious effort to translate.
  - b. Emphasis was placed on developing independent silent reading and increasing reading rate of individual students.
  - c. Frequency word counts were developed and used as a basis for graded readers.
- Broughton(1978) argued for the important role Extensive Reading could play in second language programmes.
- Nuttall (1982) wrote that the idea of Extensive Reading should be “standard practice” in second language learning. She suggested the following “slogan”: “The best way to improve your knowledge of a foreign language is to go and live among the speakers. The next best way is to read extensively.”
- Krashen (1984) supported Extensive Reading because he felt it automatically gave rise to competence in writing. In 1993, he termed it “free voluntary reading”.
- Krashen (1995) argued that ‘free voluntary reading’ could be used as a “bridge” from communicative language competence to academic language competence.
- David Eskey (1995) drew the analogy of reading instruction to teaching swimming strokes to people who hated the water. It would be only through their discovery of the rewards of reading by actually doing it, that they would become people that can and do read.
- Elley (1996), in his report on a study involving 210,000 students and 10,000 teachers in 32 educational systems around the world, concluded that “instructional programmes that stress teacher directed drills and skills are less beneficial in raising literacy levels than programmes that try to capture students’ interest and encourage them to read independently.”
- Dupre’s research (1997) in French supported the theory that Extensive Reading is more pleasurable and beneficial for language acquisition than grammar instruction and practice.
- Nuttall (1998) argued the case for Extensive Reading programmes citing research studies that showed “impressive” gains in reading ability, motivation and attitude, and overall linguistic competence. There was also evidence of gains in vocabulary and spelling.

Although research strongly suggests that extensive reading can boost second language acquisition, few second language learners engage in voluntary reading at their own initiative, ( *i.e.* Reluctant Readers) and require guidance in the form of Extensive Reading programmes.

### **Background Theory**

*Several theories come into play in Extensive Reading:*

- Krashen's Input Hypothesis (1982) made a distinction between acquisition and learning. For Krashen, the dominant mode of language learning is *inacquisition*, the largely subconscious "picking up of the language" which characterizes language in informal settings and which is similar, if not identical, to the way children develop ability in their first language." Language acquisition represents unconscious learning which takes place when attention is focused on meaning rather than form. In order to acquire language, Krashen suggested the learner must be exposed to large amounts of second language input that was "meaningful", interesting, relevant, not grammatically sequenced, and in a low anxiety setting. It is felt that Extensive Reading programmes provide such an environment.
- The L1=L2 Hypothesis suggests that second language learning, like the first, follows a highly predictable pattern. If the conditions of first language acquisition are approximated by extensive second language reading, the second language learner can achieve native like competence in a classroom. An extension of this suggests that reading for pleasure from appropriate second language texts provides subconscious and progressively more difficult second language input much like that essential for first language acquisition.
- Rumelhart (1980) proposed an "interactive model" of the reading process in which reading is a complex task of simultaneously combining "bottom-up" processes (in which the reader analyzes text in small pieces and builds meaning from these) and "top-down" processes (in which the reader makes "guesses" about the content of a passage). It is thought that Extensive Reading programmes provide the quantities of reading practice necessary for the automaticity of the "bottom-up" (word recognition) process.

## **HOW EXTENSIVE READING MAY APPEAR IN A LANGUAGE CLASS**

### **Types of Programmes**

*Extensive reading may appear as any of the following:*

- A complement to an intensive reading programme
- An extra-curricular activity where students read out of class

- The main focus of a reading course (termed an Extensive Reading Programme) where students work with a class set of books, individual reading of material, of their own choice, with follow-up activities such as reading logs, reading journals, book reports or projects. Although it is less common for extensive reading to form an entire reading course, there are well-established Extensive Reading Programmes operating around the world. They have been carried on in many countries, at varying levels of education from Elementary School to College, and in different languages.

### Characteristics

Day and Bamford (1980) put forward ten characteristics identified in successful Extensive Reading Programmes.

*They are duplicated (in abbreviated form) below:*

- Students read as much as possible.
- A variety of materials on a range of topics is available.
- Students select what they want to read.
- The purposes of reading are usually related to pleasure, information and general understanding.
- Reading is its own reward.
- Reading materials are well within the linguistic competence of the students in terms of vocabulary and grammar.
- Reading is individual and silent.
- Reading speed is usually faster than slower.
- Teachers orient students to the goals of the programme.
- The teacher is a role model of a reader for the students.

Bell (2001), in his article “Extensive Reading: What is it? Why bother?” gives ten pieces of practical advice on running Extensive Reading programmes.

### Materials

*With demands for both simplicity and authenticity, the teacher must choose from the following:*

Graded Readers available by major publishers (e.g.. Cambridge University Press, Heinemann, Oxford and Penguin

- These are readers with specific levels of word frequency and idiom counts and the introduction of new vocabulary at a planned rate.
- Broughton (1978) favours using graded readers where less than one word in every hundred is unfamiliar.
- These are a good choice for students whose second language proficiency makes it difficult for them to read texts written for native speakers.

### Texts on the Same Topic

- Reading more than one text on the same topic allows students to bring more background knowledge to each new text read.

Authentic materials such as newspapers, magazines, that are related to the second language culture

### Web Resources

- These should be chosen from suggestions by the teacher so that students do not choose those that are too overwhelming.

*Stories and articles chosen by the teacher, with the following guidelines:*

- The style should include repetition, without being monotonous.
- New vocabulary should not occur at the same place as difficulties of structure.
- The text should break in sections that are not too long. This is to give the reader a feeling of accomplishment when completed.
- Authors should be chosen with less complex structure and less extensive vocabulary range.
- The subject matter should be of real interest to the students and suitable for their age level. Rivers (1981) suggests the subject matter should be as close as possible to the type of material the students would read in their first language.

Some thought may be given to socio-cultural issues. Should there be an attempt to match materials to students' cultural background? Students bring different knowledge of text types from their first language. Is it feasible to include these in the materials?

Materials should be chosen that are at or below the reading ability of the student. They are usually at a lower level of difficulty than those chosen for intensive reading.

*This is for several reasons:*

- It builds automatic recognition of words
- It allows the reader to see words in "chunks" of language, allowing for faster reading.

*Activities that may occur:*

- Reading may be combined with a speaking component. For example, they may interview each other about their reading.
- Reading may be combined with a writing component. For example, after reading the newspaper, students may be asked to write a newspaper report.
- Class time may be included for book exchange, if there is an in-class library.
- Students may set their own goals for their next session.
- Students may progress from reading graded reading material to authentic text. It should be expected that students will "slow down" in their reading then, it becomes more challenging.

- *Students may complete any of the following:*
  - a. A reading log (recording number of pages read and at what level)
  - b. A reading journal (reflections on the text read)

*A reading journal may take the following format:*

- Date, title of book and author
- The category of the book if known by the student
- A brief statement on what the book is about
- A summary of each part as it is read
- Student's reactions to each part

Often teachers will respond to the students and if so, the student should leave room in the journal for this.

- A reflection on what they noticed about their own reading
- A book report or summary - Helgesen (1997) recommends not spending more than 20 minutes on a report
- A retelling of part of the text
- Book project
- In some Extensive Reading Programmes, teachers will allow their students to report on their reading in their native language so as not to make the "proof" of reading more difficult than the reading itself. This, of course, only works if the teacher understands the student's first language.
- Extensive reading programmes are often cited as being more "pleasurable" because there are no "tedious" exercises to complete.

*Assessment:*

- There are no reading comprehension exercises or formal assessments in Extensive Reading programmes.
- Course grades for an Extensive Reading programme may be determined by marks given for reading reports, reading journals, book reports and projects.

*Role of Teacher*

- The teacher gives recommendations on reading materials, based on student's interests.
  - a. The teacher guides students in choosing appropriate levels of material, beginning with easy books.
  - b. The teacher guides students in choosing a variety of materials of their interest. This may especially be necessary for students that choose the same type over and over.
- The teacher guides students in setting specific goals for amounts read.
- The teacher provides modeling. If class time is given for reading, the teacher reads at the same time.
- The teacher overlooks if students are not aware of the exact meaning of each word. The teacher should not jump in and explain.

- The teacher leads pre-reading activities to build interest in the text, such as in the characters, places, themes, and actions. The teacher must be careful to provide just enough to stimulate curiosity but not so much that the need to read is removed.

#### Role of Student

- The student assumes total responsibility for developing reading ability.
- The student reads without the use of a dictionary.
- The student usually chooses their own material and moves along at their own pace but must push themselves in order to show greater progress.

#### Advantages

- *The students may:*
  - a. Develop a “reading habit”
  - b. Gain more confidence in reading
  - c. Improve their attitude towards reading and become more motivated to read
  - d. Feel more autonomous over their own learning and more likely to take more initiative.
  - e. Become more “independent readers”, being able to read for different purposes and being able to change reading strategies for different kinds of texts
  - f. Become more aware of what’s available to them to read and how to access materials
  - g. Expand sight vocabulary
  - h. Acquire “incidental” grammatical competence - that is, it may be acquired even though it was not directly taught
  - i. Build background knowledge
  - j. Increase reading comprehension
  - k. Improve overall language competence
  - l. Be more prepared for further academic courses because they have read large quantities
- An Extensive Reading programme may be combined with writing or combined with speaking practice in a meaningful way (such as when students discuss with each other the books they have been reading).
- Broughton (1978) suggested that “It is by pursuing the activity of extensive reading that the volume of practice necessary to achieve rapid and efficient reading can be achieved.”
- Krashen (1993a) suggested that the benefits of free voluntary reading included “enhanced language acquisition and literacy development, more ideas and information, greater success in life, loss of verbal memory, and more fun.”

#### Challenges:

- An Extensive Reading programme may be costly and time-consuming to set up if materials are not already available. It may be difficult to get support from Administration.



- Students need to have easy access to texts within their language proficiency level. An Extensive Reading programme is easiest to establish when the students have a high level of second language proficiency. For intermediate levels, students require a specialized library within their language proficiency range. They need texts they can read without great use of a dictionary.
- It may be difficult to keep students challenged to read more difficult texts as the programme continues. Some established programmes use a “weighing scale” for students to record materials read, giving more “marks” for materials read at a higher level. Although this has proven to be a motivating or competitive factor in some cases, in others it becomes counter-productive if students try to read texts that are more difficult than they can manage and consequently become discouraged.
- Reading each student’s journals and reports can be very time-consuming for teachers.
- Students who come from a culture in which literacy is not valued may be unwilling to participate in pleasure reading or may not get support at home.
- Some teachers prefer a skills based programme and do not feel comfortable with Extensive Reading.
- Some teachers are unaware of how to use Graded Readers and so, provide a limited range of activities for students, limiting their responses.
- Some teachers feel that time spent on Extensive Reading will take away from time that could be spent on learning language skills. Others will argue that Extensive Reading provides a “richer context” for practice.
- Some people feel that if graded readers are used, they can give a false impression of the level of reading that has been achieved. They feel that some students may try “ungraded” materials too soon and may revert to using a dictionary to translate.
- Some people feel that students may place too much emphasis on the number of pages read instead of on the understanding achieved.
- Students that have only been exposed to Intensive Reading programmes may not believe that Extensive Reading is a “proper” way to learn.
- Aeberscold (1997) reported that feedback from students in an Extensive Reading programme indicated that they liked the “choice” but not the “load”

#### Research topics

- What is the impact of extensive reading on attitude and motivation to read?
- How does vocabulary acquisition while reading compare to direct vocabulary instruction?
- What is the relation between amounts of reading and growth in reading comprehension?
- What are the students’ perceptions of their reading, their habits and difficulties?

- Do students that have an extensive reading component of their programme show greater improvements reading than students who have no such component?
- Do the use of simplified authentic texts actually increase comprehension or simply confidence?
- Past studies have shown that extensive reading leads to gains in students' second language proficiency as measured on cloze tests. Would the use of cloze exercises in addition to extensive reading be more effective than intensive reading alone?
- What other improvements in the area of language uses and language knowledge may result from Extensive Reading?

### **INTENSIVE AND EXTENSIVE READING TOGETHER**

It is common for both approaches to reading to be used in the same class. For example, where extensive reading is encouraged, the teacher may have all the students read the same text so they can discuss the topic together or learn a specific skill such as writing an outline. In a class where intensive reading is mostly used, students may be asked to read texts of their own choosing to report back on, in either an oral or written format. In both approaches, it is not the nature of the skills that are of most interest but rather, the results.

### **SCANNING**

What it is

- Scanning is a quick reading, focusing on locating specific information.
- Scanning involves quick eye movements, not necessarily linear in fashion, in which the eyes wander until the reader finds the piece of information needed.
- Scanning is used when a specific piece of information is required, such as a name, date, symbol, formula, or phrase, is required. The reader knows what the item looks like and so, knows when he has located what he was searching for. It is assumed then, that very little information is processed into long-term memory or even for immediate understanding because the objective is simply matching.

When it is used

- Scanning is used often with technical, scientific or professional materials to locate specific information.
- Scanning is a valuable skill for second language learners to develop because often they do not require a detailed read of a text. There are many everyday uses for scanning, relevant to a purpose, such as reading a schedule.

Role of Teacher

- The teacher selects passages that do include specific information.
- The teacher may use authentic materials that are commonly scanned in real life, such as the telephone directory, menus, bus schedules.

- The teacher may ask students before they scan a text to note how the information is organized in the text.
- The teacher needs to remind students that as they read carefully to find the required information, they should pay particular attention to titles and keywords.

#### Role of the Student

- The student forms questions before reading. What specific information are they looking for?
- The student looks for contextual clues. The student tries to anticipate what the answer might look like and what sorts of clues would be useful.
- The student is aware of the graphic form that the answer may take, such as a numeral, a written number, a capitalized word or a short phrase that includes key words.

#### Activities

- Activities may include exercises that are devised by the teacher in which students scan for a single word or specific text.
- Activities may include exercises that are often carried on as a competition so students will work quickly.
- *Students use skills of prediction and anticipation. Students may do any of the following:*
  - a. Make predictions and guesses
  - b. Use titles and tables of contents to get an idea of what a passage is about
  - c. Activate prior knowledge about the topic of the passage by answering some questions or performing a quiz
  - d. Anticipate what they want to learn about the top
  - e. Use titles, pictures, and prior knowledge to anticipate the contents of the text
  - f. Use key words, that may have been given to them by the teacher, that do not appear in the text, that allude to the main idea
- It is an accepted view today that efficient readers are not passive. They react with a text by having expectations and ideas about the purposes of the text as well as possible outcomes. They reflect on expectations as they read, anticipate what will come next. In other words, they “interact with the text”.

## SKIMMING

#### What it is

- *Skimming is a quick reading to get:*
  - a. To know the general meaning of a passage
  - b. To know how the passage is organized, that is, the structure of the text
  - c. To get an idea of the intention of the writer

- Skimming is a more complex task than scanning because it requires the reader to organize and remember some of the information given by the author, not just to locate it.
- Skimming is a tool in which the author's sequence can be observed, unlike scanning in which some predetermined information is sought after.

When it is used

- Skimming is used when reading some general question in mind.
- Skimming is used in making decisions on how to approach a text such as when determining if a careful reading is deserving.
- Skimming is used to build student confidence and an understanding that it is possible to gain meaning without reading every word in a text.
- Skimming is used as part of the SQ3R method of reading, often for speed reading. This method involves the student in surveying, questioning, reading, reviewing and reciting. Skimming is used for the initial survey and for review.
- Skimming is a skill that a student may want to develop if they are planning to continue with academic studies. It is often used in reviewing for a test.

Role of the teacher

- *Before the students start reading, the teacher should guide students to ask themselves the following questions:*
  - a. What kind of audience was the text written for? Was it, for example, the general public, technical readers, or academic students?
  - b. What type of text is it? Is it, for example, a formal letter, an advertisement, or a set of instructions?
  - c. What was the author's purpose? Was it, for example, to persuade, to inform or to instruct?
- *The teacher should make the following clear to students before assigning a skimming exercise:*
  - a. The purpose of the exercise
  - b. How deeply the text is to be read

Role of the student

- *Students read through the text in the following manner:*
  - a. Read the title if any.
  - b. Read the introduction or the first paragraph.
  - c. Read the first sentence of each of the following paragraphs.
  - d. Read any headings or sub-headings.
  - e. Look at any pictures or phrases that are in boldface or italics
  - f. Read the summary or last paragraph.

Activities

- Students must locate facts that are expressed in sentences, not single words.

- Although speed is essential and the teacher often sets a time limit to the activity, skimming should not be done competitively. Students should be encouraged individually to better themselves.
- To improve skimming, readers should read more and more rapidly, to form appropriate questions and predictions and then read quickly
- Pugh (1978) suggests that to assess skimming, after the students have read and completed the assigned questions, further questions may be asked, “beyond the scope of the purpose originally set”. If students can answer these questions correctly, it indicates they have read the text too closely.

### **SKIMMING AND SCANNING TOGETHER**

Skimming and scanning are sometimes referred to as types of reading and at other times, as skills.

Skimming involves a thorough overview of a text and implies a reading competence. Scanning is more a limited activity, only retrieving information relevant to a purpose.

Brown (1994) suggested that “perhaps the two most valuable reading strategies for learners as well as native speakers are skimming and scanning.” Pugh (1978) suggested that since scanning is a less complex style of reading it can be introduced first. Skimming requires greater fluency and more practice is required, so it should be introduced later.

Often skimming and scanning are used together when reading a text. For example, the reader may skim through first to see if it is worth reading, then read it more carefully and scan for a specific piece of information to note.

Students need to learn that they need to adapt their reading and techniques to the purpose of the reading.

By practicing skimming and scanning, the individual learns to read and select specific information without focussing on information that is not important for meaning.

## **WRITING FOR EASY READING**

Designing your message. Your writing should be appropriate to the subject, to the needs of your readers, and to the occasion. Each sentence should convey a whole thought accurately, clearly and as simply as possible, so that your readers take your meaning and always feel at ease. They are most likely to follow your arguments, understand your evidence, and remember your conclusions, if they can relate anything new to their existing knowledge and interests.

Communicating your purpose. Help readers by providing an informative title, and effective headings and sub-headings. Help them to see the connection between sentences, paragraphs and sections. Sometimes a word is enough; sometimes much more explanation is required.

Obtaining a response. Present information in an appropriate order. Include all essential steps in any argument; give evidence in support of anything new; give examples, and explain why any point is particularly important. No statement should be self-evident, but do not leave your readers to work out any implications. Be as explicit as necessary.

Fulfil your readers' expectations. For example, always follow the words first by second, on the one hand by on the other hand, whether by or, and not only by but also. If you list a number of items, mention all or none of them in the sentences that follow: if only some are mentioned, readers may be wondering about the others when they should be thinking about your next topic.

## HOW TO BEGIN

In most business communications you will have a particular reader or a particular audience in mind, and can start with things you know will be of interest. In a news story, or in a press release, intended for an unknown audience, the most important point comes first, in an eye-catching headline - and is repeated in the first sentence of the article, because that is all some readers will read.

If you know what you wish to communicate but have difficulty in getting started, look at the opening sentences in similar compositions by other people. Begin, for example, with: a summary, recommendations, a statement of a problem, necessary background information that leads directly to a problem, an example, a definition, a question, an answer to one of the readers' six questions, an idea that has received some support (then explain why it is incorrect), an accepted procedure (then explain the advantages of an alternative). The best starting point, for the subject and your readers, will probably be obvious once you have prepared your topic outline. However, it is better to begin than to spend too much time trying to decide how to begin. Your first paragraph can be revised, if necessary, when your first draft of the whole composition is complete. The only rules about beginning are:

- Come straight to the point, with an effective heading or title,
- If possible, refer briefly to things you expect your readers to know and build on that foundation.

## CONTROL

In each document you write, pay careful attention to presentation - to the arrangement of your material, order and timing - so that you are always in control: communicating information and affecting your readers in a chosen way. Maintaining control depends first on your knowledge and understanding, and then on careful planning - which helps you to present your thoughts in an appropriate, ordered and interesting way.

Good headings and sub-headings, especially in a long composition, are signposts that help readers along and - if they are not reading the whole composition - help them to find just the information they require.

## EMPHASIS

The title, headings and sub-headings emphasise the whole and its parts. Emphasis, which is achieved in many ways, is important in all writing and is present whether or not the writer is in control. But you can use emphasis effectively only if you know how to make important points stand out from the necessary supporting detail.

Beginnings and endings are important. The first and last paragraphs (the introduction and conclusion) will be read by most people. Then in each paragraph the first and last words capture most attention. In planning a composition you have to decide on the order of paragraphs, and you may number them in your topic outline. But remember that your plan is for you, not for the reader who requires only the results of your thinking and planning.

So, omit such superfluous introductory phrases as: First let us consider ..., Secondly it must be noted that .... An interesting example which should be mentioned in this context is .... Next it must be noted that... In conclusion it must be emphasised that .... Also, omit other unnecessary introductory phrases and connecting phrases.

Never begin a paragraph with unimportant words; and end each paragraph effectively. Similarly, in a sentence emphasis falls naturally on the first and last few words: so use those words to convey information or to make connections - to help readers understand your message and follow your train of thought.

A reader's or listener's attention can be captured and held by saying things in threes: a technique over-used by some politicians. It is no accident that in ancient times there were three Graces, and in the Christmas story three wise men; that in stories for children the wolf huffed and puffed and blew the house down, and the fairy godmother granted three wishes; that in a play a choice had to be made of one of three caskets; that people give three cheers; or that one is advised to see no evil, hear no evil, and speak no evil. You will have heard many jokes about the three .... but did you ever hear one about the four ... ? Saying things in threes encourages the reader or listener to anticipate what is to be said next and makes it easy to remember what has been said (for example, 'liberty, equality and ...', 'government of the people, by the people, for ...', 'so much, owed by so many, to ...').

Items of comparable importance can be emphasised by repeating an introductory word (as in this sentence), by small letters, or by numbers.

However, if a sentence has been properly constructed, so that it reads well, emphasis will fall naturally on each part. Similarly, if a composition has been well planned it will be well balanced, with an obvious beginning, middle and end, and each paragraph break will serve to emphasise that one topic has been dealt with and it is time to start thinking about the next.

If appropriate, plan effective illustrations to convey the essential points. In writing, use more forceful language for important points than for any supporting detail; and check your first draft to ensure you have emphasised them sufficiently. In your topic



outline you may underline words or phrases to remind you of points you intend to emphasise in your composition, but in the composition itself do not underline for emphasis. Underline only those words that in a book or journal would be printed in italics.

### SENTENCE LENGTH

Long, involved sentences may indicate that you have not thought sufficiently about what you are trying to say. If as you revise your composition you find a long sentence that is difficult to read, consider how it can be improved. Perhaps it should be broken into two or more shorter sentences. The breaks between paragraphs and sentences give readers time for thought; and in a newspaper the length of paragraphs, sentences and words is intended to match what the editor thinks are the readers' needs. In some newspapers each paragraph is one short sentence. In others the paragraphs are longer, some sentences are longer, and a wider vocabulary is used.

However, although short sentences are the easiest to read, a long sentence, if it is properly constructed, may be easier to read than a succession of short ones. There is no rule that a sentence, when read aloud, should be read in one breath. Good prose is seldom written in short sentences. An opinion can be clearly expressed, even in a long sentence, as in the following forty-eight-word sentence from a novel:

It is the fashion now 'to go along with the people' but I think the people ought to be led, ought to have ideas given them by those whom nature and education have qualified to govern states and regulate the conduct of mankind.

Sentences vary in length. Short sentences are effective for introducing a new subject, long sentences for developing a point, and short sentences for bringing things to a striking conclusion, as in this extract from another novel:

'If you really want to know,' said Mr. Shaw, with a sly twinkle, 'I think that he who was so willing and able to prove that what was was not, would be equally able and willing to make a case for thinking that what was not was, if it suited his purpose.' Ernest was very much taken aback.

### RHYTHM

Good prose, like speech, has a varied rhythm that contributes to the smooth flow of words in a sentence, gives emphasis to important points, and makes for easy reading. In contrast, badly constructed sentences may irritate readers and make them less receptive to your message. So it is a good idea to read your writing aloud, and to revise any parts that do not sound well.

McCartney, in *Recurrent Maladies in Scholarly Writing*, asks writers to be sensitive to the sounds of words and to try not to offend the ear, for example:

- By unintentional alliteration, as in rather regularly radial;
- By the grating repetition of s, as in such a sense of success;



- By adding s to a word that does not require it, for example to forward and towards (but the s may be needed to make the sentence easier to read);
- By the repetition of syllables, as in appropriate approach, continue to contain and protection in connection with infection;
- By the repetition of sound, as in found around and with respect to the effect;
- By the repetition of cognate forms in different parts of speech, as in a locality located, the following procedure should be followed, except for rare exceptions; no real realisation; or
- By repeating a word with a change in meaning, as in a point to point out.

## STYLE

Some may feel that style is not important in business communications; but style is not something that can be added to writing as a final polish. It is part of effective prose.

- That clarity, completeness, consistency, order, simplicity, sincerity and consideration for the reader are basic requirements;
- That all connections should be properly made; and
- That although written for silent reading effective prose should sound well if read aloud.

When writing at work, good style depends on the writer's intelligence, imagination and good taste; on sincerity and modesty; on attention to the essential characteristics of business communication and on careful planning.

The importance of planning was emphasised by George de Bufon, addressing the Académie Française in 1703: 'This plan is not indeed the style, but it is the foundation; it supports the style, directs it, governs its movement .... Style is but the order and the movement that one gives to one's thoughts.'

Because the way you put words together reflects your own personality and your feeling for words, it would be a mistake to try to copy someone else's style: a point made effectively.

Leonard was trying to form his style on Ruskin: he understood him to be the greatest master of English Prose. He read forward steadily, occasionally making a few notes. Let us consider a little each of these characters in succession, and first, what is very peculiar to this church - its luminousness. Was there anything to be learnt from this fine sentence? Could he adapt it to the needs of daily life? Could he introduce it, with modifications, when he next wrote a letter to his brother, the lay reader? For example: Let us consider a little each of these characteristics in succession, and first (for of the absence of ventilation enough has been said already), what is very peculiar to this flat - its obscurity. Something told him that the modifications would not do; and that something, had he known it, was the spirit of English Prose. 'My flat is dark as well as stuffy.' Those were the words for him.

**Capturing and holding your readers' interest**

Your interest in your subject should be conveyed to your readers. If you are replying to a letter or preparing a document based on clear terms of reference, for example, you start with the advantage that your readers are already interested and expecting to receive a communication from you. To maintain their interest you must present information at a proper pace. If readers understand they will want to move quickly to the point. However, they must understand every word, every statement, and every step in any argument. If they have to refer to a dictionary, or read a sentence more than once, before they can understand your message, you will lose their attention.

Readers are directed away from an explanation or argument by anything irrelevant, by unnecessary detail, by explanation of the obvious, and by needless repetition. They lose interest if statements are not supported, as appropriate, by evidence or by examples.

Use cross-references to avoid repetition and to provide necessary reminders. When anything is repeated deliberately, using different words, either for emphasis or to help to clarify a difficult point, use a phrase such as *That is to say* or *In other words*. Otherwise, after studying both sentences, readers may be left wondering whether they have failed to appreciate some difference in meaning. Approach people through their interests rather than your own. In employment people are most interested in themselves, their colleagues, their department, their organisation, their profession, their own speciality, and in activities or developments likely to have a bearing on their work.

In an internal report or journal article the style of writing is usually direct and the link between paragraphs is achieved mainly by their orderly arrangement.

In a magazine with a wider readership more explanation and interpretation is needed; and in a newspaper attention is maintained by reference to familiar things, by including examples, anecdotes and analogies, and by providing attractive illustrations.

For an even wider audience, a sign (for example a traffic sign) or a cartoon (as used in the popular press to highlight the day's main story) may be used to capture attention - including that of people who cannot read.

**USING GOOD ENGLISH**

Looking critically at other people's writing will help you to improve your own, but do not be afraid to put pen to paper for fear of making mistakes.

English is bad only if it does not express the thought intended clearly and accurately in words appropriate to the context.

However, even if a sentence is grammatically correct, superfluous words make for hard reading. In business communications, clarity depends on the use of words readers will understand and expressing thoughts as simply as possible.

Poor writing may result from distraction, from not knowing what to say, from not considering how to present information, from insufficient care in the choice and use of words, or from not allocating sufficient time to thinking, to planning, to writing and to

checking, and if necessary to revising. Poor writing is also to be expected from a writer who has nothing to say, or who does not wish to express an opinion, and is so inconsiderate as to try to put up a smoke-screen of words that gives the impression that something is being said but serves only to obscure meaning.

### **OBSTACLES TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION**

Communication is not easy: an effort is needed on the part of the writer if the reader is to be interested, informed and affected in a chosen way. Failures in written communication between educated people may result, for example, from:

- Lack of practice on the part of the writer;
- The writer's unwillingness to devote enough time to thinking, planning, writing and revising;
- Failure to establish contact with readers at the start;
- Lack of attention on the part of readers, especially when the writing deviates from their interests;
- The readers' preconceived ideas, and their refusal to accept new ideas or to consider evidence that conflicts with their existing beliefs.

### **Rules for efficient communication**

- Decide, before starting to write, whom you hope to interest, why you wish to interest them, what must be said, and how you should say it.
- Write about things you know, if you have something interesting to say.
- Plan your work so that information and ideas can be presented in an appropriate order, and so that the whole composition has the qualities of balance and unity.
- Write for easy reading. Begin well. Keep to the point. Be clear, direct and forceful. Maintain the momentum of your writing, if possible by writing at one sitting.
- Check your work, and revise it if necessary.

### **IMPROVING YOUR WRITING LEARNING FROM PEOPLE WHO WRITE WELL**

In starting to play any game you can learn much by watching experts. Similarly, reading good prose will influence the way you write, just as the way you speak is influenced by the speech you hear.

Read books by successful authors and study the techniques of journalists who write well. Consider, for example, the purpose and scope of a leading article in a newspaper, or an article that interests you in a magazine. The title captured your interest. Does the opening sentence make you want to read on? Try to reconstruct the author's topic outline by picking out the topic of each paragraph. Is each paragraph relevant to the title? Are the paragraphs arranged in an appropriate order? Do they lead to an effective conclusion?

Study one paragraph. Note the ideas presented in each sentence. Which is the topic sentence? Are all these ideas relevant to the topic? Why are they presented in this order? Is it the most effective order in helping the writer to make a point (in helping the reader to understand)? Can you distinguish facts from opinions? Are the opinions supported by evidence? Is the article biased in favour of a particular point of view?

What is published in a newspaper is likely to be well written and persuasive, and to interest the people who normally read that paper, but if you compare accounts of one event in different newspapers you will probably find that they tell very different stories. This is because eye-witnesses of one event see and remember different things, and are influenced by their own previous experiences.

Then the stories submitted by reporters are edited to fit the space available in the paper, to match the readers' interests, and to suit editorial policy.

As you study the writing of others, and consider how your own writing can be improved, remember that there is no one correct way to write.

Do not try to copy someone else's style. The way you write should reflect your own personality, and your own feeling for words.

### **Learning by writing**

Evans includes editing exercises, each with three versions of a news item. Version A: the story as it appeared in print. Version B: the story edited to remove superfluous words and improve the English. Version C: rearranged and rewritten to bring out the human interest. Most people can improve their writing by considering the advice of more experienced writers, and from colleagues willing to read and comment on their work, but the best way to learn is by writing. Think before you write, plan your work, try to write without interruption, check your work carefully, and revise each composition until you are satisfied that it will serve your purpose.

### **Checking your writing for readability**

Flesch in *The Art of Plain Talk* graded writing simply, according to average sentence length, as very easy to read (fewer than ten words), difficult (more than twenty words) and very difficult (thirty words). Accepting this as a rough guide to readability, it is worth calculating the average sentence length in a few paragraphs of a document you have written recently. When writing documents that will be read only by your colleagues you may know they all can cope with long sentences that some people would find difficult to read. But when corresponding with someone you do not know, or when sending a standard letter to many people, remember that some people have difficulty with even short words in short sentences. So, prefer a short word to a longer word if the short word will serve your purpose, and try to ensure that every sentence is carefully constructed, grammatically correct and easy to read. In business, administration and management always try to convey your message as clearly and simply as you can.

## **IMPROVING BUSINESS COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

Good relations among members of a business are critical for success. Good communication skills are an important element for the development of good relationships. Poor communications starve a relationship while good communications nourish it.

This is true regardless of whether you are a member of a committee looking at starting a business or a member of a team operating a business. So, improving communication skills is important for success. But this doesn't just happen. Both the receiver and the sender must work at developing verbal and listening skills.

### **BUSINESS DISCUSSIONS**

Do not allow ridicule, punishment or lecturing in business discussions. Encourage listening, understanding, finding alternatives, commitment to action, and support for one another. Listen not only to what the other person is saying, but also to what he/she is feeling. Being respectful of all team members is important at all times. When we are under pressure we become frustrated and may verbally attack the behaviour of someone we work with.

The other person feels hurt by our comments and counterattacks. This system of attack and counterattack continues until someone withdraws from the conversation. Instead of counterattacking, the other person may hold their feelings and the situation will not escalate. However, the other person will harbour these feelings and the emotions may be vented later.

### **Sharing Our Feelings**

Instead of attacking and judging the other person's behaviour, we could have shared our feelings about our frustrations. This will tend to bring us together rather than drive us apart.

### **MAKING JUDGEMENTS VS. SHARING EMOTIONS**

Judgements and emotions are different. Judgemental statements are "I am right, you are wrong." Statements of emotions are "I am angry, I am afraid and I am worried." Judgements are often the result of how we feel. It is often an expression of our feelings. Judgements are much more likely to be heard as criticisms than are feelings. If I say, "You are wrong," you are likely to feel criticized and attacked. As soon as we feel criticized, it is hard to hear anything else that is said. Our mind is consumed by the criticism.

However, if I say, "I am angry," you are less likely to feel attacked. This is because expressions of emotion (how we feel) are true statements. If I say that "you are wrong," you will probably disagree. But if I say that "I am angry," no one can argue.

Although expressing our feelings seems to make us vulnerable, they really make us safer. If we make a judgement and attack the other person, we are isolating them and inviting them to counterattack. However, if we share how we feel, we are exposing ourselves to the other person. This makes it easier for the other person to respond in kind. Both people feel safer.

### **Ideas Versus Feelings**

Communicating ideas brings our minds together. But communicating emotions brings us together as individuals. It is assumed that we should share ideas but keep our feelings to ourselves. This is part of the culture of rural communities. However, emotions are very powerful and cannot be ignored. Feelings are more important than ideas at influencing our behaviour and decisions.

### **KEYS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION**

Below are keys to effective communications. But just reading these points will not improve your communication skills. You must practice them. Practice them until they become habits.

- Give your attention - When someone starts to talk to you, stop what you are doing and thinking. Face the person and devote your whole attention to what and how it is being said.
- Listen, not just hear - One of the keys to good communication is the willingness to listen for meaning in what the other person says and not just for the words. Watch facial expressions and body language.
- Don't let your mind wander - While the person is talking, do not think about your answer or response. Listen until the person is finished, then decide what you are going to say.
- Check for accuracy - When the person is finished talking, paraphrase back to the person what was said to you. If you heard right, then respond to that statement or question.
- Be aware of other's needs - You need to be aware of the needs of the other business associates. Each person has different needs that should be considered and respected. Although each of us has differing needs, all of us have a need for trust, responsibility, praise, security, sense of belonging, and recognition.
- Ask, don't tell - demonstrate equality - Do this by asking for advice or asking a person to do something. This shows you respect the other person as a peer or equal. Telling often implies a superior/subordinate relationship, such as boss vs. employee.
- Keep an open mind - Do not criticize, pass judgement, or preach. It is extremely important to learn to make objective evaluations about ideas, people, and

situations. You are making a value judgement when you attach your values, beliefs, or needs to an appraisal.

- Offer advice, don't give advice - Learn to offer in-sights, advice, and expertise without being forceful. It is wrong to say "this is how you should handle it" or "this is what you should do." It is better to say "what do you think about this way," or "I suggest we...." However, sometimes it is not appropriate to even soft-pedal advice. You should offer it only if asked for.
- Develop trust - Trust is the product of open and honest communications. So it is important that good communication channels exist. Also, trust is an essential ingredient of teamwork. If trust exists among business associates, teamwork and cooperation are much easier to achieve.
- Create feelings of equity - People share a sense of equality if all parties are informed, trust exists, and work is based on cooperation. For business ventures to succeed, all the parties must feel that they are equals. If one party feels left out or feels like a subordinate, success becomes less likely.
- Develop comfortable relations - Tension and stress are normal in any relationship. However, the level of tension and stress can be reduced in businesses that develop teamwork and trust through open and honest communication.
- Become genuinely interested in others - All of us have a need to feel important and be understood. One of the ways we feel important is if others are interested in us. So talk in terms of the other persons' interests and try to understand another point of view. If we expect others to understand us, we must first understand them.
- Motivate others - There are several ways to motivate people. Both negative and positive reinforcement are effective. But in the long run, negative reinforcement like criticism or punishment often creates a desire for revenge. Too often we think of positive reinforcement as receiving more income, but other positive reinforcements that require little effort are praise, trust, interest, and recognition.
- Keep a sense of humor - Laugh at the goofy things that happen. Laugh off little annoyances. Smile at every opportunity. Seeing the humor in a situation can often defuse it.

## **IMPORTANCE OF READING SKILLS**

Reading permeates every educational content area. The sequencing, decoding and comprehension skills necessary to read provide a foundation for learning. Early literacy development is particularly important to the growing learner. Skills such as alphabetic awareness and print knowledge in children under age 5 closely connect to later learning, according to the International Reading Association.



### **THE ABILITY TO SUCCEED IN SCHOOL**

Every class and school subject requires reading. Reading development is a key ingredient to any student's success, according to the article "The Importance of Reading" on the PBS Parents web site. Classes such as language, literature and English are obvious areas that require reading. Other subjects that aren't necessarily literacy-based also require reading for the student to master the content. The Common Core Content Standards set reading goals for subjects such as history, social studies, science and technology. For example, the sixth- through eighth-grade standards for science and technical subjects include key ideas such as citing technical texts to support scientific analysis, following written multistep procedures, decoding symbols and comprehending scientific texts.

### **THE LIKELIHOOD OF GRADUATION**

The ability to read has a positive influence on high school graduation rates, according to professor of sociology Donald J. Hernandez in his article "Double Jeopardy: How Third-Grader Reading Skills and Poverty Influence High School Graduation." Children who don't read by third grade have a four times higher rate of not graduating from high school on time, notes Hernandez. Although not every child who reads late will drop out, one out of every six who don't read proficiently by third grade won't graduate by age 19.

### **DOING WELL IN COLLEGE**

Proficient reading skills don't just boost success at the elementary or secondary levels. Being able to read is an essential attribute that the college student needs, according to the article "The Importance of Teaching Academic Reading Skills in First-Year University Courses" in the International Journal of Research and Review. Building literacy abilities throughout the K-12 curriculum can help students to succeed when they get to college. Without basic reading skills, students lack the know-how to navigate postsecondary coursework.

### **GETTING AND KEEPING A JOB**

Reading goes well beyond the high school and college years. Knowing how to read is a must for entering the workforce, according to the article "Essential Skills to Getting a Job" on the Office of Disability Employment Policy web site. Reading isn't just a must for word-heavy jobs such as journalism. For example, if you work as a server in a local restaurant, part of your job is to read the specials to your customers every day. Without reading skills, you can't do your job.



# Presentation Techniques and Skills

## THE RESOURCES AND TECHNIQUES AVAILABLE TO THE WRITER

We shall discuss only the best use of resources and techniques usually available to writers who have *by themselves* to produce internal reports and papers, instruction sheets and other similar documents.

If you are fortunate enough to have access to experts who can produce exploded drawings or use airbrush techniques, always involve them as early as possible in your planning and preparation for a report or paper.

But most engineers and scientists have to rely on their own resources to produce the graphic presentation of their data. What is the best way of doing this? First, review the 'language' elements available.

*The main symbols in visual presentation are:*

- Numbers (used mainly in tables);
- Words (used in tables, algorithms, or flow charts);
- Lines (used in graphs and drawings to symbolise Paths, links, a lapse of time;
- Shapes (used in symbolic charts, drawing and photographs).

These symbols constitute the equivalent of the verbal Vocabulary'. This vocabulary is put together into the visual equivalent of sentences and paragraphs, and as in your choice of verbal 'style', it is vital to:

- Consider carefully the length and complexity of the statements you ask your reader to digest;
- Be sure to conform to conventions of ‘word order’;
- Avoid the visual equivalent of wordiness and waffle;
- Control the use of jargon.

*In visual signalling, you also have available important cues that you cannot use in verbal signalling:*

- Spatial cues (alignment in columns and rows, grouping);
- Typographic cues (size, design, and weight of type);
- colour cues (shading, colouring, colour of paper as well as of print);
- Ruling (use of lines not as symbols in themselves but as a framework to separate, group and relate information);
- Use of ‘white space’ to group or emphasize items of information.

Perhaps the greatest advantage of visual presentation is that it is possible to represent three dimensions. Prose restricts information to a one-dimensional linear sequence: visual presentation enables you to show shapes, to show activities going on in parallel, to show movement in varying directions. Your reader can take in all these things ‘at a glance’, because the human eye can use a span of awareness much wider when looking at visual presentations than when looking at words (focus on any word in this sentence, and notice how much of the surrounding text you can see without changing your point of focus).

By presenting information in tables or in graphic forms, you can often make much more efficient use of your readers’ perceptual abilities than by presenting information in prose. But remember that perception and comprehension are not the same. Your readers must not only *perceive* your visual presentations but also *understand* them. So beware of complication and overloading.

Give readers the minimum data needed to make your points, not the maximum data available to justify your existence. And make your visual statements self-sufficient, so that readers can comprehend them without continuous cross-reference to the prose text. Just as it is desirable to coin a new sentence each time you want to say something, it is wise to try to produce a fresh illustration each time you decide you want to make a visual statement. Automatic re-use of pre-packed words and phrases frequently produces only approximations to the intended meaning of a statement: likewise, apparently time-saving (and thought-saving!) use of ready-made graphs or photographs frequently presents only an approximation to the point intended. As you work at communication tasks, you will constantly be tempted to trade-off efficiency against convenience. Often, you will be able to use existing visual material very effectively; but sometimes you may be tempted to write a text that fits the available visual material rather than to take extra trouble to produce visual material to suit your text. Resist this temptation.

The great advantage of using visual presentations is that they give all readers the same visual image to look at. But notice that we are not saying that readers will all see the same thing: each illustration must have a caption or heading telling readers what you want them to see in the illustration. Imagine two identical pictures of a boy kicking a ball along the pavement of a busy suburban street.

One caption reads: 'Road-safety training teaches children to stay safely on the pavement'. The other caption reads: 'We need parks to keep our children away from dangerous roads'. Readers see different points made by the same picture in the two illustrations. You might be entertained by taking any drawing or photograph designed for inclusion in a report without its caption, and asking your colleagues to tell you not only what it shows but also what *point* it is making about its content. We suspect you will rarely get a clear or unanimous response.

## **TABLES**

Tables give a systematic and orderly arrangement of items of information. Tabular layout has the particular virtue of juxtaposing items in two dimensions for easy comparison and contrast. Tables eliminate tedious repetition of words, phrases and sentence patterns that can instead be put at the tops of columns or at the sides of rows in the table.

Although tables do not make much impact by visual display, it is possible, by careful arrangements, to emphasize and highlight particular items or groups of information. There are several ways of arranging information within a table and no one way is always the best. As usual, we must return to our basic questions: what are we trying to achieve with this table? What is the required emphasis? For whom are we presenting the information? What are the interests and needs of those readers?

Tables can be organized with the information in numerical order, in alphabetical order or in an order which groups items according to common features or common values. Normally, however, readers expect the elements or entities which are being compared to be grouped or listed vertically, and to find variables, qualities or performance details listed horizontally. Readers expect to move from known material on the left to new information on the right; known (or base) information should therefore appear on the left, with explanatory, conversion, or derived material on the right.

We find it helpful to distinguish two broad types of tables: *dependent* tables and *independent* tables. A dependent table is placed in the text and is an integral part of the prose statement. It continues the sentence or paragraph in just the same way as a mathematical or chemical equation that is included in a sentence, and it needs no title or caption because it is a continuous part of the text. It follows that it must be restricted to a small amount of information, probably a maximum of two or three columns and rows, a dozen or so numbers in all. An example of a dependent table. The reader can read through this table as a continuation of the sentence that it completes.

## EUROPEAN PRODUCTION REQUIREMENTS

*The forecast provided by Production Planning, London was tabled as follows:*

| Requirement (Mt) | 1988 | 1989 | 1990 |
|------------------|------|------|------|
| Min              | 1.9  | 3.5  | 4.8  |
| Max              | 2.9  | 5.4  | 7.2  |

It was explained that these are min-max numbers and that the use of the average would be most realistic. With these numbers plus US requirements, the present plant design capable of 2.5-3.0 Mt with small-scale de-bottlenecking, would be outstripped in 1989. Thus, a European site would provide the added volume plus provide the safety of a second source.

Exploratory discussions on the concept of buying product in Europe and on stock procedures at the sites was accepted without commitment for further study. Technology was via denitrogenation, by the route:



This process yields a serious loss of nitrogen via salts and it is a very important economic facet of this process that any nitrogen loss is fully recovered. Initially, the raw material is transported to site in single-load tankers to significant points that emerge from the data and to have put the full table in an appendix.

An independent table may be placed physically within the text-but surrounded by it-but should be clearly distinguished from it. In an independent table, you are inviting your readers to look at a visual display of the information separate from their reading of the text; the amount of information being presented will require a conscious step by the reader from the text to the table and back again. Minimize the size of that step if you can, by placing the table as near as possible to the text that discusses it.

Even for non-geriatric beds at Moreton the average length of stay is much longer than at say Widepark where, for example, general surgical patients stay for an average of 8.9 days. This is because the majority of all Moreton patients are old and are kept in after acute treatment is completed, often for social reasons. Thus the atmosphere at Moreton and Woring is very slow compared to a General Hospital. Moreton General Hospital was formerly a workhouse but became a chronic sick hospital in 1944.

After the formation of the N.H.S. many improvements were carried out and a programme of ward up-grading is now virtually finished. There is also a new assessment wing, mainly for "Eastern" patients, which has improved staff morale which is generally low, because the rest of the wards are in three-floor blocks most of which have no lifts. The wards are not very wide but patients do have lockers, though not individual clothing. In general the wards are light and clean and the blocks are arranged as follows:

Ground floor: Patients attending treatment departments such as Physiotherapy

- *Middle Floor:* (sister's office)-Admissions and Patients requiring active nursing.
- *Top Floor:* Long stay, convalescent and social cases awaiting discharge.

It has only been possible to provide day rooms on the ground floors so non-ambulant patients higher up cannot use them. Brownpath Wing, where over 100 male psychogeriatrics live has proved unsuitable for the type of patients because not all significant facts or inferences that you want them to see are also important.

## RULING

The design of the ruling in independent tables presents choices: an *open* design, a *semi-closed* design or a *closed* design. An open design is one which has no vertical or horizontal rulings in it at all. A semi-closed design has just some vertical lines and/or some horizontal lines. A closed design has a complete array of both vertical and horizontal lines separating virtually all elements from all others. Which of these helps you to see most readily the information that the writer is trying to present with particular emphasis? Even if you do not know what information the writer wants to emphasize, it is possible to sense the difference of impact of the various ways of ruling a table. Most readers find an open table is confusing, giving too little help to the eye. A fully closed table is also difficult to use because the apparatus of lines seems to overwhelm the information that is being presented. Most readers prefer a semi-closed design, with some horizontal and/or some vertical lines to help signify the importance of the piece of data.

Are vertical lines or horizontal lines preferable in semi-closed tables? There can be no over-all rule, because the lines in the tables may be doing two separate things. They may be helping the readers' eyes with the simple business of seeing the figures in the table, and they may be stressing the significance of particular groupings. They may be guiding the eye *across* the page or *down*. Most readers are accustomed to looking up and down columns of figures without too much difficulty. They need more help when they have to compare figures in horizontal rows. That might seem to suggest that in semi-closed tables, the normal use of lines should be horizontal.

But you must also take account of the second function of ruling within a table. That function is to stress the significance of particular groupings. It may be that you wish to stress groupings that are horizontal or vertical. This report is based on actual operating conditions and the calculated rates have been demonstrated in the plant. The report reckons to have 31 days shutdown in January for major repairs (motor overhaul, drive and mounting repairs etc.) and a 15 days shutdown in June for part overhaul.

Therefore, all rates include 5% downtime for the two yearly shutdowns, the significance of groups, or more help simply in following the rows of figures across the page. In general, however, the eye more often needs help with horizontals than with verticals. We more often use a ruler, or a finger, to run across a line than down a column. This report is based on actual operating conditions and the calculated rates have been demonstrated in the plant. The report reckons to have 31 days shutdown in January for major repairs (motor overhaul, drive and mounting repairs etc.) and a 15 days shutdown in June for part overhaul.

Therefore, all rates include 5% downtime for the two yearly shutdowns. However, some lines are redundant, these can be removed. Note that the double line under the headings helps the eye to separate heading and content. This method of ruling looks neat, and has the advantage that it can be produced on a typewriter without taking the paper out and ruling it separately. This report is based on actual operating conditions and the calculated rates have been demonstrated in the plant.

The report reckons to have 31 days shutdown in January for major repairs (motor overhaul, drive and mounting repairs etc.) and a 15 days shutdown in June for part overhaul. Therefore, all rates include 5% downtime for the two yearly shutdowns. In designing a table, you must consider how readers will use it. Is their main objective to find a single item of information in a single 'cell' of the table (for example, the arrival time in Cardiff of the 1400 departure train from London); or is their main objective to compare the lists of figures in two columns (for example, the comparative times at various stopping points for two trains on the journey between London and Cardiff); or is their main objective to appreciate generally the over-all pattern (for example, the existence of faster trains at 'peak' hours compared with 'off-peak' hours)? To help with the first objective, more lines would probably be effective.

To help with the second, fewer lines, emphasizing complete columns rather than individual numbers would probably be better. To help with the third objective, perhaps a bar-chart would be better than a table; at least the table should make use of some means of emphasizing starting and finishing times, perhaps by using heavier print. You can obtain the effect of ruling without the use of lines by using white space to separate groups or blocks of information. When you do this, restrict your groups to blocks of five at the most. The eye can discern easily the top, bottom and centre rows within a block of five, but once you provide six or more rows in a block, it is difficult for the eye to move through the figures without help. We can 'see' a group of up to five objects (such as marbles on a table) at a glance; six objects tend to be counted as two groups of three, and so on. However, take care if you introduce blocking. Arbitrary arrangement of rows into blocks may suggest a special relationship between the rows in each block, and differences between the blocks.

## **CLARITY AND MANAGEABILITY**

There are blank spaces in some of the columns and rows, and some items are marked simply with dashes. Presumably, the writer wished the blanks to signify something different from the dashes, but it is not clear to readers what a blank space signifies or what a dash means. The principle that emerges is that there should never be blanks or other unexplained signals in a table. If you have no reading (if there was a nil value or if it was not possible to make a measurement for a particular reason) you should place either a nil within the table or some hieroglyphic such as an asterisk or dagger and explain the significance of that hieroglyphic at the foot of the table.

The difference between tables designed to make a point in an argument and tables designed to make available masses of information for scrutiny. It is far too large to be included within a text or even within an argument. You may find, however, that there are occasions on which you feel it is necessary to invite your readers to examine a mass of facts and figures at a central point within a report. In such a case, it may be necessary to use a table. But recognize the overwhelming impact of so much information presented in that way. If possible, provide some small steps by means of which your readers can approach the mass: for example, provide two or three smaller tables in which you separate some of the variables or groups of information, so that the final presentation of all the information seems less daunting.

## **BAR CHARTS**

Bar charts are often better ways of presenting numerical data than tables. Frequently it is necessary to show several different variables or relationships within overall totals. In these circumstances, the use of a table does not make this information as clear as the use of a bar chart. It shows the number of students who have various types of qualifications in different types of higher education.

But the presentation of raw numbers does not make an impact quickly. The figures in the first column are not very different in shape and size. Readers draw information from these numerical signals only after mental addition or subtraction. If, however, the information is presented in bar-chart form, it offers an immediate visual impression of the different proportions of students with various qualifications in various forms of higher education. Notice that it is possible by joining the various levels within the bars to get some of the sense of movement usually associated with the drawing of graphs. Also, note that it is possible to use bar charts horizontally, as well as vertically. If, for example, you are showing braking distances for various types of cars, it is valuable to show these horizontally because the bars reflect the spatial point you are making.

It is helpful for your readers if you label the tops of the bars in your chart either with a number or with an identifying word. Since it is mainly the top of the bar that interests readers, that is naturally the first place they look. The suppression of zero in a chart in order to emphasize some difference in levels.

# **FORMULATING A GENERAL PURPOSE OF MAKING PRESENTATION**

## **PURPOSE OF THE FORMULATION**

In many respects a dynamic formulation and a clinical diagnosis share a common purpose. Although both hold intellectual, didactic, and research interests, their primary function is to provide a succinct conceptualization of the case and thereby guide



a treatment plan. Like a psychiatric diagnosis, a psychodynamic formulation is specific, brief, focused, and therefore limited in its intent, scope, and wisdom. It concisely and incisively clarifies the central issues and conflicts, differentiating what the therapist sees as essential from what is secondary. Also like the diagnosis, additional information and changes over time may lead to modifications of the patient's dynamics and how they are formulated, with corresponding alterations in treatment. Again, like the diagnosis, the psychodynamic understanding of a patient serves as a stabilizing force in conducting any form of therapy; its general effect is conservative, discouraging a change in tack with every slight shift of the wind.

One common misconception is that a psychodynamic formulation is indicated only for those patients in a long-term, expressive psychotherapy. This belief ignores the fact that the success of any treatment may involve supporting, managing, or even modifying aspects of the patient's personality. Therapeutic effectiveness or failure often hinges on how well or poorly the therapist understands the patient's dynamics, predicts what resistances the patient will present, and designs an approach that will circumvent, undermine, or surmount these obstacles.

A second common misconception is that the construction of a psychodynamic formulation is primarily a training experience. For example, MacKinnon and Yudofsky, while agreeing with the importance of understanding a patient's psychodynamics, state: "A written case formulation is principally for the education of the clinician or for clinical case conferences. The thought and preparation involved in this exercise constitute an important learning experience for the beginning student of psychiatry." These authors then later suggest, "Even an experienced therapist can benefit from this task in a confusing or difficult case." Although MacKinnon and Yudofsky are here referring to a complete case formulation (which includes the present illness, psychopathology, developmental data, diagnostic classification, and prognosis), one may erroneously conclude that a written psychodynamic formulation is a task reserved for special situations rather than a fundamental component of all treatments.

A third common misconception, related to the second, is that the construction of a psychodynamic formulation must be elaborate and time-consuming. This view derives in part from various reviews in the psychiatric literature that, in an attempt to be inclusive, describe in detail all the requirements of a thorough evaluation or the multiple dynamic conflicts that may influence any aspect of human behaviour. The trainee may get the impression that anything short of an exhaustive dynamic explanation of each symptom or character trait is too simplified to be of value. This impression is often inadvertently reinforced when the supervisor points out some less essential aspects of the case that have been omitted in the condensed overview. A more helpful didactic approach accepts that the initial formulation is by necessity partial and tentative, but by describing the patient's leading unconscious needs and incipient defences, the formulation may be sufficient to predict initial transferences and guide supportive or



directive interventions. In time, as the clinical impression deepens, the linkage of current behaviour to formative experiences and intrapsychic conflicts will become more clear and substantiated. A fourth misconception is the notion that the formulation need not be written, as though somehow a patient's psychodynamics "go without saying." Our concern here is that if the formulation is never actually constructed and recorded, the patient's psychodynamics will remain mysterious, ambiguous, and all encompassing. E.M. Forster allegedly said, "I never know what I think until I read what I write." His point—and ours—is that the process of writing helps one achieve a clearer point of view. The written psychodynamic formulation is therefore valuable, even if seen only by the therapist who wrote it. The therapist who has a clear formulation of the patient's central conflicts is more capable of communicating that understanding to the patient in a consistent way. In addition, the dynamically prepared therapist is more likely to anticipate and recognize patterns of resistance or acting out than lag one step behind, using ad hoc (or even post hoc) formulations to respond to specific events.

A fifth and final misconception is that therapists will become so invested in their dynamic formulations that they will not be able to hear or accept material that does not fit a preconceived mold. On the contrary, constructing a dynamic formulation helps one to recognize its incompleteness, to enquire about pieces of the puzzle that are missing, to appreciate that not every piece fits neatly into place, and to accept the inevitable complexities and limited knowledge of every clinical situation. Furthermore, the formulation not only helps therapists accept their own limitations, it helps them accept the patient's pathology as well. The patient's behaviours in treatment—dependent, angry, avoidant, defiant, passive-aggressive, seductive, suspicious, non-compliant, and so on—are seen as manifestations of the patient's dynamics, as characteristic problems that can be predicted and understood and for which therapeutic interventions have been planned. As a result, the patient is not put in the paradoxical and untenable position of having to overcome his or her psychopathology as a prerequisite for treatment.

## **STRUCTURE OF THE FORMULATION**

As we conceive it, the psychodynamic formulation is relatively brief and has four parts:

- A summary of the case that describes the patient's current problems and places them in the context of the patient's current life situation and developmental history;
- A description of non-dynamic factors that may have contributed to the psychiatric disorder;
- A psychodynamic explanation of the central conflicts, describing their role in the current situation and their genetic origins in the developmental history; and
- A prediction of how these conflicts are likely to affect treatment and the therapeutic relationship.

## **PART 1: SUMMARIZING STATEMENT**

The opening paragraph outlines why this particular patient presents with this diagnosis and these particular problems at this particular time. By eliminating extraneous information, it succinctly identifies the patient, the precipitating events, the extent and quality of interpersonal relationships, the most salient predisposing features of the past history, and those prominent behaviours which the formulation will attempt to explain psychodynamically. This outline is not intended to summarize the entire case but rather to highlight the clinical situation that the psychodynamic formulation will address. By analogy, these first sentences are similar to the condensed admission note placed in the medical chart by the ward attending physician in contrast to the detailed history presented by the third-year medical student.

## **PART 2: DESCRIPTION OF NON-DYNAMIC FACTORS**

After the essential features of the case have been thoughtfully distilled, this second paragraph mentions the non-dynamic factors that may have contributed to the psychiatric disorder, such as genetic predisposition, mental retardation, social deprivation, overwhelming trauma, and drugs or any physical illness affecting the brain. Noting other etiological factors sidesteps two potential pitfalls. First, it underscores that even if non-dynamic factors have played a major role in causing the disorder, the psychodynamics of the patient cannot be ignored in the choice and implementation of the treatment (2). Second, mentioning other etiological factors serves as a reminder that certain experiences of the patient may have psychodynamic meaning even though they do not stem from psychodynamic causes. Because meaning and cause are often confused, the clinical value of distinguishing the two is worth illustrating with the following brief vignettes.

### *Example 1.*

A homemaker with a very strong personal and family history of bipolar affective illness develops another major depressive episode when her youngest child leaves for college. It would be an error to ignore the likely contribution of genetic factors in the etiology of her depression, to attribute it solely to conflicts precipitated by the child's departure, and to fail to consider pharmacological interventions.

However, even though the biological predisposition is essential for the occurrence of the illness, both the biology and the precipitating trigger must be understood psychosocially with their dynamic meanings. The feelings of unworthiness and guilt accompanying the depression may, for example, represent an unforgivable gap between a need to be a perfect mother and a self-image (conscious or unconscious) of being imperfect, bitter, angry, and uncaring.

The therapist who understands these specific dynamics may therefore state, "Your youngest child's leaving and this depression make you feel that you have failed as a mother, a role that is very important to you." Such dynamically informed empathic

remarks may tighten the therapeutic alliance, be therapeutic in their effect, increase compliance with medication if that is indicated, and synergistically enhance a placebo response.

*Example 2.*

A young man with paranoid schizophrenia becomes disorganized under the stress of writing his senior college thesis. He becomes convinced that his previously admired political science professor is now using a KGB device to control the patient's thoughts and prevent the unusually perceptive manuscript from being published. While recognizing the biological and environmental factors that have caused the psychotic episode, the dynamic formulation also helps explain the meaning of the delusion: the conscious wish for acclaim and the fear of being controlled; the preconscious recognition of being inadequate and of losing control; and the unconscious wish to be controlled, an intolerable wish that is associated with vulnerable dependency and therefore projected. Equipped with this dynamic understanding, the therapist can tailor his or her interventions accordingly. For example, in the neuroleptic management, the therapist will consider the patient's fears of being controlled by explaining in detail the type, dosage, rationale, risks, benefits, and side effects of all medication. The therapeutic stance will be influenced by the meaning of the patient's relationship with the college professor; the therapist will avoid a premature frightening intimacy as he or she remains a somewhat distant but friendly helper who is especially candid and honest yet does not expect or require the patient's trust or submission. The psychotherapeutic interventions will address the conscious wishes and fears (*e.g.*, "You wanted to write an outstanding thesis but felt the professor was controlling you") and in time the preconscious concern (*e.g.*, "You were worried you weren't doing well"), but because pointing out unconscious wishes (*e.g.*, "You secretly would like to be cared for") would be perceived as intrusive and similar to the professor's thought control, these interpretations would be avoided. The point here is not to describe the treatment of paranoid psychosis but to illustrate how an appreciation of a specific patient's psychodynamics can be useful in guiding the clinical management even in the presence of situational and biological determinants of the disorder.

*Example 3.*

A woman is biologically predisposed to panic attacks that respond to imipramine maintenance; however, the psychodynamic formulation reveals that for this rigid Catholic patient the attacks represent both fears of and wishes for losing control, a state that is unconsciously perceived as an opportunity for the expansion of forbidden sexual wishes. In response to the fear, the patient at times overmedicates herself with the tricyclic or becomes agoraphobic; in response to the wish, she sometimes "forgets" her medication, has a panic attack, and then becomes disproportionately guilty and depressed for being "irresponsible" (and for unconsciously acting on forbidden impulses). Accordingly, in consideration of the psychodynamic meaning associated with this patient's biological

disorder, the therapist combines his or her pharmacological management with directive, exploratory, and expressive techniques, advising the patient to read appropriate materials that explain the nature of the disorder and diminish unwarranted concerns of acting irresponsibly during an attack, exploring and clarifying for the patient the developmental derivatives of her conflict, and encouraging the patient to recount her dreams and fantasies. This dynamically informed process enables the patient to understand her illness and its meaning, to express her wishes more adaptively than by her intermittent noncompliance with medication, and over time to feel less guilty about her forbidden desires.

*Example 4.*

A fireman hospitalized for a severe burn develops a posttraumatic stress disorder. The psychodynamic formulation acknowledges the situational precipitants but also elucidates that for this man the intrusive thoughts and nightmares represent a conscious fear of going crazy and an unconscious fear of being a helpless dependent boy, a fear he has reacted against over the years by assuming a machismo style. In consideration of these dynamics, the psychiatric consultant addresses not only the conscious fear by reassuringly educating the patient about his acute posttraumatic stress disorder and its favourable prognosis, but also addresses the unconscious fear of passivity by supporting the patient's manliness and the heroic nature of his injury. This permits the development of a transference relationship in which the terror of the trauma can be reworked.

*Example 5.*

An elderly retired executive with a mild dementia has become so rigid and demanding that his wife has lost her freedom and patience. The psychodynamic formulation accepts the organic determinants of his change in behaviour, but also notes that the patient's inflexibility is partly due to a long-standing conscious need to be in charge, a recent preconscious recognition of his cognitive decline, unconscious feelings of anxiety and shame related to loss of adult capacities, and reparative attempts to maintain a sense of security and control by regulating his own life and the lives of those around him. By explaining these dynamics to the wife the therapist increases her tolerance, and by suggesting more adaptive ways for the patient to feel secure (clocks in every room, limited demands and expectations, consistent environment, titrated stimuli, written schedule, and so forth) the therapist is able to channel his or her dynamic understanding into simple, practical interventions.

These highly condensed examples are not intended to illustrate all the subtleties, complexities, and applications of a psychodynamic formulation but merely to indicate that the presence of non-dynamic factors—genetic, traumatic, organic, and so forth—does not preclude the clinical value of understanding a patient's psychodynamics and, conversely, that a psychodynamic formulation does not ignore the effect of non-dynamic factors on the patient's mood, thoughts, and behaviour. The dynamic formulation is

consistent with the biopsychosocial model (7), is relevant to all forms of psychiatric treatment, and is not reserved only for those psychiatric conditions in which biological features are less well defined (*e.g.*, personality disorders) and only for those treatments that are insight oriented (*e.g.*, exploratory psychotherapy). Even for disorders that are more clearly no dynamic in their etiology (*e.g.*, schizophrenia, dementia) and for treatments that are more biomedical in their approach (*e.g.*, psychopharmacotherapy), the therapist who formulates not only the cause but also the specific meaning of the illness will be better prepared, when appropriate, to communicate this understanding empathically and to intervene effectively rather than with stereotyped responses. A “pseudo humanitarian” approach, a form of verbal handholding that does not consider the character style of a particular patient, may be experienced by paranoid patients as intrusive, by histrionic patients as seductive, by obsessive patients as demeaning, by depressed patients as undeserved and therefore guilt provoking, and by dependent or phobic patients as a sanction for further regression or avoidance. To be effective, the therapist must recognize those capacities of the patient which are temporarily or permanently deficient and for which “an auxiliary ego” is indicated, the unconscious meanings of these defects to the patient, and the available strengths of the patient that will be encouraged and enhanced. As described later the psychodynamic formulation facilitates this task by helping the therapist to conceptualize the issues systematically rather than relying only on intuition.

### **PART 3: PSYCHODYNAMIC EXPLANATION OF CENTRAL CONFLICTS**

If the first part of a psychodynamic formulation is similar to a clarification (a synthetic integration of the available data), this third part is more like an interpretation (an integrative inference based on psychoanalytic principles that considers unconscious fantasies and motives). As in the clinical situation, this interpretation is of necessity speculative, a hypothesis that will be tested and modified by additional data. Unlike the clinical situation, though, this interpretation is primarily a guide for the therapist; in most instances it does not directly represent what the patient will be told.

This section of the formulation is most useful clinically if it does not attempt to explain too much in too many ways but instead focuses on the central conflicts and then uses prototypic psychodynamic models to explain how these conflicts are being resolved. The danger of not focusing on the central conflicts and of not using standard psychodynamic models is that the formulation (and consequently perhaps the treatment itself) will lack an integrative coherence.

Identifying the central conflicts requires both inductive and deductive reasoning. The aim is to find a small number of pervasive issues that run through the course of the patient’s illness and can be traced back through his or her personal history, and then to explain how the patient’s attempts to resolve these central conflicts have been both maladaptive (producing symptoms and character pathology) and adaptive

(characterizing his or her general style of pleasure, productivity, and personal relationships). Conflicts are opposing motives and wishes, both conscious and unconscious; central conflicts are repetitive, link and explain a number of important behaviours, and usually contain elements that are hidden from the patient's awareness. For example, a man may consciously wish to be less depressed but unconsciously fear that recovery will both lead to an uncontrolled expression of his own rage and free others to express their resentment against him if he is not protected by illness.

Once the central conflicts and themes have been identified, they are formulated psychodynamically. At present, at least three models of mental functioning are being used by dynamic psychiatrists. These models are overlapping and differ in the emphasis they give to one or another aspect of development and psychopathology. In practice, most psychiatrists prefer one model, on the basis of prior training and personal predilection, but use other models as the clinical situation may require. If the original model does not seem to be conceptually useful, the therapist sees if the formulation of a given patient will be more fruitful when cast in terms of an alternative model. As with many other sciences, the absence of a meta-model to explain all data makes this trial and error unavoidable.

Even though an admixture of different models is often clinically necessary, it is useful theoretically and conceptually to understand the basic concepts, virtues, and limitations of prototypic psychodynamic models. Recognizing the oversimplification involved, we will describe the three most common: 1) ego-psychological; 2) self-psychological; and 3) object relations. They all share the core concept of dynamic unconscious mental activity; that is, they assume that human behaviour is constantly influenced by unconscious thoughts, wishes, and mental representations. These three models also assume that complex psychological functions pass through a regular sequence of epigenetic stages and phases (each of which carries its own particular vulnerabilities and opportunities and involves an interaction between nature and nurture) and that the distortions, fixations, and regressions occurring at different stages will leave their mark on later development. In short, these models assert that all individuals have an inner life that is important in understanding their outer life and that they are each the product of their personal history.

The ego-psychological model emphasizes the central role of the adaptive efforts of the ego both during development and in therapy. Behaviour, mediated by the ego, is viewed as a defensive compromise among 1) wishes and impulses; 2) inner conscience, self-observation, and criticism; and 3) the potentialities and demands of reality. Effective ego functions allow an appropriate delay between peremptory wishes and actions and protect the individual from excessive anxiety or depression while providing for security, pleasure, and effectiveness. A dynamic formulation that uses this model will describe the nature of unconscious wishes, unconscious fears, characteristic defences, and the



resulting patterns of inhibition, symptoms, and character, tracing each of these through the individual's life. The ego-psychological model gives special focus to derivatives of forbidden sexual and aggressive strivings, their resolution during the oedipal phase, and the ongoing residual intrapsychic conflicts and defensive compromises that determine character and symptoms. This model gives less attention to interpersonal issues and to very early, pre-oedipal influences on development.

The self-psychological model postulates a psychological structure, the self, that develops towards the realization of goals that are both innate and learned. Two broad classes of these goals can be identified: one consists of the individual's ambitions, the other of his or her ideals. Normal development involves the child's grandiose idealization of self and others, the exhibitionistic expression of strivings and ambitions, and the empathic responsiveness of parents and others to these needs. Under these conditions, the child's unfolding skills, talents, and internalization of empathic objects will lead to the development of a sturdy self and capacities for creativity, joy, and continuing empathic relationships.

In this model, genetic formulations will trace character problems to specific empathic failures in the child's environment that distorted and inhibited the development of the self and the capacity to maintain object ties. The formulation will also describe how the individual has defensively compensated for these failures of self-development and will suggest the therapeutic strategy needed to support the resumption of self-development that had been arrested in the past, emphasizing the special transference needs of the patient.

The self-psychological model is especially useful for formulating the narcissistic difficulties that are present in many types of patients (not just narcissistic personality disorder); however, the model lacks a clear conception of intrapsychic structure, and it is less useful for formulating fixed repetitive symptoms that arise from conflicts between one's conscience and sexual-aggressive wishes.

The object relations model conceives of psychic structures as developing through the child's construction of internal representations of self and others. These representations range from the primitive and fantastic to the relatively realistic; they are associated with widely varying affects (*e.g.*, anger, sadness, feelings of safety, fear, pleasure) as well as with various wishes and fantasies (*e.g.*, of sex, of control, or of devouring and being devoured). The growing child struggles with contradictory representations and feelings of self and others, tending to split the good and bad images into different representations. At this early level of development, one may feel that one has two different mothers, for example—a good, gratifying one and a bad, frustrating one. In the more mature individual, these images are integrated into coherent representations of a self and others with multiple complex qualities, selected and formed in part to help to maintain an optimal measure of self-esteem, tolerable affects, and satisfaction of wishes.

Using this model, the psychodynamic formulation focuses on the nature of the self and object representations and the prominent conflicts among them. A special emphasis is given to developmental failures in integrating the various partial and contradictory representations of self and others and to the displacement and defensive misattribution of aspects of self or others. The object relations model is especially useful for formulating the fragmented inner world of psychotic and borderline patients who experience themselves and others as unintegrated parts; however, the model may be less useful for relatively healthier patients in whom conflict may more easily be described in terms of ego psychology.

#### **PART 4: PREDICTING RESPONSES TO THE THERAPEUTIC SITUATION**

This final section of the formulation is related to the prognosis, but rather than predicting the overall course of the patient's disorder, it focuses on the meaning and use that the patient will make of treatment. Particular emphasis is placed on understanding the probable manifestations of transference (both positive and negative) and the forms and modes of resistance. The phrasing of this prediction will be linked to the psychodynamic model used in the preceding section. For example, the ego-psychological model may emphasize what specific ego strengths and deficits the patient brings to the therapeutic situation and what defence mechanisms are likely to predominate as the patient deals with central conflicts.

The self-psychological model will emphasize the role of the therapist's empathic responsiveness and the analysis of empathic failures in the process of forming new internal structures of the self—for example, the patients' needs to idealize either them or the therapist or, at other times, to ignore the therapist except as a source of admiration for exhibitionistic strivings. Finally, the object relations model will emphasize which inner representations of self and of others are likely to be activated and potentially enacted in the therapeutic situation. All three models suggest possible patterns of transference and resistance, offering valuable guides for the therapist.

#### **SAMPLE PSYCHODYNAMIC FORMULATIONS**

Although the following psychodynamic formulations lack the authenticity, specificity, and richness of a formulation that is accompanied by a fuller knowledge of the individual history, they are intended to convey something of the format of prototypic dynamic formulations. The same patient is used to illustrate each of the psychodynamic models described previously. These illustrations are admittedly somewhat artificial because, as we have indicated, in clinical practice therapists tend to use one primary model, introducing secondary models to explain features of the patient that do not easily fit the primary model. However, by presenting each of the models in its pure form, we hope to demonstrate the common utility of all the models as well as highlight the potential and unavoidable impact of theory on treatment.



## THE EGO-PSYCHOLOGICAL MODEL

Part 1: A 52-year-old married businessman, presents on his own initiative with a depressive syndrome after being once again passed over for promotion. He himself does not understand this “rejection,” but it is probably related to his lifelong tendencies to procrastinate and to annoy his superiors either by being obsequious or by challenging their authority. He has a history of two untreated depressive syndromes, one in his 30s that also followed a professional failure and one in his 40s that followed his son’s “defiant” marriage to a woman of another religion. Mr. A’s father was a sickly, professionally frustrated “type A personality” who died of a heart attack when Mr. A was in his teens. His mother has always been a “martyr” with smoldering despair characterized by chronic insomnia, self-doubt, obsessive ruminations, and social withdrawal. She never sought treatment.

Part 2: Mr. A has essential hypertension, for which he takes methyldopa, 250 mg t.i.d.; his mother’s history suggests a genetic predisposition to unipolar depression.

Part 3: Mr. A’s central conflict is between an unconscious wish to kill off his competitors and an unconscious fear that he will be killed if he acts on that wish. Whenever he expresses derivatives of his competitive wish directly, he becomes frightened of retaliation; he therefore resorts to expressing the wish indirectly by passive-aggressive maneuvers (*e.g.*, procrastination). Conversely, whenever he responds to this fear of retaliation by being solicitous and obedient, he inwardly feels resentful and diminished. To contain this struggle, Mr. A has developed intellectual mechanisms that, although adaptive for certain aspects of his work, are mal-adaptive interpersonally in that they isolate him emotionally from others.

Mr. A’s tendency to view every situation as a competitive struggle can be traced to unresolved anal and oedipal conflicts. During early childhood, Mr. A’s depressed mother could not tolerate her son’s assertiveness and declarations of independence; instead she imposed her will on Mr. A and insisted that he eat, sleep, be toilet trained, and behave exactly the way she wanted so that her son would not be any trouble and add to her woes. As a result, Mr. A entered the oedipal period with a view that any endeavor was a power struggle, in essence asking himself, “Do I give in and bury the rage over being controlled, or do I assert myself and risk being punished either directly by my mother or internally by the guilt I feel by making her more depressed?”

This view of the world was then enhanced by competition from Mr. A’s perfectionistic and controlling father, who, frustrated by his own limitations and illness, would harshly reprimand Mr. A for any assertion within the family or failure outside of it. Fearing retaliation and struggling against his feelings of passivity, Mr. A identified with the aggressor—father and developed an even more punitive superego. Mr. A’s need to repress his competitive rage and envy was reinforced by his father’s chronic heart disease; Mr. A feared that if he were to act assertively, he would kill off his rival. When the father did die during Mr. A’s adolescence, the guilt over this unconscious oedipal victory made

Mr. A even more wary of directly asserting himself in the future. All three of Mr. A's depressive episodes were precipitated by failing to beat out competitors (colleagues or his son), unconsciously reminiscent of earlier defeats with his mother and father, but Mr. A is unaware that he is equally afraid to win and face the resultant retaliation and guilt.

Part 4: Unconsciously Mr. A is likely to view treatment as another competition. Fearful and dependent at first, when his depression begins to improve and he feels more like a "winner," he may respond with guilty fear for a triumph so undeserved in one who unconsciously is consumed with murderous wishes. In response to this guilt, he may sabotage his improvement by prematurely stopping treatment or, less destructively, by focusing on residual depressive symptoms, the side effects of antidepressant medication, or his hypertension (an affliction that unconsciously has become his punishment for killing his father). This behaviour will alternate with Mr. A's viewing the therapist as the winner (*i.e.*, the authority figure to whom he is beholden). Frightened of challenging the victor directly, Mr. A may indirectly defy this authority by appearing compliant, apologetic, and grateful but passive-aggressively "forgetting" appointments or his medication and devaluing the treatment.

### THE SELF-PSYCHOLOGICAL MODEL

Part 3: Mr. A's central problem consists of his low self-esteem and consequent need for continual recognition and approval from others, along with his inability to accept any limitations either in himself (which lead to disapproval from others) or in others (which reduce the value of their approval when it occurs). Presumably, during childhood his depressed mother and sickly father were so self-absorbed with their problems that they were unable to respond empathically to his age-appropriate aspirations; at the same time, both parents narcissistically invested in their son the hopes that his achievements would make up for their failures. Throughout his life Mr. A has strived to earn the accolades he never received as a child, and although this pursuit has led to some professional success, his self-doubt and instability of self-objects take their toll, leading to a lack of confidence, to inappropriate solicitous behaviour, and to procrastination of challenging tasks. In addition, having internalized his parents' grand expectations (in order to repair his sense of deficit as well as to compensate for theirs), he is unable to accept the limitations of others (*e.g.*, his bosses' or his son's) or himself (*e.g.*, physical illness, aging, his professional plateau). Being passed over for promotion was an injury to a sense of self that was already enfeebled; the rejection reawakened early empathic failures and unrealized ambitions. The resultant loss of self-esteem then contributed to the current depression.

Part 4: In treatment, Mr. A will attempt to elicit the therapist's admiration and will have grand (though unconscious) expectations about what can be accomplished, idealizing both himself and the therapist. However, when the therapist fails to respond with just the right empathic quality, Mr. A will be hurt and secretly enraged,

and when the real limitations of Mr. A or the therapist are exposed, Mr. A is likely to devalue the entire enterprise and become more discouraged. Potential countertransference problems may arise if the therapist prematurely limits Mr. A's need to be admired and to idealize the therapist.

### THE OBJECT RELATIONS MODEL

Part 3: Mr. A's central problem is his failure to integrate the good and bad representations of himself and others. During childhood, his depressed mother could not respond to her son's need and demands. Mr. A, unconsciously frightened that his resultant rage would destroy the very one on whom he depended, repressed his bad angry self and acted like the good obedient son. This splitting was reinforced by interactions with the controlling father who punitively viewed any of Mr. A's independent assertions as acts of defiance. Mr. A, frightened that his competitive rage would either kill off the sickly father or lead to retaliation, again repressed his bad angry self. During adolescence, when the surge towards a more autonomous identity was most intense, Mr. A's father died. Responding to unconscious guilt for a forbidden wish that had come true (*i.e.*, killing off the father), Mr. A was even more compelled to keep the bad (assertive) self repressed and to maintain a tie to the lost object, both by an identification with the father's perfectionism, and to punish himself for any success. Although this splitting has enabled Mr. A to be relatively successful and to seem basically well intentioned, the facade is fragile. The efforts with his superiors to appear "the good son" are exaggerated, leading to obsequious and subservient behaviour. Furthermore, when the bad angry self breaks through the repression, procrastination and obstinacy are the result. These signals of the bad self lead to increased self-punitive and restrictive reactions in order to keep his rage contained.

Mr. A's repression and splitting are compounded by his use of projection; that is, he projects onto others his unconscious bad self. This process only reinforces his experience of others as either unnurturing mothers or unsupportive, controlling fathers. This projection of the bad self contributed to Mr. A's viewing his son's marriage as an act of defiance. Similarly, when passed over for promotion, Mr. A not only experienced this rejection as reminiscent of enraging childhood rejections, devaluations, and abandonment but also viewed it as a retaliation for projected hostile wishes from his bad self. His depression is therefore in part the result of his punitive conscience condemning him for projected hostile wishes and for failing to meet the perfectionistic ideals of the good self.

Part 4: In treatment Mr. A will at first be quite ingratiating, the good son depressively condemning himself for past and present failures and wary that he will not meet the therapist's expectations (Mr. A's own projections). However, as Mr. A projects his resentful and defiant self, the therapist may be perceived as being both emotionally uncaring and as controlling, projections that will reinforce in the transference those

early experiences with the mother and father, respectively. The therapist should be prepared for the likelihood that Mr. A's rise in self-esteem will initially be accompanied by denigration of the therapist. The therapist must also anticipate that whenever Mr. A does express the resentful affects associated with the bad self, Mr. A's conscience will clamp down punitively and cause Mr. A to become temporarily more depressed.

### **CLINICAL APPLICATION OF THE FORMULATION**

Although there are differences among the three formulations, it is important to point out the similarities in their clinical conclusions and applications. All three formulations alert the therapist that after an initial honeymoon period, difficulties are likely to develop in the therapeutic relationship. The ego-psychological model conceives of this falling out in terms of passive-aggressive defensive mechanisms, the self-psychological model predicts a devaluation of the therapist in response to inevitable empathic failures and limitations, and the object relations model anticipates that the patient's angry and defiant self will be projected onto the therapist.

All three formulations also alert the therapist to similar countertransference problems: the ego-psychological model places these problems in terms of competitive struggles with the patient over issues of control, the self-psychological model considers problems of the therapist's being initially idealized and then devalued, and the object relations model suggests that the therapist may at times feel compelled to identify with the patient's projections and then assume the role of the uncaring and punitive figure the patient most fears and expects.

All three formulations indicate that the patient's dynamics may directly affect his depressive symptoms and compliance with whatever treatment is prescribed. The ego-psychological model views this resistance in terms of guilty fear accompanying his improvement and a need to indirectly defy authority. The self-psychological model predicts a phase of discouragement and unwillingness to accept the disappointing therapy. The object relations model foresees that depressive feelings may recur if this patient retreats from the emergence of his angry bad self during recovery and that poor compliance will accompany the view of the therapist as punitive and uncaring.

Finally, all three formulations share many similarities in indicating what therapeutic interventions will be required to manage the anticipated transferences, countertransferences, and resistances. They all see that this patient in particular will need a non-judgemental atmosphere where anger and resentment can be expressed spontaneously, he will need appropriate recognition and reinforcement of his strengths (such as his intellectual capacities), and he will need a modicum of control in his treatment (such as deciding within reason the time of day he takes his medication).

Despite these basic similarities, the different conceptual models will no doubt have some influence on the treatment's emphasis and language. We suspect that these differences would be most apparent in the nature of interpretations used in an

exploratory psychotherapy and less apparent in directive, behavioural, supportive, or psychopharmacological treatment. Using the ego-psychological model, the therapist is likely to focus on the relationship between the patient's current difficulties and earlier competitive struggles with his parents. Using the self-psychological model, the therapist will direct interpretations towards helping the patient appreciate the doubts and yearnings that underlie his fragile grandiosity and will trace perceived empathic failures in the therapist to those failures that occurred in the patient's childhood. Finally, using the object relations model, the therapist will attempt to intercept a destructive negative transference and acting out both by interpreting the patient's misperceptions of the therapist as someone (like the father) wanting to control the patient and by encouraging the patient to express through fantasies, memories, and dreams those angry feelings associated with the bad self, thereby indicating a capacity (unlike the mother) to tolerate unpleasant affects. However, in closing, it must be emphasized that the differences that may occur in an insight-oriented psychotherapy are relatively subtle compared to the more important value of the psychodynamic formulation in conceptualizing central conflicts and anticipating the transferences, countertransferences, and resistances that occur in all treatments.

### **FORMULATING THE PROBLEM**

Following problem identification and initial exploration, the practitioner attempts to formulate the problem with the client to arrive at a mutual understanding of the target of their change efforts. Usually practitioners initiate the process by stating the central concerns clients have expressed. This formulation is not a simple summary, however. Practitioners attempt to frame the problem in a way most likely to foster constructive problem-solving actions on the client's part while still reflecting the client's own concerns. To set the stage for client tasks, the problem statement should reflect how clients might act differently to obtain what they want.

For example, Sarah Robbins has voiced many complaints about her aged mother, whom she takes care of (and who refuses to be seen). Mother still tries to run her life, doesn't show any appreciation of all she does for her, and loses her temper over the slightest provocation. At this general level the problem might be formulated in terms of the mother's difficult behaviour, in terms of the strain between them, or in terms of Sarah's difficulty in coping with her mother. Clearly the last two formulations are preferable since they better prepare the way for the client to do something about the situation. This is not "blaming the victim" but rather putting the problem in the most solvable form. Sarah may be able and willing to initiate change, presumably in how she copes with her mother; the mother is more likely to change in response to what her daughter does rather than on her own initiative. The problem should also be formulated at an appropriate level of specificity. If the client expresses the problem in the form of a host of specific complaints, the practitioner should identify a unifying theme, although

the specific complaints can be used as examples. If the client's expression of the problem is general and vague, an attempt should be made to come up with concrete indicators of the difficulty. The practitioner's tentative formulation is given to the client with a request for feedback from the client as to whether or not it accurately reflects the client's main concerns. The client then may agree with the formulation or offer suggestions for revision, which are normally incorporated.

Goals may be included as part of the problem formulation, depending on the nature of the problem and the client's readiness to engage in a goal-setting process. For some difficulties, a precise goal may be inappropriate. For example, a depressed person wants relief from his or her depression. To put this wish in the form of a specific goal would add little. Other problems lend themselves to the construction of goals. For an adolescent who is having academic difficulty, a goal might be to get C's or better in four of his five courses. For still other situations, the notion of a problem as a blocked goal may apply. The problem can be stated as a goal. "Mrs. Porter wants her children returned from foster care. In general, the purpose of the problem formulation is to capture the clients' major concerns in a way to set the stage for them to begin to take remedial action. Formal considerations, *e.g.* degree of specificity or inclusion of goals, are secondary to this purpose.

## FORMULATING THE SPECIFIC PURPOSE

### SPECIFIC PURPOSE STATEMENT

The general purpose of any speech will be either to Inform; Motivate/Persuade; or Entertain your audience. As soon as you know the general purpose of your speech you can develop your *Specific Purpose Statement* (What the speaker will accomplish). Your Specific Purpose Statement is used to develop your speech. You don't actually say it in your speech.

Restrict your Specific Purpose to one idea only. In Speech 151 for the informative speech your general purpose is to inform. For an informative speech you will want to start your specific purpose statement with "I will inform my audience about...." A Specific Purpose Statement for an informative speech will be phrased much like the following statements.

Informative speech specific purpose statements:

- I will inform my audience about the two major forms of hula.
- I will inform my audience about what lifeguards do as part of their jobs.

When you have your specific purpose statement you are ready to compose your Thesis Statement/Central Idea (they are one in the same). This is the most important part of your speech. This is one sentence that encompasses the central idea of your speech.



Writing your thesis statement/central idea is a four step process:

- Choose your topic
- Determine your general purpose
- Write your specific purpose statement
- Tie it all together by composing a clear concise thesis statement/central idea

The following are effective Thesis Statements/Central Ideas for the informative specific purpose statements above:

“The two major forms of hula that have played an important role in Hawaiian history and have developed into unique dances are the Kahiko and ‘Auana.”

“Lifeguarding is a great way to spend your days on the beach, but the work includes training, teaching, and lots of practice making it more challenging than what you see on *“Baywatch.”*

Your next step is to compose the main points of your speech. Main points are complete sentences that create a dialogue with your audience. With your main points you want to create questions in the mind of your audience. You will answer the question in your support of your main points. You make a claim in your main points and you support your claim in your subpoints, sub-subpoints, sub-sub-subpoints and so on.

The following are examples of Main points:

Specific Purpose: I will inform my audience about the two major forms of hula.

*Central Idea:* “The two major forms of hula that have played an important role in Hawaiian history and have developed into unique dances are the Kahiko and ‘Auana.”

- (Main Point 1) “The ancient hula or Kahiko is a unique form of hula.”
- (Main Point 2) “The Kahiko plays an important role in the history of Hawaii.”
- (Main Point 3) “The ‘Auana or modern hula has played an important role in Hawaiian history.”
- (Main Point 4) “The ‘Auana has developed into a unique form of dance and storytelling.”

Speech 151 students can find more examples of specific purpose statements and central ideas.

## **CHOOSING METHOD OF SPEAKING**

### **METHOD TO SPEAKING CONFIDENCE**

The Porch Light\* Method to Speaking Confidence

You know the feeling. Looking out at a sea of faces, you notice a few scowls, frowns, even droopy eyelids on some of your audience members. What are they thinking? Do they disagree with your points? Are they in a bad mood? Do they just not like YOU? You bend over backwards to win them over. You smile, establish eye contact. But the longer you speak the more hopeless you feel as you see your desperate attempts to

please fall flat. At the end, feeling discouraged and anxious, you limp away. It doesn't have to be that way. By using a simple image—the porch light—you can give the same talk with such enthusiasm that scowls won't bother you. In fact, you may even be able to turn those frowns upside down!

Remember going trick-or-treating as a child? You would carefully examine all the houses to determine which ones would yield the good “loot.” Most likely, the brightly lit porches with elaborate Halloween decorations would have friendly, generous, confection-laden people behind the door. Also, you most likely skipped the houses with dark, unswept porches for their lack of promise.

Imagine the faces of your audience members as porch lights. Some will be brightly “lit” with smiles and encouraging looks; others may appear uninviting. The trick is to speak into the spirit of the bright porch lights. Let in support from those who are encouraging you.

Speak into the generosity of those porches that are lit, rather than into the perceived criticism of the uninviting ones.

Does that mean you ignore the unlit porches? No. Instead of speaking from a panicky need to win them over, address the frowning faces with the same energy that you project towards the friendly faces. Easier said than done? Perhaps, but you can make it easier if you remember the following:

- Negative expressions probably have nothing to do with you. People frown when they have a stomachache; they scowl when they're reliving a fight with their spouses; they drop off when they spent the night rocking a sick baby. Nine times out of ten, they had turned off their porch lights long before you walked in the room.
- Usually far more porch lights are ON than off. Most people in your audience want you to succeed. But you can get so focused on forcing the negative ones to like you that you don't let in the support of those who already do! It's a shame when warm, supportive energy goes unused. Besides, if you speak appreciatively into the positive energy of the “on” porch lights, the “off” porch lights see the magic that's happening between you and your supporters. That's often all it takes to turn on lights all over the room.
- Just because a person's porch light is off, it doesn't mean nobody's home. The person might just be concerned, anxious, or distracted. With a little more information or reassurance, that listener's porch light might come on more brightly than all the others.

The next time you speak, remember the wisdom of your trick-or-treating days: Don't spend a lot of time on dark, uninviting porches. Instead, enjoy the warm light of the inviting ones. That's where you'll find the best treats. And, who knows? The grumpy neighbours peeking out from their dark windows may see your joy and decide to turn on their porch lights after all.



## ANALYZING THE AUDIENCE

### DEFINITION

The audience of a technical report—or any piece of writing for that matter—is the intended or potential reader or readers. For most technical writers, this is *the most important* consideration in planning, writing, and reviewing a document. You “adapt” your writing to meet the needs, interests, and background of the readers who will be reading your writing. The principle seems absurdly simple and obvious. It’s much the same as telling someone, “Talk so the person in front of you can understand what you’re saying.” It’s like saying, “Don’t talk rocket science to your six-year-old.” Do we need a course in that? Doesn’t seem like it. But, in fact, lack of audience analysis and adaptation is one of the root causes of most of the problems you find in professional, technical documents—particularly instructions where it surfaces most glaringly. Note: Once you’ve read this section on audiences, try using the audience planner. You fill in blanks with answers to questions about your audience and then e-mail it to yourself and, optionally, to your instructor. Use the audience planner for any writing project as a way of getting yourself to think about your audience in detail.

### TYPES OF AUDIENCES

One of the first things to do when you analyse and audience is to identify its type (or types—it’s rarely just one type). The common division of audiences into categories is as follows:

#### Experts

These are the people who know the theory and the product inside and out. They designed it, they tested it, they know everything about it. Often, they have advanced degrees and operate in academic settings or in research and development areas of the government and business worlds. The non-specialist reader is least likely to understand what these people are saying—but also has the least reason to try. More often, the communication challenge faced by the expert is communicating to the technician and the executive.

#### Technicians

These are the people who build, operate, maintain, and repair the stuff that the experts design and theorize about. Theirs is a highly technical knowledge as well, but of a more practical nature.

#### Executives

These are the people who make business, economic, administrative, legal, governmental, political decisions on the stuff that the experts and technicians work

with. If it's a new product, they decide whether to produce and market it. If it's a new power technology, they decide whether the city should implement it. Executives are likely to have as little technical knowledge about the subject as non-specialists.

### **No Specialists**

These readers have the least technical knowledge of all. Their interest may be as practical as technicians', but in a different way. They want to use the new product to accomplish their tasks; they want to understand the new power technology enough to know whether to vote for or against it in the upcoming bond election. Or, they may just be curious about a specific technical matter and want to learn about it—but for no specific, practical reason.

## **AUDIENCE ANALYSIS**

It's important to determine which of the four categories just discussed the potential readers of your document belong to, but that's not the end of it. Audiences, regardless of category, must also be analyzed in terms of characteristics such as the following:

### **Background-Knowledge, Experience, Training**

One of your most important concerns is just how much knowledge, experience, or training you can expect in your readers. If you expect some of your readers to lack certain background, do you automatically supply it in your document? Consider an example: imagine you're writing a guide to using a software product that runs under Microsoft Windows.

How much can you expect your readers to know about Windows? If some are likely to know little about Windows, should you provide that information? If you say no, then you run the risk of customers' getting frustrated with your product. If you say yes to adding background information on Windows, you increase your work effort and add to the page count of the document (and thus to the cost). Obviously, there's no easy answer to this question—part of the answer may involve just how small a segment of the audience needs that background information.

### **Needs and Interests**

To plan your document, you need to know what your audience is going to expect from that document. Imagine how readers will want to use your document; what will they demand from it.

For example, imagine you are writing a manual on how to use a new microwave oven—what are your readers going to expect to find in it? Imagine you're under contract to write a background report on global warming for a national real estate association—what do they want to read about; and, equally important, what do they *not* want to read about?

### **Other Demographic Characteristics**

And of course there are many other characteristics about your readers that *might* have an influence on how you should design and write your document—for example, age groups, type of residence, area of residence, sex, political preferences, and so on.

Audience analysis can get complicated by at least two other factors: mixed audience types for one document, wide variability within audience, and unknown audiences.

### **More than one Audience**

You're likely to find that your report is for more than one audience. For example, it may be seen by technical people (experts and technicians) and administrative people (executives). What to do? You can either write all the sections so that all the audiences of your document can understand them (good luck!). Or you can write each section strictly for the audience that would be interested in it, then use headings and section introductions to alert your audience about where to go and what to stay out of in your report.

### **Wide Variability in an Audience**

You may realise that, although you have an audience that fits into only one category, there is a wide variability in its background. This is a tough one—if you write to the lowest common denominator of reader, you're likely to end up with a cumbersome, tedious book-like thing that will turn off the majority of readers.

But if you don't write to that lowest level, you lose that segment of your readers. What to do? Most writers go for the majority of readers and sacrifice that minority that needs more help. Others put the supplemental information in appendixes or insert cross-references to beginners' books.

## **AUDIENCE ADAPTATION**

Okay! So you've analyzed your audience until you know them better than you know yourself. What good is it? How do you use this information? How do you keep from writing something that will still be incomprehensible or useless to your readers? The business of writing *to* your audience may have a lot to do with in-born talent, intuition, and even mystery. But there are some controls you can use to have a better chance to connect with your readers. The following “controls” have mostly to do with making technical information more understandable for non-specialist audiences:

### **Add Information Readers need to Understand your Document**

Check to see whether certain key information is missing—for example, a critical series of steps from a set of instructions; important background that helps beginners understand the main discussion; definition of key terms. (See the section on ideas on content for details.)

**Omit Information your Readers do not Need**

Unnecessary information can also confuse and frustrate readers—after all, it’s there so they feel obligated to read it. For example, you can probably chop theoretical discussion from basic instructions.

**Change the Level of the Information you Currently have**

You may have the right information but it may be “pitched” at too high or too low a technical level. It may be pitched at the wrong kind of audience—for example, at an expert audience rather than a technician audience. This happens most often when product-design notes are passed off as instructions.

**Add Examples to help Readers Understand**

Examples are one of the most powerful ways to connect with audiences, particularly in instructions. Even in non-instructional text, for example, when you are trying to explain a technical concept, examples are a major help—analogies in particular.

**Change the Level of your Examples**

You may be using examples but the technical content or level may not be appropriate to your readers. Homespun examples may not be useful to experts; highly technical ones may totally miss your non-specialist readers.

**Change the Organization of your Information**

Sometimes, you can have all the right information but arrange it in the wrong way. For example, there can be too much background information up front (or too little) such that certain readers get lost. Sometimes, background information needs to be woven into the main information—for example, in instructions it’s sometimes better to feed in chunks of background at the points where they are immediately needed. (See the sections on structure and organization of information in a report.)

**Strengthen Transitions**

It may be difficult for readers, particularly non-specialists, to see the connections between the main sections of your report, between individual paragraphs, and sometimes even between individual sentences. You can make these connections much clearer by adding *transition words* and by echoing *key words* more accurately. Words like “therefore,” “for example,” “however” are transition words—they indicate the logic connecting the previous thought to the upcoming thought. You can also strengthen transitions by carefully echoing the same key words.

In technical prose, it’s not a good idea to vary word choice—use the same words so that people don’t get any more confused than they may already be. (See the section on transitions.)

## Write stronger Introductions—both for the whole document and for Major Sections

People seem to read with more confidence and understanding when they have the “big picture”—a view of what’s coming, and how it relates to what they’ve just read. Therefore, make sure you have a strong introduction to the entire document—one that makes clear the topic, purpose, audience, and contents of that document. And for each major section within your document, use mini-introductions that indicate at least the topic of the section and give an overview of the subtopics to be covered in that section. (See the section on introductions both for whole reports and for sections within reports.)

- *Create topic sentences for paragraphs and paragraph groups.* It can help readers immensely to give them an idea of the topic and purpose of a section (a group of paragraphs) and in particular to give them an overview of the subtopics about to be covered. Roadmaps help when you’re in a different state! (See the section on using overviews and topic sentences.)
- *Change sentence style and length.* How you write—down at the individual sentence level—can make a big difference too. In instructions, for example, using imperative voice and “you” phrasing is vastly more understandable than the passive voice or third-personal phrasing. For some reason, personalizing your writing style and making it more relaxed and informal can make it more accessible and understandable. Passive, person-less writing is harder to read—put people and action in your writing. Similarly, go for active verbs as opposed to *be* verb phrasing. All of this makes your writing more direct and immediate—readers don’t have to dig for it.

And obviously, sentence length matters as well. An average of somewhere between 15 and 25 words per sentence is about right; sentences over 30 words are to be mistrusted.

- *Work on sentence clarity and economy.* This is closely related to the previous “control” but deserves its own spot. Often, writing style can be so wordy that it is hard or frustrating to read. When you revise your rough drafts, put them on a diet—go through a draft line by line trying to reduce the overall word, page or line count by 20 per cent. Try it as an experiment and see how you do. You’ll find a lot of fussy, unnecessary detail and inflated phrasing you can chop out. (See the section on common sentence-style and clarity problems for details.)
- *Use more or different graphics.* For non-specialist audiences, you may want to use more graphics—and simpler ones at that. Writing for specialists and experts tends to be less illustrated, less graphically attractive—even boring to the eye! Graphics for specialists tend to be more detailed, more technical. In technical documents for non-specialists, there also tend to be more “decorative” graphics—ones that serve no strict informative or persuasive purpose at all. (See the section on graphics for details.)

- *Break text up or consolidate text into meaningful, usable chunks.* For non-specialist readers, you may need to have shorter paragraphs. Notice how much longer paragraphs are in technical documents written for specialists. (Maybe a 6- to 8-line paragraph is the dividing line.)
- *Add cross-references to important information.* In technical information, you can help non-specialist readers by pointing them to background sources. If you can't fully explain a topic on the spot, point to a book or article where it is. (See the section on cross-references for details.)
- *Use headings and lists.* Readers can be intimidated by big dense paragraphs of writing, uncut by anything other than a blank line now and then. Search your rough drafts for ways to incorporate headings—look for changes in topic or subtopic. Search your writing for listings of things—these can be made into vertical lists. Look for paired listings such as terms and their definitions—these can be made into two-column lists. Of course, be careful not to force this special formatting—don't overdo it. (See the sections on headings and lists for details.)
- *Use special typography, and work with margins, line length, line spacing, type size, and type style.* For non-specialist readers, you can do things like making the lines shorter (bringing in the margins), using larger type sizes, and other such tactics. Certain type styles are believed to be friendlier and more readable than others. (Try to find someone involved with publishing to get their insights on fonts.)

These are the kinds of “controls” that professional technical writers use to finetune their work and make it as readily understandable as possible. And in contrast, it's the accumulation of lots of problems in these areas—even seemingly minor ones—that add up to a document being difficult to read and understand. Non-professionals often question why professional writers and editors insist on bothering with such seemingly picky, trivial, petty details in writing—but they all add up! It reminds me of some Chinese saying about “death by a thousand cuts.”

## NON-VERBAL DIMENSIONS OF PRESENTATION

### INTRODUCTION

The success or failure of many interactional situations, like teaching, depends on the ability of the interactants to accurately decode what has been communicated. Simultaneously, they must bring out the full meaning of thoughts, intents, and affects as well as the understanding of the others through appropriate expressions. Much of the communication process is verbal, but the essence of eloquent, passionate, or spirited communication involves facial expressions, gestures, body position and movement, proxemics, and voice delivery to transmit powerfully affective elements so important

to supporting, subtly extending or modifying verbal messages. These powerful aspects of communication are definitely related to the influence of communicators and to success in social interaction and teaching.

On the “old” Tonight Show (“How old was it? It was so old, it was hosted by someone named Johnny, Tony Randall explained his love of opera by describing his reaction when he first discovered it. The set-up of his story would be seen today as politically incorrect (Randall was speaking long before Bill Maher), but the punchline is what counts: having seen his first opera, Randall exclaimed “You mean this is what I’ve been missing all these years?”

What took me so long?” I would not suggest that Anderson’s *Non-verbal Communication: Forms and Functions* is the textbook equivalent of *Carmen* or *Aida*, but after reading the book, I feel a lot like Randall. I may not have previously known what I was missing, but now that I do know, I am a committed fan.

Undergraduate non-verbal texts are similar to texts in interpersonal, public speaking, mass media, and the like in that most differences are of degree rather than kind. Graphics, sequence, exercises, and ancillaries are the primary means used to distinguish among a host of books that basically say the same things in much the same way.

This reiterative process may even be seen within the books themselves, with the second part often serving as a re-presentation of the first part, only in somewhat different packaging. This is not necessarily bad or counterproductive, but undergraduate students (many of whom are ever sensitive to reasons for not reading a book in its entirety) are not always receptive to a presentational format that is perceived as blatantly repetitive and therefore (to them) goes on twice as long as it should. While Andersen’s book avoids this major pitfall, its success should not be defined primarily in terms of what it does not do. As with Randall and opera, I am a fan because of what is delivered - and the way it arrives.

The book is divided roughly into the two major elements in the title - forms and functions, but Andersen handles the content and arrangement far more effectively than the other basic non-verbal texts with which I am familiar. Part 1 begins with with an array of definitions that explore the relation of non-verbal communication with language. Some may take issue with Andersen’s discussion of the “primacy of non-verbal communication,” but I shall leave that debate to Frank Dance and others far more eloquent and passionate when it comes to defending the “primacy of speech.” From there the text moves to the specific non-verbal codes, examining cultural, sexual, and gender differences and dimensions. Although this may not sound much different from most other NVC texts, the treatment is well done, with a solid grounding in relevant and current research.

Part 2 turns to the discussion of functions of NVC, primarily related to the personal and interpersonal dimension, with emotion, stress, immediacy, and intimate relationships each getting a chapter. Not only does Andersen focus on themes that are likely to be of



interest to the typical undergraduate - as well as many whose undergraduate days are well behind them - but he also covers them in a way that expands and enriches what was introduced in Part 1. Readers are not likely to perceive the material as little more than a rehashing of the first 131 pages. Part 3 continues the focus on functions, but moves from the personal to the public dimension with influence, persuasion, deception, and power as the chapter topics. Again, the discussions build upon what was introduced previously.

The style is accessible but not simplistic; Andersen strikes a good balance between the sophistication of expression necessary to do justice to the literature and the clarity of presentation essential to connect with undergraduate audiences. The text engages without talking down to or above the intended readers. The extensive reference list would also provide an excellent orientation for students assigned a research paper or project as part of the class.

As Tony Randall explained, once he found what he had been missing, he stuck with it; in the same respect, I plan to use Andersen's text next year in my NVC class. However, I realise not everyone may enjoy opera or every opera, so I would not presume to recommend the text for everyone or every class. But I would encourage people to take a look; you may discover something you had not realized you were missing.

### **Purpose of the Studies**

Research predominately conducted in the USA offers findings of relationships between psychosocial and personality dimensions and their social interactional counterparts in terms of non-verbal sensitivity and expressiveness. Do these findings also apply in the German context? Five correlational studies were conducted in the lectures and seminars of the first author to extend earlier findings on the relation of non-verbal skill (non-verbal sensitivity, expressiveness/"charisma") to personality dimensions: Extraversion, Directiveness, Competence and Control Orientations, Self efficacy. Because replication is considered as the cornerstone of scientific enquiry not only was one study conducted but it was also tried to replicate findings as often as opportunity was given.

### **Rationale/Review of Research**

Skill in non-verbal communication is often seen as a fundamental part of social competence. The ability to *accurately decode* and to *send* non-verbal cues *expressively and unambiguously*, matters greatly in daily and professional life.

### ***Accuracy of Decoding Non-verbal Cues***

One of the key competencies for effective communication is understanding socially agreed upon meanings for non-verbal cues. For example, research was done on the relationships between non-verbal judgement ability, clinical ability, or teaching

excellence and the satisfaction and appointment-keeping records of actual patients of physicians. The results suggest the desirability of non-verbal sensitivity among professionals. Also the power of this variable is suggested by its relation to a wide range of social-psychological and personal dimensions (see below).

In face-to-face communication interactants are decoding and encoding non-verbal cues simultaneously. Are receiving and sending skills part of a general communication ability? If this is the case, then decoding and encoding skills would be related and the task of training programmes could be reduced to just discrimination training as it was often suggested. However, reported findings from about a dozen studies found positive, weak as well as negative relationships (Knapp and Hall, 2002). The authors concluded:

*“Evidence is extremely mixed on whether being a good decoder implies being a good encoder. It does not necessarily follow that proficiency in one skill (encoding or decoding) makes one proficient in the other, although sometimes this is the case. Skill in one area may detract from proficiency in another.”*

The present project offered the opportunity to replicate findings obtained in these earlier studies.

### ***Expressiveness and Unambiguousness in Non-verbal Encoding***

From the rich body of research it can be concluded that non-verbal encoding skills play a crucial role in presentations, face-to-face communication and teaching. Two aspects of non-verbal encoding are of particular importance: *expressiveness* (frequency, intensity and variety of non-verbal expressions) and *unambiguousness* of sending.

The expressive use of non-verbal cues is often investigated and discussed as an ingredient of more general, sometimes elusive terms like buoyancy, enthusiasm, or charisma. Research reviews of Barr, Rosenshine, Klinzing, Klinzing and Gerada Aloisio (2004b) concluded that high-inference measures of those variables as well as frequencies of low-inference variables such as movement, gesture, eye contact, and variations in voice are related to aspects of *professional success*. Charismatic physicians were likely to have more patients than their less charismatic colleagues.

### ***Psychosocial and Personality Correlates of Non-verbal Decoding and Encoding Ability***

The correlation of non-verbal skill/expressiveness with a wide range of psychosocial or personality dimensions not only refers to the power of this aspect of communication but also contributes to the understanding of psychosocial constructs and their interactions. Most of the older research focuses on effects of global communicators' characteristics in a dependent relation to more concrete abilities and behaviours.

Skilled *decoders* of non-verbal signs and signals are shown to possess the following characteristics: they have been found to be *“better adjusted, less hostile and manipulating, more interpersonally democratic and encouraging, more extraverted,*

*less shy, less socially anxious, more warm, more empathic, more cognitively complex and flexible.*”. In keeping with possession of these desirable characteristics, skilled non-verbal decoders are more *self-monitoring*, are considered more *popular and sensitive* to the needs of others, and report higher levels of *warmth and satisfaction* in their own personal relationships. Mental patients scored considerably lower than the other groups tested with the Profile of Non-verbal Sensitivity.

The skill of decoding non-verbal signs and signals develops from childhood until age 20 to 30 and seems to decrease later on in life. In the studies of Rosenthal et al. positive correlations were found in samples of young test-takers while negative correlations were found among adults. In a study by Liebermann, Rigo and Campaign, women averaging 62 years were compared to women averaging 22 years in non-verbal sensitivity using the PONS; the scores of the older turned out to be significantly lower.

Also in two studies of Klinzing and Gerada Aloisio, significant differences emerged between school principals and university students (age: M = 26 years) and between docents of forestry (age: M=48 years) and their students (age: M=23 years) in *decoding abilities*, both in favour of the latter. These findings point to those reported by Rosenthal et al. suggesting that decoding skills may also be status related.

Results from samples from the USA, Australia, and Canada show that greater professional advancement was associated with lower non-verbal sensitivity. All these findings suggest that advancement in age and status may reflect changes in attention, memory, and perception. According to this assumption, data were collected to examine differences in decoding (and encoding) skills in the studies reported in this paper.

Investigation were conducted examining psychosocial correlates of *encoding abilities* by using the *Affective Communication Test* to assess “charisma”/”spirit” (ACT, Friedman et al., 1980). Measuring in part the encoding ability in terms of non-verbal expressiveness (considered itself as an important aspect of personality), these studies documented that people who were more expressive/”charismatic”, were perceived as more likable while meeting new people. They were able to influence others’ mood, had lectured to groups of people, had been an elected official of an organization, had theatrical experience, had opted or were selected for employment that involved working with and influencing people, or had worked as sales persons.

There is some evidence that intensive non-verbal expressiveness is related to unambiguousness in encoding. Accurate senders make the impression of greater expressiveness, confidence, and likeability and, among males, use more fluent speech, more fluent body movements, and more smiles. Training studies in which the successful enhancement of non-verbal expressiveness was achieved, an improvement of clarity of presentation could be observed at the same time.

Besides these social-psychological variables, also various *personality dimensions* are closely tied to expressiveness/charisma. Research on personality dimensions and the ability to enact affects revealed significant relations to characteristics considered as

important for social life like *affiliation, extraversion, self-esteem, and internal locus of control (internality)*. They were also related to *achievement orientation, exhibition* (being colourful, spellbinding, noticeable, expressive, dramatic, and showy), *playfulness*, and *dominance*. Of interest is also with what variables charisma was only *weakly* or *not* related: *social desirability, self-monitoring, impulsivity, trait anxiety, self-monitoring, lie* and *machiavellianism*. Charisma was negatively related to *neuroticism* and *social recognition*. Also no relationship between age and expressiveness was found. Furthermore, individuals with schizophrenia tended to show reduced facial expressivity and more negative than positive expressions. Thus, an increasing evidence on the relationship between “charisma” (understood largely as non-verbal expressiveness) and various personality dimensions suggests that a powerful variable is tapped which strongly influences interaction with others. Thus, non-verbal expressiveness is a social interactional counterpart of certain psychosocial and personality dimensions which are assumed to be important for professions involving intensive human interaction, like teaching. The studies were intended to replicate and extend findings for selected relationships in the German context.

### **Subjects of the Correlational Studies**

Altogether 788 undergraduate student teachers and students studying pedagogy as a major in a large German University signed up to participate in the five correlational studies. *Figure 1* gives a profile of the participants of the studies based on age, gender, number of semesters completed, and majors studied at the university. Due to fairly normal lapses data were not available for some participants. Data were not available for a number of reasons: momentary indispositions; some of the participants could not complete the test because they had to leave the session before the test was administered, they did not attend the session in which the test was administered, or took the test home and forgot to bring it back.

### **NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION**

In the realm of escaping attention, the very obvious rivals the obscure. Remember “the purloined letter”? Hiding something in plain sight. Not having awareness in all the dimensions of non-verbal communication is another form of blindness, or, at least, myopia, nearsightedness, just as debilitating as the physical handicap. Beyond mere awareness is a higher level of perception, involving memory and sensitivity components. That level, to cure the blindness, can only be attained by training and education. Start with BIBLIOTHERAPY, wide reading. Such a higher consciousness will further the evolution and survivability of the human race and will probably be attained in the future, near or distant. Circumspection with intelligence. Two policemen in Missouri saw something; they rescued two boys from a kidnapper, one of them who was held captive for 4+ years almost under the noses of the community which was trying to find

them. To see what is in front of your nose is a constant struggle, said Orwell. You can see something, but you have to have a word to name it or you cannot communicate what it is you see, to yourself or to others. You have to build the vocabulary (nomenclature) undergirding perception. Perception is a response involving both sensation and memory in the same instant. The word unlocks the sense. Otherwise you remain dumb (in the sense of mute). Study! So it is with non-verbal communication. Often times it involves response without awareness, as in subliminal perception, or habit, submerged below the threshold. The play-face. The eyebrow flash. Tongue-showing. Seating position in a room and apprehension. Submissive posture. Body orientation. Makeup. Dress for success. The list is nearly endless. When the elements of non-verbal communication (in the column) are cross-listed with the demographics (in the row), a matrix is created. (Please see the diagram on the “Culture” page.) In every cell, one facet of the individual’s self-presentation is isolated, for study, analysis, understanding, for raising awareness above the threshold and increasing knowledge.

Non-verbal communication is those attributes or actions, other than words, which have socially shared meaning and the potential for feedback. Are they attributes or actions which are intentionally sent? No.

### Some Categories

- Kinesics (body movement, gestures)

NOTE: Some movements become emblems (symbolic, like the finger-”okay” sign, American sign language) and are verbal, not non-verbal, communication.

- Proxemics (body spacings)
- Haptics (touch, tactile communication)
- Paralinguistics (vocalics)
- Volume, force
- pitch (optimum, range)
- Rate
- Articulation (enunciation)
- Variety
- Quality
- Fluency (pause)
- Oculistics (eye behaviour)
- Chronemics (time management)
- Objectics (artifacts)
- Physical appearance (dress, skin colour, body shape or type, etc.)
- Face (expression, micro-momentary expression, affect display)
- Environment (proximate type, arrangement, location, etc.)
- Smell (olfaction)
- Demographics

### **Internationality**

Most people have no awareness or only a vague notion about how some of their choices in clothing, facial expressions, artifacts, etc., are affecting their self-presentation. Much of the meaning of one's non-verbal behaviour is not known by the communicator, well hidden in habits of a lifetime. Others might interpret the behaviour as intentional. Who is that stunning woman dressing for? Me? Her husband? Some body else? Most are not aware of what is happening, perceptual thresholds needing lowering. Apparently women are more aware than men. Most find it difficult to articulate what is influencing them, although there are probably some subliminal effects contributing to some affect, or feelings —good or bad vibes. Non-verbal behaviour contributes the major part of what is derived from a communication situation. This topic begins to spill over into the realm of culture.

## **PIE CHARTS AND SURFACE CHARTS**

In drawing pie charts, remember that it is easiest for readers to read clockwise from the twelve o'clock position. Also, it is normally most effective to place larger segments first, provided that does not distort a time sequence.

That is useful for showing proportions within rising figures over a period of time is a surface chart. A surface chart is a cross between a chart and a graph. A visual impression can be made, emphasizing not only development over a period of time but also the proportional changes within the totals over that period of time.

### **GRAPHS**

Graphs need to be composed with as much care as any other type of verbal or visual communication. Unfortunately, it is common to find that little thought is given to choice of scale and to emphasizing the precise point which is to be made. The weaknesses in graphs that occur in too many scientific and technical reports. It is mystifying, designated simply Graph A. As there is no explanatory caption, readers are required to remember what Graph A was supposed to be showing or have to refer back to the text to remind themselves. The line of the graph is scarcely visible, and it is not at all easy to see how many changes of direction there are in the line as it moves forward in time. It may be that the writer's intention was to emphasize that the results scarcely rose above the bottom axis. But it would probably have been better to emphasize the flatness of the graph in general, and the small changes in movement in particular, by choosing a different scale. What we see here is the equivalent of thoughtless choice of words in making a verbal statement. However, this graph was not designed to make a single point within an argument. It must be seen as a 'reference' graph. Once again, we must distinguish between tactics chosen to make a point during an argument, and tactics used to present masses of inter-related data for readers to scrutinize at greater length. But even so, it would probably help readers if that graph were approached by means of two or more



steps presenting smaller elements of the information and gradually building up to the composite package provided. Visual presentation can be overdone; the inexperienced user of charts and diagrams often fails to resist the temptation to try and say too much at a time. The keynote of nearly all successful diagrammatic presentation lies in simplicity of design and absence of cluttering detail. A sequence of logically developed charts is invariably preferable to a single monsterpiece, which in saying everything conveys nothing. How many lines is it possible to accommodate comfortably on a graph? Once again in discussing effective communication, there is no single correct answer. Everything depends upon the precise objective of the graph that you are drawing. But if those lines had begun to move across one another, the load of information would have been too great to absorb.

The different lines are labelled by means of small symbols and a key is provided in the top left corner of the graph. Most readers find this an irritating practice, since they are obliged to move their eyes frequently from the identifying symbols on the lines to the keys in the top corner and back again to ensure that they are not misunderstanding the information being presented. Wherever possible, it is desirable to put the label at the ends of the lines so that the reader does not have to keep moving to and fro across the graph to find identifying information in a key. A graph labelled in this way. Notice, however, that the label for the left-hand curve seems to be in the wrong place. It would be better on the left of the curve. A moment's thought shows that in fact all the labels are on the top right-hand end of the curve; but this 'verbal' logic conflicts with the visual logic of the eye. Visual logic should always take precedence.

## FLOW CHARTS

Flow charts use lines to help readers see sequences and movements through a process or a set of facts or possibilities. Lines are used to enable each reader not only to follow a path, but also to ignore information which might be relevant to other readers but is not relevant to him or her. Normally, in creating an algorithm or a flow chart, the writer wishes to make it easier for readers to decide which details, circumstances or conditions relate to their interests and needs. The information is arranged in a hierarchy, enabling each reader to start by asking the most important overall question, and subsequently to follow a decision-taking sequence through a number of points at which simple decisions between two paths are possible. The paths normally represent a sequence in time or priority in physical or mental operations.

But not all flow charts are algorithms. A conventional circuit diagram can be described as a flow chart, as it shows all the paths or flows in a circuit without necessarily emphasizing any principal flow. But the best circuit diagrams, too, are structured to help the reader recognize groups of operations, sequences, primary and secondary flow, or feedback.



## LOGICAL TREES

The simplest type of flow chart is a logical tree (otherwise called a family tree, or a genealogical tree). By reducing the information to a series of questions and comments, the writer has managed to avoid generating dense paragraphs of prose setting out various possibilities, and the actions that should be taken in the light of those possibilities. This enables readers to concentrate on the particular faults they identify in the apparatus before them.

## USE OF SYMBOLS

The reader simply by the use of lines. All other information is provided in words. It is possible to use flow charts to reduce the number of words as well. This can be done by introducing pictorial representation into the presentation as well as words. By use of recognizable symbols, the writer has managed to give an impression of the various stages in the process, culminating in the production of the literature and its dispatch from the factory.

Not many flow charts go this far in pictorial representation. Most rely on the use of well-known symbols to add information to that which is written in words within the various elements on the flow chart. Some of the most familiar symbols in use. A circle indicates a starting or finishing point, a diamond or lozenge shape indicates a question and a rectangle indicates an instruction or decision point. Use of conventional symbols, and reliance on readers' recognition of information conveyed not by words but by the use of symbols. However, this practice can become dangerous because some readers may not recognise the significance of the symbols used in the presentation.

Particularly, readers in other countries may not understand symbols that are very familiar to you. Most British readers understand the meaning of a tick as used; in many other countries, the symbol is not used.

In some countries, too, a cross (x) customarily signifies a positive response (not, as in Britain, a negative response). For example, in a register of attendees at a meeting in France, the secretary puts a cross by the name of each person present (not, as in Britain, by the name of each absentee).

So, when you use symbols in your illustrations or text, try to choose symbols that are in use everywhere. Avoid the confusion that arises when organizations create different ways of symbolizing a single meaning. Seven ways of symbolizing the earliest and latest times of an event in a Critical Path Analysis network! Of course, the safe way to proceed is to use international standards and to give readers a key to symbols at the start of each document.

But remember that your readers may not be using the document as frequently as you are, and extensive use of symbols identified by keys may place heavy loads on your readers' memories.

### **Emphasis on flow and Functions**

A common fault in flow charting is to make all movement or flow seem to be of equal importance. A flow chart in which it is difficult to see the relative importance of different pieces of information and different movements. A simplified and clarified flow chart emphasizing by different weights of line and symbols the main movement and the feedback within the flow. Sometimes flow charts become long and complex if you attempt to show all possible paths, branches and outcomes on a single chart.

One way of reducing complexity is to have a 'family' of charts-a main chart showing an overall flow, indicating branches to lower-level charts that give more detail of specific decision-points or procedures. Another helpful technique for reducing the length of flow charts is to 'bend' them. Block diagrams can be used particularly successfully to indicate the linking of functions or other structural entities in scientific and technical work. And if the information is not too complicated, it is possible with benefit to superimpose the two functional layouts one upon the other, to produce a flow chart which shows functional blocks with the explanation in words and the circuit diagram all in one presentation.

### **Skilful use of Lines, Shapes and Tones**

In this discussion of graphic presentation techniques, we have not included analysis of the advantages and disadvantages of different types of specialized technical drawing such as orthographic projection, isometric projection and so on. Neither have we discussed the production of illustrations using air-brush techniques, multiple colours and other specialized techniques. However, some of the simple but effective techniques used by professional illustrators *are* available to the producer of reports and papers.

For example, you do not have to be a professional illustrator to use lines, shapes and shading effectively in your presentations. A valuable summary of the tactics the non-specialist illustrator can use to show relationships. Simple photographs, emphasizing size, scale and position can be used effectively in reports and papers at low cost and without specialized help.

### **A Word of Caution**

Finally, let us emphasize that although the presentation of factual information in diagrams or even in pictorial charts can ensure that it will be understood and remembered better than when it is presented in a table, much depends on the skill with which the presentation is matched to its aim and audience.

Indeed, for some readers, the inclusion of graphical illustrations in a text may *decrease* accuracy of recall and grasp of an argument over-all. Much seems to depend on the intelligence of the readers and the extent of their training in how to interpret visual presentations.

## VISUAL SIGNALLING

In turning to consider the use of tables, graphs, diagrams and other illustrations in the presentation of information, we are not changing our topic. Our subject is still clear communication, and we are still discussing how to make precise, manageable statements using language. Words, graphs and drawings are all visual patterns used to symbolise or represent meaning. In both graphic statements and verbal statements, we use a variety of hieroglyphics-dots, dashes, and other marks on paper-as symbols to carry information.

Words, after all, are made up of letters which are composed of combinations of lines and circles; for example, the difference between 'o', 'p', 'd', and 'b' lies only in the positioning of the line tangential to the circle. So words and drawings are not conflicting or competing modes of expression. They are, at most, extremes on a continuum, with words at one end making minimum use of the visual appearance of the signals, and with drawings and graphic presentations at the other end making maximum use of the visual appearance of the signals.

We have discussed how statements in words often cause difficulty for receivers because they contain unfamiliar vocabulary or signals, because they are too long and complex, or because they require the reader to hold in mind too many inter-related clauses and conditions. Visual statements can be difficult for the receiver for similar reasons: they may contain vocabulary or signals with which the reader is unfamiliar; they may be too long or too complex; they may contain too many inter-related items and conditions for the reader to absorb. So, just as writers must be skilful in selecting words and sentence structures from the verbal code, they must be equally skilful in selecting and handling the elements from the visual code.

### THINKING ABOUT THE TASK

Tactics for selecting and handling information applies equally to the choice of visual techniques. As always, aim and audience are the governing factors in this choice, and it is especially important to consider two questions:

- What is the precise function of the table or illustration?
- Will the readers of the paper receive this information more readily in verbal or in numerical/visual form?

We have argued earlier that the way a text is organized and laid out, and the rate at which information should be 'unloaded' or packed into our pages, must be varied according to the function of the text. In a dictionary or a parts list, it is effective to pack together a great deal of information tightly and economically, because these texts are designed for reference, for scrutiny and cross-checking of particular items. We must make it easy for 'readers' to find their way into and around the assembled information, but we do not have to construct a coherent discourse; the entries are not statements in a connected argument.

Tactics of selection and organization are different from those used in a report or an instruction sheet. In just the same way, tactics in using tables and graphic techniques must be related to the precise function of the document as a whole and of the visual items in particular. Distinguish between tables and charts that are to be used for reference, as stores of classified and juxtaposed information, and visual statements that are to be used to make a point in an explanation or argument.

Tables and drawings designed as reference material can be packed tightly in the equivalent of dictionary or parts-list form. They are usually best separated from the main text of a report or paper so that they are not an obstacle to the readers' smooth progress through the argument. Tables and drawings that are designed to make a point as part of an argument should have simple structures and carefully judged information-loads. They should be placed as close as is physically possible to the point in the prose text at which you want readers to take in the information they provide.

For example, providing a mass of information about the enthalpy of methane for reference and for scrutiny of detail. In most circumstances, it would distract the reader if it were part of the text, and it would be best placed in an appendix. A specially drawn graph, based on the same information; but it is a simpler statement designed to make one particular point. It was placed within the prose text of a report, close to the point in the argument at which the visual point was needed. A practical tip: abstractions of information like this can often be made simply by putting tracing paper over a complicated original and inking in the significant lines. The traced outline can then be photocopied (perhaps even reduced) and included conveniently within a typewritten report or paper. The second important question-will the readers receive the information more easily in verbal or in numerical/visual form-is of particular concern to writers who must communicate to specialists from a wide range of backgrounds. It is well established that readers will take more information more rapidly from documents if they know what to expect from the document and where in the document to look for it. It is also well established that some people are by nature and training more inclined to be 'verbalizers' and others are more inclined to be 'visualizers'.

Some readers will find it easier to assimilate the verbal statement, 'Output falls to half within the first hour, to a quarter within the next hour, and then stabilises at one tenth for the remainder of the run'; other readers will absorb that information more rapidly if they are shown a simple graph that shows output plotted against time. In writing for engineering and scientific readers, you will probably decide that they will usually be helped by the use of tables and graphic presentation techniques; but *which* technique still requires careful thought. Readers who like block diagrams may be bemused by complex drawings of electronic circuits. In debates with engineers and scientists about the relative effectiveness of different algorithm layouts, we have been surprised to find how powerful is the influence of 'what they are used to'.

## Job Interview

A job interview is a process in which a potential employee is evaluated by an employer for prospective employment in his company, organization, or firm, and was established in the late 16th century

### ROLE

A job interview typically precedes the hiring decision, and is used to evaluate the candidate. The interview is usually preceded by the evaluation of submitted résumés from interested candidates, then selecting a small number of candidates for interviews. The job interview is considered one of the most useful tools for evaluating potential employees. It also demands significant resources from the employer, yet has been demonstrated to be notoriously unreliable in identifying the optimal person for the job.

Multiple rounds of job interviews may be used where there are many candidates or the job is particularly challenging or desirable. Earlier rounds may involve fewer staff from the employers and will typically be much shorter and less in-depth. A common initial interview form is the phone interview, a job interview conducted over the telephone.

This is especially common when the candidates do not live near the employer and has the advantage of keeping costs low for both sides. Once all candidates have been interviewed, the employer typically selects the most desirable candidate and begins the negotiation of a job offer.

## PREPARATION

It is very important to be well prepared for an interview. A common reason employers give for not hiring an applicant is the inability of the applicant to fully explain the contents of his or her résumé. Therefore it is paramount to be able to discuss in detail every item listed on one's résumé, and if possible to give examples when appropriate. It is also wise to research the company before the interview. To avoid being nervous, the applicant should practice answering difficult questions. Good sources of interview questions can be found by searching the Internet.

## PROCESS

A typical job interview has a single candidate meeting with between one and three persons representing the employer; the potential supervisor of the employee is usually involved in the interview process. A larger *interview panel* will often have a specialized human resources worker. While the meeting can be over in as little as 15 minutes, job interviews usually last less than two hours.

The bulk of the job interview will entail the interviewers asking the candidate questions about his or her job history, personality, work style and other factors relevant to the job. For instance, a common interview question is "What are your strengths and weaknesses?" The candidate will usually be given a chance to ask any questions at the end of the interview.

These questions are strongly encouraged since they allow the interviewee to acquire more information about the job and the company, but they can also demonstrate the candidate's strong interest in them. Candidates for lower paid and lower skilled positions tend to have much simpler job interviews than do candidates for more prestigious positions. For instance, a lawyer's job interview will be much more demanding than that of a retail cashier. Most job interviews are formal; the larger the firm, the more formal and structured the interview will tend to be. Candidates generally dress slightly better than they would for work, with a suit (called an interview suit) being appropriate for a white-collar job interview.

Additionally, some professions have specific types of job interviews; for performing artists, this is an audition in which the emphasis is placed on the performance ability of the candidate. In many companies, Assessment Days are increasingly being used, particularly for graduate positions, which may include analysis tasks, group activities, presentation exercises, and psychometric testing.

A candidate should follow up the interview with a thank-you letter, expressing his or her appreciation for the opportunity to meet with the company representative. The thank you letter ensures that the candidate will stay fresh in the interviewer's mind. The primary purpose of the job interview is to assess the candidate's suitability for the job, although the candidate will also be assessing the corporate culture and demands of the job.

## **YOUR FIRST JOB INTERVIEW**

Interviews are essential in the application process as the recruiter will get a first hand look at the candidate. You cannot easily find a company that will hire you without any interview. You will be scrutinized and asked unexpected questions that you will have to think fast or else you will end up with a totally awkward answer.

But these are excited times as you get interviewed for the first time for a job. Even though will not be hired for the job, this should be a learning experience for you. Not everyone gets them the first time but you can do it.

### **PREPARING FOR THE INTERVIEW**

You can never be too prepared for a job interview especially if it is your first time. You have to know the company background, the job description and the skills that you can match to the job description. Sitting down in front of a recruiter without any idea of the company background and what exactly they do is never good.

Do not think that being familiar with the industry will give you a good idea of their company. Each company has their special practices that you need to be aware of. That means you have to hunt for data that is not written in the company web site. Look for online data of some employees or even their customers.

### **NO EXCUSES**

Informing your interviewer that this is your first interview after graduating from college is OK. But using it as an excuse is always a no-no. Remember that you are applying for a job not just an intern wherein you will not be solely responsible for the mess in the office.

Do not make any excuses as this will cripple your chances of getting hired. Companies are not looking for employees to understand but they are looking for employees who can be efficient. It does not really matter if you are experienced or not as long as you can persuade them that you can get the job done.

### **BECOME PROFESSIONAL**

A professional is never late, dresses appropriately, does not slouch when sitting and formal in addressing the interviewer unless being asked not to. These are only few of the things you should do to show your professionalism.

Unless you are applying to be a comedian or a clown, you need to have proper business attire for a well paying job. The interviewer may not seem to show the same professionalism that you do but that should not be an excuse. By showing your professionalism, you are showing your dedication to work or at least to the interview and you show your respect to the company you wish to work with. Your first job interview might not go as planned. But it is just your first interview. If you have not heard from



them after two weeks, get in touch with them for a follow up or assume that you were not hired for the job. Learn from that experience and move on by considering other companies.

## JOB INTERVIEW TIPS

An important aspect in applying for a job is the interview that you have to go through and get through successfully, for you to be able to bag the job that you have been eying. If you reach interview phase of the job hunting process, it can be said that you have reached first base, and it is very necessary to be fully prepared for it so you can move on until you are finally hired. If this is your first time for a job interview, some degree of stress and nervousness is but natural, but you can easily overcome it by getting yourself fully prepared for whatever questions that you may have to answer.

*Here are some of the practical interview tips that you can follow:*

- *Practice for the Interview:* Get hold of a list of job interview questions that most employers ask of job applicants. You know best what you are good at, so maximize this without sounding boastful about it. Practice how you will be able to get this across to the interviewer in a calm manner. Being calm during the interview is one way to impress any job interviewer.
- *Prepare what you know about the Company:* Prepare a response thoroughly when you will be asked the question “What do you know about our company?” Most of these facts about any company are found in the “About Us” portion of any company’s web site which you can easily access. You can even have the interviewer’s name as the web site may also have a listing of a firm’s staff including those who are responsible in hiring people. Knowing about the company that you are interested to join is already a big plus when you are interviewed.
- *Watch job interview tips videos:* To get an idea and a feel of the actual interview situation, especially if you are a first timer in this thing. Doing this will give you the confidence to answer the questions better—you will likely hear the usual interview questions in these videos.
- *Be on time for your interview:* Being on time for the interview is the most important thing, as one who comes late will surely flunk an interview, if ever he gets to be interviewed at all. Firms normally do not want tardy people and this can be best gauged just in the scheduled interview. Be at the company’s premises well ahead of your interview time to be sure you will be there when the interviewer calls for you.
- *Dress properly:* Make sure that you are in proper attire for interview. You should also have all the necessary documents that may be asked for and be ready to take down notes when necessary.

- *Stay calm and composed:* During the actual job interview try to relax and stay as calm as possible. It is natural to have some initial nervousness, but your prior preparation should be able to help you overcome it after a while. As long as you have done your practice in answering the interview questions, there should be no reason to be scared at all.

If ever there will be a question that you have not prepared for, be sincere by telling the interviewer straight that you do not know the answer. That will be better than trying to fool him with a non-sensical answer. He will appreciate you more if you are candid enough. At least he will know the kind of person that you are—he may not really want anything to do with a quibbler, or one who cannot be mature enough to tell the truth when needed.

## INTERVIEW RULES

Being aware of interview rules will help you in better preparation and thereby giving that additional confidence to face and answer immaculately during the course of interview. When you go job hunting, you are likely to come across general information on job interviews that may be good to keep in mind when you prepare for your own job interview. Reaching the interview portion of the job-hiring process is already a big accomplishment for you, so make sure not to botch it.

You get called for interview only when you worked hard in looking for the job—it is as if you have reached the first base. It will be helpful for you to remember the following tested rules when you face your interviewer:

- *First 10 seconds:* Interviewer decide about you in the first 10 seconds. They may not have all the time for other questions the answers of which will not be useful to the company that is hiring. Interviewers in the first place may have been the ones who actually prepared these rules, because they have to interview many applicants in their working day.
- *First impression:* You have to make a good first impression. This is normally the case even in other situations in life. A potential employer's first encounter with you could be the very thing that will determine whether he will hire you or not. The saying that first impressions last can never be truer at this time.
- *Asking questions:* Always ask insightful questions. Of course the company interviewer will appreciate you if you do this, he may not want to be waylaid by silly questions. Of course you must have done some research beforehand on the company in order to be able to ask relevant questions.
- *Being informed:* Learn as much as you can about the company, you should have this knowledge beforehand as the interviewer will likely ask you on what you know about their firm. It should be easy to learn facts about a company, as most companies now publish information about themselves in their web sites. Study them carefully.

- *Answering difficult questions:* They will probably ask questions designed to trip you up. When this happens, and if you do not know how to answer them, be candid in telling them that you would not know the answers to the questions. This is much better than you quibbling uselessly. They will appreciate you better with your frankness and sincerity. They will likely be expecting that you be candid with them always when you will actually be working with them later.
- *Be prepared:* Have some quick answers to interview questions at the ready. You must have gone over a list of usual interview questions as part of your preparation, so be ready with the answers for them. There is no substitute to being sufficiently prepared.

The above list may just be rules that may apply to any interview. May be it will help if you answer interview questions successfully, but that is really not all that matters in getting hired for the job. The most important thing to remember is about presenting yourself in the most authentic way that takes care of impressing the interviewer/s.

Some people botch their interview chances when they are not fully prepared, and when they do not appear as natural as the persons they truly are. Presenting yourself as somebody else who is not your natural self may show, and that will not be good for you. It is best that you just act your natural self during your talk with the interviewer. That may be what he is looking for in job applicants. You should not forget that the interviewer is experienced in his craft and he cannot be fooled by an applicant who is just pretending and not behaving his true self.

## **JOB INTERVIEW DURING COMPETITIVE TIMES**

These days, more number of people are competing for jobs that may be much less in number and in kind. Many companies have closed down and those that have remained in operation may be looking for replacements for the people they have retrenched as part of a downsizing strategy, instead of completely closing up shop. While there is a recession in full swing, there are instances when downsized companies are suddenly swamped with orders for their goods since some countries still have better economies and the goods they sell which they source from the US are still continuing to sell in their respective markets.

Hence, companies in this situation have to produce fast the goods ordered from abroad, and they have to recall some people or hire new ones even for part-time jobs, to meet the needs for products of their clients overseas. So, the situation now in some businesses is one of a come-and-go basis, and they have to cope with the business fluctuations by making use of part-time workers.

You could be one of those who continue to search for jobs because you have a family to support and you have to survive in these difficult recessionary times. If you have been invited to an interview after you have filed several applications, you could be

among the luckier ones whose CVs must have been closely scrutinized by HRD personnel. Something about you and your previous work experience, or the way you have presented yourself when you submitted your job application must have impressed the one tasked to interview you. He may be the same person who received your application initially.

Here is the key, and the most important thing to remember when you report for that interview, is that most likely they want you to be the one to get the job among the others applying. They want to know if their search is over, so for the length of the interview, the job is yours practically.

Remember that first impressions are always incredibly important. People, like interviewers, do make up their minds quickly so be yourself right from the start.

Of course maybe you can turn up the volume on those bits about you that most match the job at hand, and turn it down on the bits that do not have anything to do with the job in question. This move is supposed to help you show yourself in your best light.

However, be careful that you will not be noticed just pretending to be a kind of person which you are not actually. People, especially experienced interviewers, can smell pretence in the interviewee anytime and your being unnatural and artificial could mean a disaster for you after the interview. Neither will it be good for you to lie about yourself when answering questions of the interviewer.

Just like when you are cross-examined by an experienced trial lawyer in a criminal hearing, the interviewer can easily spot inconsistencies in your answers to his questions. The best way to go about it in your interview is to be factual in telling about what you have been doing and about your experience. By just being yourself in the interview is already a strength that cannot be easily assailed.

When you are asked questions that you do not know how to answer, say so frankly—the interviewer may even yet appreciate you for your candidness. And because he is impressed with your confidence that you know the job that you are applying for, while noting those questions you frankly admitted not knowing, he might just quickly sign the approval of your hiring.

## **STAYING CALM DURING INTERVIEW**

When you report for that important job interview after days of hard work filing and submitting job applications, it cannot be helped to feel some apprehensive excitement. This is but natural for anyone, so you have to do something about it beforehand. Your preparation of course will be of much help like studying and reviewing even for a number of times the nature of the job and the company you are applying for so you will develop understanding of what you are going into. The interview you are about to undergo is just the beginning of a new life with the company, should they decide to hire you after the interview.

The interviewer who will be handling you, will understand the uneasiness that you may show—he has seen this in many applicants before in his career with the HR Department of the company.

A job applicant is always expected to be a little jittery, of course with some job seekers trying very hard not to show it. The company however, is unlikely to hire the over-relaxed, too calm, or even the laid back type of job applicant. They see in this kind of person some bad traits or a “don’t care” attitude which they may not like later when he is already on the job with the company.

The HRD experts especially know what everyone goes through in the interview, regardless of how skilled or experienced he may be. So do not worry too much about that interview, go right ahead into it. There are ways however to help in staying calm during the interview and among the first things you can do is to look at the company’s web site and try to have answers in your mind to the following questions:

- What does the company web site tell you about them?
- Why do you want to be employed by them?
- Think about what they need, if they are hiring people
- Who are the competitors of the company?
- Do you feel that they are they well established?
- What are the things that you want to know about them?
- What do you like about the company?

Having the answers to the above questions stored in your mind could at least dispel some unfounded fears you may have of going into something that you are not familiar with. When you find yourself in the company’s premises waiting for the interview to start, feel at ease in talking with staff members, especially on something which you know best. As most interviews are of the two-way type, meaning the interviewer will likely encourage you to ask questions too, have these questions ready, even if you have to make written notes on them. Your study of the company’s web site would have prepared you with the questions. You may even have done some practice asking those questions back home.

## **JOB INTERVIEW TECHNIQUES**

### **THE STATISTICS ON HOW WE MAKE AN IMPRESSION**

Your appearance makes an instant impression when meeting people for the first time actually, in the first 30 seconds.

Statistics show that when we meet new people the impact we make is via:

- 55%—the way we dress, act and walk through the door.
- 38%—the quality of our voice grammar and overall confidence.
- 7%—from what we actually say.

**What to Wear**

Choose clothes to show you'll fit in with the company "look" or "culture". Check out what their employees are wear-ing and try to match that. If anything, wear on the side of conservative and formal. Even when going for manufacturing or blue collar jobs, it is definitely worth the effort to wear a collar and tie. Stay away from lots of jewellery—one simple pair of earrings and a watch is sufficient. (Remember, we are trying not to rule ourselves out based on what our interviewer believes, so keep away from anything that is not mainstream —ie; nose/chin/eyebrow/tongue rings.)

**Other Presentation and Grooming Tips**

- Have a shower, wash your hair and shave on the morning before the interview.
- Have your clothes either dry-cleaned or washed and ironed properly.
- Cut and clean nails and wear clear/pale nail polish.
- Limit the amount of perfume/aftershave/jewellery you wear.
- Have a haircut, beard trim and neck shave if needed.
- Clean, and if necessary polish shoes.
- Wear something you feel comfortable in—if you're not used to wearing a tie or makeup—don't wear it to an interview (studies have shown women who wear make-up to work get promoted more quickly).

**Body language/ Non-verbal Communication*****Do...***

- Smile.
- Maintain eye contact.
- Sit up straight.
- Slightly lean forward in chair.
- Acknowledge all people conducting interview.
- Nod when appropriate.
- Arrive 5-10 mins early.
- Give good firm handshake.

***Don't***

- Fidget, touch their desk.
- Shake your leg, flick hair, sniff, scratch.
- Yawn, look at watch at anytime.
- Slouch, lean back, cross arms/legs.
- Smoke, chew gum, swear or use slang.
- Stare, look too serious.

- Make any bodily noises.
- Appear overly nervous or rushed.

## TELL ME ABOUT YOURSELF — THE MOST COMMON QUESTION ASKED

Very often this is where we begin to give out too much information, which is exactly what the employer wants. They want to hear all the reasons why they should not hire you. Here are some dos and don'ts for answering this question. In the space below write your good answer to this question.

### Do

- Talk about skills and job qualifications.
- Talk about how you can save, or make the company money.
- Talk about community involvement which is non controversial.
- Tell them about good grades/marks, relevant education or training.
- Tell them about “the extra” you did in past jobs you enjoyed.
- Common interests.

### Don't

- Ramble.
- Talk about hobbies unless they underscore abilities needed for the job or are.
- Talk about personal problems, financial problems, recent illnesses, family issues, drug issues.
- Talk about salary requirement.
- Tell them about goals which do not benefit the company.

### Tell Me about Yourself

*For Example:* I have recently completed a Certificate III in Business at Sarina Russo Schools where I have developed advanced skills in MS Packages. Then talk about your work experience and skills.

## TYPICAL INTERVIEW QUESTIONS/GUIDE TO ANSWERS

*Be prepared to answer typical questions like:*

| Question Possible      | Answers/Suggestions                                                                                                                                                              |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tell me about yourself | They want to know about your work accomplishments and skills – not your personal life. Keep your answer to 1– 2 minutes; do not ramble, do not give your life history, summarize |



|                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Why do you want us?                                                             | your résumé, steer away from religion/politics etc.<br>Talk about how you will fit Their to work for needs; how you can make a significant contribution to specific company goals. |
| Why should we pick you for the job?                                             | Give examples of your successes, your skills that the employer would require, your knowledge, experience and abilities.                                                            |
| Why haven't you found a job by now?                                             | Finding any job is easy, finding the right job is more difficult—tell them you are being selective.                                                                                |
| Can you work under pressure or to deadlines etc?                                | Yes, it's a way of life in business—give a specific example of how you have done this.                                                                                             |
| How do you resolve conflict within your team?                                   | First, discuss the issues privately with the particular team, never get working involved in politicking.                                                                           |
| What salary/wage are you asking?                                                | Give a salary range you are comfortable with. You can find this information out on wagenet or <a href="http://www.jobsearch.ov.au">www.jobsearch.ov.au</a>                         |
| What are your weaknesses?                                                       | Don't say "none". Try to turn a negative into a positive, or talk about a weakness you had previously, but have addressed and it is no longer an issue.                            |
| What are your strengths?                                                        | Present at least 3 and relate them to the to company and jobs you are applying for.                                                                                                |
| What do you know about our company?                                             | Show that you have done your homework—have a minimum of 3 pieces of information about the company that is "I read in your annual report..." or "I noticed in your brochures..."    |
| What interests you in this job/career/industry? Why do you want to work for us? | Talk about the reputation of the company, the opportunity to start /develop your career path, the experience you gain from the company.                                            |
| Why did you leave job?                                                          | Always answer honestly,, but never your last criticise previous employers <i>e.g.</i> "I                                                                                           |

Give me an example  
of...

Realised that the career opportunities  
I was looking for were not going to  
happen with that company” or “I  
needed more of a challenge.”

Have a few examples rehearsed that  
address: customer service, dealing  
with people, team work, conflict  
resolution, your accomplishments.

## QUESTIONS TO ASK THE INTERVIEWER

During the interview, you should get the interviewer to talk at least 50% of the time. This will allow you to learn about the company, the position, your prospective supervisor and future opportunities.

You can use the information learned during the first interview to impress the employer in the second and third interviews. This information will also help you decide whether you want the job.

The following is a list of questions to ask the interviewer. Read through them and circle a couple that you may use for your job interview.

- How many employees does the company/department have?
- How long has the position been vacant?
- What would the career path be for someone starting in this position?
- Do you offer training?
- Will there be any on the job training if I am successful?
- When will I start?
- When will I find out if I am successful for this position?
- How do you think I have performed during this interview?

You may have a few more to ask, these are just some tips for you to think about. Always have at least one question to ask.

## INTERVIEW ETIQUETTES

Getting a job for the first time takes more than just education and knowledge of the industry. There are things that you need to consider when you are trying to get the job for the first time. This might be the first time that you will try to convince someone to hire you and give you a good salary. The head hunters and the human resource department will not just take a good look at your résumé and hire you immediately. The interview process is not even just about the answers you gave to your interviewer.

There are things that you should take care of and most of them are based on your movements. Remember that this is not a question and answer session with your teacher but you are pitching yourself to the interviewer. It takes more than the right answer to get through the head hunters and the interviewer.

## **EYE CONTACT**

The greatest sign of confidence when speaking with interviewers is eye contact. Every time you answer questions, look at your interviewer straight in the eye. This will tell them that you are sincere and spontaneous with your answer.

It could be that you have practiced for that question but through eye contact, you are giving a sign that you understand the question and knows how to answer that question without even thinking. But too much eye contact is of course bad. You do not have to look at them directly in the eye intently. As much as possible, your eye contact should be widened that you are actually looking at their face.

## **Posture**

Anything other than sitting and standing straight is intolerable. When asked to sit, sit up straight and when you stand up, be professional and stand up straight. Your interviewer may place his foot on top of the table but that does not mean you are given a free reign on slouching. Just sit up straight and answer the questions as professionally as possible. Although it could give an impression that you are stiff, it is better than to give an impression that you are not confident enough on your movement. When sitting, your hands should be as comfortable as possible. If you want to sit down with closed hands, you are welcome to do it. But never cross your hands in front of your chest. You do not want to be too bossy in front of your interviewer.

## **Movement and Handshakes**

During the interview, sit still as much as possible. There are times that you may want to move your hands and you are welcome to do it. But you have to move your hands to a minimal level. You do not have to move them as if you are an orchestra conductor. When everything has been done, never forget to handshake. Like every transaction that you will do in the future, a handshake will end everything professionally. Stand up straight, look at your interviewer in the eye and firmly hold their hand while during the handshake. These are the actions that you interviewer will consider and will lessen your chances of getting hired if you do not observe them.

## **ENDING THE INTERVIEW PROPERLY**

Job interviews should start good, flow better and end in the best possible way. If you are able to wrap up your interview in the best possible manner, your interviewer will easily remember you and get you picked up from the rest of the group. Wrapping up an interview in a high note is a little bit difficult. Unless the interviewer tells you it's over, you get to sit there and wait for any questions your interviewer would ask. You just got to be prepared for almost anything. But there's another technique to get the message across — ask the questions yourself. The interview will be more than happy to answer

those questions and you can use those questions as the vehicle to drive your point effectively. When the interview is on its conclusion, your interviewer may ask you if you still have any concerns. That's where you ask certain questions to easily drive your point. Questions such as the most challenging part of the job should be your vehicle to explain how you can handle such a difficult situation. Of course you have to prepare your answer before you ask that or else it will work to your disadvantage instead of boosting your chances of being hired.

There are also certain questions that you should never ask at the end of the interview or in any part of the interview for that matter. Questions about salary and benefits should be left to the salary negotiation part.

Although you and your interviewer know that you're in it for the money, you should at least show that you are dedicated enough to work and earn their respect before they offer you anything. Just wait since you'll have plenty of time to haggle for your pay during the negotiation or else you'll never reach that stage.

There are also questions that would send a message to the employer that you're interested to stay in the company for a long time. If you are able to effectively portray that message, you can get a good mark in getting that job. Ask your interviewer regarding promotions as well as the future of the department you'll most likely work for.

There are departments that could be a dead end for your career. Be honest that you are planning to be with the company for a long time and you want to improve your career ask the company and particularly the department advances.

When the interview is really wrapped up, never forget your formalities — be sure to stand up straight, moving closer a little bit for a handshake while making a direct eye-contact. These actions are actions of a professional and if you are at ease in doing these things, you should give that air of confidence without having to brag about it.

To seal the deal send a thank you letter to the interview, this will be a great follow-up to what you have talked about. If you are vying for a position that many are applying for, the thank you letter will get you remembered easily because not everyone is writing a simple thank you letter.

## **FACING THE SECOND INTERVIEW**

Your first interview was a breeze. The interviewer was impressed by the way you present yourself and how you were able to answer certain questions. As an experienced job hunter, you were able to prepare a specific answer for most questions that were thrown at you. You might have asked specific questions that have gained the interest of the interview.

But as much as you have charmed your interviewer, the job screener might not end there. There are companies who will further screen their candidates with another interview. This second interview is usually conducted by companies who are looking

for individuals to fill in a higher position. This will further screen the candidates in order for a more viable candidate for the job position. If you are applying for higher position, expect more than one or even two interviews before being selected.

### **PERSONALIZATION DURING THE SECOND INTERVIEW**

In the second interview, the screeners may ask for more specific questions. They might even pose problems and expect an instant answer for the candidates. Although this is a little bit unfair, this does happen. The company is actually testing your instincts not only as an employee but a solution provider. During the second interview, they will gauge if you are able to instinctively provide the right answer or formulate the right action steps to provide solution with the problem.

The only preparation you could do for this challenge is to review your values that you have presented during the initial interview. One of the signs that you are indeed a problem solver and a leader is consistency with your answers. Never think that since the first interviewer is not present, you could just reformulate your values. They have taken notes during the interview or have even made an extensive report regarding your experience and personality during the interview. Be consistent with your values as you apply them to problems posed by your interviewers.

### **Persons behind the Second Interview**

You may notice that I pluralized the word “persons”. Yes, they will be more than one person who will be interviewing you. Sometimes the second interview will still be one-on-one but if you are aiming for a higher position, don’t just expect to impress the hiring manager; you need to impress most of the upper management.

Expect a panel interview for your second interview. You will be scrutinized, asked bizarre questions and your values might even be challenged by the panel. If you could survive the grueling panel interview, you have just proven yourself worthy of the job. If you don’t get hired for the position, think of the 2nd interview as training for another grueling job interview in other companies.

To ace the panel interview, you just have to be calm. Sit straight so that blood will properly flow in your body, making you think better plus you’ll look professional and confident. When you are asked by an interviewer, answer them directly and look at them straight in the eye. Not only you are projecting confidence you are also projecting the capacity to work with the leaders in the industry without intimidation.

## **OVERCOMING THE OVER-QUALIFIED CLAUSE**

There are job positions that are way too easy for you. It could be because of your education experience or you have the skills that could easily tackle that situation. In short, you are over qualified for that position. Based on your education, background

and experience, you should be hired without any problem. But you didn't get the job because you're over-qualified. Instead of being happy to accommodate someone who could be in that position without any problem, they went for someone who could do the job in a satisfactory manner. Hiring managers and headhunters often are in a lookout for someone qualified for the position. That means someone should have enough education and experience and anything below and beyond that should never be hired.

### **REASONS WHY OVER-QUALIFIED CANDIDATES ARE NOT ACCEPTED**

Candidates who are over-qualified are often not hired not because of the skills but because of the attitude of the employee once he or she starts in that job position. As a position that is too easy, the over-qualified employee might get easily bored with the job. Instead of being productive for the company, the employee ended up being a burden.

The hiring managers are usually hesitant to hire someone who is over-qualified because the employee might think that he or she is too "smart" for the position and starts bragging about it. The employee might overpower the less experienced and less educated supervisor if the supervisor doesn't know how to handle superior employees.

Low salary would also cause discontent for those who are over-qualified. But this is a rare problem for over-qualified individuals because they know what they putting themselves into. But the biggest reason why hiring managers do not want to hire over-qualified individuals is the lack of loyalty. Over-qualified employees might only use the job as a temporary position while looking for a better opportunity. This is possible because the candidate has the right skills and education for a better position and they might be using the money just to make ends meet.

### **COMBATING THE OVER-QUALIFIED PROBLEM**

Setting things clear in your cover letter—before you even sit down for an interview—let the company know that you are aware of being overqualified. Clear things up that you understand that even though the company is looking for someone "less" than what you know, you are still interested with the job and could work better with lesser pay.

- *Assure them that you're OK with the pay:* you may negotiate but never ask too much. Remember that they will only hire you for specific tasks and not for your added skills and experience.
- *Be enthusiastic:* being excited about the job position is infectious. If you could demonstrate excitement for the job, the hiring manager will most likely be interested in you.

Show them your dedication to the idea of teamwork— since you are working for a lesser position, your job would always involve a team. Demonstrate your dedication as a team player by presenting situations that you were with a team and worked your way together to increase productivity.

## **INFORMATIONAL INTERVIEW**

Landing another job requires research which means a lot of information should be obtained before considering the company. The company web site, different printed materials and news regarding the company may give the data needed regarding the company. But have you ever thought of actually marching into the office of the company you are planning to work with and ask them about it? That type of information gathering is called informational interview. That type of interview might not get you the job but will give you up close and personal information regarding the company you are planning to work with. Remember that you are not looking to land a job there but rather gather some information regarding the company.

### **A Business Visit**

Compared to a job interview, you are not there to bother anyone until they give you the job that you are looking for. What you have to do is to schedule with the company so that you can talk to anyone regarding the company. You can inform them that you are considering their company for a position but you have to stress that you are not there to persuade them that you are the right person for the job. It's a totally different thing—you will be the person who will be conducting the interview and not them.

### **Come Prepared**

You don't just visit a company because you are looking to ask them some questions that pops in your mind. It's very unprofessional if you conduct an interview prepared. Sure you might have different questions to the owner or manager but those questions might be shallow. You are just wasting the manager's time as well as your time since no concrete information was asked. Bring some notes on what to ask and those questions better be related to your skills, the company's goal and objectives and their daily operations. You don't just go there and ask when was it established or how many employees they have. You will know these through different print media or those questions might not even help your career.

### **Advantages**

The greatest advantage you can get from informational interview is building a good relationship with the company. Showing your interest with the company profile is OK and would even generate interest with the company. You will not be talking about yourself but the company will be trying to explain their operations to you.

The flow of information will only come from the company you are planning to work with. But this is also a great opportunity to inject some of your personal information. You can relate their daily operations to your personal experience and your thoughts and views with the company status might be useful for the company. If you have the time, conduct an informational interview to more than one company. You can gather as many



information as you can and use them to customise your cover letter, résumé and prepare your answer to impress your future employer and increase your chances of getting hired.

## **BODY CONTROL DURING THE INTERVIEW**

Your posture will be greatly evaluated during the interview. You might have great ideas and delivered them perfectly in words but those words will be nothing if they are never reflected in your actions. Posture and body movements are the first things that will be noticed by the interviewer. Since you only have a few minutes to impress the interviewer, the first impression is very important. How you move will be a large part of your interview. You should always be conscious of your actions as they could indicate your professionalism and interest on your job.

### **MODERATION**

The key to proper movements during the interview is moderation. You can move your hands, nod your head or even move your body a little bit as long as they are done in moderation. If you don't move a lot, you'll be considered as a stiff and you'll be perceived as someone who is not open to fresh ideas. Too much movement is an indication that you are very interested in the job but you can be too aggressive for the company. Besides, too much movement might be a sign that you are just forcing your opinion.

### **SINCERITY**

From the time you enter the room, be sincere. If you don't feel like smiling or expressing yourself sincerely, don't bother showing up for the interview. When you have to smile in the introduction, do it. If you don't want to, then don't but be sure to be professional on how to handle yourself so that you'll provide a good impression. If you're not friendly try to be very professional. A short introduction and a quick "how are you" could easily break the barriers and introduce the air of friendship. Be sure to stand by what you feel and show it professionally.

### **CROSSING YOUR LEGS**

Sit down, plant your feet firmly on the ground and never cross your legs. This action is often seen as a sign of disrespect in Middle Eastern countries and during interviews, crossing of legs could easily spell disaster. It doesn't matter how good you look when you are crossing your legs. This action is a sign that you are not formal or serious regarding the interview. It is often perceived that you are not really interested and you just wanted to be in other places. Just sit down in a regular manner and you can easily establish your professional side.

## USING OF FINGERS

When you want to move your hands, move it to slowly prove your point. But never think about using your fingers to prove your point. You can point your finger anywhere but in merely using the finger you are giving a sign that you are an arrogant person and you want to force your idea no matter what. Don't expect to be hired if you point your finger to the interviewer. Not only that act is disrespectful but it's also threatening. Be conscious on how you move during the interview. It will make or break your chances of being accepted.

## HOW TO TURN SOMEONE ELSE'S MISTAKE TO YOUR ADVANTAGE

Your dream job is about to become reality. A recruiter gave you the heads up about the perfect position at Humungous Conglomerate, Inc. You went through five interviews as well as a battery of psychological tests mandated by their HR department. You passed everything with flying colours and the hiring manager told you that you were a lock for the job. Dreams of a 30% salary increase were already dancing through your head. And then came the call. You picked up the phone expecting to hear congratulations and instead the words coming through the receiver were, "I'm so sorry to have to tell you this, but we messed up."

It turns out to be a snafu on the part of the recruiter as well as the hiring manager. Company policy is to post all jobs openings internally before going outside and this wasn't done until just a few days ago. Someone from another department applied for the position and got the job today. Your dream job, stolen! This is so unfair!

How you respond now is critical. You can take the easy way out and be bitter and angry. Scream at the recruiter about how he wasted your time and how you'll never work with him again. Sit at your desk and stew about the lost opportunity and how far behind you've fallen in your work. Do any number of non-productive things out of frustration. Or you could think long term and turn this disappointment into an opportunity to help your career. You've always wanted to work for this company and now you've got your foot in the door. Not only have you made a good impression on the hiring manager and HR director (and whomever else you interviewed with), but they both should feel that they owe you a favour for the trouble you've gone through.

Take advantage of this goodwill by asking for their help. Of course, you first want to thank them for their time and the chance to interview for the job. This should be done by phone or even in person, if possible. Otherwise, an e-mail will suffice. Also, ask them to keep you in mind for any other openings that they think you'd be a good fit for.

Then follow-up with your request for a (small) favour. This could be any number of things, depending on the company and the industry you're in, but keep it small. For example, if you're a writer or editor, ask them if they would make themselves available

to be quoted in an upcoming article. If the company runs events or conferences, ask if you could get a complimentary invite to one that interests you. Or, maybe all you ask for is an introduction to a manager in another part of the company in order to extend your referral network.

Don't ask for anything unreasonable here. You're only trying to extract a tiny pearl out of this rotten oyster of a situation that didn't go your way in the first place. After you've thanked them, reminded them to think of you for other positions and asked for a small favour, remember to stay in contact with them going forward. Networking is the best way to find your next job and it's important to keep your contacts warm using a regular communication schedule. While your dream job didn't come through this time, by focusing on the positive you've gotten something out of it, gained new contacts at a great company and set yourself up for future success.

### **WHY SHOULD I HIRE YOU?**

"Why should I hire you?" This is the question that is often asked by interviewers and most especially business owners who personally talk to the candidates for the open position. If you ace this answer, you will significantly increase your chances of getting hired. Anything below that will automatically get rid of any chances of getting hired. That means never joke about this question or answer them very lightly during the interview. You are practically presenting yourself against other candidates who may or may not have answered this question in a very convincing manner.

This question is often asked by the interviewer when they already have someone in mind or just interviewed a person who is very capable to the job position available. With your answer, you will be compared to the person that has impressed them in previous interviews. Basically they are giving you a chance to impress them one more time so that you will be hired and not the other candidate.

Before you answer that question, consider this: most companies and businesses today are looking for candidates who know not just their job but also the work of others. You need to have more than one skill just to be hired today.

Aside from skills, your dedication to work should also require you to sacrifice your time just to meet deadlines and other parameters that should increase or improve the business. Also consider the candidates that were interviewed or will be interviewed. They might have the same skills as you have and could even have better qualifications than you have.

Answer this question by showing that the company will be in a better position when you are hired. Of course, you cannot promise that you will bring the company millions but you will be contributing more than enough to help in improving the company and even your co-workers.

Do not start naming your skills because they already know that and you already told them about those skills in the early part of the interview. What you will tell them then is

characteristics that will benefit the company in so many ways. Recount to them your previous experiences wherein you were able to work not only the things written in your job description but other things as well. As we have said, companies today are looking for people who will work above and beyond their work description.

Expect that this question will be asked a lot nowadays. More and more people are taking time to study to increase their competitiveness in different jobs they are applying for. Because the skills and education are practically the same in most candidates, it is the question of character that will differentiate the good ones from the better ones. So do not think that this question will only pop-out once in a while. Practice in answering this question so that when the time comes, you will be fluent and you could answer this question flawlessly. It is a very simple question but requires a very convincing answer to impress the interviewer.

## **FACING THE INTERVIEW ON THE PHONE**

Phone interview is a form of interview that allows the human resource department to weed out candidates who may not face the interview in the long run. It is a simple question and answer interview wherein facing it is no problem as long as you are disposed to answer those questions.

Getting the call from the company as a fresh graduate may be a little bit exciting but remember that the call is never an assurance that you are hired. It is another stage that you have to go through so that you can move to a more formal interview.

### **STAYING CALM**

When a company calls you, stay calm. Being excited about it is OK but you do not want to be too excited. When you hear your phone rings and the caller ID says it is from the company you want to work for, do not pick it up immediately.

Not that you want to convey that you are desperate for the job but you have to breathe first before you pick up the phone. By taking a deep breath, you will be able to calm yourself and would think clearly during the job interview. Although you are not hiding your excitement, you should calm yourself to answer the questions well.

### **TAKING NOTES**

When you are expecting a phone call, it is always recommended to have your résumé just in case they want to ask some questions about it. But you do not just bring out the résumé; you need to have an actual notepad or just a blank sheet of paper during the call. You will be asked a lot of questions and you might need to take notes during the interview. This will prevent you from forgetting the questions and ask them correctly. You will not have any second chance during the interview so you have to listen intently.

## **ONE WAY EXCHANGE OF INFORMATION**

When on the phone for an interview, expect that the interview will be all about you. During the face to face interview you may interact and listen to what they say about certain topics but this will never happen during the phone interview.

You will be bombarded with questions not only personal but also test questions. Phone interview questions are usually the same for each candidate so that they could easily gauge the answer of the candidate. Forget about talking to the interviewer regarding personal questions as this will be very inconvenient.

## **HOW TO ANSWER BASIC INTERVIEW QUESTIONS?**

Interviews are never the same but there are certain questions that will be most likely asked during the interview. That is why it is important to prepare for this type of interview because there is a great chance that you will be asked that question. The interviewers and headhunters know that you have prepared and expected to receive a well prepared answer. Anything below that is unacceptable which will lessen or even diminish your chances of being hired.

### **Tell Me about Yourself**

The current trend of interview is geared towards discussion of personal experience and views instead of answering specific, job related questions. By freely talking to the interviewer, you let your guard down and your true personality and life-view comes out. But they do have to start somewhere and that usually starts with a simple question, “tell me about yourself”. The interviewers are expecting a short and straight answer. Most call this answer as “elevator pitch” wherein you try to sell yourself to someone in as little words as possible. When asked with this question, answer in the following pattern:

- Who you are.
- What you have done.
- What you can do for the company.

By using this pattern, you set everything clear and the discussion could start with a good note about yourself. If you stick your answers and response on the elevator pitch, you will be fine.

### **What Do You know about the Company?**

You are expected to know the history of the company, the job you are trying to acquire or even the mission-vision of the company. What the interviewer is actually looking for is the delivery. Everyone could say the history of the company since they could be found online anytime. But not everyone could say it nicely. In your end, you should know how to carefully describe the company and ending the description with a good note. It is just common sense since the interviewer expects you to have a positive

outlook of the company. Research on what the company has done for the industry as this could be the perfect tool in answering that question.

### **What Can You Do for the Company?**

This is a very tough question especially for fresh graduates since they do not have any relative experience yet. To properly answer that question, the candidate should think of the mission or objectives of the company and pattern their skills and positive characteristics on those objectives. That way you will give an impression that you are a perfect candidate for the company. This answer would again require you to research more about the company in terms of their success rate and how they were able to achieve it. Tough questions should always be expected during the job interview. But any candidate could prepare for the toughest questions so that they could answer those difficult questions. Through preparation, they are increasing their chances of impressing the interviewer which in turn increase their chances of getting hired for the available job.

### **HOW TO CREATE BETTER FIRST IMPRESSION?**

First impression is very important in job interview. Think about it: you only have three to five minutes to impress your interviewer. If you start up in a really bad note, you will have a very hard time improving your image in only three minutes. First impression will set the tone of the question and answer. The disposition and mind frame of the interviewer will be greatly influenced by the first impression and usually, you can't really change that mind frame in a few minutes.

### **Everything Starts with a Question**

As soon as you settle in your chair during the job interview, you will be asked with the first question and your answer will set the tone of the rest of the interview. The common question interviewers ask is, "tell me about yourself". When asked with this question, be careful in anything that you have to say. The interviewer will take a note of everything that you say and will provide follow up questions based on what you just said. To properly answer this, you need to prepare an elevator pitch. It's a 20 to 30 second pitch which will tell who you are, what you have done and what you intend to do once hired. It is short and straight to the point. By limiting your answer, you are also limiting your mistakes. You just have to let the interviewer figure out the next questions. It's better to leave them suspended for additional information rather than to give everything and get them disappointed on your answer.

### **Posture and Dress**

Aside from what you have to say, there are also non-verbal things that you can do that might give out the wrong impression. One of those non-verbal acts is your posture. This is very basic but if you don't do it right, you will not be hired. A person's posture

says it all—your self-confidence, your ability to relate to co-workers and the way you handle work. Slouching or being too stiff is a bad way to start an interview. You just have to stay calm and sit straight. If you want to remove the pressure of being too stiff or to avoid the temptation to slouch, shake your hands and feet before you enter the interview room or before you are seen by the interviewer. That will get the blood pumping and will make you calm a little bit. Another way to have a good first impression is the way you dress. No one is asking you to wear the latest business fashion line for men and women. What is required though is that you have to have to present yourself with a clean looking and presentable business suit.

### **Handshake**

This is another verbal action that you have to take care if you want to have a good first impression. Your interviewer will most likely extend his or her hand for a handshake first and you have to reciprocate with a firm handshake. Look the interviewer straight in the eye and address him or her by the first name or have a casual greeting. Remember that the first impression is very important as this will set the tone of your interview process.

## **HOW TO ANSWER DISCRIMINATORY INTERVIEW QUESTIONS**

An interview is often conducted by a company in order to gain more information from you. There are questions that might have been answered in the résumé but companies or at least the interviewer wants to hear it from you. It is also your chance of clarifying things in your résumé so that you can impress the interview and possible gain a job offer. On the other hand, it might also become the stage where you can reveal yourself as incompetent for the job. Although this could be averted, it could be possible.

But even though the aim of interviews is to gain more information from you, there are certain boundaries during the interview that they should not cross. Among them is the type of questions they should not ask. These types of questions vary from state to state, however, they can be easily summarized into this—any questions that are not related to your job which would lead to discrimination are never allowed.

For example, you will be asked what your religion is, your political affiliation and even your physical disabilities not related to your job function. Of course, there are questions related to physical abilities that will be allowed. For example, if you are trying to become a customer service representative over the phone, you need to have at least a decent hearing ability. Fortunately, these questions are rarely asked and the ones that are asking these questions are probably inexperienced themselves. Most of the time these questions are asked out of curiosity and not really about offending you or for the purpose of offending you.



The best thing about it is that they may even apologize for that type of question or even warn you about it if they will ask you with that type of question. On the other hand, what if they do ask that question? You will of course, be placed in a dilemma since you want the job and one of the ways to get the job that you really want is to answer that question. There are two ways of politely answering this type of questions. The first option is to politely decline to answer that question and inform the interviewer that you see it as discriminating. The second option is to deal with that question is to answer that and use it as segue way for your own question.

The first option could be used if you really think that the question is really offensive while the second option could be used if you think the question was asked in good faith. But you should never go berserk just because a question has been asked. Remember that you are trying to get a job and you do not want to be set off by just a single question. Just politely inform the interviewer that you think it is discriminating and you do not want to answer the said question. The interviewer will surely be aware of this and will move on to other topics and questions.

## TYPES OF INTERVIEW

### BEHAVIOURAL INTERVIEW

A common type of job interview in the modern workplace is the behavioural interview or behavioural event interview. This type of interview is based on the notion that a job candidate's previous behaviours are the best indicators of future performance. In behavioural interviews, the interviewer asks candidates to recall specific instances where they were faced with a set of circumstances, and how they reacted.

*Typical behavioural interview questions:*

- “Tell me about a project you worked on where the requirements changed midstream. What did you do?”
- “Tell me about a time when you took the lead on a project. What did you do?”
- “Describe the worst project you worked on.”
- “Describe a time you had to work with someone you didn't like.”
- “Tell me about a time when you had to stick by a decision you had made, even though it made you very unpopular.”
- “Give us an example of something particularly innovative that you have done that made a difference in the workplace.”
- “What happened the last time you were late with a project?”

A bad hiring decision nowadays can be immensely expensive for an organization—cost of the hire, training costs, severance pay, loss of productivity, impact on morale, cost of re-hiring, etc. (Gallup international places the cost of a bad hire as being 3.2 times the individual's salary.)

### Stress Interview

Stress interviews are still in common use. One type of stress interview is where the employer uses a succession of interviewers (one at a time or *en masse*) whose mission is to intimidate the candidate and keep him/her off-balance. The ostensible purpose of this interview: to find out how the candidate handles stress.

Stress interviews might involve testing an applicant's behaviour in a busy environment. Questions about handling work overload, dealing with multiple projects, and handling conflict are typical. Another type of stress interview may involve only a single interviewer who behaves in an uninterested or hostile manner. For example, the interviewer may not make eye contact, may roll his eyes or sigh at the candidate's answers, interrupt, turn his back, take phone calls during the interview, or ask questions in a demeaning or challenging style.

The goal is to assess how the interviewee handles pressure or to purposely evoke emotional responses. This technique was also used in research protocols studying Stress and Type A (coronary-prone) Behaviour because it would evoke hostility and even changes in blood pressure and heart rate in study subjects.

The key to success for the candidate is to de-personalize the process. The interviewer is acting a role, deliberately and calculatedly trying to "rattle the cage." Once the candidate realises that there is nothing personal behind the interviewer's approach, it is easier to handle the questions with aplomb. Examples of stress interview questions:

- *Sticky situation*: "If you caught a colleague cheating on his expenses, what would you do?"
- *Putting you on the spot*: "How do you feel this interview is going?"
- *Popping the balloon*: "(deep sigh) Well, if that's the best answer you can give... (shakes head). Okay, what about this one...?"
- *Oddball question*: "What would you change about the design of the hockey stick?"
- *Doubting your veracity*: "I don't feel like we're getting to the heart of the matter here. Start again—tell me what *really* makes you tick."

Candidates may also be asked to deliver a presentation as part of the selection process. The "Platform Test" method involves having the candidate make a presentation to both the selection panel and other candidates for the same job. This is obviously highly stressful and is therefore useful as a predictor of how the candidate will perform under similar circumstances on the job. Selection processes in academic, training, airline, legal and teaching circles frequently involve presentations of this sort.

### Technical Interview

This kind of interview focuses on problem solving and creativity. The questions aim at your problem-solving skills and likely show your ability and creativity. Sometimes these interviews will be on a computer module with multiple-choice questions.

### **Telephone Interview**

Telephone Interviews take place if a recruiter wishes to dwindle down the number of prospective candidates before deciding on a shortlist for face-to-face interviews. They also take place if a job applicant is at a significant distance away from the premises of the hiring company such as abroad or in another state.

### **Case Interview**

A case interview is a job interview in which the applicant is given a question/situation/problem/challenge and asked to resolve the situation. The case problem is often a business situation or a business case that the interviewer has worked on in real life. After the applicant is given information about the case, the applicant is expected to ask the interviewer logical and sequential questions that will enable the applicant to understand the situation, probe deeper into relevant areas, gather pertinent information and arrive at a solution or recommendation for the question or situation at hand.

Case interviews are mostly used in hiring for management consulting and investment banking jobs. Firms use case interviews to evaluate analytical ability and problem-solving skills; they are looking not for a “correct” answer but for an understanding of how the applicant thinks and how the applicant approaches problems.

During case interviews, interviewers are generally looking for the following skills:

- Numerical and verbal reasoning skills.
- Communication and presentation skills.
- Business skills and commercial awareness.

Candidate's are often asked to estimate a specific number, often a commercial figure (such as market size or profitability). Candidate's are expected to demonstrate reasoning rather produce the exact answer. A case interview can also be conducted as a group exercise. Here several candidate's are given some briefing materials on a business problem and asked to discuss and agree upon a solution. The interviewers normally sit around the exterior of the room as silent observers. They assess candidates communication and interaction as well as analytical thinking and commercial awareness.

### **Informational Interview**

An informational interview is a meeting in which a job seeker asks for advice rather than employment. The job seeker uses the interview to gather information on the field, find employment leads and expand their professional network. This differs from a job interview because the job seeker asks the questions. There may or may not be employment opportunities available. The term was coined by Richard Nelson Bolles, author of the best-selling career handbook, *What Colour Is Your Parachute?* Informational interviews are initiated by the job seeker. There are many avenues the job seeker may pursue to obtain the informational interview.

Career and social networking, newspaper want ads, job boards, placement services, company web sites, human resource contacts, job search engines, and professional recruiters. While the job seeker initiates the interview, he must follow the basic guidelines for interview etiquette. He must arrive promptly, dress appropriately, prepare informational questions, and make a good first impression.

### **Exit Interview**

Interview which is conducted by an employer of a departing employee. They are generally conducted by a relatively neutral party, such as a human resources staff member, so that the employee will be more inclined to be candid, as opposed to worrying about burning bridges.

For this reason, some companies opt to employ a third party to conduct the interviews and provide feedback. The purpose of an exit interview is usually to gather data for improving working conditions and retaining employees. Common questions asked in exit interviews are, “What are your primary reasons for leaving”, “What did you find most satisfying about your job”, “What did you find most frustrating about your job”, “Were there any company policies or procedures that made your work more difficult”, etc. Many career advisers recommend treating an exit interview like a hiring interview, in that criticism of the past employer should be limited to statements about the company as a whole, rather than specific individuals.

Schools may also conduct exit interviews with students before graduation, or even as a requirement of it. This is sometimes called a graduation interview. During elections, pollsters may conduct random exit polls, though these are not required.

## **BEFORE THE INTERVIEW**

### **PREPARATION**

- *Research the company:* Web site, brochures, phone book ad, receptionist.
- *Research the job:* Receptionist, job contact.
- Plan your transport.
- Have the Exact address.
- *Practice your questions:* Job, company, direction.
- *Practice your answers:* Tell me about yourself, what do you bring to the job.
- *Plan what you’re going to wear 2 days before:* Iron it and put it All on to make sure.
- *Have your paperwork ready in your portfolio:* Spares of everything, clean.
- *Get up to speed on current affairs:* Read the headlines for couple of days.
- *Know the name and pronunciation of the interviewer along with position title:* Who are they and how do they fit into the picture, anybody else.

**PUNCTUALITY**

*Give yourself plenty of time to:*

- Arrive.
- Refresh and gather your thoughts.
- Revive.
- Read over your notes and résumé.

**PRESENTATION**

- *Clothes:* Neat, clean, ironed and appropriate for position.
- *You:* Be well groomed and confident. Carry a comb or brush with you and freshen up prior to going into the interview.
- *Résumé:* Make sure your résumé is on clean paper and NOT creased or folded.
- Ensure the information is presented in an appealing, easy to read way and that is correct.
- If you are in any way concerned that you may be late, call the Employer and notify them.

**DRESS FOR AN INTERVIEW**

*Remember:* First impression is last. If you look good, you will feel good.

**MALES**

- Business suit.
- Dark business shoes—remember to polish.
- Business shirt.
- Professional tie (leave the one with cartoons on it at home).
- Dark socks (match trousers and shoes, keep the cartoon birthday socks for BBQs).
- Neat haircut (if you have long hair, tie it back).
- Clean shaven (if you have a beard make sure it is trimmed).
- Trousers, business shirt and tie are acceptable if you do not have a business suit.
- Be careful not to use too much aftershave.

**FEMALES**

- Business suit (skirt/ trousers and jacket).
- Court shoes—remember to polish.
- Neat haircut (if you have long hair, tie it back).
- Remove chipped nail polish.
- Make-up (perhaps arrange to have a make-up consultation).

- Stockings (if wearing a skirt).
- Skirt/trousers and a business shirt are acceptable if you do not have a business suit.
- Keep jewellery to a minimum.
- Be careful not to use too much perfume.

## **PREPARING FOR AN INTERVIEW**

### **BEFORE INTERVIEW**

Arrive approx 10 minutes early. This gives you time:

- To gather your thoughts.
- To check your appearance.
- To ensure you are at the right address.

Introduce yourself to the receptionist. Remember, their assessment of you starts as soon as you enter their premises. You must always be polite and friendly.

### **YOU SHOULD GIVE TO THE RECEPTIONIST**

- Your name and the time of your appointment.
- The name of the person going to interview. If you don't know it, ask the receptionist!

Thank the receptionist, wait quietly and:

- Be careful how and where you sit.
- Be ready for the interviewer.

### **GREET THE INTERVIEWER**

- The interview has now started so make a good impression. Be ready to shake hands and introduce yourself.

You must:

- Be alert and quick to respond to the interviewer.
- Be mindful of your smile, your handshake and how you move.

### **Enter the Interviewer's Office and**

- Do not sit down until you have been invited to do so.
- If you have a choice, sit about an arms length from the interviewer's desk.

### **Watch the Way You Sit and be Careful of Your Posture**

- Do not lean on the desk or on the arms of the chair.
- Sit up straight, don't slouch, don't lean back and don't fold your arms.
- Do not put anything on the interviewer's desk until it is 'tabled'.
- Remember to keep smiling and be friendly.

- Avoid nervous habits.
- Do not play with your fingernails.
- Keep your hands off your ears, hair, beard and collar.
- Do not play with your jewellery.
- Never tap your fingers or feet on anything.

**Remember, Once You are in There and the Interview Proper has Started**

- Volunteer positive information only—never anything negative.
- Stress your good points eg skills, qualities, experiences.
- Do not talk about what you cannot do or what training you need.
- Answer the interviewer's questions as you have rehearsed.

Do not smoke, even if you are invited to. Don't chew lollies, chewing gum. Only accept a glass of water or a cup of tea or coffee if the interviewer is having one.

**At the End of the Interview**

- Be ready to ask suitable questions.
- Summarize your qualifications and suggest that the interviewer contacts your referees.
- Tell that you are very interested in the job.
- If the interviewer offers you the job accept it then and there.
- Thank them for the interview and don't ramble on.

## **APPLICATIONS, RESUMES AND INTERVIEWS WHY THEY GO TOGETHER**

It is time to apply for jobs again. You might be fed up with your current job, unemployed, recently graduated, or in any number of situations, however you have decided it is time to start looking for employment and you are just beginning to realise that it takes hard work and dedication to find a good job. You will almost always need to submit an application for the particular position, a current résumé, other information like transcripts, and then you simply wait for the interview. However, does your job application and résumé have any effect on whether you are called back for an interview or not?

The answer is absolute! If you are truly interested in getting a job then you need to be able to make it through the first round which is simply reviewing applications and résumés.

If your application and résumé do not make a good impression then you can forget an interview. So, read the following information on job applications, résumés, and interviews and you will be better prepared to apply for jobs and more than likely increase your call backs.



## **JOB APPLICATIONS**

What job are you applying for? With which company? What is your experience level? And how much do you want to get paid? These are all questions that are frequently asked on a job application. Additionally, your full name, address, phone number, social security number, past employers, and other questions appear on job applications. The big question here is how well do you fill out these job applications? Do you answer all the questions? Or, do you leave a couple blank or many? No matter what you normally do you will learn now what you should do.

All questions on job applications should be answered fully and correctly. This means that every question must receive a response even if it is simply to write “not applicable”. If you leave a question blank then potential employers will wonder why. They might assume you did not understand the question, wanted to hide the answer, or simply rushed through the application. None of these assumptions, even if they are just that, win you any points with future employers. So, what can you do to avoid this? The answer is as simple as responding to all the questions on a job application. Doing this will show the potential employer that you understood all questions and are interested in making all information known.

Amazingly, many job applicants continue to only partially fill out their job applications and wonder why they are not getting called back for interviews or job offers. The reason is because if applicants cannot properly fill out a job application most employers toss the application in the trash because they are showing they don’t take the job seriously or that they are not qualified for the position. As a result, if you are applying for a job and must fill out a job application as the vast majority of individuals will be required to do make sure that it is filled out correctly, honestly, and completely.

## **RESUMES**

In addition to job applications many employers will request a résumé. Basically, a résumé has your personal information including contact information, skills, educations, past jobs, and even a salary history. Of course, there are many types of résumés and you will be required to submit the type that is requested by the potential employer. Make sure you are aware what type this is because if you submit any old résumé and a specific type is requested then you can be sure you won’t win any points with the potential employer. So pay attention to the application requirements, the type of résumé you need, and how to submit it. All of this information is important and should be paid close attention to.

For example, if an employer is accepting résumés via e-mail and you send one in the mail, by fax, or drop a copy off then the employer will feel as if you don’t know who to follow directions or don’t care about them and will probably toss your résumé and application. Submitting a résumé and application is just as important as how you submit them, so keep this in mind. Also, submitting your résumé and application properly will

be the best way to ensure you get an interview. Many times individuals won't get an interview after they have submitted everything properly just because they don't meet the requirements for the job, however you can forget getting an interview if you don't properly submit the information requested.

## **INTERVIEWS**

If you manage to get an interview then you should be pleased because you made it through the first round. That means that your application and résumé were submitted correctly and that the potential employer found something in the information you provided that was of interest and possibly qualified you for the position.

However, once you get called in for the interview you can plan on lots of questions and a personal evaluation to see how you measure up. All of the questions in the interview will be used to see how you respond under pressure and your answers will be compared to the job requirements as well as the other applicants. Then, if you make it through the first interview and are the best applicant you might be offered the job, or else invited for a second interview.

As you can see, the entire process of applying for a job from submitting your application and résumé to going for the interview has a direct impact on whether or not you are considered for the job. So, if you are really serious about getting a job make sure you take all of the processes seriously and you will increase your chances of getting that job you have been dreaming of.

# Business Communication and Information Technology

Business communication is the sharing of information between people within an organisation that is performed for the commercial benefit of the organisation. It can also be defined as relaying of information within a business.

## OVERVIEW

Business communication (or simply “communication”, in a business context) encompasses topics such as marketing, brand management, customer relations, consumer behaviour, advertising, public relations, corporate communication, community engagement, reputation management, interpersonal communication, employee engagement, and event management. It is closely related to the fields of professional communication and technical communication.

Media channels for business communication include the Internet, print media, radio, television, ambient media, and word of mouth. Business communication can also refer to internal communication that takes place within the organisation. Business communication is a common topic included in the curricula of Undergraduate and Master programmes of many colleges and universities. There are several methods of business communication, including:

- Web-based communication for better and improved communication, anytime anywhere...

- Video conferencing which allow people in different locations to hold interactive meetings;
- Reports are important in documenting the activities of any department;
- Presentations are very popular method of communication in all types of organisations, usually involving audiovisual material, like copies of reports, or material prepared in Microsoft PowerPoint or Adobe Flash;
- Telephone meetings, which allow for long distance speech;
- Forum boards, which allow people to instantly post information at a centralized location; and
- Face-to-face meetings, which are personal and should be succeeded by a written followup.
- Suggestion box, it is mainly for upward communication as because some people may hesitate to communicate to the management directly so they can give suggestion by drafting suggestion in suggestion box.

## **EFFECTIVE BUSINESS COMMUNICATION**

A two way information sharing process which involves one party sending a message that is easily understood by the receiving party. Effective communication by business managers facilitates information sharing between company employees and can substantially contribute to its commercial success.

### **FACE-TO-FACE**

Face-to-face communication helps to establish a personal connection and will help sell the product or service to the customer. These interactions can portray a whole different message than written communication as tone, pitch, and body language is observed. Information is easier to access and delivered immediately with interactions rather than waiting for an e-mail or phone call.

Conflicts are also easily resolved this way, as verbal and non-verbal cues are observed and acted upon. Communicating professionally is very important as one is representing the company. Speak clearly and ask questions to understand the needs and wants, let the recipient respond as one resolves the issue. Decisions are made more confidently during a face-to-face interaction as the recipient asks questions to understand and move forward with their decision.

### **E-MAIL**

When using e-mail to communicate in the business world, it is important to be careful with the choice of words. Miscommunication is very frequent as the reader doesn't know what non-verbal cues one is giving off, such as the pitch, tone, or expressions. Before beginning an e-mail, make sure the e-mail address one is using is appropriate

and professional as well as the message one is going to send. Again, make sure the information is clear and to the point so the recipient isn't confused. Make sure one includes their signature, title, and other contact information at the end.

### **Telephone**

When making a business call, make it clear who is on the line and where one is from as well as one's message when on the phone. Smile and have a positive attitude as the recipient will be able to read the caller and that will affect how they react. When leaving a message, make sure one is clear and brief. One should state their name and who they are and the purpose for contacting them. If replying to a voice-mail, try to respond as soon as possible and take into consideration the time of day. Don't call too early or too late, as it is important to respect other's time. Also be mindful of where one is and the noise level as well as the people one is around when trying to reach someone by phone.

When making a sales call, hope for the person one are trying to connect to does not answer the phone. Leave up to five enticing messages and one's target audience will be ready to speak when one either gets a call back or one calls and reaches the person.

The enticing message prepares the person to speak to the representative. It may be that the person is not interested based on what one had said in each voice message. Always be polite and accept that one may have many more to call. If the individual is reached, one might ask if there might be someone better suited for the advertised programme. If one is calling and leaving voice messages, include time of availability for callbacks. There is nothing worse than a callback coming to one when one is not available. Use the telephone as a great communication tool. Be polite and always put oneself in the other person's position.

### **Listening**

When listening to another employee or customer speak it is very important to be an avid listener. Here are some obstacles that you might have to overcome:

- Filters and Assumptions
- Biases and Prejudices
- Inattention and Impatience
- Surrounding Environment

A good way to overcome these factors is by using LOTS Better Communication method. This method includes four steps in order to produce good listening skills and the ability to respond with an educated statement.

The four steps to this method are:

- Listen
- Observe
- Think
- Speak

Doing all of these things while showing good eye contact and body posture will assure the speaker that he/she is getting full attention from the listeners.

### **CHOOSING COMMUNICATION MEDIA**

When choosing a media of communication, it is important to consider who are the respective audience and the objective of the message itself. Rich media are more interactive than lean media and provide the opportunity for two-way communication: the receiver can ask questions and express opinions easily in person.

### **Subliminal Method of Communication**

Subliminal perception refers to the individual ability to perceive and respond to stimuli that are below the threshold or level of consciousness, which proved to influence thoughts, feelings or actions altogether or separately. There are four distinct methods of communicating subliminally.

These are visual stimuli in movies, accelerated speech, embedded images in a print advertisement, and suggestiveness which is not normally seen at first glance. Focussing on Subliminal Communication through visual stimuli, Marketing people have adopted this method even incorporating it films and television shows. Subliminal method of communication first made its debut in a 1957 advertisement, during which a brief message flashed, telling viewers to eat popcorn and drink Coca-Cola.

Since that time, subliminal communication has occupied a controversial role in the advertising landscape, with some people claiming it's omnipresent, while others emphasize it's not real.

As of publication, there is still an ongoing scientific debate about whether subliminal advertising works. Subliminal messaging is a form of advertising in which a subtle message is inserted into a standard ad. This subtle message affects the consumer's behaviour, but the consumer does not know she's seen the message. For example, a marketer might incorporate a single frame telling consumers to drink tea in a movie. In print media, advertisers might put hidden images or coded messages into ad text.

### **Arguments for Effectiveness**

A 2009 study at the University College of London found that people were especially likely to be affected by negative subliminal communication. For example, a cosmetic advertisement conveying to a consumer that she is ugly might be more effective. Subliminal ads "prime" the brain to seek out stimuli that match the message in the advertisement, according to a 1992 study published in "Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin." This can affect behaviour, particularly when a message addresses an individual's insecurities or behavioural tendencies and when a consumer is in a context that allows her to act on the ad's message.

## ORGANISATIONS

- Founded in 1936 by Shankar with the Association for Business Communication (ABC), originally called the Association of College Teachers of Business Writing, is “an international organisation committed to fostering excellence in business communication scholarship, research, education, and practice.”
- The IEEE Professional Communication Society (PCS) [2] is dedicated to understanding and promoting effective communication in engineering, scientific, and other environments, including business environments. PCS’s academic journal, is one of the premier journals in Europe communication. The journal’s readers are engineers, writers, information designers, managers, and others working as scholars, educators, and practitioners who share an interest in the effective communication of technical and business information.
- The Society for Technical Communication is a professional association dedicated to the advancement of the theory and practice of technical communication. With membership of more than 6,000 technical communicators, it’s the largest organisation of its type in North America.

## THE COMMUNICATION PROCESS

### REASONS FOR COMMUNICATING

If we were to ask a small group of business people to list reasons for needing to communicate with their customers, we might anticipate responses such as these: to sell a product or idea, to inform about some feature of a product or of the business itself, to build better customer relations, to stimulate interest in a product or issue. As diverse as these reasons may appear, communication specialists recognise two broad categories in which people engage in communications: to inform and to persuade. Even though we will attempt to deal with these as two separate categories, the distinction between them often will become cloudy and ill defined. Nonetheless, in order to provide a convenient point to begin this discussion, we will assume this two-point classification. To understand the distinction between communications that inform and those that persuade, recognise that we become familiar with a novel issue in two stages: knowledge acquisition and attitude formation.

### Knowledge

In the first step, a receiver obtains knowledge about a topic. This knowledge may be complete, in which case all information about the subject is successfully acquired by the receiver. It is more likely, however, that information the receiver obtains will be incomplete in some details. This may be a result of insufficient information supplied to the receiver (the message is not complete), inadequate attention of the receiver to the



message (the receiver selectively disregards information), or a combination of both. Apart from incomplete information, a more troublesome condition exists from the communicator's viewpoint: A receiver's knowledge base may contain incorrect information or information that is, in some way, distorted. Here, as in the previous category, the trouble may lie in the message or the receiver.

Each can affect the accuracy of knowledge in one of two ways. First, information in the knowledge base (sent by the source) may omit relevant details from story accounts, presenting only one side of an issue.

For example, in a congressional newsletter, we may learn that our representative voted to reduce federal taxes, suggesting we have great reason to celebrate. But we are not told this action will require an increase in state and local taxes. Compensation for reductions in federal revenue sharing (necessitated by the tax cut) will force tax hikes in other areas. We have learned only the good news—none of the bad—and so have not been given the entire story.

A second form of information distortion may simply be an inaccuracy of some sort—a lie, a factual error, or a faulty representation or interpretation. In addition, inaccurate information may be a product of distortion or exaggeration or a characterisation of details that are out of their correct proportion. For instance, the old “fish story” often has an accurate foundation—someone really did net a fish—only in the telling of the story, the fish may have acquired new and impressive dimensions. The public communicator struggles to modify such distortions because they contain an element of truth particularly resistant to correction. Fundamentally they are correct; factually they are distorted and inaccurate.

In these cases, messages bear information that may be distorted or wrong. The message source may err or intentionally deceive the audience and so present faulty information. If receivers are naive and have no basis on which to refute the inaccuracy, they may accept it as fact, thus contaminating their knowledge base. But the source of inaccurate knowledge often may be the receiver him- or herself, who, through processes of selective perception outlined earlier, may deliberately or unwittingly distort information that becomes part of this knowledge base. We like to believe that what we know is accurate and true, and often, in order to maintain that conviction, modify incoming information to conform to our preconceptions.

If we strongly support one team in a football game, we may “see” many fouls by the other team that go unrecognised by referees. We may recognise bad manners only by the other candidate in a political debate. We may hear nothing but sweet music in our own children's recitals. Our knowledge base, what we understand to be true, is constructed not only by input from outside messages, which may or may not be accurate, but from our own perceptions born of what we already hold to be true. It takes a skillful public communicator to change the knowledge base of receivers who are committed to a position and believe that what they know is accurate.

## Attitudes

Knowledge is the precondition for attitude formation, a second feature of receiver response to an issue or event. Once we know about something, we tend to form attitudes about it. They may be subtle, ill-formed, and weak attitudes, but nonetheless they represent our inclinations, dispositions, and evaluative feelings towards a subject. Understand several features of attitude formation: First, attitudes need not be articulated to exist. We do not need to state or even to recognise consciously our attitudes about a product or person before we act on them. We often buy one product instead of another not because we have explicated our feelings about the relative advantages of each, but because of some faint likes or dislikes that subtly bring us to make a selection. We may vote for a candidate because of some vague, ill-formed impression rather than for well developed and rational reasons.

Second, attitudes often are formed with incomplete information. Most of us have neither the need nor the desire to construct our attitudes from complete information that guarantees objectivity and rigour. Occasionally, for important decisions that have serious implications, we may become more analytical and thorough. But even in these instances, we terminate our investigation once we are comfortable with an evolving attitude. From this point forth, through the processes of selective exposure and selective perception, we seek out and interpret information that confirms the attitude. In this sense, we often deprive ourselves of valid and significant information that would otherwise contribute to an objective and rational process of attitude formation. Few of us are so temperate as to keep a completely open mind, particularly on matters about which we hold strong convictions.

The third feature of attitude formation derives: Attitude formation is not often a conscious process that we approach in a logical, orderly manner. At times we may prepare to make a major decision by consciously seeking and evaluating information from many sources that contribute to a sound, well-reasoned judgement. But most of our attitudes, particularly those about less-pressing issues, are shaped over time through slow, ongoing processes that often take place beyond our recognition. There is an important lesson in this for public communicators. While we may develop an uncontrollable enthusiasm for our product, we can rarely expect public audiences to share our excitement—either about the product or about the messages dealing with our product. Attitude formation often occurs subliminally and incrementally. People do not always seek information on which to base an attitude. Often such information must be imposed on them. A casual exposure to a message, a glimpse at the product on a store shelf, a passing conversation—all contribute to developing attitudes.

While we have argued that attitude formation is often a slow, passive activity, at times people approach matters with surprising enthusiasm. When people perceive something to be important or to have some recognisable utility, they become more active in the information-seeking process and develop more acute sensitivities to

messages dealing with the issue. People in the market for a new automobile or appliance, or who are planning a vacation, often develop an interest in the array of possibilities and seek out information that will enable them to make an informed choice.

This characteristic response to issues of perceived significance suggests a technique through which the public communicator may make an impact on listless audiences. First, elevate the perceived importance of an issue. Show the audience how this matter relates directly to them. Cultivate within the audience a perception of personal relevance and concern for the topic. Then, proceed to deal with the substantive issues. For example, the large federal deficit has long escaped the concern of average Americans. In order to generate support for budgetary reform, a political candidate first must demonstrate how the deficit impacts, or will impact, on the average voter. Only then can the candidate get on with the job of convincing people about what should be done about the problem. This characteristic response to issues of perceived significance opens a wide range of opportunities through which the public communicator may make a substantial impact on intended audiences. Accordingly, the initial strategies of many communication campaigns may be to elevate the perceived importance of an issue and thus cultivate among audience members a need to become more active in the information-seeking process.

## **ELEVATING THE SALIENCE OF AN ISSUE**

A recurring fantasy of many business communicators is to have customer audiences aggressively seek information about their products. Expectations, of course, are that with skillful management of the communication programme, enthusiasm for information will translate into demand for the product or service. Many businesses, however, face the formidable task of stimulating among potential audiences an initial interest in the product and in messages that advance that product. We will deal with this issue from several viewpoints throughout this book, but will begin with a discussion of agenda setting in order to place these matters into a larger context.

### **Agenda Setting**

Our daily schedules are a mosaic of issues and events that demand our attention. Many of these are personal: a dreaded visit to the dentist, ways to occupy a houseful of visiting relatives, balancing our checkbooks. A large number of issues, though, come from beyond our immediate personal domains. What is the Soviet policy towards arms control? How can we manage the acid rain problem? What teams will make it to the Super Bowl this year? Generally, for those matters beyond our personal experiences, the media serve as the primary sources of information. What we read, see, and hear through the mass media factor into the array of items on our daily agenda. Agenda setting is really about the competition for our attention. At times a personal concern

may become so compelling that we find little time or energy to deal with anything else. A single world event of major proportion may diminish the significance of all other events, intruding even on our personal lives.

The assassination of a president, explosion of a space shuttle, and core meltdown at a nuclear power station are so important and so preoccupy the agendas of population members that by comparison all other matters shrink. Except for circumstances where one or two events may dominate the agenda, we typically establish, among all the issues with which we must deal, an informal ordering according to their perceived importance. Then we apportion our energies in dealing with them. Increasingly, the media are playing an important role in this process, not only by revealing topics that may be included in agendas, but by suggesting a weighting for the topics. Thus, they propose a rank order of importance. Considerable evidence substantiates that the media agenda serves as a model for individual agendas and, by extension, public agendas. Front page, top of the news, lead item stories become leads on the public agenda.

Personal items factor prominently into the overall agendas of an individual, and a history of personal tastes and interests is important in how one perceives the relevance and importance of ongoing events. There is not, however, a one-to-one correspondence between the media and personal agendas. The media serve rather as cuing agents.

They suggest the relative importance of issues and events occurring outside the individual's scope of observation. Depending on individual characteristics and personal concerns, a person's agenda will usually reflect priorities suggested by the media. For public communicators to influence desired audience members, therefore, they must compete for placement on personal agendas by establishing the importance of a product or service. The ultimate goal is to get on the agenda and therefore be worthy of the individual's consideration.

Towards this end, one strategy is to demonstrate the importance of a product, candidate, or issue at the personal level, thus exhibiting its significance among the things with which the individual must deal in his or her personal life. For instance, a communication campaign for microcomputers may attempt to demonstrate that such equipment will help a business person to do more work in less time, thus freeing him or her to spend more time with friends and family. The campaign implies that consideration of the microcomputer belongs on the personal agenda.

Depending on the nature of the product or service, the communicator may find it useful to link information in the campaign with issues beyond those of immediate personal utility. Demonstrating that a political candidate will help build the image of a community may have no direct usefulness to an individual, but it may be important in a larger sense of community pride. People do have concerns and interests that exceed their personal worlds. Getting on their agendas may be accomplished by demonstrating the importance of an issue among all issues competing for their attention, even those without direct personal implications.

The notion of agenda setting helps us to conceptualize how people view issues worthy of their concern and, moreover, how they establish a priority among those items. From the public communicator's viewpoint, it provides a usable description of a process instrumental in developing strategies to inform or persuade. People enter on their agendas things they feel are important or useful. In order to be considered by an audience, then, a product or service must be portrayed as having some significance.

### **Specific Techniques**

A variety of techniques, applied under appropriate circumstances, may enhance the perceived importance of an issue. First, we may portray an issue to be important to others and, through inference or direct claims, assert a logic that will compel target audience members to acknowledge personal importance. People evaluate themselves by observing others. Recognition that an individual's comparison group has adopted a prescribed attitude or has engaged in some recommended behaviour will probably suggest importance. Simply that other people are paying attention to an issue implies an inherent significance. If those with whom we identify find value in something, then we, too, may wish to examine it further.

Advertisers have used this technique with considerable success. Among the best examples are television political advertisements in which a candidate is shown speaking before throngs of adoring onlookers. Political conventions capitalize on this technique with camera shots of clamoring thousands enthusiastically supporting positions aired from the podium. The message in these cases is clear: Here are casts of thousands—made up of people just like you—who see great merit in these issues and in this candidate.

If they recognise something important here, shouldn't you? Perhaps, upon inspection, these issues will hold some significance for the audience member, but at this point that conclusion is unimportant. This is only an initial step in the strategy to establish the legitimacy of the issue and to create the perception that something here is important enough to merit further attention. Remember at this point we are employing a tactic that will enable us to enhance the importance of a topic, to place it on personal agendas. Characterizing a topic as important to comparison groups is only one of several approaches to establishing the significance of an issue. Another widely used tactic involves the linkage between something we wish to promote and something already important to audience members. We then equate our issue with one already installed on individual agendas. Successful use of this technique can establish the prominence of an issue within a short time. Consider a recent example in which medical research confirmed the role of calcium in preventing osteoporosis.

News of this discovery spread quickly. Because of its importance to public health, it has achieved a prominent place on personal agendas. Little was required to "promote" the significance of this information, given its inherent value to this health-conscious society. The lesson in this example, however, is found during the months that followed

the revelation. Advertisers sought to demonstrate a linkage between the calcium content of their products and the now-recognised dietary importance of calcium. Vitamin companies, milk and cheese producers, and manufacturers of prepared foods that use high-calcium ingredients made bold claims in their advertisements.

They touted the health benefits of their products. In print and broadcast media, advertisements stated the virtues of calcium, then tied a specific product to the issue. Implications of such strategies are evident. While audiences may not have thought much about grated cheese before, if they think calcium intake is important—and we now all know it certainly must be—then they must also think cheese is important. The association between the product and the larger issue is evident.

A third design often used to establish a sense of the importance of an issue is a two-stage process involving first the creation of the perception of a need (where none already exists) and then identification of the product or service that can gratify this need. One might argue that audience members will see the logic of paying attention to something once they have been impressed with the need it is designed to satisfy. Through this approach, one creates a need where it had not existed before. People who, for their entire lives, have gotten along without a product or service must be convinced that they cannot now live without it. Although such an approach is often difficult, time consuming, and subject to problems, it does have a reasonable history of success.

An example is found in the burgeoning microcomputer industry that discovered an important first step in its marketing strategy: to convince small business owners they needed a microcomputer to maintain their competitive edge. Since the beginning of time, though, businesses have been run, many of them very successfully, without computers.

The industry, consequently, had to create the perception of a need for computers before it could mass market its innovation. Because of successful development of this perception, acceptance by a few early adopters, affordable prices, and other support marketing schemes, computers have in a short time—fewer than six or seven years—become as commonplace in offices as typewriters. With such a revolutionary innovation, one that had so few precursors that could have prepared an audience, it was essential that potential adopters become stimulated to recognise a need.

There are, of course, a wide range of needs that may serve the purposes. The computer example describes a professional need to improve efficiency and remain competitive. But there are personal needs, too, that may be examined. For instance, consider the need to be informed about a topic (which perhaps may serve even deeper needs, such as the needs for self-esteem and the respect of others). Promoters of news magazines, adult education courses, and self-instruction computer software often suggest the need for a person to be knowledgeable about a given issue. Audience members may never have considered purchasing such a product until they were convinced of their need to be informed about issues or events.



Successful use of this technique stimulates audiences to recognise their need for information, then proposes a specific product as an answer to that need. Professional and personal needs are among many that have been used in recent campaigns. Scores of others include those based on stimulation of social, physical, and psychological categories of needs.

Need stimulation generally includes the early phases of product promotion, but alone cannot sustain public attention in a product or service. Assuming audiences recognise a genuine need for a product or service (and do not ultimately conclude there is no real need where one was suggested), other communication and promotional activities must be employed to continue audience interest and attention. Although need stimulation techniques may continue as part of an ongoing strategy, they are most effective in the early stages of a campaign to elevate on public agendas the merits of an issue.

The communication process where perceptions are elevated sufficiently to render an issue worthy of audience consideration—in other words, to enter the issue onto the audience agenda. Paraphrasing previous writings on agenda setting, this phase of the communication process is designed to suggest not what audiences should think, but what they should think about. Messages in this phase do not attempt to inform or to motivate as much as they attempt to suggest the issue is worthy of a person's attention.

Only after the relative importance of an issue has been recognised by audiences and has drawn their attention can the communicator begin to instruct and to persuade.

## **DIRECT MAIL**

Direct mail has become increasingly important as a means of audience contact. We discuss direct mail only briefly in this section, but will take a more detailed look, at how it can be used in a public communication campaign.

It is easy to obtain usage statistics on the mass media since there are only a relatively few outlets. Over the years industry watchers have gathered reliable and detailed information on how people use radio and television and even the eleven thousand magazines currently in publication. Direct mail statistics are more difficult to assemble. Every business, agency, and organization serves as its own outlet. While there may be hundreds or thousands of media channels, there are millions of direct mail channels, making it impossible to compile specific usage information. Direct mail usage is therefore based on assumptions and extrapolations, and even compilers of these statistics caution that there is a reasonable margin of error in the data.

Nonetheless, the DMA has attempted to track the use of direct mail based in part on U.S. Postal Service reports. Over the years there has been a steady increase in the mailing technique. Between 1982 and 1985, there was a 40 per cent increase in the total number of direct mail pieces. In 1985 the DMA reports there were more than 55 billion



direct mailings within the United States and 16 million from the United States to overseas destinations. From these figures it is evident that direct mail is becoming increasingly popular among U.S. companies and organizations. They are using direct mail to get their messages across to voters, consumers, and supporters.

They are sending letters, brochures, fliers, coupons, and dozens of other forms to convince, cajole, inform, and stir people about issues of all sorts. Direct mail picks up where the mass media leave off. Direct mail provides targeted and personal contact with audiences. Computers, sophisticated mailing lists, and other technological advancements have made direct mail a convenient and affordable way to reach specific audience members. It enables communicators to shape their messages to meet individual needs.

An effective communication programme must account for all essential elements of the communication process. Occasionally, a seat-of-the-pants campaign brings about the intended education or persuasion of an audience, but such examples are few and far between. The mass communication process has become far too complex in recent times to allow campaigns based on a hunch to have much success. With the expanded array of available media options, exposure patterns of audiences have become more complicated and difficult to pinpoint by intuition.

The vast array of messages competing for attention diminishes the probability that audiences will recognize any one of them and that, by even a smaller chance, the message will have an intended effect on individuals. One observer estimates the average American is exposed to some sixteen hundred commercial messages per day but notices only eighty of them. Only twelve of these messages, Parker says, elicit any response at all from the recipient. In order to be among the fortunate few to win the notice of an audience, communicators must draw from a variety of techniques to improve their chances in the competitive information marketplace.

The complexity of media exposure patterns and competition for audience attention present obstacles that some public communicators are willing to concede when they conduct a seat-of-the-pants campaign. Most acknowledge the inadequacy of such an approach, however, when faced with current message production and placement charges. Production and distribution of messages are expensive.

Radio spots may cost several hundreds to several thousands of dollars to produce. A thirty-second radio spot aired during drive time in an average city may cost as much as four hundred dollars or more. Television spot production has run as high as several hundred thousand dollars for a thirty-second network-quality advertisement, although the average is a little under \$100,000.

Smaller television stations may charge several hundred to several thousand dollars to air a thirty-second spot during prime time, and for the same time slot, networks typically charge between \$150,000 and \$200,000. Of course, for special programmes, network rates can be even more shocking.

## THE SMCR MODEL

### The Competition for Audiences

In a poorly planned public communication programme, not only does the communicator stand to miss the audience entirely, either because of a poor selection of media or inadequate message preparation, but also, given the sizable charges for time and space, he or she may waste money in the process. Recognizing this waste compels business and political communicators to abandon seat-of-the-pants strategies.

Over the years a good deal of practical experience, field research, and academic study have unfolded essential components of the communication process that serve to guide the business communicator in making intelligent decisions.

They assist the communicator in asking appropriate questions about the audience, media, issues at hand, and goals for the communication programme. Informed strategies enable the communicator to see important links among these components and the interrelationships that serve to explain how the manipulation of one component affects other components. A useful starting point for an examination of the communication process is with the Berlo model, which records four principal components inherent in nearly all communication scenarios: a Source, a Message, a Channel, and a Receiver (SMCR).

Certainly this is communication in its most basic form. A source sends a message through some kind of channel to a receiver. Who says what, how, and to whom? Nearly every communication event, no matter how simple or complex, involves these four components. This elementary model is fundamentally simple yet beguilingly complex. It is accurate yet, it is not complete. Basic communication students study this model to gain an understanding of communication. We will use it here as a paradigm for complex public communication strategies.

### The Source

The source, which in a majority of cases will be the company, spokesperson, or political candidate, is that individual or group who is perceived by a receiver as the originator of the message. Who does the receiver think is the source of a message?

For instance, when Bill Cosby performs E. F. Hutton's television commercials, there is a strong likelihood that Bill Cosby is considered by most television viewers to be the source of the message—not the investment firm.

A senatorial candidate may hire a speech writer during a campaign, but when the candidate delivers that speech, he or she will be perceived by the audience to be the source of that message, not the speech writer.

Perceptions of the receiver, then, are critical in discussions of the source. Despite those who may be behind the scenes of a public communication, it is essential to consider audience perceptions of who the source may be.

Audience notions about the source are no small matter in the public communication process. The image projected by that source, as a composite of physical appearance, voice, demeanor, and more, may be the most critical feature of the entire communication event. That image determines the message acceptance by and the impact on an audience. A source that comes across well to audience members will promote attention and enhance the persuasiveness of the message. A source that fails to appeal to the intended audience will yield poor results.

Perhaps because the importance of the source has long been known to public communicators, a good deal of research in past years has focused on the characteristics associated with an effective source.

Specifically, these studies have asked what makes a source believable to an audience and what enhances the capacity of that source to persuade an audience to accept the message. What is it that makes a source credible to an audience?

Although we will provide an in-depth examination for the purposes of this introduction we will note that in most studies three component parts constitute source credibility: trustworthiness, expertise, and charisma.

Trustworthiness deals with the inherent faith and confidence audience members place in the source. First, the source that does not have a stake in an issue and so stands to gain little from an audience's acceptance of a message will be viewed as more trustworthy. Additionally, if the source is known to audience members and has, over time, consistently provided good, honest, and accurate information, he or she will probably be perceived as trustworthy and the message viewed more positively. For years, CBS news anchor Walter Cronkite provided information that audiences perceived to be factual and believable, and so he was rated consistently as among the most trustworthy people in America.

Expertise is often measured by college degrees, years of experience in a field, awards, and citations for excellence. A source who can demonstrate expertise reveals his or her capacity to deal authoritatively with a topic. An aeronautical engineer will be perceived by audiences as having high expertise when discussing flight characteristics of a new aircraft. The president of a successful brokerage firm will be perceived as an expert on stock market matters. Note, however, that expertise is subject specific. Although the stockbroker may know Dow Jones, this investment expert is out of his or her element when discussing aeronautical designs. Audiences recognize these limitations and are quick to confine source expertise to subject areas.

Finally, charisma, or dynamism as it is sometimes called, is the peculiar quality possessed by some people that grants them special influence over others. Although this trait is ascribed to the source, it is really a matter of personality, appearance, and demeanor recognized by the receiver as compelling features of that source. Some audience members may sense strong charismatic qualities in a source, while others are unable to detect such presence. A teenager, for instance, may be driven to near hysteria by the magnetism

of a rock star. The teen's parents, however, may not recognize anything remotely attractive in the same musician. Charisma, then, like trustworthiness and to a lesser extent expertise, is a trait perceived to reside in a source.

Two features of source credibility emerge from this brief discussion. First, each of the component parts of credibility is imputed to the source by the receiver. It could be argued that the source may possess certain qualities of trustworthiness, expertise, and dynamism that can be measured on an absolute scale. For example, the source may have no evident stake in the issue at hand and may have consistently provided accurate information. Furthermore, this source may have college degrees to demonstrate expertise and may be an attractive person who can speak well and move audiences. Unless the intended receivers recognize and value these features, they are meaningless.

In sum, we can consider the credibility of a source only as a function of the receiver's perceptions. Therefore, public communicators should plan their strategy not only to get out the message but to get out the message about the messenger as well.

The second observation about source credibility also involves the receivers: Audience members vary considerably over what constitutes a credible source. Different receivers ascribe different levels of credibility to a source because of different value structures, exposure levels, interests, and a host of other factors that make one audience member unlike another. There is no such thing as a generic, highly credible source that can be effective with all audiences. There are only some sources that are perceived as highly credible by some receivers. In order to maximize the benefits from selecting a highly credible source, the public communicator must carefully match source characteristics with concerns of the intended audience.

Often this means the communicator must give up one audience in favour of another or develop a stratified campaign that presents different messages borne by different sources to different receiver groups. "One source fits all" may not work in any given campaign. We may need to reach young audiences with a sports figure, religious audiences with a member of the clergy, professional audiences with a respected authority in the field. To make such a determination, we must examine the group and the nature of the topic. These features of source credibility suggest a noteworthy dimension of complexity in the public communication process.

## **E-MAIL**

Although e-mail has been used in writing programmes for nearly a decade to familiarize students with the technology and to teach collaborative writing, only since 1983 has the rhetoric of e-mail begun to be understood and transformed into a useful pedagogy. E-mail is notorious for messages that reflect the writer's failure to analyse audiences who will receive the message and the impact of the message. For example, in a study rich in theoretical and practical implications, Sussman and Golden of the

University of Louisville, and Beauclair of Price Waterhouse, in a collaborative study, found that e-mail users “may focus their attention on the process of sending the message while ignoring its impact on the receiver. They may tend to concentrate more on the electronic functions typing, scanning, and executing commands — than on who will receive the message and how it will be interpreted”. Because e-mail, more than hard copy memos, removes all non-verbal cues, senders have to assume more responsibility for the objective reality of the message. E-mail research is showing that careful rhetorical analysis is even more problematic in e-mail than in standard written memos and letters, in which slower generation forces more careful analysis.

E-mail researchers have discovered that writers are more careful when writing standard memos than when writing on a computer screen. Sims found that e-mail messages had more of a spoken quality, lacked connections between sentences, exhibited poor spelling and punctuation, and showed little efforts by senders to impress receivers. The use of metadiscourse to control meaning in e-mail needs further study. For example, Sussman, Golden, and Beauclair recommended that (a) e-mail users need to use more metadiscourse, specifically incorporating parenthetical interpretive cues for the receiver that pointedly tell the receiver the sender’s views rather than assuming that the receiver will infer the tone; and (b) that the sender’s use of conversational tone without any dramaturgical cues can result in misinterpreted statements.

## **THE INTERNET (WORLD WIDE WEB)**

With a web browser, you can use the Web address of a business or other organisation to access its Web site from a personal computer and see the pages it provides - which include, for example, words, pictures, videos, plans and maps. Via the Internet, therefore, much useful information is available - but also much unsupported opinion, and much that is fiction.

Unlike the papers published in professional journals (in printed or electronic versions), much of the material on Web pages has not been subjected to peer review and editing. Also, the contents of Web pages may be changed at any time, so it may not be possible to state the source of information obtained from the Internet in such a way that readers can consult the same source and read an identical document themselves. Keep these reservations in mind when you use the Internet. Also, because Web pages may change at any time, if a document is of particular interest you are advised to download it to your computer or to make a hard copy.

Many organisations include a Web address on their headed notepaper and in advertisements, and there are directories of Web addresses, but if you do not know an address you can try to guess it - because most Web addresses comprise: www (the World Wide Web), the name of the organisation (for example, ons = Office of National Statistics), an extension indicating the type of organisation (for example, com = company;

gov = government), and the country (for example, uk = United Kingdom) - with full stops where there are commas in this sentence but with no spaces. For example, [www.ons.gov.uk](http://www.ons.gov.uk) is the Web address of the Office of National Statistics, a government department in the United Kingdom. However, when you access a Web address you must check that the site is that of the organisation you are seeking - because different organisations, perhaps with opposing objectives, may have very similar addresses.

Via the Internet you can also, for example: (a) study previously inaccessible archives, (b) browse through the catalogues of major libraries, (c) scan pages of both current issues and back numbers of newspapers, (d) search indexes for bibliographical details and abstracts of publications likely to be of interest to you, and (e) read (and, if necessary, print out or download to your computer) articles from journals published electronically.

The Internet also makes on-line instruction available. For example, many of the course materials produced by the Open University in England are available via the Internet, with tutorial support, to students in many countries in Western Europe.

Many individuals have an Internet account with an internet service provider (ISP), and pay for it either by a direct charge or through a telephone company. Anyone making much use of a personal computer will find the use of the Internet expensive, because a search for information can take a long time. You pay directly, because of the cost of the service, and indirectly if you value your time. Also: (a) your search will not necessarily be successful, and (b) you will not be able to rely on the relevant material you do find, much of which is likely to be opinion - unsupported by evidence. As when reading review articles (secondary sources) you will need to refer to primary sources for the evidence upon which statements are based.

Search engines are used in looking for information on the Internet. Many of these offer both a simple search and a more complex search that may be called an advanced search. However, no search engine could search the whole of the Internet, and if you enter identical search requests into different search engines you will find differences in their outputs even when searching for specialist terms. One reason for these differences is that organisations developing Web pages use many different key words, not just the most appropriate words, in an attempt to direct searches to their pages. Another reason is that some search engines accept new Web pages quicker than others, and some store pages for longer than others.

## MANAGING THE INTERNET

Perhaps the least understood aspect of the Internet is its management. In recent years, this subject has become the subject of intense commercial and international interest, involving multiple governments and commercial organizations, and recently congressional hearings. At issue is how the Internet will be managed in the future, and, in the process, what oversight mechanisms will insure that the public interest is



adequately served. In the 1970s, managing the Internet was easy. Since few people knew about the Internet, decisions about almost everything of real policy concern were made in the offices of DARPA. It became clear in the late 1970s, however, that more community involvement in the decision-making processes was essential.

In 1979, DARPA formed the Internet Configuration Control Board (ICCB) to insure that knowledgeable members of the technical community discussed critical issues, educated people outside of DARPA about the issues, and helped others to implement the TCP/IP protocols and gateway functions. At the time, there were no companies that offered turnkey solutions to getting on the Internet. It would be another five years or so before companies like Cisco Systems were formed, and while there were no PCs yet, the only workstations available were specially built and their software was not generally configured for use with external networks; they were certainly considered expensive at the time.

In 1983, the small group of roughly twelve ICCB members was reconstituted (with some substitutions) as the Internet Activities Board (IAB), and about ten "Task Forces" were established under it to address issues in specific technical areas. The attendees at Internet Working Group meetings were invited to become members of as many of the task forces as they wished.

The management of the Domain Name System offers a kind of microcosm of issues now frequently associated with overall management of the Internet's operation and evolution. Someone had to take responsibility for overseeing the system's general operation.

In particular, top-level domain names had to be selected, along with persons or organizations to manage each of them. Rules for the allocation of Internet addresses had to be established. DARPA had previously asked the late Jon Postel of the USC Information Sciences Institute to take on numerous functions related to administration of names, addresses and protocol related matters.

With time, Postel assumed further responsibilities in this general area on his own, and DARPA, which was supporting the effort, gave its tacit approval. This activity was generally referred to as the Internet Assigned Numbers Authority (IANA). In time, Postel became the arbitrator of all controversial matters concerning names and addresses until his untimely death in October 1998.

It is helpful to consider separately the problem of managing the domain name space and the Internet address space. These two vital elements of the Internet architecture have rather different characteristics that colour the management problems they generate.

Domain names have semantics that numbers may not imply; and thus a means of determining who can use what names is needed. As a result, speculators on Internet names often claim large numbers of them without intent to use them other than to resell them later. Alternate resolution mechanisms, if widely adopted, could significantly change the landscape here.



The rapid growth of the Internet has triggered the design of a new and larger address space (the so-called IP version 6 address space); today's Internet uses IP version 4. However, little momentum has yet developed to deploy IPv6 widely. Despite concerns to the contrary, the IPv4 address space will not be depleted for some time.

Further, the use of Dynamic Host Configuration Protocol (DHCP) to dynamically assign IP addresses has also cut down on demand for dedicated IP addresses. Nevertheless, there is growing recognition in the Internet technical community that expansion of the address space is needed, as is the development of transition schemes that allow interoperation between IPv4 and IPv6 while migrating to IPv6.

In 1998, the Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers (ICANN) was formed as a private sector, non-profit, organization to oversee the orderly progression in use of Internet names and numbers, as well as certain protocol related matters that required oversight. The birth of this organization, which was selected by the Department of Commerce for this function, has been difficult, embodying as it does many of the inherent conflicts in resolving discrepancies in this arena. However, there is a clear need for an oversight mechanism for Internet domain names and numbers, separate from their day-to-day management. Many questions about Internet management remain.

They may also prove difficult to resolve quickly. Of specific concern is what role the U.S. government and indeed governments around the world need to play in its continuing operation and evolution. This is clearly a subject for another time.

## **ADVANTAGES OF INTERNET**

*There are many advantages of using the Internet, such as:*

### **Global Audience**

Content published on the World Wide Web is immediately available to a global audience of users. This makes the World Wide Web a very cost-effective medium to publish information. Reaching more than 190 countries.

### **Operates 24 hours and 365 days**

You don't need to wait until resources are available to conduct business. From a consumer's perspective as well as a provider's business can be consummated at any time. The fact that the Internet is operational at all times makes it the most efficient business machine to date.

### **Relatively Inexpensive**

It is relatively inexpensive to publish information on the Internet. At a fraction of the cost to publish information by traditional methods, various organizations and individuals can now distribute information to millions of users. It costs only a few thousand dollars to establish an Internet presence and publish content on the Internet.

**Product Advertising**

You can use the World Wide Web to advertise various products. Before purchasing a product, customers will be able to look up various product specification sheets and find out additional information. You can use the multimedia capabilities of the World Wide Web to make available not only various product specification sheets but also audio files, images, and even video clips of products in action. The beauty of the Web is that it allows customers to explore products in as much detail as they desire. If the client just wants a general overview, he or she can look at the advertising information. For those wanting more in depth information, you can provide white papers and product descriptions for download. The Web allows a business to provide timely information, you can simply place the information on the Web page and it is available immediately for your customers.

**Distribute Product Catalogs**

The World Wide Web is a very effective medium for distributing product catalogs. In the old days, putting together a product catalogue used to be very costly in terms of time and money needed to publish and distribute it. The World Wide Web changes all this by allowing content developers to put together a sales catalogue and make it available to millions of users immediately. Furthermore, unlike printed product catalogs that are usually updated around once a month, product catalogs on the World Wide Web can be updated as needed to respond to various changing market conditions.

**Online Surveys**

Traditional methods of performing surveys are often relatively slow and expensive compared to online surveys conducted on the Internet. For example, in order to fill out various needs of customers or what they would like to see in a future product, it's often necessary to compile a list of address and mail a questionnaire to many customers.

The success of such an attempt is not always guaranteed and can be very costly in terms of mailing the questionnaires and entering responses to a databases and analyzing it. On the other hand, you can use the World Wide Web to automate the whole process. For example, you can set up a CGI script to conduct online surveys. Results of such a survey can be automatically updated to a database. This database can then be used to keep a pulse on various opinions and needs of customers.

**Announcements**

With the World Wide Web, you can distribute various announcements to millions of users in a timely manner. Because there is virtually no time lag from the time it takes to publish information to making the information available to users, the Web is an ideal medium to publicize announcements. As more people discover the virtues of the Web and get connected to the Internet, the Web will become the medium of choice for many organizations and individuals to publicize various announcements.

**Provide Technical Support**

You can also use Web site to provide technical support to users. Because Web pages can be updated immediately with new information, various technical support literature can be immediately modified in light of new findings and developments.

This can be accomplished without having to distribute changes to all users affected by any changes using traditional mediums of information distribution, which are often quite costly compared to the World Wide Web.

**Create Online Discussion Forums**

By using applications such as WebBoard, it's possible to set up online discussion forums on the Web.

**Obtain Customer Feedback**

The interactive nature of the World Wide Web is ideal for obtaining customer feedback. You can easily set up a CGI script to obtain customer feedback about a product or service.

Because customer feedback submitted by customers can be read immediately, it's possible to respond to various customer concerns in a timely manner, increasing customer satisfaction and quality of customer service.

**Immediate Distribution of Information**

When information is added to a Web site, it's immediately available for browsing by millions of Internet users. The World Wide Web is an ideal medium of information distribution because it takes away the time lag associated with publishing content and actually making it available to users

**Easy Integration with Internal Information Systems**

Internet information systems deployed on the Internet can be easily integrated with internal information systems managed with office productivity applications such as Microsoft Office.

**Powerful Content Publishing Tools**

A new breed of Internet aware applications will start emerging in software stores by the time you read this. These applications will enable users to develop content for the World Wide Web by simply saving as an HTML file.

In addition to software developers making existing applications Internet aware, various new, powerful, and easy-to-use Internet content publishing applications are also being developed. These applications will make the task of publishing content on the Internet even easier. Most of these applications are developed for Windows users.

**Multimedia**

The capability to incorporate multimedia into Web pages is a major advantage of using World Wide Web to publish information. For example, many Web sites use sounds and video clips to make the content easier and more interesting to browse.

**Formatting Capabilities**

Content published on the World Wide Web can be richly formatted by using various HTML tags and graphic formats. The capability to do this is a major reason for the success of the World Wide Web. In addition to using HTML tags and various multimedia formats in Web pages, various interactive controls can also be added to a web page. This capability allows Web site content developers to create "active" Web sites. For example, before a user sends some information to a Web server for processing, a VBScript or JavaScript subroutine can be used to verify information typed in by the user. Various formatting capabilities, along with technologies such as Java and VBScript, make the World Wide Web a richly interactive medium that you can use to distribute information to millions of users.

## **COMPUTER COMMUNICATIONS**

We have thus far avoided mention of the budding computer communication industry that, without doubt, will have a major impact on the ways businesses communicate among themselves and with clients. Cost of equipment necessary for computer communication is beyond reach of the average person, and applications for such a service are limited to professional settings. Nonetheless, there are two reasons why this discussion is relevant to our purposes. First, there are immediate uses for computer communications among many specialized audiences.

Businesses, educational institutions, political organisations, and others have already adopted the equipment necessary for computer communication and are now in a position to utilize computer-based interpersonal programmes. Second, as costs are reduced for computer equipment and the technology diffuses further into the population, audiences and uses for such programmes will expand. The design we describe here is only an early prototype that will probably go through many modifications to accommodate expanding audiences and improvements in technology. This example draws positive features from several existing computer communication programmes and thus represents an amalgam of the best components rather than a single programme currently in operation.

**SETTING AND BACKGROUND**

A political consulting firm in Arlington, Virginia, spotted a trend in the use of professional campaign assistance by candidates running for small state and local offices.

As campaigns have become more sophisticated with extensive use of mass media, direct mail, and polling technologies, candidates have had to supplement their small campaign staffs with help from professional consultants.

Market analysis revealed that candidates often had difficulty locating such help, and when they did hire these specialists, they often had to pay for more services than their small campaigns really needed. The firm decided there was a national market for one-stop shopping for campaign consulting services. Candidates around the United States could turn to this outfit for assistance in audience measurement, campaign strategy design, media purchases, fund raising, and other political campaign features. They could buy an entire package or use only those services they needed at any given time.

Moreover, the company believed it could provide most of its services directly from Arlington and avoid spending a great deal of time on site. Although company specialists would travel to the field if necessary, the plan called for most of the work to be done from the main office in northern Virginia.

The essential communication link between the company and clients would be the computer. Data could be sent back and forth, problems could be examined and discussed, budgets could be debated, media could be planned. In fact, communication required for all activities could be accomplished quickly, accurately, and efficiently by exchanging information between computers over the telephone lines. For instance, a client in Missouri could send telephone survey data to Arlington where they would be processed and analysed. Within hours, results complete with charts, graphs, and recommendations could be sent back to the client.

The computer system would allow transmission of complex material that could otherwise be sent conveniently only by mail. In the heat of a political campaign, even overnight mail is too slow. The computer links made this consulting plan possible. Information could be exchanged quickly with virtually no limitation on the complexity of data that could be sent.

Since computers were so important in the operation of this service, the company decided to involve them in the interpersonal portions of the promotion. This consulting firm established initial contact with potential clients through mass media and direct mail. They would then demonstrate the capacity of their system to engage in an interpersonal dialogue using the computer connections.

## **PROGRAMME DESIGN**

It is typical for such consulting firms to work exclusively with one political party. Such was the case in this instance. Consultants who work exclusively with one party enjoy the confidence of candidates and party officials. They also find it easier to obtain general information about people who plan to run on that party's ticket. With its party connections, the Arlington firm was able to get a mailing list for the direct mail portion of the campaign.

The company firm generated personalized letters to several thousand announced candidates. It prepared several versions of the letter based on the office sought, incumbency status of the candidate, region, previous party successes in the area, and probable campaign issues. Computer-typed letters were addressed to each candidate by name, and letters were further personalized by using the candidate's name throughout the text.

Mass media (only magazines in this case) were used in the following way. The firm advertised this service in political party magazines received by large numbers of party regulars, officeholders, and staff members. Interested readers were given an address to which they could write and a toll-free number to call if they wished additional information about the company's services. Through either channel, the receiver was placed on a list that would bring a copy of the personalized letter (the same one sent out in the direct mail phase). Only the letter, and not the mass media ads, contained specific information about the interpersonal portion of the programme. Significant programme costs made it necessary for the company to limit enquiries, where possible, to serious prospects. If a receiver was sufficiently stimulated by descriptions in the letter to make the enquiry, he or she would have some reasonable level of interest in the service.

The letter provided simple step-by-step instructions for the receiver to become involved in the interpersonal communication programme—called the “demonstration.” Receivers were told what hardware and software they would require and what they should expect when they had established contact for the demonstration. First, they were to call an 800 number. A company representative would answer and review with the caller the basic design of the consulting services being promoted. In other words, the caller was given a standard sales pitch. But the programme went beyond that.

The caller was prompted to ask questions, discuss problems, or deal with any relevant aspect of these consulting services. When this interaction played out, the caller was asked for several items of information that were used by the representative to prepare the demonstration programme. The caller was asked to turn on his or her computer, printer, and modem (equipment that enables computers to communicate over phone lines), load the communication software, and then observe the computer screen.

Using the information provided by the caller, messages appearing on the screen showed colour charts, budgets, and other information selected for their substance and visual appeal. For the grand finale, a message on the screen instructed the receiver to turn attention to the printer that typed out three pages of statistics, charts, and a radio script.

The printer then produced a final message wishing the candidate (by name) success and expressing the consulting firm's desire to assist in the campaign. A message flashed on the screen directing the caller to pick up the phone for further conversation with the company representative. At this point, talk turned to specific commitments to the service, follow-up demonstrations, and additional discussions.

This computer communication system is an example of a truly specialized, interpersonal communication approach, possessing many of the features we look for in one-on-one communications:

- It provides for feedback. Interactants first make verbal contact and establish a rapport, then they communicate through computer keyboards and other computer devices (such as sending data contained on a disk) in an iterative fashion. The same channel allows information to flow back and forth between sender and receiver.
- Information exchange is rapid. People can send and receive information instantaneously, avoiding the serious problems that result from delayed transmissions. In some applications this feature may be critical.
- Receivers are self-selected. Clients who use the computer to interact with a business choose to do so. They are inclined, therefore, to have a particular interest in the topic and so are stronger business prospects.

As we said at the beginning, the use of computers is just now being explored for interpersonal business communications. Technology within the next decade will no doubt considerably expand these uses for specialized interpersonal programmes. Businesses stand to save time and money.

They will be able to do a great deal of work from a single location, reducing travel requirements and enabling a single employee to handle a greater number of accounts. An accountant in New York can work on the books of a client in Seattle without leaving his or her desk. Moreover, he or she can discuss intricacies of these books with as much ease as if everyone were in the same room.

A small automotive engineering firm in Albuquerque can review details of its new windshield design with prospective clients in Detroit who have decided to see what the distant firm has to offer. Companies may conduct sales, respond to queries, and generally engage in the give-and-take we have come to expect with interpersonal communications.

Although there will still be need for other forms of interpersonal contact, we expect computer communication to be an increasingly important addition to the available repertoire of approaches.

## **BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION**

Communication is the exchange of ideas, opinions and information through written or spoken words, symbols or actions.

Communication is an important part of our world today. The ability to communicate effectively is considered a prized quality. But people in the world are not alike. These differences, however, can cause problems in sending/receiving messages. Simply these are the hurdles in the way of communication and anything which blocks the meaning of a communication is a barrier to communication.



## CONVENTIONS OF MEANING

There are a lot of meanings for a single word. So, it may mislead the reader from the real meaning. Miscommunication may occur due to the use of 'Denotations' and 'Connotations'.

*Denotations:* Denotation is the dictionary definition of a word. It means name, object, people or events without indicating positive or negative qualities. These words don't have clear meanings. Such words are: Car, Desk, Book, House, *etc.*

*Connotations:* A word that separates the meanings of a word from its usual definition is called connotation. These have clear meanings. Such words are: BMW, BC book, mental house *etc.*

So, use of denotations instead of connotations may mislead the reader. Choose connotations and denotations wisely.

## DIFFERENCES IN PERCEPTION OF REALITY

Because of changing world, everyone has its own concept of reality. Each person's mental filter is unique. In our daily interactions with others, we make various abstractions, inferences and evaluations of the world around that may cause problems in the way of communication.

*Abstraction:* It means selecting some detail and omitting others. It may cause problem in communication. One must always try to avoid Slanted statements. That's why news reporters are said to quote the statement of a person as it is to show it a fact or true statement.

*Inferences:* It means conclusion on the basis of assumptions. But for some situations inferences proves fruitful but for some situations it is risky and sometimes dangerous.

*Evaluation:* It is a person's own perception or opinion towards a certain fact. So, difference in perception may become a hurdle in communication.

## VALUES, ATTITUDES AND OPINIONS

Communication is also affected by the Values, attitudes and opinions of the communicators. People react favourably when they receive agreeable message. Occasionally people react according to their attitude towards a situation rather than to the facts.

*Closed Minds:* Some people hold rigid views on certain subjects. They don't consider facts and maintain their views. Such person is very hard to communicate with.

*Sender's credibility:* Usually people react more favourably to that communicator who has credibility. So, Values, attitudes and opinions may also become hurdles in the way of communication.

## PRINCIPLES OF EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

The purpose of effective communications in a training environment is to ensure students accurately understand the material presented by the instructor.

*There are basically two principles you need to understand that have to do with communicating effectively:*

- The identification and removal of barriers
- The communication process itself.

## **INCREASES OF BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION**

The existence of certain barriers increases the potential for poor communication. By being aware of these barriers, you can reduce them and enhance the clear understanding of your students.

### **Lack of Common Core Experience**

One barrier is the lack of common core experience. You are unlikely to find any group in which students have the same common core experience. For example, if you say that a kiwi tastes like a kumquat, students who have tasted one would have the experience to make the proper relationship. However, for the students who have tasted neither, the comparison would have no meaning. To prevent that problem, determine student experience level before you prepare your lesson. Then check for understanding as you use examples and analogies with your explanations.

### **Overuse Of Abstractions**

Abstractions are concepts, ideas, or words that are not directly related to the subject being discussed. To avoid confusion you should speak in concrete terms—be specific. Be aware of the background and experience level of your students and use appropriate terms and examples. Remember, you will normally have more experience in the subject matter than any of your students, so you have the responsibility of ensuring understanding. This requires that you not only present the information, but also that you check to ensure the students understand exactly what you intended.

### **Fear**

Fear may be one of the greatest barriers to effective communication. The fear of showing ignorance, fear of disapproval, fear of losing status, and fear of judgement are common barriers. Many times, students will have anxieties or fears about their abilities. Students may hesitate to take part in your discussions because they have a lack of confidence and are afraid they will appear ignorant. That, in turn, brings about a fear of judgement and a fear of losing status in front of their peers. Try to understand your students' fears. Provide a threat-free learning environment by being encouraging and non-judgemental of the students.

Remember how long it took you to learn your subject matter. Take the time to recognise the individual differences in your students so that you will know how to motivate them. Since you have control of the class, you must direct the class energy in

a positive direction. Do not allow fellow students to make fun of or exhibit disapproval of a struggling student. Avoid embarrassing any of your students or offending human values. Follow the basic principle of motivation by giving them positive feedback.

### **Environmental Factors**

Environmental factors such as noise and temperature may interfere with the communication process. Obviously, noise is a barrier to hearing what is being said. If students are overly hot or cold it may be difficult from them to listen attentively. However, more subtle factors may also affect the communication process. The colour of the walls, uncomfortable seats, the location of pictures or illustrations, and the arrangement of students in relation to the instructor may all become barriers to effective communication. You should constantly strive to identify and eliminate barriers to effective communication. Some will be obvious while others maybe very difficult to detect. Your awareness of barriers, along with a knowledge of the communication process, will assist you in communicating effectively.

## **THE COMMUNICATION PROCESS**

The communication process consists of a message being sent and received. The message may be verbal or non-verbal. The same basic principles apply whether humans, animals, other forms of life, or combinations of these are involved. Your challenge, as an instructor, is to not merely communicate with your students—but to communicate effectively. Effective communication involves a message being sent and received. Added to this however, is the element of feedback to ensure that the message sent was received exactly as intended. This concept may be illustrated using the three-step communications model.

### **Sending the Message**

There are four elements involved in sending a message. First, as the instructor (sender), you formulate the message you intend to communicate. Next, you consider possible barriers that may affect the message. This includes your experience, the terms you will use, and even your feeling towards the subject or the students. External barriers such as noise must also be considered. Third, you encode the message; that is, you put the message into the words you want to use. Last, you clearly communicate (send) the message.

### **Receiving the Message**

There are also four elements involved in receiving a message. The students (receivers) will first hear and/or see the message you sent.

Second, the message is affected by external barriers, if any, and the students' own internal barriers. Possible internal barriers may include the students' experience level,

their understanding of the terms used, their attitude towards the material, or the way they feel about you. Third, your students decode the message through the use of mental images. For instance, when you say the word circus, the receiver does not “see” the letters that form the word. Instead, a mental image of some sort appears. How many different mental images might arise among your students for this one word alone? A clown, a big top, lions, acrobats, and so forth.

Fourth, the students interpret the message. Clearly, at this point in the process there is no way for you to determine that all of the students received the message you intended. To determine this, you must get feedback.

### **Feedback**

Feedback, which may take several forms, provides essential information about your success in communicating the message. To get feedback, have the students respond to oral questions and encourage them to ask questions. The students’ non-verbal behaviours also provide important clues as to their understanding of the material. Facial expressions and body movements often indicate when students are unsure about the meaning of your message.

You should be careful in accepting a “yes” response when you ask “Do you understand?” Obtain meaningful feedback by asking questions that require the students to provide answers which indicate that they in fact do understand exactly what you intended.

## **EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION SKILLS AND TECHNIQUES**

There are many skills and techniques you must master to be an effective communicator and instructor. Many of these skills you already possess, all that is required is that you use them to their best advantage. Others, you need to learn and practice.

### **Listening**

Listening is one of our most important communication skills. It is an active process of hearing and understanding that demands concentration and attention. Both you and your students have responsibilities in the communication process. You must ensure that the learning environment is free of distractions that might interfere with the students’ ability to listen. Be alert to the non-verbal behaviours of your students. Facial expressions reveal much of what is happening in the mind of a student.

A quizzical look indicates some misunderstanding has occurred or a question needs to be addressed. A student leaning slightly forward and maintaining good eye contact with you is probably interested and sincere about learning. An affirmative head nod indicates approval, agreement, or understanding. Conversely, eye contact out the window or someplace other than the front of the room may indicate boredom or lack of interest.

Fidgeting in the chair or a slouched posture may also be an indication of something other than effective listening. Raised hands and relevant questions are sure signs that you are communicating effectively. Learn to determine if students are listening by the type of feedback they provide. Effective listening depends on motivation, and you are the prime motivator in your classroom. Students should arrive for instruction ready to learn. They should participate and ask questions as they arise. Students must understand that they have responsibility for their own learning. This requires active listening on their part.

### **EFFECTIVE INSTRUCTOR DELIVERY TECHNIQUES**

Delivery style has a major impact on student motivation and determines to a great extent how well students listen. Studies have shown that spoken words alone account for only seven per cent of the impact of the message. The following Factors are important considerations in your delivery of instruction.

#### **Articulation**

Articulation is simply understandable speech. You can achieve good articulation in two ways. First, enunciate; speak clearly. Second, pronounce; accent syllables and reproduce consonant and vowel sounds in conformity with the accepted standard—the dictionary. To be a good speaker, make crisp, distinct enunciation your goal. Avoid slurring and mumbling. Avoid slang such as jist, git, gonna, whut, watcha, or hafta. In rehearsal, exaggerate your enunciation beyond what is required in normal speech. Apply the principle of sharpened enunciation not only in your classes but in ordinary conversation. Make it a habit. If you have a regional accent, such as a Southern drawl or a New England twang, don't try to eliminate it—make the most of it! It's part of your personality. A slight accent is pleasant and adds interest and personality to your speech. However, be sure that people from other parts of the country can understand you.

#### **Grammar**

Grammar concerns the correct usage of the spoken or written word. It is like a code. When you use the code correctly, the message comes through clearly and quickly. But when you make encoding errors, the one who receives the message has to labour to extract the precise meaning. Sometimes your message never comes through exactly right. However, as an instructor, never commit glaring grammatical errors like “him and me is going,” “I seen,” “he give,” or “it run.”

#### **Rate of Speech**

As a speaker, you should neither talk at a slow, plodding rate that puts your listeners to sleep nor rattle off words so rapidly that they run together. As a rule, speak fast enough to be interesting yet slow enough to be understood. Just as a good baseball

pitcher keeps the batter alert by changing the speed of the ball, take advantage of a vocal change of pace to hold the interest of your audience. Your rate of speech should be governed by the complexity of the thought, idea, or emotion you are communicating.

Use a fast rate for joy, excitement, or vigorous action. Use a slow rate for a deliberate or methodical presentation. Add emphasis by either slowing or speeding your rate. The normal rate of delivery is 125 to 150 words per minute.

### **To Improve Common Rate Difficulties, Observe the Following Suggestions**

Slow, ponderous rate. Force yourself to think faster so that you can speak faster. Using a tape recorder, read aloud and interpret the meaning of the words by the rate at which you speak them. Then play back the recording. If your rate is still too slow, record the same reading selection again but force yourself to use a faster rate of speech to cut down the total playback time.

### **Fast, Machine-gun Delivery**

Curb your impatience to blurt out ideas. Take time to make them clear. Force yourself to slow down. Recognise the listeners' need to absorb ideas; give them time to do so by saying words clearly and by pausing longer between ideas. Read aloud, observing the marks of punctuation. Express the meaning of the words carefully at the rate that fits your interpretation. Taking care to enunciate more precisely will generally slow your rate.

### **Halting, Choppy Rate**

Concentrate on speaking complete ideas or sentences. Take a deep breath before you begin a sentence; breathe between, not in the middle of, ideas or phrases. Sometimes a choppy rate results from tenseness, nervousness, or lack of familiarity with the subject matter.

### **Pauses**

In writing, punctuation marks separate thoughts and ideas and give the desired meaning and emphasis to words. In speaking, pauses serve the same functions to a large degree. You may use pauses to gain humorous, dramatic, or thought-provoking effects. Use them as a vocal means of punctuating for effect. Proper use of pauses gives listeners a chance to absorb ideas and gives the speaker a chance to breathe and concentrate on the next point. Pauses also give emphasis, meaning, and interpretation to ideas.

*The following suggestions will help you overcome common pausing difficulties:*

- *Not enough pauses:* Begin by reading aloud something that you like. Force yourself to pause between ideas and at periods, commas, and other punctuation marks. Try to adopt the attitude of the artist who makes a few brush strokes and then steps back to evaluate the results.

- *Too many pauses:* A lack of knowledge of the subject, failure to organise material thoroughly, or inadequate rehearsals usually result in too many pauses in the speaker's delivery. Study your material and organise it on paper. Then rehearse until your thoughts and words flow smoothly. Thorough familiarity with the subject matter increases verbal fluency.
- *Overuse of verbal connectors:* Pauses, properly placed in the flow of speech, are often more effective than words. Filling pauses with meaningless, guttural sounds gives listeners the impression that you are not confident of what you are saying, and that you are not prepared to speak to them. Too many "uhs" and "ahs" may be detrimental to an otherwise effective lesson presentation. To improve on this difficulty, use the same techniques suggested for eliminating too many pauses and leave out the "uhs" and "ahs."

### Inflection

Inflection is a change in the normal pitch or tone of the speaker's voice. Just as musical notes become melody when arranged in different relative positions on the musical scale, your voice becomes more interesting and words more meaningful when you use changes in pitch.

Using inflection can increase the emphasis on certain words. The following example illustrates how inflection on different words changes the meaning of a question. Say the question to yourself, raising your pitch (but not your volume) on the underlined words, as indicated:

- What am I doing?
- What am I doing?
- What am I doing?
- What am I doing?

Inflection is the key to expression of mood. It can be emotional, persuasive, or convincing. Using inflection can move an audience to tears or laughter and create a lasting impression. Without inflection, the audience may fall asleep. Like pauses, inflection is a way of punctuating speech; it can put the question mark at the end of a question, make a statement of fact more positive, or help to put an exclamation mark at the end of a strong statement. Inflection is the principal difference between just saying words and speaking ideas with meaning: Try the following suggestions to improve inflection:

- *Read aloud and communicate your emotions:* Inflection conveys feeling and meaning. However, feeling also produces good inflection. As an instructor, you must show your feeling about what you say. To practice using inflection, read aloud and communicate your emotions. Using a tape recorder is a good way to improve inflection because you must communicate emotion entirely through your voice; gestures or visible facial expressions provide no help.



- *Downward and upward inflection:* Generally, downward inflection at the end of a sentence expresses conviction. However, downward inflection within the sentence itself gives a sense of finality to the thought and creates a mental break in the listeners' thoughts. Use slight upward inflection within the sentence to indicate that the thought is not yet complete; that serves to bind ideas together and to give unity to the thought. Use upward inflection at the end of a sentence only when you ask a question or imply uncertainty.

## Force

Forceful speech combines the volume or carrying power of the voice with the demonstrated vitality, strength, and conviction of the speaker; it includes the proper placement of stress or emphasis on key words and phrases. Like rate, pauses, and inflection, force is a way of conveying conviction, of giving meaning, or of adding emphasis. Yet, unlike rate, pauses, and inflection, it cannot be set apart distinctly. Force involves rate, pauses, and inflection plus carrying power, fullness of tone (or body), and proper regulation of loudness. Listeners will not respond to a speaker who shouts and is insensitive to their feelings. Neither will they be convinced by the cool, detached manner of a speaker who is consistently calm, quiet, or patronizing. To communicate, you must awaken reactions and feelings in your listeners. Knowledge of the subject and of the sequence in which you plan to present ideas will help you to calmly lead the thoughts of your audience. You can then drive home a point with power and let silence underline the significance of your words.

Through your gestures, voice, movement, eye contact, and choice of words, you can convey force to your listeners. But your listeners will neither hear you nor see you unless you project words and actions with a vitality and strength of conviction. Force is not loudness, shouting, wild gesturing, or vulgar language. Force is knowing what you want to say and then saying it with implicit firmness and undeniable confidence. The following common difficulties with force have accompanying suggestions for improvement:

- *Lack of volume:* To increase volume, select someone in the back of the room and concentrate on making him or her hear you. Rehearse in an empty classroom and speak to an imaginary person in the back of the room. Since these exercises will make you aware of the distance involved, they will motivate you to increase your volume. When you speak with increased volume, you will be able to feel your diaphragm working.
- *Dropping volume at end of words or sentences:* Dropping volume usually results when a speaker incorrectly associates a drop in volume with downward inflection. Develop the habit of paying attention to the sound of your own voice so that you can judge whether you are being heard. Practice lowering the pitch of your voice without dropping the volume. Record your voice so that you can

hear how you sound to others. Read aloud, and concentrate on projecting every word in a thought or idea to an imaginary listener seated in the back of the room.

- *Failure to give emphasis to main points or key words:* To emphasize main points and key words, you must first know your subject well. Then you can communicate main and subordinate ideas by stressing key words and phrases using volume, pitch, rate, and pauses. That will result in convincing and authoritative presentations.

## **SPEECH IMPROVEMENT IN COMMUNICATION**

This chapter has addressed specific ways to correct common difficulties; however, two methods will improve all aspects of your speaking voice.

First, listen closely to polished speakers on television, such as popular newscasters. Their techniques of speech make them good models for study. Don't try to imitate them exactly, but study how they use their voices to give meaning to their words and emphasis to their ideas. Second, listen to yourself daily as you instruct and casually converse with your contemporaries.

## **EYE CONTACT**

The most powerful element of instructor presence in front of a class is direct eye contact with your audience. By looking directly in the eyes of each of your students, you personalize the lesson being presented and stimulate the desire for them to listen more intently. Each student should have your direct eye contact several times during an instructional period. Make and maintain this eye contact for 3 to 5 seconds. This time interval is appropriate for personal contact without being overbearing or creating some level of discomfort for individual students.

Scan the entire class without developing a mechanical pattern. Avoid the common pitfall of talking to the chalkboard or visual aid panel or to any other training aid you may be using. Maintaining effective eye contact enhances your credibility. Another important reason for looking directly at your students is to observe their non-verbal reactions to your instruction.

## **Body Movement**

Body movement is an important part of successful communication; it reinforces, emphasizes, and clarifies verbally expressed ideas. Because body movement is so easily adaptable for communicating, skilled pantomimic actors can tell complicated stories involving many characters through physical movement alone. However, your actions while instructing must reinforce rather than contradict your words. Make sure the image you present and your body movements strengthen your communication. Movement is the motion of the whole body as you travel about the classroom. Movement attracts the

attention of the listener because the eye instinctively follows moving objects and focuses on them. Movement can help you convey thoughts to your audience. The basic rule in movement is moderation. Do not remain glued to one spot, but do not keep on the move all the time. As your skill and experience increase, your movement will become less obvious and more meaningful. Learn to modify the degree of movement to make it natural and meaningful.

Plan your movement so that you are at the proper place at the proper time. For example, when using an overhead projector with a transparency, plan movement so that you are at the machine when it should be turned on; when you need to open the curtains, plan movement so that you are at the curtain control point at the time the curtain should be opened.

## **GESTURES**

A gesture is a natural movement of any part of the body that conveys a thought or emotion or reinforces oral expression. Your arms, hands, and facial expressions are your principal tools of gesture.

Your gestures will depend to a large extent on whether your personality is vigorous and dynamic or calm and easygoing. Regardless of your personality, gestures will add to the effectiveness of your speech if you relax your shoulders, arms, and hands and concentrate on communicating to the audience the meaning and importance of your ideas. When the gesture is natural, it is effective. If the gesture is artificial, posed, or strained, it detracts rather than reinforces.

Practice gestures as a natural part of your speaking manner; they should arise spontaneously from enthusiasm and conviction. Descriptive gestures portray an object or illustrate an action. Describe the size, shape, or movement of an object by imitation. Show a vigorous punch by striking with your fist; show height by holding your hand at the desired level; show speed by a quick sweep of your arm. Pantomime a complicated or humorous movement as you describe it. Use your hands to sign a message, such as a “V” formed with two fingers as a symbol of victory.

### **Facial Expression is a Type of Gesture**

To change opinions or to inspire or interest people, your face must show what you are feeling and thinking. Facial expressions show many feelings, such as joy, dejection, anger, and poise. The most common fault in facial expression is the deadpan face that shows a total lack of expression. Another common difficulty is the use of a constantly intense expression, usually manifested by a frown. Overcome this problem by relaxing all over; then use your intensity only on key ideas. Finally, remember that you are neither a wooden statue nor a clown. You are a human being. The more natural you appear and act, the more you will influence your listeners. The classroom is no place for a poker face.

## **ATTITUDE**

Your speech reveals how you feel about what you say. It has an emotional impact on others. Thus, emotion indicates how you feel about all that surrounds you—it shows your attitude. Attitude affects the words you use. The four specific indicators of a good speaking attitude are sincerity, confidence, enthusiasm, and humour. Sincerity, from the speaker's point of view, is the apparent earnest desire to convince the audience of the truth and value of an idea. The two sources of sincerity are a personal, intense belief in your subject and a belief in the value of your subject to your listeners. The first of these sources is ideal because intense personal belief is natural sincerity that shows in your every word or gesture. The second source is more rational than emotional. If you know your teaching material is valuable, you will present it in an honest and forthright manner.

You will not rely on gimmicks or questionable reasoning to make your presentation look good. By showing that you believe in what you say, you convince your students of the importance of the subject. Sincerity shows in a number of ways: directness of manner, facial expressions, clarity of explanation, proper combination of humility and authority, and the effective use of the voice and body to reinforce and emphasize ideas.

Remember that students must see, hear, and feel that you believe in what you say. Confidence is a personal attitude or feeling of assurance. It is belief in your ability to perform a task well. To be confident and control stage fright requires two prerequisites: knowledge of the subject and belief in your ability to speak. You obtain knowledge of a subject through research and study. Belief in your ability comes from rehearsal and experience. These requirements are entirely up to you to accomplish in your own way.

## **ENTHUSIASM**

Enthusiasm is the outward manifestation of sincerity and confidence. From the speaker's standpoint, enthusiasm is a strong personal excitement or feeling about a cause or a subject. Enthusiasm is not shouting; it is not phony, overdramatic speech; it is not waving of the arms and leaping about on the platform. Rather, it is the way you show your belief in your subject! How you show enthusiasm is governed by your personality. If you are a vigorous and dynamic person, you may show enthusiasm by brisk, energetic movement; sweeping gestures; a rapid rate of speech; widely-varying inflection; and plenty of vocal force.

If you have a more subdued nature, you will move and gesture with less energy and speak in more measured tones. You will use force only on the key words and ideas; make more use of the pause for effect; and maintain a calm, pleasant, but confident and authoritative manner. Most instructors show enthusiasm by combining characteristics from both of these styles.

## HUMOUR

You may be a sincere, confident, and enthusiastic instructor, yet still lack the humour needed for effective instruction. If you lack a sense of humour, you will seem unreal, inhuman, or very conceived. Humour shows that you are, after all, just another human being and that you have a warm, lively interest in all that goes on around you. Having a sense of humour does not necessarily imply an ability to tell funny jokes, although tasteful, relevant jokes certainly have a place in good instruction.

A more effective type of humour is spontaneous humour. Take advantage of unexpected humorous classroom situations that sometimes arise—make a brief comment, pause, or simply smile. Humour directed at yourself is very effective. Most people laugh when someone important is receptive to being the object of good humour.

In addition to decency, the only rule to follow in using humour is good judgement. Take care not to direct humour at a specific person. Students may resent having a classmate singled out. Be sure your humour is good natured and lightly done. Clean humour is as American as the hot dog and will often assist student learning.

## Feedback

Observation of your students provides important feedback that will help you in evaluating the effectiveness of your communications skills. Puzzled brows, frowns, and whispered questions between students indicate that you have not communicated effectively. The students have unconsciously shown signs of a lack of understanding. The observation of these signs and their on-the-spot analysis is called feedback. That again underlines the importance of maintaining good eye contact with your students. Students can also send signs of positive feedback.

*You may often knowledge:* When you see a student's observe students at the very moment they gain new face light up, you are seeing understanding take place. This positive feedback is one of the most personally rewarding experiences of an instructor.

Feedback is important because it indicates how you must adjust your instruction to communicate effectively. If the students have obviously not learned, then you must modify your instructional approach. Feedback makes the learning process an intercommunication between the students and the instructor.

*As such:* it is critical to the success of the instructional mission.

## ORAL QUESTIONS

For two-way communication to take place between you and the students, you must use good, thought-provoking questions throughout the lesson. The use of oral questions allows you to determine from time to time if you are maintaining essential communication. When properly planned, implemented, and evaluated, oral questioning improves effectiveness and, more importantly, student learning. The greatest resource for enhancing your classroom instruction is the students themselves.

Training is most effective and learning more permanent when the students take an active part in the process. Students need to interact with the subject matter and the instructor during the lessons rather than just at test or performance time.

The responsibility of active class participation lies with you, the instructor. Avoid over using the questioning technique of asking “are there any questions?” That does not stimulate much thought or generate productive class participation. As an instructor, always remember that one purpose of questioning is to help students get involved in learning the material at hand. Some instructors have mastered the technique of teaching a lesson almost entirely through the use of oral questions. Questions add variety to a lesson and require active student involvement.

However, questions are only as effective as the manner in which they are used. You can defeat the whole purpose of the questioning technique by using it improperly, so make sure you learn how to use questions properly. If you don’t have a natural knack for oral questioning, you can develop some degree of skill by setting yourself a goal for improvement and then practicing constantly.

Try to decrease the amount of one-way communication in the classroom by asking questions as much as you make statements. You will find that you have a natural compulsion to “tell,” which is understandable. After all, that is probably what your instructors did. Studies show that in a typical classroom, someone is talking two-thirds of the time; and of that time, the instructor does two-thirds of the talking.

Through good questioning techniques, you can increase and improve the amount of student responses beyond the one-word contribution. A key point to remember is that the intent of a question is to elicit a response. Effective use of questions will result in more student learning than any other single technique. Becoming skillful in the art of questioning will increase your effectiveness as an instructor.

### **Purposes of Oral Questioning**

The primary purpose of oral questioning is to stimulate the students to think. Navy requirements call for people who can operate complex equipment and carry out those troubleshooting and maintenance procedures needed to keep the equipment operating at peak performance. To perform those duties effectively, sailors must be trained to analyse, compare, and interpret facts, data, and methods, all of which require a high calibre of thinking. Oral questioning also provides you with a practical means for establishing the level of instruction. Students may vary greatly in the quantity and quality of background knowledge they have acquired through previous training and experience.

You must determine the level of achievement of the students before proceeding with the presentation of new subject matter. Although you may use a pretest or a questionnaire for this purpose, the quickest and simplest means is a series of oral questions. Oral questioning has three other important purposes: First, it arouses interest in the subject matter. Second, it focuses attention upon a particular area of the subject matter. Third,

it drills students on subject matter they must recall precisely, such as correct terminology, functions of parts, and safety precautions. Use questions to achieve the following benefits:

- Discover each student's interests, abilities, and depth of knowledge.
- Arouse student interest in the subject matter of the lesson.
- Stimulate discussion, and keep it closely tied to the subject matter.
- Review and summarize important points.
- Test students' knowledge of what the lesson has covered, and check the effectiveness of the instruction.

### **Characteristics of a Good Oral Question**

Questions that are poorly worded, vague in meaning, or ambiguous will frustrate both you and the students. Students who do not comprehend the true meaning of poorly phrased questions will hesitate longer than usual and then give uncertain answers. You may feel dissatisfied with the answers and reprimand the students for their lack of attention and understanding.

The students, knowing that they have answered unsatisfactorily through no fault of their own, may lose enthusiasm and withdraw from active participation.

You can avoid frustrations of this kind by planning your questions well in advance as well as carefully choosing and arranging words and phrases. The construction of good oral questions requires three considerations; level of instruction, use of interrogative, and clarity of meaning.

### **Level of Instruction**

In asking questions, use simple words, correct grammar, and complete sentences. Use words the students know and understand. As the course progresses, introduce new terms and more technical phraseology.

Ask questions at times that suit your presentation of course material. Plan questions that require students to think before answering. Don't use questions that give away the answer or that students can answer with a simple yes or no.

### **Use of Interrogative**

Use the interrogatory word or phrase at the beginning of your question so that students know immediately when you are asking a question. Let's consider two examples where this is not done:

- The two sizes of firehose most frequently used in the Navy are what?
- You can determine whether or not explosive vapors are in a compartment by what means?

Questions worded in this way handicaps the students in at least two ways. First, the students are expecting a declarative statement, not a question. Second, they cannot identify the meaning of the question until the final words are spoken.



*Note the improvement in these same questions when the interrogatory word or phrase is placed at the beginning:*

- What are the two sizes of firehose used most frequently in the Navy?
- By what means can you determine whether or not explosive or toxic vapors are in a compartment?

### **Clarity of Meaning**

Avoid the use of catch or trick questions as a teaching device, especially for beginners. Make sure the wording of the question conveys to the students the true or intended meaning. The students must understand what you want, regardless of whether they know the correct answer. “Where are storm warnings flown aboard ship?” is a good question; but “Where are storm warnings flown?” fails to indicate what point is being tested. Make your questions brief, and limit them to one thought. To include too many factors in a single question confuses the students. Ask well-stated, clearly understood questions in a normal conversational tone as part of the lesson. After each lesson, re-evaluate your questions in light of how the student responses contributed to better learning.

### **Types of Oral Questioning**

Learn to use oral questions throughout the lesson. Use them in the introduction to create interest and focus attention on the subject matter and during the lesson presentation to ensure student understanding. Then use them at the end of the presentation for review and drill purposes. Feel free to ask factual, thought-provoking and interest-arousing questions as often as you choose. Other types of questions may serve one or more useful purposes if used sparingly, but may prove ineffective if you use them too often.

#### ***Factual Question***

The factual question asks for specific information; for example, “When was the first U.S. nuclear powered submarine built?” Although the primary purpose of the factual question is to help students memorize facts, it may, under certain conditions, have important secondary purposes. For example, you could use a factual question to arouse interest, to focus attention upon certain parts of the subject matter, and to assist in determining the level of instruction.

#### ***Thought-Provoking Question***

A thought-provoking question normally begins with such interrogatory expressions as “What is the advantage of,” “What is the difference between,” “Why is this method considered superior to,” “How would you solve the problem if,” and so forth. The value of this type of question is that a single question, properly used will stimulate the students to think. Prepare good, thought-provoking questions on key lesson points in advance.

### ***Interest-Arousing Question***

An interest-arousing question may sound, superficially, like a factual question. “How many Navy ships were involved in collisions at sea during the past year?” Since the question calls for an exact number, students will doubtless attempt to recall the collisions about which they have read or heard. When asking an interest-arousing question, however, you are not interested in exact numbers, exact names of ships, or exact situations. Your main purpose in asking the question is to focus the students’ attention and get them thinking about the subject you are about to present. Multiple-Answer Question A multiple-answer question is one that has more than one correct answer. It can be used to increase student participation or cause students to think about the other students’ answers. A multiple-answer question generates a high interest level and improves listening skills. A factual, thought-provoking, or multiple-answer question may also be one that is interest-arousing. That depends upon your intention in asking the question, not upon its form or content.

However, if you overestimate the knowledge of your students, a question intended to be factual may turn out to be thought-provoking. If you underestimate the students’ knowledge, a question intended to be thought-provoking may turn out to be factual. As previously mentioned, certain kinds of questions are effective if used occasionally but are detrimental if used frequently. Typical of these types of questions are the yes or no question, the leading question, and the canvassing question.

### ***Yes/No Question***

The yes or no question, of course, calls for a simple answer—yes or no. This type of question has value in arousing interest, focusing attention, encouraging student participation, and serving as a lead-in to other kinds of questions, such as “Why do you believe that to be true?” An excessive use of yes or no questions tends to encourage students to guess.

### ***Leading Question***

A leading question is one that suggests its own answer; for example, “You wouldn’t smoke in the paint locker, would you?” or “The 40mm gun is larger than the 20mm gun, isn’t it?” If used properly, leading questions have value in focusing attention, in arousing interest, and in emphasizing a point. You can also use leading questions to help the student think the matter through to the right answer. If you notice students groping for the right answer, ask a question that directs their attention to information they know but have overlooked in answering the question. That has value when used skillfully because it builds a student’s confidence. Occasionally, use the leading question to help awkward students, saving them the embarrassment of failure in front of the class. If used too frequently, leading questions discourage any real thinking and become boring to the students.

### ***Canvassing Question***

Use a canvassing question to determine those who are familiar with a specific area of subject matter. If you are teaching damage control for instance, you may ask “How many of you have been involved in an actual shipboard fire?” A show of hands provides information about student experiences that you may find useful as your lesson progresses. It gives you a great opportunity to bring some real life examples into your lesson and to provide some individual recognition for student contributions. Canvassing questions can also help to determine class level.

### **Techniques of Oral Questioning**

*The AAUW Report:* How School Shortchange Girls was addressed earlier. Gender bias has also played a significant role in questioning techniques within the school system. As mentioned earlier, boys demand more attention and get it. When boys call out answers, teachers usually listen while the same behaviour exhibited by girls is corrected. Even when boys do not volunteer, teachers are more likely to call on them than girls. Girls receive less teacher praise, fewer remedial comments on their work, and less specific comments about their performance. The implication for you as an instructor is to be aware these behaviours will continue in class unless you correct them. Set the same standards for responding to questions and enforce them uniformly. Provide remediation to both males and females in coaching them through incorrect responses.

Do not spend an inordinate amount of time taking questions from males alone. Know that females may be hesitant to respond to questions, but by providing a safe environment for all your students, you will gain culturally-sensitive class and curriculum include more favourable attitudes towards other groups, a reduction in stereotyping, and increased academic achievement.

### ***Five Step Questioning Technique***

A recommended technique of oral questioning consists of five steps: asking the question; pausing; calling upon a student; evaluating the student’s answer; and finally, emphasizing the correct answer. Put time and thought into making each step count in the teaching process. The first step in good questioning techniques is to state the question. Since the intent of questioning is to provoke thought, ask the question before calling on a person to answer. That encourages each member of the class to formulate an answer.

Many instructors make the mistake of calling on a student before stating the question. That allows the rest of the students to relax and not formulate an answer. When you state the question first and then pause for a few seconds, everyone will begin actively thinking of an answer. This thinking process enables students who you do not select to answer the question time to think so that they may add to the response. Identifying there spondent before asking the question may startle and fluster some students so much that they may not be able to respond, even if they know the answer. State the

question clearly, giving one central thought, by placing the interrogative word at the beginning of the statement to alert students that a question is coming. Do not repeat the question or change the wording of the question unless necessary. After asking a question, pause to allow the students time to think through their answers.

Vary the duration of the pause depending on the difficulty of the question and the level of the students. Most instructors fail to pause long enough after asking their questions. Calling on a student too quickly is as detrimental as calling on the student before asking the question. After pausing for a reasonable time, call on a student by name to answer the question.

That satisfies a basic student need for recognition. If students feel you recognise their individual efforts, they will put forth greater effort. When selecting a person to respond, consider both the difficulty of the question and the individual abilities of students. Consistently assigning a difficulty question to a slower learner will remotivate that student. Spread the questions around without establishing a predictable pattern.

A predictable pattern includes calling on students either in alphabetical or seating order or calling upon a select few whose names you know. Scattering questions also prevents mental loafing. Faster learners will dominate the class if you do not control student participation. Achieve a balance between calling on volunteer respondents and non-volunteers. Allow only one student to answer at a time, but encourage all students to participate and volunteer answers. Although you may not call upon every student, let students know you expect them to take an active part. The next step is to comment on the given answer or acknowledge the response. That demands a careful and quick mental evaluation of the answer for accuracy and completeness. Provide feedback to the responder and class on the quality of the answer.

When a student gives an incorrect answer, be critical only of the answer and not the student. Be sure to provide positive reinforcement for correct answers. The strength of the reinforcement depends on the difficulty of the question asked and the relative difficulty level for the student selected. Do not overdo the reinforcement. A simple “correct” or “thank you” may suffice. The fifth and last step in the process, which is optional, is to emphasise or repeat the answer given.

## **ADVANTAGES OF ELECTRONIC COMMUNICATION**

The following points highlight on the advantages of electronic communication:

1. **Speedy transmission:** It requires only few seconds to communicate through electronic media because it supports quick transmission.
2. **Wide coverage:** World has become a global village and communication around the globe requires a second only.
3. **Low cost:** Electronic communication saves time and money. For example Text sms is cheaper than traditional letter.

4. Exchange of feedback: Electronic communication allows instant exchange of feedback. So communication becomes perfect using electronic media.
5. Managing global operation: Due to advancement of electronic media, business managers can easily control operation across the globe. Video or teleconferencing e-mail and mobile communication are helping managers in this regard.

## **DISADVANTAGES OF ELECTRONIC COMMUNICATION**

Electronic communication is not free from the below limitations:

1. Volume of data: The volume of telecommunication information is increasing in such a fast rate that business people are unable to absorb it within relevant time limit.
2. Cost of development: Electronic communication requires huge investment for infrastructural development. Frequent change in technology also demands for further investment.
3. Legal status: Data or information, if faxed, may be distorted and will cause zero value in the eye of law.
4. Undelivered data: Data may not be retrieved due to system error or fault with the technology. Hence required service will be delayed.
5. Dependency: Technology is changing everyday and therefore poor countries face problem as they cannot afford new or advanced technology. Therefore poor countries need to be dependent towards developed countries for sharing global network.

## **VOICEMAIL**

Voice Mail System (also known as voice mail, voice message or voice bank) is a computer-based system that allows users and subscribers to exchange personal voice messages; to select and deliver voice information; and to process transactions relating to individuals, organizations, products and services, using an ordinary telephone. The term is also used more broadly to denote any system of conveying a stored telecommunications voice messages, including using an answering machine. Most cell phones services offer voice-mail as a basic feature, many corporate PBXs include versatile internal voice-messaging services and \*98 Vertical service code subscription is available to most individual and small business land line subscribers.

## **HISTORY OF VOICEMAIL**

The term Voicemail was coined by Televoice International (later became Voicemail International) for introduction of the first US wide Voicemail® service in 1980. Although VMI trademarked the term, it eventually became a generic term used for referring to virtually all automated voice services employing a telephone. Voicemail popularity

continues today with Internet telephone services such as Skype, Google Voice and ATT that integrate voice, voicemail and text services for tablets and smartphones. Voicemail systems were developed in the late 70s by Voice Message Exchange (VMX). They became popular in the early 80s when they were made available on PC-based boards. In September 2012 a report from USA Today and Vonage claimed that Voice mail was in decline. The report said that the number of voicemail messages declined 8 percent compared to 2011.

### **Voicemail features**

Voicemail systems are designed to convey a caller's recorded audio message to a recipient. To do so they contain a user interface to select, play, and manage messages; a delivery method to either play or otherwise deliver the message; and a notification ability to inform the user of a waiting message. Most systems use phone networks, either cellular- or landline-based, as the conduit for all of these functions. Some systems may use multiple telecommunications methods, permitting recipients and callers to retrieve or leave messages through multiple methods such as PCs, PDA, Cellphones or Smartphones. Simple voicemail systems function as a remote answering machine using touch-tones as the user interface. More complicated systems may use other input devices such as voice or a computer interface. Simpler voice-mail systems may play the audio message through the phone, while more advanced systems may have alternative delivery methods, including e-mail or text message delivery, message transfer and forwarding options, and multiple mailboxes.

Almost all modern voicemail systems use digital storage and are typically stored on computer data storage. Notification methods also vary based on the voice-mail system. Simple systems may not provide active notification at all, instead requiring the recipient to check with the system, while others may provide an indication that messages are waiting. More advanced systems may be integrated with a company's PABX, with a call center ACD for automatic call distribution; with mobile or paging terminals for message alert; and computer systems/data bases for delivering information or processing orders. Interactive Voice Response (IVR) systems may use digital information stored in a corporate data base to select pre-recorded words and phrases stored in a voice-mail vocabulary to form sentences that are delivered to the caller.

### **Message centers**

The conventional solution to efficient handling of telephone communication in businesses was the "message center." A message center or "message desk" was a centralized, manual answering service inside a company staffed by a few operators who answered all incoming phone calls. Extensions that were busy or rang "no answer" would forward to the message center using a device called a "call director". The call director had a button for each extension in the company which would flash when that

person's extension forwarded to the message center. A little label next to the button told the operator the person being called. While it was an improvement over basic multi-line systems, the message center had many disadvantages. Many calls would come in simultaneously at peak periods, such as lunch time, and operators were often busy. This left message attendants with little time to take each message accurately. Often, they were not familiar with employees' names and "buzzwords" and how to spell or pronounce them. Messages were scribbled on pink slips and distributed by the internal mail system and messages, often arrived at people's desks after lengthy delays, contained little content other than the caller's name and number, and were often inaccurate, with misspelled names and wrong phone numbers.

Tape-based telephone answering machines had come into the residential telephone market, but they weren't used much in the corporate environment due to physical limitations of the technology. One answering machine was needed for each telephone; messages couldn't be recorded if the user was using the phone; messages had to be retrieved in sequential order; and messages couldn't be retrieved remotely, selectively discarded, saved, or forwarded to others. Further, the manufacturers of PBXs (private branch exchanges—the name for corporate phone systems) used proprietary digital phone sets in order to increase the functionality and value of the PBX. These phone sets were, by design, incompatible with answering machines.

In the 1970s and early 1980s, the cost of long distance calling decreased and more business communications were conducted by telephone. As corporations grew and labour rates increased, the ratio of secretaries to employees decreased. With multiple time zones, fewer secretaries and more communication by phone, real-time phone communications were hampered by callers being unable to reach people. Some early studies showed that only 1 in 4 phone calls resulted in a completed call and half the calls were one-way in nature (that is, they did not require a conversation). This happened because people were either not at work (due to time zone differences, being away on business, etc.), or if they were at work, they were on the phone, away from their desks in meetings, on breaks, etc. This bottleneck hindered the effectiveness of business activities and decreased both individual and group productivity. It also wasted the caller's time and created delays in resolving time-critical issues.

### **Voicemail invention**

The first public records describing voice recording were reported in a New York newspaper and the *Scientific American* in November, 1877. Thomas A. Edison had announced the invention of his "phonograph" saying "the object was to record telephone messages and transmit them again by telephone." Edison applied for a U. S. patent on December 1877 and shortly thereafter demonstrated the machine to publishers, the U.S. congress and President Hayes, recording and playing "Mary had a little lamb..." and "there was a little girl who had a little curl..." and other ditties popular at the time.



In an article outlining his own ideas of the future usefulness of his machine Edison's list began with "Letter writing, and all kinds of dictation without the aid of a stenographer." In other words, "voice messages" or "Voice-mail". By 1914, Edison's phonograph business included a dictating machine (the Ediphone) and the "Telescribe", a machine combining the phonograph and the telephone, which recorded both sides of telephone conversations.

For nearly one hundred years, there were few innovations or advances in telephone services. Voicemail was the result of innovations in telephone products and services made possible by developments in computer technology during the 1970s. These innovations began with the Motorola Pageboy, a simple "pager" or "beeper" introduced in 1974 that was generally offered in conjunction with answering services that handled busy/ no-answer overloads and after hours calls for businesses and professionals. Operators wrote down a caller's message, sent a page alert or "beep" and when the party called back, an operator dictated the message.

With the introduction of "voice" pagers, like the Motorola Pageboy II operators could transmit a voice message directly to the pager and the user could hear the message. However, messages arrival was often untimely and privacy issues as well as the high cost eventually caused the demise of these services. By the mid 1970s digital storage and analog to digital conversion devices had emerged and paging companies began handling client messages electronically. Operators recorded a short message (5–6 seconds, *e.g.* "please call Mr. Smith") and the messages were delivered automatically when the client called the answering service. It would only take a short step for the first voicemail application to be born.

Computer manufacturers, telephone equipment manufacturers and software firms began developing more sophisticated solutions as more powerful and less expensive computer processors and storage devices became available. This set the stage for a creation of a broad spectrum of computer based Central Office and Customer Premises Equipment that would eventually support enhanced voice solutions such as voicemail, audiotex, interactive voice response (IVR) and speech recognition solutions that began emerging in the 1980s. However, broad adoption of these products and services would depend on the global proliferation of touch tone phones and mobile phone services which would not occur until the late 1980s.

### **Invention of voicemail controversy**

Many contributed to the creation of the modern-day voice-mail. Legal battles ensued for decades. The true first inventor of voicemail, patent number 4,124,773 (Audio Storage and Distribution System), is Elkins. "Though Elkins received a patent in 1978, telecommunications giants began offering voicemail without paying Elkins a penny in royalties." "Elkins never expected to spend 10 years of his life battling some of the world's largest corporations, either. But once he patented his system, he figured he

should protect it.”Later, Elkins successfully licensed his patented technology to IBM, DEC, WANG, among many others. Unfortunately, his patent did not address simultaniety of voice message access and storage and the application for patent was filed after the patent application of the system patented by Kolodny and Hughes. as described below.

### **Pioneering applications**

One of the first modern day voicemail applications was invented by Gerald M. Kolodny and Paul Hughes, which was described in an article in the medical journal, Radiology (Kolodny GM, Cohen HI, Kalisky A. Rapid-access system for radiology reports: a new concept. Radiology. 1974;111(3):717-9) A patent was applied for by Kolodny and Hughes in 1975, prior to the patent applications of both Elkins and Matthews and was issued in 1981 (U.S. patent 4,260,854). The patent was assigned to Sudbury Systems of Sudbury Massachusetts who proceeded to market and sell such systems to corporations and hospitals. IBM, Sony and Lanier, as well as several smaller makers of voice-mail systems, licensed the Sudbury patent for their voice-mail systems. A patent suit, brought by Pitney Bowes, claiming prior art to the Sudbury patent, was denied by the U.S. District Court, District of Connecticut on November 8, 2000. A similar suit brought byVDI Technologies against the Kolodny and Hughes patent claiming prior art was dismissed by the U.S. District Court in New Hampshire on 12/19/1991.

### **IBM Audio Distribution System**

The first voice-messaging application, the Speech Filing System, was developed at the IBM Thomas J. Watson Research Center in 1973 under the leadership of Stephen Boies. It was later renamed the Audio Distribution System (ADS).

ADS used the human voice and the fixed-line touch-tone telephones that predated computer screens and mobile phones. The first operational prototypes were used by 750 IBM executives mainly in the USA for their daily work. Those prototypes ran on an IBM System/7 computer attached to an IBM VM370 for additional storage.

In 1978 the prototype was converted to run on an IBM Series/1 computer. In September 1981 IBM started marketing ADS in America and Europe: the first customer installation was completed in February 1982. ADS, marketed by IBM and briefly by AT&T Corporation, was well featured for voice messaging, the result of IBM’s considerable human-factors research plus observation of operational use. Using a 1980s computer requiring air conditioning, it was expensive and physically large. With further development it grew to handle up to 3000 users, 100 hours of messages, multiple languages, message notification to a host computer, and 16 simultaneous users.

ADS could be connected to exchange lines and private exchanges including the IBM 2750 and 3750 Switching Systems available in Germany, France, Italy, Belgium, and the UK.

*IBM sold many systems. Installations included:*

- The 1984 Atlanta Olympic Games with 7 systems serving 7800 athletes and 6000 staff — and computer voice prompts in 12 languages for 55,000 messages
- General Motors, USA with 8 ADS systems saving 30% of the costs of its long-distance calls
- Systems across America and Europe for insurance-company staff to report their appraisals of damaged vehicles and hear the locations of their next appraisal sites
- Esso in France and Mars in England for salesforce coordination
- Rowntree's in York, England to liaise with the chocolate-makers' agents across time zones in Europe, North America, the Middle East, and Australia
- *Italy*: 10 systems across Italy for the public to call to hear locally-relevant autostrade traffic-delay information
- *Milan, Italy*: two systems for automated airport announcements, handling multiple languages.

### **Delta 1**

Another company, Delphi Communications of California, deserves some partial credit for invention of voicemail. Under the leadership of Jay Stoffer, Delphi developed a proprietary system called Delta 1 that picked up incoming calls directly from the telephone company. Stoffer presented the Delphi concept publicly to the association of Telephone Answering Services around 1973 and the prototype system was launched in San Francisco in 1976 by a Delphi company called VoiceBank. Delphi developed Delta 1 as a purely service-oriented voice messaging system to answer subscriber telephones for businesses and professionals. Delta 1 required human intervention for message deposit. While three machines were built, only one machine was put into operational service. The completely automated voice messaging system (Delta 2) was developed for initial operational use in Los Angeles in 1981. Apparently Delta 2 was built, installed and operational for a short while, but unfortunately Delphi's major early investor, Exxon Enterprises, abruptly shut down Delphi in July, 1982. Nothing further was done with Delphi's technology. A patent was applied for and issued for Delphi's Automated Telephone Voice Service System. The patent, U.S. Patent No. 4,625,081, was issued after Delphi's closure, but Delphi's assets (and the patent) were transferred to another Exxoncompany, Gilbarco, which made equipment for gas pumps at filling stations. Gilbarco is now owned by GEC in the United Kingdom.

### **VMX**

In 1979, a company was founded in Texas by Gordon Matthews called ECS Communications (the name was later changed to VMX, for Voice Message exchange). VMX developed a 3000-user voice messaging system called the VMX/64 and was the

first company to offer a voice messaging system for sale commercially for corporate use. In the early 1980s, VMX sold voice messaging systems to several large corporations, such as 3M, Kodak, American Express, Intel, Hoffmann–La Roche, Corning Glass, Arco, Shell Canada and Westinghouse. The impressive list of early adopters started the ball rolling on corporate voice-mail. While VMX began with a good start, it failed at developing the market, and the company was not a commercial success. It took several years before its products could answer outside calls (and then only under certain circumstances), they were physically enormous, expensive, light on important user features and had serious reliability issues. In addition, the user interface was cumbersome, requiring the users to remember non-intuitive multi-digit Touch-tone commands. Matthews, a prolific entrepreneur and patenter, applied for and was granted a patent on voice-mail (patent number 4,371,752) which issued in February, 1983. The patent was promoted as the pioneering patent for voice-mail. However, the patent application was filed on 11/26/1979, 5 years after and issued in 1983, 2 years after that of Kolodny and Hughes as described above, and cannot therefore be considered as the pioneering foundation of voice mail.

VMX asserted infringement first with IBM, AT&T and then Wang, but all three companies reportedly would have been able to invalidate the patent on the basis of prior art and their licenses from Sudbury Systems Inc, for their Kolodny and Hughes patent (see above). VMX cleverly achieved a settlement where the patent was let stand, not challenged in court and IBM, Wang and AT&T (in separate settlements) received royalty-free licenses to all VMX patents. Wang, the last of the majors to get such a license for itself and Voice-mail International, essentially paid \$20,000 and cross licensed a few patent applications (not issued patents).

IBM and AT&T also cross-licensed a number of patents to VMX, most of which were obsolete or outdated. VMX could claim that several major companies licensed the patent (even though they paid almost nothing to VMX for the rights), but that part wasn't disclosed. The patent was never challenged in court and VMX then continued to assert (incorrectly) that it had invented voice-mail and that Matthews was the “father of voice-mail”. Following the settlement with Wang, VMX settled with Octel Communications in exchange for a small payment and Octel's agreeing not to litigate any VMX patent, Octel received a paid-up, royalty-free license on all existing and future VMX patents.

### **IVR Voice Recognition**

In 1985, Voice Response Inc. (formerly Call-It Co) a subsidiary of Lee Enterprises, Davenport IA, entered the fast-growing Interactive Voice (IVR) response market under the direction of Bob Ross, President. About a year later, VRI introduced one of the first “successful” IVR applications that utilized voice recognition (rather than touch tone) to capture caller responses. Voice recognition technology had great difficulty with

regional and ethnic differences and nuances which resulted in a high incidence of error. VRI discovered that hesitation (delayed response) signaled caller confusion or misunderstanding which often resulted in an inaccurate response. VRI developed proprietary techniques that measured user response times and used the data to make real-time changes to the application's dialog with the caller. VRI found that the confidence level of a "suspect" caller response could be increased by asking "Did you say (Chicago), Yes or No", a standard question heard in order taking or reservation making IVR applications today. VRI pioneering applications, including subscription fulfillment for Time -Life Magazine, proved faster and less expensive than call centers using live operators and although VRI did not survive, their voice recognition processes became industry standards and VRI's patent USPTO - patent RE34,587 was eventually licensed by Intel/Dialogic and Nuance.

## MULTIMEDIA

The use of computers to present text, graphics, video, animation, and sound in an integrated way. Long touted as the future revolution in computing, multimedia applications were, until the mid-90s, uncommon due to the expensive hardware required. With increases in performance and decreases in price, however, multimedia is now commonplace. Nearly all PCs are capable of displaying video, though the resolution available depends on the power of the computer's video adapter and CPU.

Multimedia is the use of text, pictures, audio, and/or video to deliver information. Multimedia is technology, content, applications, and people. It encompasses many concepts and ideas that are important to understand. Specific terminology pertaining to multimedia include:

*Information:* Facts, ideas, beliefs and stories that when communicated, provide value to the receiver in the context of multimedia, information comes in many forms including text, pictures, audio and video. This term is included because multimedia falls into the greater realm of computer-based information systems technology.

*Domain:* A domain in the multimedia world is a relatively narrow or focused area of information or knowledge such as astronomy or famous authors, but it can also be a broader area of organized information such as encyclopaedia.

*Interactivity:* A stimulus-response behaviour in which a computer programme presents options that the user can select from that lead to further options. Multimedia software applications are designed to logically organize information, making it easily accessible to cyclopedia offers the user a list of letters from A to Z to narrow the search for a specific subject. When the user clicks on a letter, he or she is presented with a list of subjects in alphabetic order within the selected letter to further narrow the search. The user then selects the specific subject and is presented with information. Interactivity, in this case, is used to enable the user to rapidly locate and view information.

*Application:* A computer programme that serves a specific purpose or use such as word processing or spreadsheet programme. Multimedia products include games, educational programmes and corporate briefings to name a few. Multimedia products may also be referred to as products.

*Content:* Specific information for a multimedia product in the form of text, pictures, audio and video. Content may start out on paper or videotape but is then captured to digital format for editing and incorporation into a multimedia product. Multimedia products typically contain a set of multimedia content that is specific and unique to that application.

*Developers:* Managers, designers, programmers, graphic artists and other skilled individuals who participate in the development of multimedia products. Sometimes referred to as producers.

*Users (also known as End Users):* Those individuals or groups who use and/or apply multimedia products for work or play.

*Authoring Tools:* Software programmes for developing and delivering multimedia products. Tools include programmes for text and graphic editing, audio and video capture and editing and multimedia authoring.

*Product:* A completed multimedia product that is distributed for use by end users. Products are often sold to consumers via commercial outlets.

## **HISTORY OF MULTIMEDIA**

Since the late 1970s, desktop computers used in the home and office have evolved into sophisticated systems that help us get our jobs done, deliver information, and provide entertainment.

Presents a timeline of some of the key technologies that have contributed to the evolution of multimedia computers. Do not worry if some of these terms, especially the ones pertaining to hardware, seem unfamiliar to you right now, because they will be discussed in detail later in this book.

The main point is multimedia technology did not happen overnight.

Multimedia technology has changed the way we look at computers. The first computers were seen as single-purpose machines that solved incredibly complex mathematical problems. During the 1960s, mainframe computers were used to manage large corporate databases and financial systems. The 1970s saw computer terminals throughout an organization being used for publishing and information management. The 1980s brought the desktop computer so everyone could have a computer at his or desk for word processing, spreadsheets, and even games. Bringing the computer to the individual in the office, the home, and the classroom meant looking at the computer as more than just a fancy typewriter or automated bookkeeper.

In the mid-1980s and into the 1990s, computer developers started looking at how computers could be used as never before.



*At the same time, advances in technology brought about:*

1. Faster desktop computers
2. Increased working memory capacity in computers
3. Higher data storage capacity in disk drives and CD-ROMs
4. Digital audio and video
5. Graphic operating systems that worked by pointing and clicking at objects on the screen instead of having to remember cryptic command sequences such as “dir .exe” to find a programme
6. Local and wide area networks that connected users to the world
7. Thousands of applications ranging from word procesors to a myriad of multimedia products that have changed the workplace, classroom, and the home.

Computer developers started looking to multimedia – the delivery of information using text, pictures, audio, and video—as a way to utilize computers in a uniquely personal way. Multimedia computers could be used to increase efficiency and productivity on the job, provide information at our fingertips in the home, and help students learn more effectively both in and out of the classroom. These personal gains meant that people would see computers as practical and useful tools in their everyday lives.

*Since the late 1980s, multimedia technology and applications have found many places in our lives:*

- At home where a wide variety of games and reference products such as encyclopaedias and cookbooks are put to use
- At the office where marketing presentations and training are essential how to get a new job done
- At school where interactive software programmes assist students in learning mathematics, science, and new languages
- In shopping malls where interactive computer terminals, called kiosks, help us to design greeting cards or to find out where specific stores are located.

The impact of multimedia technology on our daily lives is often more than we realise. The bottom line is that if there is a need to inform, teach, or entertain multimedia technology can play a key role.

## **MULTIMEDIA SYSTEMS**

A *Multimedia System* is a system capable of processing multimedia data and applications. A *Multimedia System* is characterised by the processing, storage, generation, manipulation and rendition of Multimedia information.

## **CHARACTERISTICS OF A MULTIMEDIA SYSTEM**

*A Multimedia system has four basic characteristics:*

- Multimedia systems must be *computer controlled*.
- Multimedia systems are *integrated*.



- The information they handle must be represented *digitally*.
- The interface to the final presentation of media is usually *interactive*.

### CHALLENGES FOR MULTIMEDIA SYSTEMS

Supporting multimedia applications over a computer network renders the application *distributed*. This will involve many special computing techniques — discussed later.

Multimedia systems may have to render a variety of media at the same instant — a distinction from normal applications. There is a temporal relationship between many forms of media (*e.g.* Video and Audio).

*There are two forms of problems here:*

- Sequencing within the media — *playing frames in correct order/time frame in video*
- *Synchronisation* — inter-media scheduling (*e.g.* Video and Audio). Lip synchronisation is clearly important for humans to watch playback of video and audio and even animation and audio. Ever tried watching an out of (lip) sync film for a long time?

*The key issues multimedia systems need to deal with here are:*

- How to represent and store temporal information.
- How to strictly maintain the temporal relationships on play back/retrieval
- What process are involved in the above.

Data has to be represented *digitally* so many initial source of data needs to be *digitise* — translated from analog source to digital representation. This will involve scanning (graphics, still images), sampling (audio/video) although digital cameras now exist for direct scene to digital capture of images and video. The data is *large* several Mb easily for audio and video— therefore storage, transfer (bandwidth) and processing overheads are high. Data compression techniques very common.

### MODERN COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGIES

As the name itself implies, new communication technologies are those which are of more recent origin. Interactivity is their distinguishing feature. For the purpose of this unit, new communication technologies can also be understood as those which are capable of a much higher degree of interactivity than that offered by the traditional communication technologies. Writing, printing and electronic media like radio and television are examples of traditional technologies which are essentially one-way in nature. Therefore, their interactive capabilities are very limited. Besides, this limited interactivity occurs after considerable delay. For example, a newspaper which depends on the traditional technology for print can be said to be interactive to the extent that it publishes readers' letters in its 'letters to the editor' column. Similarly, a radio station too is interactive in that it broadcasts programmes which carry responses to audience

queries. We can, therefore, say that interactivity is at best a marginal property of traditional communication media. In the new communication technologies, on the other hand, interactivity is the main property. The use of computers in one form or the other, as an integral part of their system, is what enables them to be interactive. In the following sections, we will take up for study some of the main technologies under this category.

*Computer Networks:* The idea of interlinking and communicating with the aid of computers was as old as the mainframe computers of the 1970s. Owing to their prohibitive price, the mainframes came to be owned only by mega-establishments like governments, big business houses, universities etc. Individuals could not afford them for personal use. At the same time, the high cost of the mainframes required their owners to find ways and means to maximize their utilization in order to make them cost effective. The networking of computers, it was found, allowed simultaneous access to a single mainframe by any number of users. Naturally, this development suited owners and users alike. Computer networks thus emerged as a kind of public utility to help users communicate with a central computing facility such as a database, and retrieve information too. In the decades that followed, computer technology advanced by leaps and bounds. This resulted in the invention of much smaller computers that displayed greater capabilities at just a fraction of the price.

At present the use of computer networks for various specialized and general purposes has become quite common, even in the less developed parts of the world. In our own country, computer networks are widely used by public sector organizations, big business houses, government department etc., for their day-to-day transactions. Indian Airlines, Indian Railways and a few state undertakings own computer networks dedicated to managing their operations. Such real-time flow of information enables planners and other decision makers at the headquarters to decide on appropriate policies, taking into consideration the latest statistics. In the absence of such computer networking in the past, it is said that vital decisions at the national level had to be taken with the help of data which were at least a decade old! Apart from helping administrators, NICNET is also said to be regularly used for other application like exchange of expert medical advice by specialists to doctors working in remote areas.

On a global scale, INERNET is the largest computer network which permeated almost all parts of the world. Composed of thousands of interconnected networks initially in the united states, INTERNET can offer you an immense range of information services such as electronic mail file transfer, databases and multi-media INTERNET also provides connectivity to mobile receivers through a wireless broadcasting service operating on satellite links. Computer networks have several advantages over interpersonal communication. Asynchronocity that is the flexibility inherent in the system to enable information exchange without the need for the sender and the recipient to be present simultaneously, is one such advantage. However, it also suffers from various drawbacks like the lack of a human touch. Communication

engineers constantly endeavour to improve the so-called 'user friendliness' of the system concerned by approximating it to interpersonal interaction.

*Teleconferencing:* Teleconferencing is a mean by which individuals or groups located at different places can exchange data, speech, visual materials like graphs or diagrams, or moving pictures of themselves and any other relevant information. Teleconferencing is made possible by the integration of computers and communication in such a manner as to form a holistic system which can work in real-time. Depending on the particular application, scope and complexity involved, Teleconferencing can be classified under the following types:

- *Computer conferencing:* in the case, only computer data can be exchanged among multiple locations. Real time interaction among the location is possible, but only the extent of computer data. The physical linkages among the several computers can be in the form of telephone wires or through wireless means as in the case of microwave or satellite.
- *Audio conferencing:* In this participant can actually talk to one another as if in a face to face situation facilities are provided for any one location to talk any other or all of them simultaneously. In addition, audio teleconferences also enable exchange of computer data on the same physical link (telephone cables or wireless). Audio teleconferencing enables real time exchange of information without losing the human touch.
- *Audio Graphic conferencing:* This is a more advanced form of audio teleconferencing in which, in addition to audio and computer data, still graphics like drawing, maps etc, can also be exchanged. Further refinements in technology enable even slow scan video pictures to be exchanged as a part of the audio teleconferencing system. The same pairs of telephone wires would suffice to carry all the above 'Bandwidth Compression' techniques which are technically known as ISDN (integrated data network services).
- *Video conferencing:* This is the highest form of teleconferencing in which a two-way exchange of moving pictures is possible without any restriction, in addition to audio and data. The telecommunication links required for such conferencing system prove to be very costly because of the fact that moving pictures need very wide bandwidths. Hence, a lower version of video teleconferencing which is called 'one-way video and two-way audio is gaining currency. In the latter case, the main location (typically the headquarters of an organization) will have facilities for sending audio as well as video which are received by all the remote locations. But the remote locations will have facilities for sending only audio, and not video. In other words, while the remote locations can receive both—pictures and voices—they will be able to respond only through voice. Teleconferencing of this kind has been widely experimented with by many organizations in India using satellite links.

Already, Teleconferencing has been an accepted form of technology in advanced countries, especially for business communications. It is only a matter of time before this technology becomes popular in countries such as ours, because the necessary infrastructure like telephone links and satellite are already available. Teleconferencing is gaining popularity due to the minimal physical travel demanded of its participants. The time-saving involved in this process is also a significant factor. The experience of advanced countries has been that, apart from economizing on time and travel, teleconferencing also help in improving corporate efficiency and participatory management.

*Teletext:* Teletext is a form of broadcast technology by means of which several 'pages' of textual information (say, latest weather reports, stock exchange figures, airline train reservations etc.) Can be transmitted on an already existing television channel. The teletext information is encoded in the so called 'vertical blanking interval' of the television screen which is invisible in the normal course of television viewing. However, when activated by a teletext 'decoder' at the receiving end, the television screen starts displaying the-teletext information in lieu of the normal TV programme. Facilities exist in teletext to enable viewers to choose a particular page of teletext containing relevant information which serves their needs, and recall that particular page. Thus, a businessman wanting to know the latest trend in the stock exchange can press his decoder for the particular page containing stock market news, and get the display on' his TV screen instantly. He will be able to view that page as long as he wishes, or he can turn over to some other page or revert back to the normal TV programme as per his wish. TV stations equipped with a teletext service, normally update the information at regular intervals, say every half an hour, for the benefit of the viewers. About 300 teletext pages (a page means one TV frame containing information) can be accommodated per TV channel and a collection of these pages goes by the name of 'teletext magazine'. The pages of a teletext magazine can incorporate illustrations like graphs, bar charts etc., in addition to simple text. The Delhi Station of Doordarshan provides a teletext service on the second channel; access to it is possible with the help of a decoder. The magazine contains specific pages earmarked for national and international news, travel information, sports, local announcements, weather reports etc. A few main pages of the magazine are also put out in the 'picture mode' *i.e.*, on the main channel itself for the benefit of use not equipped with decoders. It is possible to extend this service to other Doordarshan stations for the benefit of viewers all over the country: Teletext is a simple technology which can be used to advantage for public communication. The advantages inherent in broadcast media such as instant and widespread reach, to an unlimited clientele, are applicable to teletext as well. Different countries have teletext services which conform to different technical standards, and a universal code of transmission is yet to be invented. Its essential simplicity, instantaneous dissemination of messages and ease of updating information make it a worthwhile technology with myriad applications.

*Radio Text:* Better known by the term 'Radio data systems' (RDS), Radio text is a technology similar to Teletext but with the important difference that it works in conjunction with FM Radio (frequency Modulation) while Teletext works on television. While conventional radio broadcasts on medium wave and shortwave bands have the advantage of larger service areas for a given radio station, the severe congestion of radio stations in these bands in recent years has forced the use of higher frequency bands for radio transmission. Use of these higher frequency bands as in the case of the FM Radio, however, would mean restricting the reach of a radio station essentially to line of sight range which is about 30 km radius. FM stations are ideal as local radio stations, as they can offer programmes of local community interest, high fidelity music, local news etc., to the public. Radio text is to be seen as a value-added service on FM Radio. This technology essentially consists of transmitting data and other textual material piggyback on the FM carrier so that the listeners/viewers who are equipped with a radiotext 'decoder' can extract this signal from an ongoing FM transmission and watch the same on a computer screen which forms a part of the radiotext receiving system. Facilities are available in a decoder to select either the radiotext or the normal FM transmission at will. In addition, the listeners or viewers, as in the case of teletext, will be able to select the particular page of information of their interest and hold on to it for any length of time. Audio signals of speech quality (*i.e.*, of restricted bandwidth) can also form part of a radiotext signal. This would mean that institutions like Open Universities can transmit their audio lessons or radiotext, while simultaneously transmitting portions of their print material. Experiments of thin kind are already underway with the joint 'collaboration of All India Radio and Yashwantreo Chavan Maharashtra State Open University, Nasik. An important deterrent for widespread use of Radiotext of such applications, however, is that the receiving system works out to be several times costlier than the FM Radio set itself. Moreover, FM Radio is still in its infancy in our country and the availability of FM radio sets is rather rare. Under the circumstances, the widespread use of Radiotext in our country will be unlikely in the near future.

*Videotext:* Videotex (please note the absence of 't' at the end of the word) is another form of interactive communication technology which is in wide usage in several advanced countries. While the teletext operates on television and radio text on FM radio, Videotext works with the help of the public telephone network. The home computer, telephone connection and the domestic TV set/computer screen form integral components of a Videotext system. Customers provided with Videotext facilities can make use of it for such varied applications as electronic shopping, access to databases, tele-banking, or exchanging messages with friends. As Videotext is essentially interactive it has much more to offer than teletext or radio text in terms of selective information exchange and retrieval. However, a well developed and reliable telephone network is essential for operating a Videotext service. For this reason, as of now, Videotext services

are popular only in advanced countries. With gradual improvements taking place by way of digital telephone exchanges and replacement of conventional telephone wires with optical fibres, the reliability as well as capacity of telephone systems everywhere are bound to increase in due course. Value-added services like the Videotext too are expected to gain in popularity alongside such developments.

*Interactive Cable Distribution Systems:* Dissemination of television programmes via cable to a community of households started in the 50s. To begin with advantages of cable distribution was seen as improving the reception conditions of television in isolated mountainous-regions. Later on, TV signals received via satellite were put out on cable distribution systems, thus offering many more TV channels for the viewers. With this, the popularity and spread of cable distribution systems grew dramatically. Concurrently with the distribution of satellite channels, facilities like 'pay TV' in which individual viewers have the choice of receiving programmes of their preference at a price, have also been introduced. In other words, the cable systems have been endowed with interactive properties. Advancements in digital technology and fibre optics have resulted in further improved versions of cable distribution. For example, viewers in the advanced countries can now make use of the cable for receiving programmes of their choice at the press of a button. The selected programme is then down-loaded by the cable company onto the viewer's terminal as a compressed 'digital packet' in a matter of seconds. The programme is then held in the electronic memory of the receiving terminal which can be viewed straightaway or some time at leisure. The asynchronicity of interactive cable distribution systems is a unique advantage in the gamut of new communication technologies.

*Communication Satellites:* Transnational television, *i.e.*, transmission of television programmes from one country to, another, became a reality with the development of Communication Satellites. These satellites are stationed in an orbit above the earth's equator at a height of about 36,000 km. called the geo-stationary orbit. All satellites parked in the geostationary orbit have a period of rotation equal to 24 hours and hence, appear stationary to an observer on the earth. Besides, the great distance of the orbit also offers the advantage of the satellite to 'see' as much as one-third of the earth's surface thus enabling it to cover such a vast area. Communication Satellites are owned by various individual nations as well as collectively by groups of nations to cater for several applications like broadcasting, television and telecommunications. INTELSAT (International Telecommunications Satellite Consortium) is an international body consisting of more than 90 member countries of which India is one. The satellites commissioned by INTELSAT cater to, the collective needs of the member countries as per a mutually agreed tariff structure. Ground terminals (these are known as earth stations) for receiving/sending signals from/to the satellites are located in several places in the member countries. In India, two such earth stations have been established for the INTELSAT network—one near Pune and the other near Dehradun. Most of the



international telecommunications traffic and exchange with other countries of live coverage of events takes place via the INTELSAT network. India is credited with taking several major initiatives in the field of satellite communications. The famous SITE experiment (Satellite Instructional Television Experiment) during 1975-76, in which about 2400 remote villages in the country were served by television programmes via satellite, is a case in point. The experiment has proved the efficacy of satellite communications as a cost effective means for countrywide dissemination of educational and developmental TV programmes. Gradually, our country has developed its own satellite system, INSAT (Indian National Satellite System). INSAT is a multi-purpose satellite service catering to telecommunications, radio and TV transmission and weather forecasting.

The second generation of INSAT satellites which are currently in operation, have a larger number of transporters which can be used for further expansion of satellite communications. In particular, regional telecasting can be extended in all language zones and new services like teleconferencing introduced. Mushrooming of satellite-based transnational television in recent years is a cause for concern as well as hope. The sudden spurt in the availability of satellite channels all over the country from across our borders would mean a potential threat to our own national broadcast media. The virtual absence of any legal mechanisms to check or control these transmissions of external origin can jeopardize our own priorities in the communication sector and divert the attention of the populace away from important information on developmental activities. On the other hand, the competitive presence of external channels call motivate the local broadcasters to become more professional and quality conscious. Direct Broadcast Satellites (DBS) are specially designed for broadcast applications so that the signals transmitted from them can be directly received by home receivers equipped with a small dish antenna (typically half a meter diameter) and an interfacing unit. Use of such satellites obviates the need for land based retransmitting stations (called LPTs). DBS is in extensive use in Europe, the USA and Japan.

As mentioned earlier, the application areas to which multi purpose satellites like the INSAT can be put to use are many and varied. Satellite communications have in fact become so common that we take them for granted. Whenever you dial a long distance telephone call, say from India to the USA, your voice and that of the person you have called travel via some satellite route or the other, most probably via the INTELSAT network. You may notice in such cases, a very small but clearly discernible delay of a fraction of a second in receiving the response of the other person. A similar delay will be felt by the person at the other end while receiving your voice. This is because of the extraordinarily long journey of thousands of kilometres which the voice signals have to traverse on the satellite route. Of course, such delays are common not only to telephone conversations but also all other traffic taking place through satellite communications. Many national newspapers which are published



simultaneously from multiple locations take advantage of satellite communication for instant transmission of their pages from one publishing centre to another. For example The Hindu has arrangements for publishing its Delhi edition by transmitting pages from Madras to Delhi through INSAT.

### COMPARISON OF NEW COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGIES

In the foregoing sections, we have surveyed the salient features of some of the new communication technologies individually. It is to be noted, however, that real-life situations often employ the simultaneous use of more than one technology in a given situation. For example, the STAR TV programmes that you receive on your home TV set, reach you by means of satellite communications up to the point of your cable operator's terminal, and from then on, via cable. Similarly, a long distance telephone call may get connected via microwave or a submarine cable for part of the route and via satellite for the rest of its journey.

Such combinations, however, usually do not affect the technical quality of the communication in question. So, the users for the most part remain unaware of the details of the technology mix involved. Nevertheless, every technology has its distinct attributes, advantages and disadvantages, because of which an optimal technology selection is possible for any given application. Some of these have already been discussed in the concerned sections earlier; what follows is a relative assessment of the various technologies with regard to communication parameters like interactivity, asynchronicity and demassification.

*Interactivity:* While interactivity is a property in which the new communication technologies, as a rule, excel over the traditional ones, some of them are evidently much more interactive than others. Teleconferencing and video teleconferencing can be cited as the most interactive while, teletext or radiotext can be placed at the other end of the interactivity scale. Even in the traditional communication media, the ordinary telephone is a very good interactive device. The strength of the new technologies in this regard, is that their interactivity is much more extensive and is not necessarily limited to just two individuals as in the case of the telephone.

*Asynchronicity:* The term asynchronicity refers to that property of the medium whereby the simultaneous presence of all the participants in a communication exercise is not compulsory. For example, in a computer network, facilities like "store and forward" enables the message to be retrieved at a convenient time other than the one at which the message has actually been sent. Thus, while real time exchange of communications is possible through such a technology, it offers the added flexibility of asynchronicity. The degree of asynchronicity varies from one technology to the other. It can be said to be the highest where only computers are required to interact without live human intervention, as in the case of Electronic Mail, or computer data are only kind of teleconferencing. It is least in a two-way video teleconferencing.

*Demassification:* Traditional media like press, radio or television are instances of 'one-to-many' kind of communications. Therefore, they are unsuitable where the communication needs are more individualized. Demassification refers to the extent to which a given technology can lend itself to such individualized communication. The normal telephone system is an ideal example of a technology endowed with a high degree of demassification. New communication technologies in general possess this characteristic while at the same time enabling communication among large groups or individuals dispersed over large areas. In other words, the new communication technologies are the reverse of the traditional technologies. Teleconferencing or computer communication is high in their demassification while teletext is at the lower end of the demassification ladder.

## **SOCIAL ISSUES**

As we have noted earlier, the new communication technologies have not yet penetrated sufficiently in Third World countries like ours. Therefore, we will not be able to determine their likely impact on our society with any degree of certainty. What we can conjecture in this regard is by studying the experience of developed countries like the USA which have been using these technologies over a considerable period and by extrapolating the impact of some of the present technologies like television. Noted communications scholar, Everett Rogers, says that the new communication technologies have a marked social impact in the following respects, especially during their adaptability stages.

- As newer technologies are relatively costlier and knowledge-intensive, they will be adopted only by the higher echelons of society at first, who can really afford them. Thus, ironically, communication gaps would widen among several sections of society because of the new communication technologies. This phenomenon is, of course, not unique for the new technologies. When television was introduced, a similar thing has happened as only the rich could embrace this medium in the beginning. As the ownership of TV sets gradually increased, the initial imbalances have become less pronounced. A similar situation is expected in the case of the new technologies. Despite initial imbalances, however, overall information flow in the society is bound to go up.
- What happens by way of information imbalance within a society is also true of situations among countries at large. Advanced countries which are already information-rich tend to become richer, thereby widening the information gap between countries. This may lead to an unfavourable situation for the Third World countries which are already at the receiving end of the technological supremacy of the First World.
- Information overload is likely to happen, which in turn poses problems of coping with selective retrieval of required information, from heaps of randomly accumulated information. Here again, the new technologies themselves are likely

to come to our rescue, as for example special computer software which may enable users to obtain such selective display of information as is relevant to them.

- Unemployment may abound in certain sectors as the new technologies would eliminate or render surplus certain traditional jobs and occupations. Some new jobs and new occupations may be created in their place, but not in numbers sufficient enough to compensate the loss of traditional jobs. Displacement of jobs may be felt more acutely during the introductory phase of the new technologies, than when the technologies in question get integrated fully into society.
- The universal presence of computers and easy access to them via networks is likely to raise problems concerning privacy and security of communications. Use of special passwords and the like are of course an obvious protection, but they too have their limitations. Clever use of special software may also enable computer miscreants/hackers to break the secret passwords and get at the classified information straight away.
- Greater use of the new technologies may enable the organizations concerned to become more decentralized in their decision making and other functions. Here again, an exact opposite may be possible as the new technologies permit much tighter monitoring on the movements and performances of subordinate staff thereby bringing about a 'Big-Brother' kind of centralized control. Much depends on the way the managements want to use the new technologies.
- It is feared the gender-inequality will increase. Though unfounded, the apprehension is prevalent that boys rather than girls will adapt themselves faster and more easily to things like computer programming, due to their supposedly inherent superiority in mathematical skills. This is of course a debatable point. However, in the initial stages of adoption of the new technologies, social pressures may be generated because of gender inequalities.

From the above discussion, you may be inclined to think, that since these new technologies have certain undesirable effects on society, they might as well be avoided entirely. Such thinking, however, would be too short sighted and technophobic to be true. The history of technology is replete with instances of social. Instability and resistance upon introduction of major technological innovations. Eventually, however, as the society adapted itself to these new innovations and assimilated their full impact, the initial resistances were found to have melted away. Not only were those, the new technologies themselves found to be instrumental in finding solutions to the very problems what they had generated in the first place. In case any particular technology was found unable to conform to the above pattern, sociological forces would automatically tend to relegate such a technology into oblivion. The case of the new communication technologies that we have discussed in this unit, can be no exception to this overall trend.

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